

THE CLEAN GOSPEL OF MARK

A Passage by Passage Commentary on the Earliest Gospel Using Quranic Verses

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A Humble Servant and Fellow Witness

The Quran corrects the prophets it names and does not soften the corrections, and four of the five figures it says were given a book carry heavy records. The fifth, 'Īsā AS, carries none. Beside him stands Yaḥyā AS, of whom the negation is stated outright rather than merely omitted. This commentary takes that asymmetry as its starting point, reads the one passage in which the corpus interrogates 'Īsā AS directly and finds it returns clean, and holds that the silence is a guard rather than an elevation: it is what makes the servanthood declared from the cradle a thing chosen rather than a thing conceded. From that position the earliest Gospel is read entire. Not eighteen selections, and not a harmony: every passage of Mark from the first verse to the last, in order, with nothing skipped and nothing smoothed. Each passage is quoted, read against the corpus, and then tested as a structure, and where the words of the two texts diverge on the surface, the structural reading is allowed to finish the sentence the words began. The reading finds one pattern running the length of the book, authority received rather than held, and it finds that pattern to be the same one the corpus attaches to every miracle it records of this prophet: by My permission, four times in a single verse. What emerges is a Gospel that agrees with the Quran far more deeply than either community has been taught to expect, and that diverges from it in a small number of places that can be named, counted, and in most cases traced to the same operation the corpus performs on itself. Eight such corrections are recorded. The threads that bind the book, a verb of strength, a spitting, four Aramaic words, six interruptions, nine silencings, are counted as they arrive, with one preposition standing apart at the close. And the ending that stops at fear is set beside the verse that lifts fear from the friends of Allah ﷺ, so that the last word of the one text meets the first mercy of the other.

THE FINDING IN BRIEF

For fourteen centuries the Quran and the Gospel have been read as opposite accounts of the same figure. This commentary reports that on the evidence of the two texts themselves, they are not.

The Quran corrects its prophets and does not soften the corrections. Adam forgot. Noah asked for what he had no right to know. Abraham confessed a fault in his own prayer. Moses killed a man and asked for a sight he was refused. Jonah ran. David was forgiven a named thing. Solomon was corrected by a bird. Muhammad, peace and blessings be upon him, was corrected by revelation seven times, itemised in Part I, and twice told to seek forgiveness for his own offence.

Jesus is the only bearer of a scripture in the whole corpus with a clean file. Four of the five who were given a book carry heavy

records. He carries nothing: not a rebuke, not a lapse, not a line. And of Yaḥyā AS, who stands beside him in the same surah, the negation is stated outright: he was not a tyrant, not disobedient, in the very word the corpus uses of Adam's slip.

The silence is not an elevation. It is a guard. Had a fault been recorded, the servanthood would have been proved by deficiency: a servant because he could not be more. Instead the corpus has him declare himself a servant from the cradle, before anything else is said about him, and states one verse later that the Messiah does not disdain to be a servant. Disdain presupposes a height. The silence is what makes the servanthood chosen rather than conceded.

What the corpus addresses in the received picture is not a set of claims but three grammatical constructions, and to each it supplies the correct form. The equation that makes the Messiah convertible with Allah ﷻ is refused, and the same construction is written affirmatively elsewhere with the office correctly filled.

The number is barred, in the very verse that supplies three designations for one referent. And begetting is denied by asking how there could be offspring with no consort, with the mechanism given in the next clause, *kun fa-yakūn*. Nothing is taken and left empty. And the earliest Gospel, written before the settlement that raised those constructions, uses none of them once.

Where it denies begetting it names what replaces it, in the same breath. Twice, at Q 2:117 and Q 19:35, the claim of offspring is refused and the mechanism is given in the next clause: *kun fa-yakūn*, Be, and it is. Command, not procreation. The corpus also meets the inference from a birth without a father with a harder case: Adam had neither father nor mother, and nobody has ever concluded divine sonship from that. Fatherlessness is not the ground. The mechanism is.

And the earliest Gospel drops the begetting clause with its own hand. At the baptism the voice from heaven speaks in the words of the second Psalm, you are my son, and the Psalm's next clause, today I have begotten you, is the clause Mark does not carry. The quotation stops one phrase short of generation, at the beginning of the book, in the mouth of the voice itself. What the corpus fences six centuries later, the first evangelist had already declined to write.

What the corpus keeps is nearly everything else. The conception without a father, stated four separate times in four surahs. The title Messiah, eleven times, never withdrawn even in the clauses that condemn what was said about it. Word from Him. Spirit from Him. Strengthened by the Holy Spirit, three times. Speech from the cradle. A book given. Clay formed and breathed to life. The blind and the leper healed. The dead raised. The taking and the raising. Peace over his birth, his death, and his rising. A place among the five prophets of the solemn covenant. Compassion and mercy placed in the hearts of his followers.

The grammar the corpus condemns, it also demonstrates in its own voice, and that locates the condemnation precisely. The corpus rejects the sentence that fills the office of protector and life-giver with a creature. Then at Q 42:9 it writes the very construction it rejected and fills it correctly: *fa-Allāhu huwa al-Walī*, *wa-huwa yuḥyī al-mawtā*, so Allah ﷻ, He is the Protector, and He gives life to the dead. Five times across the corpus the same form recurs with the same subject. The condemnation was never of the sentence-shape. It was of the name placed in it. The office is real, the throne is real, and the corpus's whole quarrel is with the occupant the settlement seated there.

The prayer of this Gospel and the prayer of this corpus run on a single voice, and the corpus proves it with a missing word. Through Sūrat al-Baqarah the questions come to the Prophet ﷺ, they ask you about the new moons, about fighting, about wine, and every answer is routed through him: say, qul. One question breaks the pattern. When My servants ask you about Me, the answer comes with the messenger removed from the sentence: I am near, I answer the call of the caller when he calls Me. No qul. The one subject on which the intermediary is deleted from the

grammar itself is Him. Mark's prophet withdraws alone to pray, tells the paralytic's household that the forgiving runs above, and dies with a address on his lips. The two texts keep the same line open and keep it unbrokered.

Even the salt is the same covenant. Mark closes the hardest chapter of discipleship with have salt in yourselves, and the instruction has puzzled readers because salt is the one thing in the ancient kitchen a man cannot grow. That is the point, and the Torah had already made it law: the covenant of salt at Numbers 18:19 is a stipend, the priests eat what they did not produce, and the court of Persia says we eat the palace's salt to mean we are on the king's provision. A covenant sealed in salt is a declaration of dependence built into the material itself. The corpus carries the same economy without the token: every joining of hearts is His purchase, not yours, and what you were given to keep, you were given.

The blood goes the same way as the salt. At the supper Mark's prophet calls the cup the blood of the covenant, in the words of Sinai, where the blood was thrown upon the people and never drunk. The corpus, correcting its own community's sacrifice, states the principle that closes the arc: neither their flesh nor their blood reaches Allah ﷻ, but the reverence from you reaches Him. Blood applied, then salt added, then the word alone: the covenant token is progressively interiorised across the three scriptures until nothing ascends but *taqwā*. The Gospel's cup stands at the middle of that arc, and the corpus stands at its end.

Where the two texts seem to part on the resurrection of the married, they are two halves of one sentence. Mark says that in the rising they neither marry nor are given in marriage: the human transaction is denied. The corpus never once puts the wedding verb in creaturely hands in the Garden; it says We paired them, *zawwajnāhum*, with He as the only subject the verb ever takes there. The one text removes the contract from the creatures, the other assigns the pairing to the Lord, and together they say a single thing: the transacting ends, the gift remains.

A tower of readings collapses when one Hebrew word is put back. The riddle of Psalm 110, David calling his own descendant my lord, powered centuries of argument for a more-than-human son. In Hebrew the verse is two different words, YHWH said to adoni, the second an ordinary honorific said to kings and to Joseph the slave-steward. Greek rendered both as *kyrios*, and the riddle was born in translation. The corpus keeps the two tiers the Hebrew kept, *rabb* reserved, *sayyid* human, and names the collapse of names as the error itself.

And the corpus has a word for the space the woman with the flask occupied. She anointed him unbidden, the objectors priced her act, and he called it a good work and bound it to the gospel wherever it goes. The corpus names that category: things Allah ﷻ has left alone, *‘afā Allāhu ‘anhā*, an unlegislated space that the legalists rush to fill and the Lord had deliberately left open. The

objectors legislate; the master receives; the corpus supplies the doctrine of the open ground under both.

The Gospel ends at fear, and the corpus's first word over the friends is that fear is lifted. The oldest manuscripts of Mark stop mid-sentence: they said nothing to anyone, for they were afraid. The corpus's proclamation over the awliyā' is lā khawfun 'alayhim wa-lā hum yaḥzanūn, no fear upon them, nor shall they grieve. The one text breaks off where the other begins, and the reader who holds both watches the sentence finish across the gap of six centuries.

Nothing in the argument requires taking anyone's word for anything. Every claim rests on a construction anyone can check with a concordance, a lexicon, and a standard grammar. Where a claim rests instead on the structural method this commentary carries, that is said in the open, and the method is set out in the appendix in plain terms.

PROLOGUE · THE READING DEVICE

This commentary reads the Gospel of Mark from a single fixed position: the position of a reader who holds the Quranic account of 'Īsā AS entire, and holds nothing else.

Not a neutral reader, because there is no such reader. Not a Christian reader testing the Quran against the creeds, and not a polemicist testing the Gospel against a verdict already reached. The device is narrower and more honest than either: take the corpus's own picture of this prophet, the whole of it, the affirmations with the denials, and walk through the earliest Gospel asking of each passage one question. Does this stand, from here?

Three disciplines govern the walk, and they are stated now so they need not be repeated.

The first discipline is that the text is quoted before it is read. Every passage of Mark appears in this commentary, in order, from the first verse to the last. Nothing is skipped because it is inconvenient, and nothing is rearranged because it would read better. Where the Gospel is difficult for this reading, the difficulty is exhibited. Where it is difficult for the received reading, that is exhibited too. A commentary that selects is an argument wearing a commentary's clothes.

The second discipline is that grammar outranks tradition. Both texts arrive wrapped in centuries of interpretation, and both wrappings are set aside in the same motion. The corpus is read by its own usage: what a root does across its whole attested field, not what a school later said it must mean. The Gospel is read by its own Greek: what the evangelist wrote, not what the settlement four centuries later decided he must have meant. When this commentary says the two texts agree or part, it means the sentences do, checkable in a lexicon, not the communities.

The third discipline is the one that makes this a structural commentary and not only a comparative one. Every claim a text makes has three registers: what stands, what moves, and how the two bind. A reading closes when the three hold together and enclose something, the way three edges enclose a face; it breaks when they collapse into each other; it stays open when a register is missing and nothing in either text supplies it. This commentary lets that test finish what the surface words begin. Where Mark and the corpus diverge in wording, the structural reading is sovereign: if the two sentences occupy the same geometry, the divergence is dissolved and the dissolution is shown; if they do not, the divergence is named and kept. And where neither the words nor the structure can close a question, the commentary says in one sentence what is missing and from which side it would have to come, and leaves the door standing open. That sentence is not a failure of the reading. It is the reading, working, at the edge of what a reading can do.

A word about voice. The commentary speaks once. The work behind it involved excavation and testing, drafts and corrections, and none of that history appears here, because a finished reading owes the reader its findings and not its diary. What is framework-internal is said to be framework-internal. What is checkable is left checkable. And what was learned in the making, that the text kept opening past what the makers expected, is acknowledged in a single sentence here at the threshold: this reading was taught, in the making of it, more than it brought, and the One who taught it is generous beyond what is asked from below.

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HOW TO READ THIS COMMENTARY

The shape of a movement. Part IV runs in ten movements. Each opens with a short box, *What to Watch*, naming the four things in that stretch a reader should keep an eye on. Then the Gospel is read passage by passage, in order, and every passage has the same three parts.

The three parts of a passage. First the Gospel itself, set as a block quotation and given in the earliest recoverable form. Then *Commentary based on Quran*, which is not a footnote to the Gospel but a reading of it from the Quranic register, and which corrects where the two part. Then, where one is given, *Structural Commentary*, which asks a different question and is set out at Appendix A. Ten of those close a movement entire and are marked as such; five belong to a single passage, because in each of those cases one scene holds the whole architecture rather than one move within it.

The two registers. The running commentary reads Mark from the Quranic position: what the corpus affirms, where the two texts meet, and where they part. The Structural Commentary asks only whether the passage holds together, and on what. A passage can hold together and be false, and the two questions are kept apart throughout.

The mark ۞. It closes a Structural Commentary when the passage's three registers stand apart and compose. Raised, ۞ GOL↑, it marks the two places where a single utterance carries the whole architecture. Where a reading does not close, no mark

is used and the reason is stated in words. Appendix B lists every reading and the term that binds it.

The boxes. Boxes are set apart from the running text and are distinguished by their titles. *What to Watch* opens a movement. A numbered box, such as *Box 1 | The Two Devices*, holds a standing idea that governs more than the passage it sits in. *The Fence* marks the limit of what a section establishes. A *Part Summary* closes a part, and an *at a Glance* box gathers a list the book has been counting. The Structural Commentary is not a box: it is a heading, and it is one of the three parts of a passage described above.

Quotation and citation. Gospel passages are set as block quotations and given in the earliest recoverable form. Quranic references are surah:verse. The Gospel is cited as Mk in running prose and as Mark in headings, boxes, and tables; any other book is named in full. Arabic and Greek appear wherever the word itself is the evidence, transliterated with long vowels marked (ā, ī, ū), ' for 'ayn and ʾ for hamza, and emphatic consonants dotted beneath. No knowledge of either script is assumed anywhere.

Honorifics are components of the names they attach to and travel through every line: Allah ﷻ, the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ, and the prophets AS.

PART I • THE READER

Four things the Quranic register carries into the Gospel before a line of it is read.

Box | Part I Summary

The corpus corrects its prophets and does not soften it. Thirteen named figures carry a recorded fault, including four of the five who were given a book.

Two carry nothing, on two different grounds. 'Īsā AS is the only one of the five scripture-bearers with a clean file, the other four carrying heavy records. And of Yahyā AS the negation is stated outright rather than merely omitted.

The silence is a guard, not an elevation. A recorded fault would have proved servanthood by deficiency. The clean file is what makes it chosen, which Q 4:172 states one verse after the three designations.

The two clean files are two ends of one relation. Confirmation requires two parties. Merging them deletes the relation rather than perfecting it.

Fidelity is guaranteed; comprehension never is. Q 75:19 places the explication after the recitation and assigns it upstream.

I.1 · The Fault-Record, and the Two It Does Not Touch

Take the corpus at its own word and the inventory is stark. The table gives it at a glance; the paragraphs beneath give each case in the corpus's own words.

Table*: The prophetic fault-record at a glance

Prophet	What the corpus records	Where
Adam AS	Forgot the covenant; found without resolve; disobeyed and erred	20:115, 20:121
Nūḥ AS	Asked for what he had no knowledge of; warned against ignorance	11:46
Ibrāhīm AS	Confesses a fault in his own prayer; the star, moon, and sun sequence	26:82, 6:76-78
Lūṭ AS	Offers his daughters; wishes for tribal strength rather than the Ground	11:78, 11:80
Ya‘qūb AS	Grief past its bounds until his eyes whiten; a precaution he concedes useless	12:84-86, 12:67
Yūsuf AS	An inclination restrained from outside; reliance on the cupbearer	12:24, 12:42
Hārūn AS	Charged with disobeying his brother's command	20:93
Ayyūb AS	An oath requiring accommodation to discharge; called ever-returning	38:44
Mūsā AS	A killing he calls Satan's work; a refused request and explicit repentance; his brother seized	28:15, 7:143, 7:150
Dāwūd AS	Realised he was tested; sought forgiveness and was forgiven a named thing	38:24
Sulaymān AS	Distracted past the hour; corrected by a bird on knowledge and haste	38:31, 27:22
Yūnus AS	Absconded like a runaway slave; thought he would not be constrained	37:140, 21:87
Muhammad ﷺ	Seven corrections: frowned and turned away (Q 80:1); pardoned for a permission granted before verification (Q 9:43); concealed within himself and feared people (Q 33:37); the ransoms taken at Badr (Q 8:67); a near-inclination averted from outside (Q 17:74); forbade himself a lawful thing (Q 66:1); and twice commanded to seek forgiveness for his own offence (Q 40:55, Q 47:19)	seven loci, listed at left
Yahyā AS	Nothing. The negation stated outright: not a tyrant, not disobedient	19:14
‘Isā AS	Nothing at all	

Adam AS. *Wa-laqaḍ ‘ahidnā ilā Ādama min qablu fa-nasiya wa-lam najid lahu ‘azmā* (Q 20:115). We took a covenant from him before, but he forgot, and We found in him no resolve. Two named deficits, and then *‘aṣā Ādamu rabbahu fa-ghawā* (Q 20:121), disobeyed and erred. His own confession, *rabbānā*

ḡalamnā anḡusanā (Q 7:23), is self-attributed wronging, and the words of return were given to him rather than found by him (Q 2:37).

Nūḡ AS. He interceded for his son and was answered *innahu laysa min aḡlik, innahu ‘amalun ḡhayru ṡālīḡ, ḡa-lā tas’alni mā laysa laka bihi ‘ilm, innī a’izuka an takūna min al-jāḡilīn* (Q 11:46). Do not ask Me what you have no knowledge of; I admonish you lest you be among the ignorant. That word is spoken to a prophet in the middle of a flood.

Ibrāḡīm AS. In his own prayer of praise: *wa-lladhī aḡma‘u an yaḡḡira lī kḡaḡī‘atī yawm ad-dīn* (Q 26:82), and who I hope will forgive me my fault on the Day of Judgment. Unprompted, in a passage of glorification, a prophet asserts a *kḡaḡī‘a* attached to himself. Beside it the star-moon-sun sequence at Q 6:76-78, three times *ḡādhā rabbī* and three times withdrawn, and the prayer for a father later disowned at Q 9:114.

Lūḡ AS. At Q 11:78 he offers his daughters to the crowd, a proposal the text neither endorses nor has him retract. At Q 11:80, *law anna lī bikum quwwatan aw āwī lā ruknīn ṡadīd*, if only I had power against you or could take refuge in a strong support, a wish for tribal muscle rather than for the Ground he serves.

Ya‘qūb AS. Grief past its bounds until his eyes whiten (Q 12:84) and his own sons tell him he will destroy himself (Q 12:85). A precaution ordered at Q 12:67 and conceded useless in the same breath. Then his own correction, *innamā aṡkū bathḡī wa-ḡuznī ilā Allāḡ* (Q 12:86).

Yūsuf AS. *Wa-laḡad ḡammat bihi wa-ḡamma biḡa lawlā an ra‘ā burḡāna rabbīḡ* (Q 12:24), the inclination placed on him with an external restraint interposed. And Q 12:42, the request to the cupbearer followed by *ḡa-ansāḡu ṡ-shayḡānu ḡḡikra rabbīḡi ḡa-labitha ḡī s-sijni biḡ‘a sinīn*, several years added to the sentence.

Hārūn AS. *A-ḡa-‘aṡayta amrī* (Q 20:93), did you disobey my command, and his defence that he feared being blamed for splitting the people.

Ayyūb AS. An oath sworn that required a divine accommodation to discharge without perjury, *ḡudḡ bi-yadika ḡighḡan ḡa-ḡrib bihi wa-lā taḡnath* (Q 38:44), with *awwāb*, ever-returning, as his epithet.

Mūsā AS. The killing, self-typed as *ḡādhā min ‘amal aṡ-shayḡān* and *rabbī innī ḡalamtu naḡṡī* (Q 28:15-16) and later called *ḡanb* in his own mouth (Q 26:14). The request at Sinai, *rabbī arinī anḡur ilayk*, refused with *lan tarānī*, and his waking words *ṡubḡānaka tubtu ilayk* (Q 7:143), an explicit repentance for having asked. The tablets thrown and his brother seized by the head (Q 7:150), then *rabbī ḡḡfir lī wa-li-aḡḡī* (Q 7:151), forgive me and my brother, himself first. And three broken undertakings with ḡḡḡ AS, with *lā tu‘āḡḡidḡnī bimā naṡītu* (Q 18:73) as his own admission.

Dāwūd AS. *Wa-ḡanna Dāwūdu annamā ḡatannāḡu ḡa-staḡḡfara rabbahu wa-kḡarra rāḡi‘an wa-anāb* (Q 38:24), followed by *ḡa-*

ḡḡafarnā laḡu ḡḡālik, so We forgave him that. The pronoun has a referent.

Sulaymān AS. The horses and the missed hour (Q 38:31-33). The body cast on the throne and the return, *ḡumma anāb* (Q 38:34). And the hoopoe returning with *aḡaḡtu bimā lam tuḡīḡ bihi*, I have encompassed what you have not, correcting the prophet-king on knowledge and on haste in one line (Q 27:20-22).

Yūnus AS. *Abaḡa ilā al-ḡulk al-maṡḡḡūn* (Q 37:140), absconded, the verb for a runaway slave. *ḡa-ḡanna an lan naḡḡira ‘alayḡ* (Q 21:87), he thought We would not constrain him. His confession *innī kuntu min aḡ-zālimīn*. And the Prophet ﷺ told directly, *wa-lā takun ka-ṡḡḡīb al-ḡūḡ* (Q 68:48), do not be like the man of the fish.

Muḡammad ﷺ. *‘Abasa wa-tawallā* (Q 80:1), he frowned and turned away. *‘Aḡā Allāḡu ‘anka lima aḡḡinta laḡum* (Q 9:43). *Wa-tukḡḡī ḡī naḡṡika mā Allāḡu muḡḡḡī wa-taḡḡṡḡā an-nāsa wa-Allāḡu aḡaḡqu an taḡḡṡḡāḡ* (Q 33:37). *Lima tuḡḡarrimu mā aḡalla Allāḡu lak* (Q 66:1). The Badr ransoms (Q 8:67-68). The near-inclination averted only by external firming (Q 17:73-75). *Mā taḡaḡḡḡama min ḡanbika wa-mā ta‘aḡḡḡar* (Q 48:2), *wa-waḡa‘nā ‘anka wiḡrak* (Q 94:2), and twice the imperative *wa-staḡḡfir li-ḡanbik* (Q 40:55, Q 47:19).

Against all of that, silence on two.

The comparison has to be drawn in the right class or it proves nothing. Of the twenty-five prophets the corpus names, most appear only in a list, or in a short cycle with an adversary and a deliverance, and carry no recorded fault for the plain reason that there is no narrative in which one could be recorded. Nothing follows from their silence. Idrīs AS occupies two verses. Dhū al-Kiḡl AS and al-Yasa‘ AS are names in an enumeration.

So the class that carries information is the figures the corpus treats at length, and within that class the sharpest and least arguable line is those given a book. There are five.

Table*: The scripture-bearers

Prophet	The book	Fault recorded
Ibrāḡīm AS	the ṡuḡuf, Q 87:19	Yes. A fault confessed in his own prayer, Q 26:82
Mūsā AS	the Tawrāt and the Furḡān, Q 2:53	Yes. The heaviest record in the corpus
Dāwūd AS	the Zabūr, Q 4:163	Yes. A named thing forgiven, Q 38:24
Muḡammad ﷺ	the Qur‘ān	Yes. Seven corrections, itemised above
‘Īsā AS	the Inḡīl, Q 5:46	None

Four of the five carry heavy records. The fifth carries nothing, and that is the observation. It does not rest on counting minor figures,

it does not turn on where a borderline case falls, and it cannot be dissolved by pointing at a prophet the corpus mentions in passing.

Beside him stands one further figure, distinctive on a different ground.

Yahyā AS receives the negation stated outright: *wa-barran bi-wālidayhi wa-lam yakun jabbāran ‘aṣiyyā* (Q 19:14), dutiful to his parents, and he was not a tyrant, not disobedient. That last word is the root used of Adam AS at Q 20:121 and of Hārūn AS at Q 20:93. It is applied to Yahyā AS only in order to be denied.

‘Īsā AS receives nothing at all. Not a correction, not a rebuke, not a lapse. He is the only scripture-bearer in the corpus with a clean file.

And the pairing with Yahyā AS is lexical rather than incidental. Q 19:7 marks his name as unprecedented, *lam naj‘al lahu min qablu samiyyā*, We had given that name to no one before, and the corpus then plays on it: his blessing at Q 19:15 closes on *yawma yub‘athu ḥayyā*, the day he is raised alive, the Arabic form of the name and the word for living sharing their consonants. The paronomasia is the corpus's own and does not depend on any claim about the name's ultimate derivation, which is from the Hebrew Yôḥānān. ‘Īsā AS is *rūḥun minhu*, a spirit from Him. The two figures the fault-record does not touch are the one whose name the corpus rhymes with living and the one who is spirit from Him, and both stand at the same register.

The distribution is also asymmetric by design. If the lapses were a literary convention for humanising the prophetic type they would fall evenly across the figures the corpus treats at length. They do not: they fall on four of the five scripture-bearers and on most of the extended narrative cycles, and they are absent from exactly the one place where a reader of either tradition would most expect to find one. Fault is recorded where a mechanism is being taught and withheld where it is not.

I.1a · The One Candidate, and Why It Returns Clean

A negative claim about a corpus is only as good as the search behind it, and there is exactly one passage that a reader will raise against it. It should be raised here rather than left.

Q 5:116 is the only place in the corpus where the Source addresses ‘Īsā AS directly and puts a question to him. The setting is the reckoning, and the question is an accusation in form: *a-anta qulta li-l-nāsi ittakhidhūnī wa-ummiya ilāhayni min dūni Allāh*, did you say to the people, take me and my mother as two gods besides Allah ﷻ. If a rebuke of ‘Īsā AS exists anywhere in the corpus, it is here.

Read the exchange whole and it returns the opposite of a rebuke.

The question is put and the answer is immediate and threefold. *Subḥānak*, glory be to You, a refusal of the premise before anything else. *Mā yakūnu lī an aqūla mā laysa lī bi-ḥaqq*, it is not for me to say what is not mine by right, a refusal to occupy a

formulation rather than a denial of a deed he might have done. Then the epistemic boundary, *ta‘lamu mā fī nafsi wa-lā a‘lamu mā fī nafsik*, You know what is in my self and I do not know what is in Yours, which places the verification with the questioner rather than with the answerer. And then the affirmative content at Q 5:117: *mā qultu lahum illā mā amartanī bihi an u‘budū Allāha rabbī wa-rabbakum*, I said to them only what You commanded me, worship Allah ﷻ, my Lord and your Lord.

The passage is therefore an interrogation that returns clean, and an interrogation that returns clean is evidence for a file rather than against it. The corpus has the form available for the other outcome and uses it freely elsewhere: *fa-lā tas‘alni mā laysa laka bihi ‘ilm* to Nūḥ AS, *lan tarānī* to Mūsā AS, *‘afā Allāhu ‘anka* and *‘abasa wa-tawallā* to the Prophet ﷺ. Here the question is put and no fault is returned.

Two related passages are worth naming with it and are the same shape. At Q 5:110 the corpus recounts every favour and every work and attaches its permission-clause four times, and adds no correction. And at Q 43:59 the corpus says of him only *in huwa illā ‘abdun an‘amnā ‘alayhi wa-ja‘alnāhu mathalan li-Banī Isrā‘īl*, he was only a servant whom We favoured and made an example. The strongest available reduction in the corpus's vocabulary is *only a servant*, and it carries no fault with it.

So the ‘Īsā AS row of the table above is empty because the one entry a reader would expect to find there was examined and returned nothing.

I.2 · What the Silence Is For

The obvious reading of the silence is elevation. It is the wrong reading, and the corpus supplies the right one in the next verse of the very passage that raises the question.

Track the relation between exception and servanthood across the corpus and it runs inverse: the higher the ontological anomaly, the heavier the servanthood declaration. ‘Īsā AS is the only figure who speaks from the cradle, and the first word out of his mouth in the entire corpus is *‘abd. Innī ‘abdu Allāh, ātāniya al-kitāba wa-ja‘alanī nabiyyā* (Q 19:30). Servant first, book second, prophet third, at the moment of maximum miraculous exception.

Now see what the silence buys. Had the corpus recorded a fault for ‘Īsā AS, that fault would have become the proof of mere humanity, and the servanthood would have been established by deficiency. A servant because he could not be more. Instead the corpus establishes servanthood by declaration from a figure it never faults, which is the harder and stronger claim, and it states it one verse after the three designations:

> **The Messiah will never disdain to be a servant of Allah ﷻ, nor will the angels brought near.** > > *Lan yastankifa al-Masīḥu an yakūna ‘abdan lillāh wa-lā al-malā’ikatu al-muqarrabūn.* · Q 4:172

Yastankif is the verb of disdain, of holding oneself above. It presupposes a height from which disdain would be intelligible. The verse does not say he is too small to be more. It says he is not too proud to be less. And the angels are placed beside him in the same clause, which sets the height at which the disdain would have been conceivable.

That is the voluntariness guard, and it is the office the fault-silence performs.

Box 1 | The Two Devices

The corpus runs two complementary devices on the prophetic record and they must not be confused.

The clean file on 'Īsā AS and Yaḥyā AS is the voluntariness guard. Servanthood declared by a figure never faulted is chosen; servanthood forced by deficiency is not. Q 4:172 and Q 19:30 state it.

The marked file on the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ is the anti-counterfeit device. To impersonate a figure whose record contains 'abasa wa-tawallā addressed to himself in the third person, an impostor would have to write his own rebukes. No claimant volunteers a fault-file. The corrections are tamper-evidence, and the corpus adds two further locks: the office is sealed by declaration at Q 33:40, and at Q 3:144 an anti-cult clause is revealed at the exact moment a rumour of his death ran through a battlefield.

Different mechanisms, different purposes, both running at once.

I.3 · The Two-Place Office

Because the two clean files stand together, the natural next thought is that they are one figure. The corpus closes that route with a single verse and opens a better one.

> **Allah ﷻ gives you glad tidings of Yaḥyā, confirming a word from Allah ﷻ.** > > *Anna Allāha yubashshiruka bi-Yaḥyā, muṣaddiqan bi-kalimatīn min Allāh.* · Q 3:39

Confirmation is two-place. A confirmer attests something, and the something is not himself. If the word is 'Īsā AS, and the natural reading six verses later at Q 3:45 makes it so, then Yaḥyā AS is attester and 'Īsā AS is attested, and no one attests his own arrival. The relation requires two terms, and collapsing them deletes it rather than perfecting it.

Q 6:85 enumerates them as members of a set, *wa-Zakariyyā wa-Yaḥyā wa-'Īsā wa-Ilyās, kullun min aṣ-ṣāliḥīn*, and enumeration presupposes distinctness. Q 19 runs them as adjacent cycles with incompatible origins: a barren wife for one (Q 19:2-15) and no man at all for the other (Q 19:16-33). The peace-formula is spoken over Yaḥyā AS at Q 19:15 and spoken by 'Īsā AS about himself at Q 19:33, the same words in two grammatical positions.

What the pairing is, then, is one two-place office with two seats. And that reading explains the silence at both ends where the merger cannot: an attestation is only as clean as both of its poles.

A confirmer with a recorded fault has his attestation impeached; a confirmed figure with a recorded fault has an unimpeached attestation pointing at damaged goods. The joint cleanness is a structural requirement of the office, not a coincidence of two biographies.

The corpus has the same pattern elsewhere, named. Mūsā AS asks *wa-j'al lī wazīran min ahlī, Hārūna akhī, ushdud bihi azrī, wa-ashrikhu fī amrī* (Q 20:29-32). One command, two persons, the sharing requested and granted, and the two never once collapsed. One office, two nodes, persons kept distinct.

This matters immediately, because Mark stages the collapse and declines it. Herod says John the baptiser has been raised, and adds the beheading himself so no reader misses that he knows better. The crowd cycles John, Elijah, or one of the prophets. Mark reports three confident identifications and ratifies none, and the reader who read chapter one already holds the correct structure.

I.4 · Transmission and Comprehension

The reader carries one more law, and it governs what he is permitted to conclude from anything he finds.

The corpus guarantees the fidelity of its transmission in its most severe available language and never once guarantees the exhaustive comprehension of its transmitter.

Fidelity: *wa-mā yanṭiqu 'an al-hawā, in huwa illā waḥyun yūḥā* (Q 53:3-4), he does not speak from desire. *Qul mā yakūnu lī an ubaddilahu min tilqā'i nafsī* (Q 10:15), it is not for me to alter it of my own accord, with the self barred by name. And *wa-law taqawwala 'alaynā ba'da al-aqāwīl, la-akhadhnā minhu bil-yamīn, thumma la-qata'nā minhu al-watīn* (Q 69:44-46), a threat of a severed aorta that never fired.

Comprehension: the opposite treatment. *Qul lā aqūlu lakum 'indī khazā'inu Allāh wa-lā a'lamu al-ghayb* (Q 6:50). *Law kuntu a'lamu al-ghayba la-staktharu min al-khayr* (Q 7:188). *Mā adrī mā yuf'alu bī wa-lā bikum* (Q 46:9). Each prefixed with the imperative say, so these are commanded declarations rather than concessions extracted. And a standing open petition, *wa-qul rabbi zidnī 'ilmā* (Q 20:114), the only thing in the corpus its bearer is told to ask increase of.

Then the verse that separates the two axes explicitly and assigns both to the Source:

> **Do not move your tongue with it to hasten it. Upon Us is its gathering and its recitation. So when We have recited it, follow its recitation. Then, upon Us is its explication.** > > *Lā tuḥarrik bihi lisānaka li-ta'jala bih. Inna 'alaynā jam'ahu wa-qur'ānah. Fa-idhā qara'nāhu fa-ttabi' qur'ānah. Thumma inna 'alaynā bayānah.* · Q 75:16-19

Gathering is His. Recitation is His. The instruction to the transmitter is *follow*, a fidelity verb and not a comprehension verb. And then *thumma*, afterward, in sequence: the explication is

also His, placed after the recitation and stated as an ongoing undertaking rather than a completed state.

The in-corpus precedent is the Khidr AS cycle at Q 18:65-82. A scripture-bearing messenger of the first rank is shown a knowledge from a source he does not hold and is told he could not have patience with what he did not encompass. A full narrative cycle spent on the proposition that completeness of office does not entail completeness of comprehension.

The consequence for this commentary is exact and it is what makes the reading device honest. A verbatim standard preserves structure independently of any transmitter's or reader's grasp. A token deposited unaltered carries whatever it carries whether or not anyone downstream unfolds it. So the structures recovered below are present in the two texts as tokens, and nothing in the recovery requires or asserts that any transmitter unfolded them.

PART II · THE DISTILLED QURANIC CHRISTOLOGY

This is the equipment the reader brings. It is set out as an inventory rather than as an argument, because the first thing an inventory does is dissolve the assumption on which both receptions rest, that the two accounts stand at opposite ends of a spectrum.

Box | Part II Summary

Affirmed: sixteen items, listed in full at II.3.

Addressed: three grammatical forms only. A convertible identity marked by the separative pronoun, an ordinal inside a count, and offspring in the generative sense.

And each is answered rather than merely refused. The corpus writes the equational form affirmatively elsewhere with the office correctly filled; it keeps threeness as structure in the very verse that bars the number; and it supplies *kun fa-yakūn*, command rather than procreation, in the clause adjacent to the denial at Q 2:117 and Q 19:35. Nothing is taken and left empty.

The Word has a prior residence and seven predicates the corpus gives to nothing created, and is then named with a man's name in a clause where the grammar breaks to follow the person.

The crucifixion verse denies their agency and their knowledge, not a death; the taking is assigned to the Source in three places, one of them in his own mouth.

II.1 · What the Corpus Affirms

Gathered without selection, from every surah in which the material occurs.

The conception. *Fa-arsalnā ilayhā rūḥanā fa-tamaththala lahā basharan sawiyyā* (Q 19:17), We sent to her Our Spirit and it presented itself to her as a well-formed man. Her protest, *annā yakūnu lī ghulāmūn wa-lam yamsasnī basharūn wa-lam aku*

baghiyyā (Q 19:20), no man has touched me and I have not been unchaste, and the answer, *huwa 'alayya hayyin wa-li-naj'alahū āyatan li-l-nāsi wa-raḥmatan minnā wa-kāna amran maqḍiyyā* (Q 19:21), a sign for mankind and a mercy from Us, and a matter decreed. The parallel at Q 3:47 with the same protest and the same answer, *kadhāliki Allāhu yakhlūqu mā yashā'*. And twice more in the corpus's own summary voice: *wa-allatī aḥsanat farjahā fa-nafakhnā fihā min rūḥinā wa-ja'alnāhā wa-bnahā āyatan li-l-'ālamīn* (Q 21:91), and *wa-Maryama bnata 'Imrāna allatī aḥsanat farjahā fa-nafakhnā fihī min rūḥinā wa-ṣaddaqqat bi-kalimāti rabbihā wa-kutubihī wa-kānat min al-qānīnīn* (Q 66:12).

The virgin conception is therefore stated four separate times, in four surahs, in the corpus's own voice, with the mother's own denial of contact preserved in two of them.

The mother. Chosen and purified: *inna Allāha iṣṭafāki wa-ṭahharaki wa-ṣṭafāki 'alā nisā'i al-'ālamīn* (Q 3:42). Provisioned without reckoning at Q 3:37. Named a *ṣiddīqa*, a woman of truth, at Q 5:75. The only woman named in the whole corpus, and a surah carries her name.

The titles. *Al-Masīh*, the Messiah, eleven times: Q 3:45, Q 4:157, Q 4:171, Q 4:172, Q 5:17 twice, Q 5:72 twice, Q 5:75, Q 9:30, and Q 9:31. Four of the eleven stand inside formulas the corpus is condemning, which sharpens the observation rather than weakening it: the corpus rejects the predication and never withdraws the title, so the very clause that rejects *Allah* ﷻ is the *Messiah* calls him the Messiah while rejecting it. *Kalima*, a word from Him: Q 3:39, Q 3:45, Q 4:171. *Rūḥ minhu*, a spirit from Him: Q 4:171. *Wajīhan fī al-dunyā wa-l-ākhirati wa-mīna al-muqarrabīn* (Q 3:45), eminent in this world and the next and of those brought near. *Mubārakan aynamā kuntu* (Q 19:31), blessed wherever I am. *Ghulāman zakiyyā* (Q 19:19), a pure boy, spoken by the angel before the conception. *Āyatan li-l-nāsi wa-raḥmatan minnā* (Q 19:21). And *innahu la-'ilmun li-l-sā'ati* (Q 43:61), he is knowledge of the Hour.

The strengthening. *Wa-ayyadnāhu bi-rūḥi al-quḍus*, We strengthened him with the Holy Spirit, three times: Q 2:87, Q 2:253, Q 5:110. The verb is from the root for strength in the hand and means bracing, not replacing.

The speech. *Wa-yukallimu al-nāsa fī al-mahdi wa-kahlan* (Q 3:46, and again at Q 5:110), he will speak to people in the cradle and in maturity. And the cradle speech itself at Q 19:30-33, in the first person, opening on *'abd*.

The teaching given. *Wa-yu'allimuhu al-kitāba wa-l-ḥikmata wa-l-Tawrāta wa-l-Injīl* (Q 3:48, and Q 5:110). And the Injīl itself described: *wa-āṭaynāhu al-Injīla fihī hudan wa-nūrun wa-muṣaddiqan limā bayna yadayhi min al-Tawrāti wa-hudan wa-maw'izatan li-l-muttaqīn* (Q 5:46), guidance and light and admonition.

The works. *Annī akhlūqu lakum min al-ṭīni ka-hay'ati al-ṭayri fa-anfukhu fihī fa-yakūnu ṭayran bi-idhni Allāh, wa-ubri'u al-*

akmaha wa-l-abraṣa wa-uḥyī al-mawtā bi-idhni Allāh, wa-unabbi'ukum bimā ta'kulūna wa-mā taddakhirūna fī buyūtikum (Q 3:49). Formation from clay with breath, the blind and the leper healed, the dead raised, and knowledge of what is eaten and stored in houses. Repeated in the second person at Q 5:110 with the permission-clause attached four separate times. And *bi-idhni*, by My permission, is attached to every one of them without exception.

The mission. *Wa-muṣaddiqan limā bayna yadayya min al-Tawrāti wa-li-uḥilla lakum ba'da alladhī ḥurrima 'alaykum* (Q 3:50), confirming the Torah and making lawful some of what had been forbidden. Sent *ilā Banī Isrā'īl* (Q 3:49), a bounded mission. And announcing what comes after him at Q 61:6.

The disciples. *Man anṣārī ilā Allāh, qāla al-ḥawāriyyūna naḥnu anṣāru Allāh* (Q 3:52, and Q 61:14). Called helpers of Allah ﷻ in the corpus's own approving voice.

The table. *Rabbanā anzil 'alaynā mā'idatan min al-samā'i takūnu lanā 'īdan li-awwalinā wa-ākhirinā wa-āyatan mink* (Q 5:114), and the answer *innī munazziluhā 'alaykum* (Q 5:115).

The taking and the raising. *Innī mutawaffika wa-rāfi'uka ilayya wa-muṭahhiruka minā alladhīna kafarū* (Q 3:55). *Bal rafa'ahu Allāhu ilayhi wa-kāna Allāhu 'azīzan ḥakīmā* (Q 4:158).

The peace. *Wa-l-salāmu 'alayya yawma wulidtu wa-yawma amūtu wa-yawma ub'athu ḥayyā* (Q 19:33), the threefold peace spoken by him about himself.

The covenant rank. *Wa-idh akhadhnā minā al-nabiyyīna mīthāqahum wa-minka wa-min Nūḥin wa-Ibrāhīma wa-Mūsā wa-'Īsā bni Maryam wa-akhadhnā minhum mīthāqan ghalīzā* (Q 33:7). Named among the five from whom the solemn covenant was taken. And at Q 42:13 the same religion is enjoined on Nūḥ, Ibrāhīm, Mūsā, and 'Īsā AS in one verse. And revelation given to him at Q 4:163 in the same list as the rest.

The community. *Wa-ja'alnā fī qulūbi alladhīna ittaba'ūhu ra'fatan wa-raḥmah* (Q 57:27), We placed compassion and mercy in the hearts of those who followed him. And *la-tajidanna aqrabahum mawaddatan li-lladhīna āmanū alladhīna qālū innā naṣārā, dhālika bi-anna minhum qissīsīna wa-ruhbānan wa-annahum lā yastakbirūn* (Q 5:82), the nearest in affection, and the reason given is the absence of arrogance among their priests and monks.

That is the affirmed inventory. It is not a residue. It is nearly the whole apparatus.

II.2 · What the Corpus Addresses, and in What Grammatical Form

What the corpus speaks to is three constructions, and each is identifiable by its grammar rather than by its vocabulary. This is the observation on which the whole comparison turns, and it is checkable by anyone who can read an Arabic clause.

The convertible identity.

> **They have disbelieved who said: Allah ﷻ is the Messiah, son of Maryam.** > > *La-qad kafara alladhīna qālū inna Allāha huwa al-Masīḥu bnu Maryam.* · Q 5:17, and again at Q 5:72

Definite subject, *Allāha*. Separative pronoun, *huwa*. Definite predicate, *al-Masīḥ*. In Arabic this is the strongest available identity construction: it asserts convertibility with no remainder on either side, A is B and B is A. The pronoun exists precisely to mark an equational sentence.

And the precision of the target can be measured from inside the corpus, because the corpus writes this very construction in its own voice and fills it correctly. *Fa-Allāhu huwa al-Walī*, so Allah ﷻ, He is the Protector, *wa-huwa yuḥyī al-mawtā*, and He gives life to the dead (Q 42:9). Definite subject, separative pronoun, definite predicate: the identical equational form the denial condemns, now with the life-giving clause attached in the next breath. The form recurs with the same subject across the corpus, *huwa al-ḥaqq* and *huwa yuḥyī al-mawtā* at Q 22:6, again at Q 22:62 and Q 31:30, *inna Allāha huwa al-Razzāq* at Q 51:58, and again at Q 57:24. Six occurrences in all. So the condemnation at Q 5:17 was never of the sentence-shape. The corpus reserves that shape and uses it freely of Him. What is condemned is the occupant of it: the office of protector and of giver of life to the dead is real, the equational seat is real, and the disbelief is seating a creature there. That is worth carrying through the whole addressed-file, because it means the corpus is not banning a grammar. It is guarding a throne.

The numeral.

> **They have disbelieved who said: Allah ﷻ is the third of three.** > > *La-qad kafara alladhīna qālū inna Allāha thālithu thalāthah.* · Q 5:73 > > **And do not say three. Stop; it is better for you.** > > *Wa-lā taqūlū thalāthah, intahū khayran lakum.* · Q 4:171

An ordinal inside a count, and a prohibition on a numeral.

The generation.

> **The Jews said 'Uzayr is the son of Allah ﷻ, and the Christians said the Messiah is the son of Allah ﷻ.** > > *Wa-qālati al-Yahūdu 'Uzayrun ibnu Allāh, wa-qālati al-Naṣārā al-Masīḥu ibnu Allāh.* · Q 9:30 > > **It was not for Allah ﷻ to take to Himself any offspring. Glory be to Him.** > > *Mā kāna lillāhi an yattakhidha min waladīn, subḥānah.* · Q 19:35 > > **How could He have offspring when He has no consort?** > > *Annā yakūnu lahu waladun wa-lam takun lahu ṣāḥibah.* · Q 6:101

The last of these is decisive for what the denial targets. It asks how He could have a *walad* when He has no consort, and *walad* is the generative-biological term. The mechanism denied is procreation. And in two of these places the corpus supplies the replacement in the same breath, at Q 2:117 and again at Q 19:35, which is set out at II.5a. And Q 112:3, *lam yalid wa-lam yūlad*, denies begetting in both directions, with Q 112:2 supplying the

reason first: *aṣ-Ṣamad*, the solid without hollow, since a thing that begets must have an interior from which something issues.

And Q 43:81 is worth having whole because it shows the register of the refusal: *qul in kāna li-l-Raḥmāni waladun fa-anā awwalu al-‘ābidīn*. Say: if the Merciful had a son, I would be the first of the worshippers. The refusal is not of honour paid; it is of the mechanism claimed.

And Q 5:116, which names its own target. *A-anta qulta li-l-nāsi ittakhidhūnī wa-ummiya ilāhayni min dūni Allāh*. Did you say to the people, take me and my mother as two gods besides Allah ﷻ. The triad named is Allah ﷻ, ‘Īsā AS, and Maryam AS. That corresponds to no conciliar formula of any Christian communion, then or since. Whatever its historical referent, the target the corpus names is a Marian triad and a numbered polytheism.

So the whole addressed-file, gathered, condemns exactly three forms: a definite convertible identity, an enumeration, and biological generation. No fourth appears anywhere in the corpus.

II.3 · What Is Actually Addressed

Set the two inventories side by side and the result is not the one either polemic expects. But they are not two lists of the same kind, and presenting them as one grid has misled readers in both directions.

The first is content: sixteen items the corpus affirms about ‘Īsā AS, gathered without selection. The second is not content at all. It is three grammatical constructions, each addressed for a stated reason, and each answered with a correct filling supplied elsewhere in the corpus and, in two of the three, in the adjacent clause. What the received picture leaves behind after the corpus has spoken to it is a residue only if one assumes something was taken and nothing put back. Nothing here is taken and left empty.

A term should be fixed before the lists, because the whole comparison turns on it. Throughout this commentary *the received picture* means the fourth-and-fifth-century conciliar settlement and the piety it authorised: eternal generation from the Father's substance, begotten not made; consubstantial identity stated as an equation; a threeness of persons stated as a count; and the devotional grammar built on those clauses. It does not mean the New Testament text itself. The relation between that text and the settlement raised on it is exactly what Part IV measures, passage by passage, and the measurement should not be prejudged by the vocabulary.

Table: The affirmed inventory

What the corpus affirms of ‘Īsā AS

Conception without a father, stated four times
The title Messiah, eleven times, never withdrawn
A word from Him
A spirit from Him
Strengthened by the Holy Spirit, three times
Speech in the cradle and in maturity
A book given, with guidance and light
Clay formed and breathed to life, by permission
The blind and the leper healed, by permission
The dead raised, by permission
Purity declared by the angel before conception
The taking and the raising to Him
Peace over his birth, his death, and his rising
A place among the five of the solemn covenant
Compassion and mercy placed in his followers' hearts
Knowledge of the Hour

Table*: The three constructions addressed, with their grounds and their fillings

The construction addressed	The ground the corpus gives	What stands in its place
The convertible equation. Definite subject, separative pronoun, definite predicate: <i>inna Allāha huwa al-Masīhu bnu Maryam</i> (Q 5:17, Q 5:72)	Destructibility, stated in the same verse: <i>fa-man yamliku mina Allāhi shay'an in arāda an yuhlīka al-Masīha bna Maryam</i> , who could avail against Allah ﷻ if He willed to destroy the Messiah. With <i>kānā ya 'kulāni al-ṭa'ām</i> (Q 5:75) and <i>al-Ḥayyi alladhī lā yamūt</i> (Q 25:58)	The identical construction, affirmed, with the office correctly filled: <i>fa-Allāhu huwa al-Walī wa-huwa yuhyī al-mawtā</i> (Q 42:9). The same form five further times, at Q 22:6, Q 22:62, Q 31:30, Q 51:58, and Q 57:24
The ordinal inside a count: <i>thālithu thalāthah</i> (Q 5:73), and the prohibition <i>wa-lā taqūlū thalāthah</i> (Q 4:171)	Membership in a counted set. The nearest parallel construction in the corpus is <i>wa-Manāta al-thālithata al-ukhrā</i> (Q 53:20), a named triad of the pre-Islamic Arab cult, where the ordinal constitutes a set and its members. What is barred is enumeration used to make Him one of a number	The identical construction, affirmed, with the relation correctly stated: <i>mā yakūnu min najwā thalāthatin illā huwa rābi'uhum wa-lā khamsatin illā huwa sādisuhum</i> , there is no counsel of three but He is the fourth of them, nor of five but He is the sixth (Q 58:7). And threeness as structure kept in the very verse that bars the number, three designations for one referent at Q 4:171, with Sūrat al-Ṣāffāt swearing by three ranks and concluding <i>inna ilāhakum la-wāḥid</i> (Q 37:1-4)
Offspring in the generative sense: <i>walad</i> (Q 9:30, Q 19:35, Q 112:3)	No consort: <i>annā yakūnu lahu waladun wa-lam takun lahu ṣāhibah</i> (Q 6:101). With the reason given before the consequence at Q 112:2, <i>aṣ-Ṣamad</i> , the solid without hollow, since a thing that begets must have an interior from which something issues	<i>Kun fa-yakūn</i> , supplied in the next clause at Q 2:117 and again at Q 19:35, with the inference closed at Q 3:59 by the harder case of Adam AS. Set out at II.5a

Read that way, the three rows are one operation performed three times. The corpus does not remove a claim and leave a hole. It

identifies a construction, states why that filling fails, and writes the correct form.

And the second row is not an exception to the first. Q 58:7 writes the ordinal inside a count of Him, affirmatively, in the corpus's own voice: *He is the fourth of them* where three confer, *the sixth* where five do. So ordinal-in-count is no more forbidden as a grammar than the equational form is, and Q 9:40 says *thāniya thnayni*, the second of two, of the Prophet ﷺ in the cave. What Q 5:73 speaks to is narrower and the distinction is exact: at Q 58:7 He is the fourth of three *by presence*, not by membership, since the counsel is of three and He is not counted into it. At Q 5:73 the number is used to constitute a set of which He is made a member. Presence, not membership: that is the whole of the second row, and the corpus supplies the verse that draws the line.

And the first row carries a further observation that refines II.2 rather than qualifying it. The construction addressed at Q 5:17 is not faulted as a construction. The corpus writes it affirmatively six times over, with the separative pronoun and the definite predicate intact, and twice with the life-giving clause following directly. So what is refused is the predicate placed in the frame and never the frame itself. A recipient-title cannot occupy the position, and the morphology says so before any theology does: *masīh* is the *fa'īl* form in the passive sense, the one acted upon, like *qatīl* and *jarīh*, while *walī* is not passive. Q 42:9 puts the whole of it in one verse: the taking of protectors besides Him refused, the frame filled correctly, and then *wa-huwa yuhyī al-mawtā*.

The third row is real and stays, and one thing that does not follow from it should be stated here. The corpus states the denial of generation and names its targets. It does not follow that the Gospel read in Part IV holds the position denied, and it does not: Mark uses no begetting-verb of him in relation to God anywhere, and at the baptism he quotes the second Psalm and declines the clause of generation that stands in the psalm's next breath.

Box | The Fence

What is established in this section is a fact about grammatical form and a fact about vocabulary distribution, and both are checkable with a concordance.

What is not established, and what nothing here licenses, is an inference from either to a doctrine the corpus refuses in the same breath. Q 5:73 closes on *wa-mā min ilāhin illā ilāhun wāḥid*, and Q 37:4 is the conclusion drawn from the three ranks and not a qualification of it.

The honest form of the observation is about method rather than about content: the corpus addresses a filling and demonstrates the correct filling in the same form elsewhere, so a reader who attends to construction rather than to vocabulary sees both moves. That is how it teaches. It seals nothing about what is taught.

The affirmed inventory is substantially closer to the received picture than either reception has been willing to say, and what the corpus addresses is narrow and precisely aimed. Classical Christian theology also denies begetting in time and by division, and it also denies that the Word is a second god counted beside the first. What the corpus does that the later councils did not is refuse the *number* as a permissible way of stating the relation at all, and it refuses it in the same verse in which it supplies three names for one referent.

II.4 · The Word: Residence, Predicates, and the Naming

The reader's doctrine of the Word is stated in his own book and owes nothing to any later theology.

The prior residence. *Wa-innahu fī ummi al-kitābi ladaynā la-‘aliyyun ḥakīm* (Q 43:4), in the Mother of the Book, with Us, exalted and wise. *Wa-‘indahu ummu al-kitāb* (Q 13:39), with Him. *Bal huwa qur’ānun majīd, fī lawḥin mahfūz* (Q 85:21-22). *Innahu la-qur’ānun karīm, fī kitābin maktūn* (Q 56:77-78). Four locative expressions and one structure: the recitation has a residence that is not its earthly descent, and the residence is with the Source. The descent-language presupposes it from the other direction, *innā anzalnāhu fī laylati al-qadr* (Q 97:1) and *nazala bihi al-rūḥu al-amīnu ‘alā qalbik* (Q 26:193-194).

The priority. Surah ar-Raḥmān opens on four verses in strict order. *Ar-Raḥmān. ‘Allama al-Qur’ān. Khalaqa al-insān. ‘Allamahu al-bayān.* The Merciful. He taught the Recitation. He created the human. He taught him the discrimination. The teaching stands at verse two and the creating at verse three: the gathering is taught before the receiver exists to receive it. And the name at the head is the mercy-name and not the creation-name, so the assembling of what is known is placed under mercy.

The instrumentality. *Innamā amrunā li-shay’in idhā aradnāhu an naqūla lahu kun fa-yakūn* (Q 16:40, and Q 36:82). Everything that comes to be, comes to be by an utterance. The Word is not one created item among others; it is the operator under which created items arrive. And Q 2:117, Q 3:47, and Q 19:35 all carry the same clause.

The predicates. The corpus assigns to its own Word a set it assigns to nothing created. *‘Aliyyun ḥakīm* (Q 43:4), exalted and wise, both of them divine names. *Qur’ānun majīd* (Q 85:21) and *qur’ānun karīm* (Q 56:77), glorious and noble, both of them divine names. Inexhaustible under a hypothetical of unbounded material supply: *qul law kāna al-baḥru midādan li-kalimāti rabbī la-naḥida al-baḥru qabla an tanḥada kalimātu rabbī wa-law ji’nā bi-mithlihi madadā* (Q 18:109), and with seven seas added at Q 31:27 the outcome is unchanged. Complete and unalterable: *watammāt kalimatu rabbika ṣidqan wa-‘adlan, lā mubaddila li-kalimātih* (Q 6:115), and *lā tabdila li-kalimāti Allāh* (Q 10:64).

Seven predicates across six verses, four of them divine names, all of them carried by a term the same verses locate with Him.

Inexhaustibility in particular is predicated of no created thing anywhere in the corpus.

The naming. The corpus does not stop at a doctrine. It attaches the Word to a person, and the Arabic performs the attachment in its own grammar:

> **Maryam, Allah ﷻ gives you glad tidings of a word from Him. His name is the Messiah, ‘Isā son of Maryam, eminent in this world and the next.** > > *Yā Maryamu inna Allāha yubashshiruki bi-kalimatin minhu, ismuhu al-Masīḥu ‘Isā bnu Maryam, wajīhan fī al-dunyā wa-l-ākhirah.* · Q 3:45

The word for *word* is feminine in Arabic. The pronoun in *ismuhu*, his name, is masculine, and *wajīhan*, eminent, is masculine accusative. The agreement breaks at exactly the point where the announcement of a word becomes the naming of a man. The grammarians noticed it; al-Zamakhsharī explains the break by agreement with the thing named rather than with the naming word. That explanation is correct and it is the point. The verse announces a word and names it as a man in one clause, and where the announcement turns into a personal reference the grammar changes gender to follow.

Then Q 4:171 adds the third designation, and Q 3:39 attaches the term a second time by making Yaḥyā AS its confirmer.

II.5 · Three Registers, and the Barred Count

Q 4:171 supplies three tokens for one referent in a single breath and then, in the same verse, bars the arithmetic.

> **The Messiah, ‘Isā son of Maryam, is only the messenger of Allah ﷻ, and His word which He cast to Maryam, and a spirit from Him. So believe in Allah ﷻ and His messengers, and do not say three.** > > *Innamā al-Masīḥu ‘Isā bnu Maryama rasūlu Allāhi wa-kalimatuḥu alqāhā ilā Maryama wa-rūḥun minhu. Fa-āminū billāhi wa-rusulihi wa-lā taqūlū thalāthah.* · Q 4:171

The verse does not delete the structure it just supplied. Three orthogonal registers of one object are not three objects, and the count is the collapse. Read as contradiction, one half must be gutted. Read as one move, the grammar is exact.

The origin register. *Rūḥun minhu*, a spirit from Him. The preposition is origin-marking and not partitive, the same construction used of Adam AS at Q 15:29 and Q 38:72 and of the human generally at Q 32:9. This is the register the corpus describes only apophatically: *quli al-rūḥu min amri rabbī wa-mā ūtītum mina al-‘ilmi illā qalīlā* (Q 17:85).

The articulate register. *Kalimatuḥu alqāhā ilā Maryam*, His word which He cast to Maryam AS. The verb is to cast down from a height: a form laid into a receiving substrate. This is where the Word of Q 43:4 stands, with Him, exalted and wise, in the Mother of the Book.

The delivered register. *Rasūlu Allāh*, the sent one, placed firmly inside creaturely conditions. *Mā al-Masīḥu bnu Maryama illā rasūlun qad khalat min qablihi al-rusul, wa-ummuhu ṣiddīqatun*,

kānā ya'kulāni al-ṭa'ām (Q 5:75), they both used to eat food. And *in huwa illā 'abdun an'amnā 'alayhi wa-ja'alnāhu mathalan li-Banī Isrā'īl* (Q 43:59).

One referent, three registers, three prepositions doing the joining, and no count.

And a further verse governs the whole: *inna mathala 'Īsā 'inda Allāhi ka-mathali Ādam, khalaqahu min turābin thumma qāla lahu kun fa-yakūn* (Q 3:59). This is standardly read as the demotion that settles the matter, and it does something narrower and something broader. Narrower, because the verse is explicitly a likeness and the likeness it draws is on the mode of origination alone: it says nothing about the attributes of the Word, nothing about the residence, nothing about the divine names carried by the Book. Broader, because a comparison runs in both directions. If 'Īsā AS is like Adam AS in the mode of the utterance, then Adam AS was constituted by the Word too, and Q 15:29 adds the second token to Adam AS as well. Both designations of Q 4:171 have Adamic parallels. The effect of Q 3:59 read carefully is not to lower 'Īsā AS to dust but to raise the whole anthropology to Word-and-Spirit.

Where, then, is the differentia? The text puts it in the casting: *alqāhā ilā Maryam*, direct and unmediated, with no father in the line, which Q 3:47 and Q 19:20 both make explicit. The distinction is in the mode of arrival.

One clause has to be exact here or the seven predicates of II.4 leak. The casting is an act, and an act is not a transfer of the thing predicated. What bears exaltation, wisdom, glory, nobility, inexhaustibility, completion, and unalterability is the Word in its residence, *fī ummi al-kitābi ladaynā*. The corpus predicates none of the seven of any vessel, and it predicates none of them of Adam AS either, though Adam AS carries both designations. So the reading is that the casting proceeds from what carries the predicates, and not that the predicates travel with the cast. Every fence in II.6 holds on that reading and fails on any other.

II.5a · Kun fa-yakūn: What the Corpus Supplies in Place of Generation

The denials of II.2 raise a question the corpus answers and this commentary, in earlier form, walked past. If the mechanism denied is generation, what is the mechanism affirmed?

The corpus names it eight times, in one fixed phrase, and the distribution of those eight is the argument.

Table: Every occurrence of *kun fa-yakūn*

Locus	Context
Q 2:117	Immediately after the claim that Allah ﷻ took offspring
Q 3:47	The conception announced to Maryam AS
Q 3:59	The likeness of 'Īsā AS to Adam AS
Q 6:73	The Day He says <i>kun</i>
Q 16:40	After a denial that the dead are raised
Q 19:35	Immediately after the denial that Allah ﷻ takes offspring
Q 36:82	After the question who gives life to decayed bones
Q 40:68	He who gives life and causes death

Two at the offspring-denial, two at 'Īsā AS, and four at raising and at life-and-death. Not one of the eight sits in a passage about ordinary manufacture. A phrase that could serve as a general formula for divine making is instead concentrated on exactly the questions this commentary is reading.

The denial and the mechanism stand in one breath, twice. This is the observation that most directly serves Part II, and the two verses should be read whole.

> **And they said, Allah ﷻ has taken offspring. Glory be to Him. Rather, to Him belongs whatever is in the heavens and the earth, all devoutly obedient to Him. Originator of the heavens and the earth. When He decrees a matter He only says to it: Be, and it is.** > > *Wa-qālū ittakhadha Allāhu waladā, subḥānah, bal lahu mā fī al-samāwāti wa-l-arḍi kullun lahu qānitūn. Badī'u al-samāwāti wa-l-arḍi wa-idhā qaḍā amran fa-innamā yaqūlu lahu kun fa-yakūn.* · Q 2:116-117

> **It was not for Allah ﷻ to take to Himself any offspring. Glory be to Him. When He decrees a matter He only says to it: Be, and it is.** > > *Mā kāna lillāhi an yattakhidha min waladīn, subḥānah, idhā qaḍā amran fa-innamā yaqūlu lahu kun fa-yakūn.* · Q 19:35

The same three moves in the same order, in two separate surahs: the offspring claim, the glorification that refuses it, and then the mechanism that replaces it. The corpus does not deny generation and leave a gap. It denies generation and names what stands in its place in the next clause.

Which sharpens II.3 considerably. Where the corpus addresses generation it supplies the alternative by name, in the adjacent clause. The relation between the Source and what proceeds from it is command and not procreation, and the two verses that state the denial most sharply are the two that say so.

The likeness at Q 3:59 is a kun-likeness, and it answers the sonship inference directly. The verse does not merely compare two originations. It gives the mechanism: *khalaqahu min turābin thumma qāla lahu kun fa-yakūn*. Dust, then *kun*.

And the term of comparison is exact. The inference the verse meets is that a birth without a father implies a divine father. Its answer is a case that is more anomalous still and from which nobody has ever drawn that conclusion. Adam AS had no father *and* no mother. 'Īsā AS had a mother and no father. If absence of paternal generation grounded divine sonship, the stronger claim would be owed to Adam AS, and no one has ever made it. So fatherlessness cannot be the ground. The mechanism is, and the mechanism is command.

That is why the two threads of Part II converge here. The corpus denies *walad* on precisely the consort-grounds, *annā yakūnu lahu waladun wa-lam takun lahu ṣāhibah* (Q 6:101), how could He have offspring with no consort. Generation requires two, and where there is no second there is no generation to speak of, so the human anomaly cannot supply a divine paternity that the corpus has already ruled out on its own side. What the anomaly does mark is a mode of arrival, which is what Q 3:47 says in answer to Maryam AS's own protest, *annā yakūnu lī waladun wa-lam yamsasnī bashar: kadhāliki Allāhu yakhluqu mā yashā', idhā qaḍā amran fa-innamā yaqūlu lahu kun fa-yakūn*. Thus He creates what He wills; when He decrees a matter He says to it, Be. And Q 19:21 answers the same protest with *huwa 'alayya hayyin*, it is easy for Me.

No father, and no difficulty either. Which is why the reading of II. 5 holds and runs in both directions: if what is said of the one is *kun*, what is said of the other is *kun*, and Q 15:29 and Q 38:72 add the second designation to Adam AS as well. The effect of Q 3:59 is to raise the anthropology rather than to lower 'Īsā AS.

And the particle is immediate. The phrase is *fa-yakūn*, not *thumma yakūn*. The *fa-* marks consequence without interval, where *thumma* would mark sequence with one. Command and result are not separated by a process. That is worth carrying because the same instantaneity is read at Mk 1:41 in Part IV, where the conditional is cashed in two words and the restoration carries Mark's own *euthys*.

One further tie the corpus makes and this commentary uses at II.8. The Spirit is said to be *min amri rabbī*, from the *amr* of my Lord (Q 17:85), and the *amr* is said to be *kun*: *innamā amruhu idhā arāda shay'an an yaqūla lahu kun fa-yakūn* (Q 36:82). Two verses, one term between them. Whatever else the corpus withholds about the Spirit, and Q 17:85 withholds a great deal in the same breath, it places it on the command-side rather than on the made-side, and the command is the utterance.

Where this stops. The clustering is a distributional fact and the two denial-plus-mechanism verses are a grammatical one, and both are checkable by anyone with a concordance. What neither establishes is anything about rank. Q 3:59 makes the mechanism common to 'Īsā AS and Adam AS, and Q 15:29 and Q 32:9 make the second designation common to the human being as such, so a mechanism shared by every created thing distinguishes nothing within the class of created things. The fence of II.6 holds unchanged: the shared layer establishes layer-structure and no

rank, and the differentia at Q 4:171 remains where the text puts it, in *alqāhā*, the mode of the casting.

II.6 · The Layer Split, and the Grammar of the Crucifixion Verse

The corpus splits the human figure by its own word-discipline, and the split is what governs the passion narrative.

What perishes is named with one word: *kullu man 'alayhā fān* (Q 55:26) and *kullu shay'in hālikun illā wajhah* (Q 28:88). What remains is named with another: *wa-yabqā wajhu rabbika dhū al-jalāli wa-l-ikrām* (Q 55:27). The face is never once placed under the death-law and the self is never once placed in the remainder.

And the death-law's quantifier is bounded by a separate declaration in negation-grammar. *Kullu nafsin dhā'iqatu al-mawt* (Q 3:185, Q 21:35, Q 29:57) ranges over created selves, because the Uncreated is separately declared deathless: *wa-tawakkal 'alā al-Ḥayy alladhī lā yamūt* (Q 25:58), with *al-Ḥayy al-Qayyūm, lā ta'khduhu sinatun wa-lā nawm* (Q 2:255). The exception is stated on its own warrant, in its own verse, before any inference arrives.

One inference is worth refusing explicitly, because a reader who has followed the corpus's own attribution of a *nafs* to the divine, at Q 3:28, Q 5:116, Q 6:54, and Q 20:41, will construct it. The syllogism runs: the death-clause carries no *illā*, the divine *nafs* is attested, therefore the divine *nafs* is under the clause. It does not close. An unrestricted quantifier in one verse is not the only way a corpus can mark a boundary, and Q 25:58 marks this one directly rather than by exception: the Living who does not die, in negation-grammar, in its own verse. And the word-discipline runs the other way as well, since what remains at Q 55:27 and Q 28:88 is named *wajh* and never *nafs*, and what perishes is never named *wajh*. The corpus does not owe an exception clause in one place for something it declares outright in another.

Now the crucifixion verse, read as it is written.

> **And for their saying, we killed the Messiah, 'Īsā son of Maryam, the messenger of Allah ﷺ. They did not kill him and they did not crucify him, but it was made to resemble so for them. Those who differ about it are in doubt of it; they have no knowledge of it, only the following of conjecture. They did not kill him with certainty.** > > *Wa-qawlihim innā qatalnā al-Masīḥa 'Īsā bna Maryama rasūla Allāhi, wa-mā qatalūhu wa-mā ṣalabūhu wa-lākin shubbiḥa lahum. Wa-inna alladhīna khtalafū fīhi la-fī shakkin minhu, mā lahum bihi min 'ilmin illā ittibā'a al-ẓann, wa-mā qatalūhu yaqīnā.* · Q 4:157

The subject throughout is *they*. The verse denies their accomplishment and their knowledge, and it states its own ground immediately: they have no knowledge of it, only the following of conjecture. It is a verse about a claim to know, made by people the verse says were operating on supposition.

Then the agent changes and the taking is affirmed. *Innī mutawaffika wa-rāfi'uka ilayya* (Q 3:55), the agent Allah ﷻ. *Fa-lammā tawaffaytanī kunta anta al-raqība 'alayhim* (Q 5:117), in his own mouth. And *yawma amūtu* (Q 19:33), also his own. The corpus never denies a death-event. It denies their agency in it and their certainty about it, and assigns the taking to the Source.

Shubbiha lahum carries the rest. The root is the root of *mutashābihāt* at Q 3:7, resemblance. A resemblance-object was presented to their sight, which requires no substitute body. It requires that their instrument reached the manifest layer while the event ran at a layer their sight did not reach. And the corpus states that stratification of the manifest and the hidden directly: *huwa al-awwalu wa-l-ākhiru wa-l-zāhiru wa-l-bāṭinu wa-huwa bi-kulli shay'in 'alīm* (Q 57:3).

One fence closes this and it is the corpus's own. The surviving layer is universal, not an exemption. *Min rūḥi* is said of Adam AS and of the human generally, so a layer untouched by the death of the perishing one establishes layer-structure and nothing about rank. Even the raising is stated in the universal return-vocabulary: *rafa'ahu Allāhu ilayh*, the same direction-token as *innā lillāhi wa-innā ilayhi rāji'un* (Q 2:156) and *wa-ilayhi yurja'u al-amru kulluh* (Q 11:123).

II.7 · What the Corpus Supplies That the Gospel Lacks

The reader notices immediately that Mark begins in the wrong place, and that his own book begins where Mark does not.

Mark has no infancy narrative. No annunciation, no conception, no birth, no genealogy, no childhood. He opens in the wilderness and by verse nine the man is in the water.

The Quran supplies exactly the missing front end, in detail. The annunciation to Zakariyyā AS and the annunciation to Maryam AS run as adjacent panels in Surah Maryam and again in Surah Āl 'Imrān. The conception with the mother's own protest preserved. The withdrawal to a distant place, the palm trunk, the stream, the shaking of the dates, the vow of silence, the return to her people carrying the child, their accusation, her gesture toward the infant, and the cradle speech. Q 19:16-33 is a continuous narrative of everything Mark omits.

So the two texts are complementary at the front end rather than contradictory. And the reader, holding Q 19, reads Mark 1 as a text that begins its account at the Jordan and says nothing about what came before, which is exactly what Mark's own silence is.

The corpus also supplies four other things Mark does not carry: the Injīl as a book given rather than composed (Q 3:48, Q 5:46), the table from heaven (Q 5:112-115), the raising (Q 3:55, Q 4:158), and the sign of the Hour (Q 43:61).

And there is one detail where Mark and the Quran agree against the other three Gospels. Mark alone calls him *ho huioṣ tēs Marias*, the son of Mary, with no father named, at Mk 6:3. The

reading is not unanimous: a minority stream, P45 among the witnesses, has the son of the carpenter and of Mary, which is the harmonising direction and is what the critical editions therefore decline. The variant is noted here on the same grounds the longer ending is noted at V.1. Matthew changes it to the carpenter's son. The Quran names him invariably and in every single occurrence *'Isā bnu Maryam*, son of Mary. On the naming convention, the earliest Gospel and the Quran use the same form, and the two later Gospels do not.

II.8 · The Word Before the Word

One more thing the reader holds: the knowledge that the doctrine of the divine Word is not the property of either community.

Memphite Ptah conceives in the heart and commands with the tongue by the early Old Kingdom, with the personified powers of utterance and perception beside him. Sumerian and Akkadian cosmology carry the creative command. Vedic speech is personified and speaks in the first person at Rig Veda 10.125, and the Upanishads state that speech is the absolute. The Avestan sacred formula is a spoken thing with cosmological force. Genesis 1 runs ten creative speech-acts and Psalm 33:6 compresses the whole to word and breath. The Aramaic Targums render the operative divine presence as the Memra, which creates, speaks, walks, covenants, judges, and saves, and which is functionally identified with the Name while remaining grammatically distinct. Heraclitus makes the *logos* cosmological. Wisdom is personified as preexistent and instrumental in three separate books. Philo synthesises the whole into a first-begotten, an image of God, and that through whom all things came to be, decades before any Christian text exists.

Two of those nodes matter for this reading and the rest are context.

The Memra matters because it is Aramaic and not Greek, Jewish and not Christian, liturgical and contemporary, and because it carries the with-and-as structure exactly: distinct in grammar and identified in function. Whatever John 1:1 states, it was not a Christian invention when it was stated, and it was available in a Semitic language in synagogue liturgy.

And beneath the Memra runs a root chain. The Aramaic term is a noun from the root for saying. Genesis 1's ten instances of *and God said* are the same Semitic root. And the Arabic reflex of that root is *amr*, command, which the Quran deploys at precisely the creative-utterance position: *innamā amrunā li-shay'in idhā aradnāhu an naqūla lahu kun fa-yakūn* (Q 16:40). One triliteral root, three corpora, one syntactic position.

And the corpus closes the chain on itself. Q 17:85 ties the Spirit-term to the same root by preposition, the Spirit is *min amri rabbī*, from the *amr* of my Lord; and Q 36:82 says what the *amr* is, *innamā amruhu idhā arāda shay'an an yaqūla lahu kun fa-yakūn*. Spirit from command, command as utterance. The root that carries the Word in Genesis and in the Targums is the root the

corpus uses for its own creative command, and it is also the root by which it locates the Spirit. That is an internal link rather than a comparative one, and it is set out with the rest of the *kun* material at II.5a.

This is recorded as convergence and never as descent. Independent strata arriving at one architecture is evidence about the architecture; it is not a transmission claim, and none is made.

II.9 · Bayān: The Faculty, and Why It Is a Fourth Thing

The held distinction that runs through all of the above is sterile until something is done with it, and the corpus says what.

Return to the four verses that open Surah ar-Raḥmān. Source, inscription, substrate, faculty. Three of those are coplanar in the sense that matters: a source, a form, and a receiver do not by themselves constitute a reading. Something must perform the distinguishing, and the fourth verse names it.

Bayān is from the root of the preposition *bayna*, between. It is the faculty of between-making: of holding two things apart and registering the distinction as a distinction. And the Word is named by the same operation. *Kitāb mubīn*, the distinguishing Book, at Q 12:1, Q 26:2, Q 27:1, Q 28:2, Q 43:2, Q 44:2. And *al-Furqān*, from the root meaning to split apart, which is the name given to the whole revelation at Q 25:1 and to a prophet's equipment at Q 2:53 and to a decisive day at Q 8:41.

So what passes from the articulate register to the created vessel at Q 55:4 is not content. It is the operation itself. The bifurcation between the Ground and the Word actuates downstream as the receiver's own capacity to perform the very holding-apart that constitutes it. Not a merger and not a collapse, but instantiation: the structure reproduces itself in the receiver as the receiver's own faculty.

The corpus keeps the distinction lexically, which is the check. Vocalisation is predicated of birds at Q 27:16, *'ullimnā mantiqa al-ṭayr*, and of skins and of all things at Q 41:21, *aṭṭaqanā Allāhu alladhī aṭṭaqa kulla shay'*. Everything speaks. Only the human distinguishes.

And the gift is universal: *al-insān*, the human as such, not one human and not a class. Which is also the standing offer at Q 8:29: *in tattaqū llāha yaj'al lakum furqānan*, if you guard yourselves He will make for you a criterion, addressed in the plural to the ordinary and conditional on nothing but the guarding.

Box 2 | The Four-Verse Architecture

The corpus states its whole apparatus in four verses, and this commentary is one performance of the operation the third verse commands.

The Word given. Q 55:2, before the receiver exists.

The faculty given. Q 55:4, the between-making operation, to the human as such.

The test issued. Q 4:82, *aḥadā yataḍabbarūna al-Qur'ān*, *wa-law kāna min 'indi ḡhayri Allāhi la-wajadū fīhi ikhtilāfan kathīrā*. Trace it through: had it been from other than Allah ﷻ they would have found much discrepancy. The corpus supplies its own defeater and names the register, internal coherence, and the verb means to follow a thing to its terminus.

The completion deferred. Q 75:19, the explication retained upstream and placed after the recitation, so that the test is real and its answer is not pre-supplied.

Deposit, instrument, challenge, deferral.

II.10 · Aḥad and Wāḥid: Two Words for One

A last register-fact, because it governs both the cosmic passages of Mark and the whole question of counting.

Surah aṣ-Ṣāffāt opens on an oath sworn by ranking itself, *wa-l-ṣāffāti ṣaffā* (Q 37:1), and lands at *inna ilāhakum la-wāḥid* (Q 37:4). It runs the lineage polemic and closes it at Q 37:158 with the sharpest available word, *wa-ja'alū baynahu wa-bayna al-jinnati nasabā*, they made between Him and the jinn a kinship. And then the ranked ones speak for themselves: *wa-mā minnā illā lahu maqāmun ma'lūm*, *wa-innā la-naḥnu al-ṣāffūn*, *wa-innā la-naḥnu al-musabbihūn* (Q 37:164-166). There is none of us but has a known station.

One ordered line, every position holding a determinate known station, and kinship a relation between stations while the Source holds none.

Surah al-Ikhlāṣ states the negative of the same geometry, and it denies exactly three rank-relations: no successor, no predecessor, no peer, the last of these using a word for rank-equality. All three are positions in an ordered line.

And the two surahs use two different words for one. Ṣāffāt says *wāḥid*, one-of-a-count, spoken from inside the ranked line where counting is the native operation. Ikhlāṣ says *aḥad*, one-without-a-second, the word that refuses the count, and it is the word used in negative constructions for not-a-single-one. Two registers, two words, and the choice tracks the register exactly.

That is the same move as the prohibition on the numeral at Q 4:171. The corpus is not hostile to threeness as a structure; it supplies three names in one breath. It is hostile to the operation of counting applied where counting does not belong, and it marks the boundary with its own vocabulary for one.

PART III · WHY MARK

Before the commentary itself, the plain report on the text the reader has opened.

Mark is the earliest of the four, roughly 66 to 70, and it opens with nothing. No genealogy, no infancy, no prologue. By verse nine the man is in the water. Whatever the other three do to set a frame before anything happens, Mark simply starts.

The prose is paratactic to the point of bluntness, *and* upon *and*, with *immediately* roughly forty times. Much of it is in the historic present, past events narrated in present tense about a hundred and fifty times, which nearly every translation flattens into the past. In Greek it reads like someone telling you what happened while it is happening.

The Greek is rough, and the roughness is demonstrably original because the two Gospels that copy him tidy it. Three columns side by side and two of them are smoothing the third.

And what he leaves in is the receipt. At Nazareth he *could* do no mighty work there (Mk 6:5), which Matthew softens to *did not*. He is the carpenter, the son of Mary, with no father named (Mk 6:3). His own family come to seize him because they think he is out of his mind (Mk 3:21). The disciples are thick for sixteen chapters and never stop being thick. Peter is called Satan. Nobody in the book comes off well, including the narrator's own side, and there is no visible effort to manage that.

Then it ends at Mk 16:8 in the oldest witnesses. The women flee the tomb and say nothing to anyone, for they were afraid. The book ends on a conjunction.

That roughness is the same property the Quranic fault-record has, one register over. A composed hagiography does not include *he frowned and turned away* addressed to its own founder in the third person, and a composed gospel does not include a family who think the subject is mad and an ending that stops mid-breath. Both texts authenticate by what they declined to remove, and the reader posited here recognises the property immediately, because his own book taught it to him.

One further fact makes Mark the right text for this reading. Mark has no doctrine of the Word. None. No *logos*, no preexistence, no with-God clause. The entire apparatus of the Johannine prologue is absent from the earliest Gospel, which is exactly what the lineage of II.8 predicts if that prologue is a later editorial synthesis drawing on an inheritance already available in Alexandria and in the synagogue. The stratification shows up as an absence in the oldest layer.

Which is why the primitive layer's own register is the one closest to the Quranic reading. *Why do you call me good? No one is good but God alone* (Mk 10:18), a predicate deflected rather than accepted, which is the corpus's own *lā aqūlu lakum 'indī khazā'inu Allāh* (Q 6:50). *Not even the Son* (Mk 13:32), which is

lā yujallihā li-waqtihā illā huw (Q 7:187). Repeated commands to say nothing. A text with no interest in establishing what four centuries of councils would establish from it.

Mark reads clean because there is almost no overlay to strip.

One distinction guards this choice from a familiar objection. The critique of Hellenisation, that the message of a Galilean teacher was recast in the categories of Greek metaphysics, lands squarely on the settlement and on the doctrinal vocabulary that grew toward it, the essence-language, the person-count, the equational creed. It does not land on Mark. His Greek is a carrier and nothing more: paratactic, Semitic under the surface, and four times it stops translating altogether and keeps the Aramaic in the prophet's mouth, *talitha kum, ephphatha, Abba, Elōi Elōi lema sabachthani*, each glossed for the Greek reader as a foreign thing preserved. A text being Hellenised does not keep the source language at the moments of address and translate it in an aside. Mark's Greek is wrapping paper around an Aramaic voice; the settlement's Greek is replacement contents. The critique that condemns the second is the very reason this commentary trusts the first. And the four preserved addresses will be counted again in Part V, because they turn out to fall on a pattern.

Box | Part III Summary

Mark is earliest and least edited. Roughly 66 to 70, no genealogy, no infancy, no prologue.

The roughness is demonstrably original. The two Gospels that copy him tidy it, and you can watch the tidying in parallel columns.

What he left in is the receipt. A family who thought him mad, a *could not* where a later hand wrote *did not*, disciples who never understand, and an ending that stops on a conjunction.

He has no doctrine of the Word at all. The Johannine prologue's whole apparatus is absent from the earliest Gospel.

Which puts his own register closest to the Quranic one: predicates deflected, the hour reserved, and repeated commands to say nothing.

PART IV · THE GOSPEL ENTIRE

What follows is the whole of Mark, in ten movements, every passage in its place. The discipline is the one announced in the prologue: the Gospel is quoted, then read from the fixed position, then tested as a structure. Corpus verses are given in translation with the Arabic where the Arabic itself is the evidence. Threads that run the length of the book, a preposition, a verb, a gesture, are counted aloud as they arrive, and the counts are gathered in Part V. Where the reading closes, it closes quietly. Where it cannot, the missing piece is named in one sentence and the walk continues.

One practical note. Mark's text is quoted from the earliest recoverable form, and where the manuscripts divide at a point that matters for this reading, the division itself is reported, because the copyists' hands are part of the evidence.

The Voice and the Wilderness · Mark 1:1-13

Thirteen verses, and the whole book in miniature: a title, a forerunner, a baptism, a voice, and a wilderness. Mark has no genealogy and no infancy because his beginning is not a birth. It is an announcement arriving on a man already grown, which is the corpus's own shape for every prophet it sends.

Box | What to Watch

The title line carries *euangelion* and *Christos*, the announcement and the anointed, which are the corpus's *bushrā* and *al-Masīḥ*.

The forerunner performs the two-place office of Q 3:39: an attester pointing away from himself, measuring the distance by a sandal-thong.

The voice at the water quotes the second Psalm and stops one clause before *today I have begotten you*.

The wilderness places the appointed trial where Q 22:52 places it, as a stage of the office rather than a hazard to it.

The Title Line · Mark 1:1

> The beginning of the gospel of Jesus Christ.

Commentary based on Quran

Archē tou euangelīou Iēsou Christou. Four words in Greek, and two of them are load-bearing.

Euangelion, good news, is not a genre here; the book-name came later. It is the content: a glad announcement. The corpus's word is *bushrā*, and its verb *yubashshiru* is the very verb of the annunciations, Allah ﷻ gives you glad tidings of Yahyā at Q 3:39, gives you glad tidings of a word from Him at Q 3:45. The two texts open the same account with the same speech-act: not a biography beginning, but good news announced.

And *Christou* is a title, not a surname: the anointed, *al-Masīḥ*, which the corpus confers eleven times and never once withdraws. So the first line of the earliest Gospel says, in its own Greek, exactly what the corpus's annunciation says in its Arabic: here begins the glad announcement concerning the Messiah.

A textual matter belongs here because it sits in the very first verse. Many manuscripts continue *huiou theou*, son of God, and the earliest hand of Codex Sinaiticus does not. The words were supplied by a corrector. Whether the phrase fell out by a copyist's slip or was added by a copyist's piety cannot be settled from the outside, and this commentary does not need to settle it. What can be said is narrow and checkable: the one Gospel whose opening line carries the phrase insecurely is the earliest one, and the direction of every later scribal instinct we can watch in this book

runs toward adding reverence, not subtracting it. The title line that is certain is the one this reading needs: the beginning of the good news of the Messiah.

The Forerunner · Mark 1:2-8

> As it is written in Isaiah the prophet: Behold, I send my messenger before your face, who will prepare your way; the voice of one crying in the wilderness, Prepare the way of the Lord, make his paths straight. John appeared, baptizing in the wilderness and proclaiming a baptism of repentance for the forgiveness of sins. And there went out to him all the country of Judea and all Jerusalem, and they were baptized by him in the river Jordan, confessing their sins. Now John was clothed with camel's hair and wore a leather belt around his waist and ate locusts and wild honey. And he preached, saying: After me comes he who is mightier than I, the strap of whose sandals I am not worthy to stoop down and untie. I have baptized you with water, but he will baptize you with the Holy Spirit.

Commentary based on Quran

Mark opens with a citation and gets the label rough: the composite is Malachi and Isaiah welded together, and he files the whole weld under Isaiah. Matthew and Luke, copying him, quietly keep only the Isaiah half so the label becomes true. The seam is original and the smoothing is watchable, the first exhibit of the pattern Part III promised: this text preserves its own roughness, and the roughness is the receipt.

But the content of the weld is the structure the reader already holds from Q 3:39. A messenger sent *before the face*, preparing the way of one who comes after: that is confirmation as a two-place office, an attester and an attested, *muṣaddiqan bi-kalimatīn min Allāh*, confirming a word from Allah ﷻ. Mark's first scene after the title is the corpus's Yahyā AS doing the corpus's Yahyā-work: pointing away from himself at the one he exists to announce. And the pointing is total. *After me comes he who is mightier than I: erchetai ho ischyroteros mou opisō mou*. Mark the word *ischyroteros*, mightier, the comparative of strength, because this book is going to conduct an argument in that root, and this is its first occurrence. The count begins here: strength, one.

Then the sandal. *The strap of whose sandals I am not worthy to stoop down and untie*. Every tradition that received this figure kept this image; it is one of the very few sayings that crossed into every stream whole. And the corpus's tradition kept it in the mouth of its own Prophet ﷺ in the transmitted literature concerning the two of them, the honouring of the one who comes by the one who announces. The image survives because it is doing exact work: untying the sandal-thong is the task of the lowest servant of the house, and the announcer declares himself below it. Confirmation is not rivalry. The attester's greatness is measured by how low he places himself before the attested, and Q 3:39 had already given the announcer his own honours in the same breath as his office, *sayyidan wa-ḥaṣūran wa-nabiyyan*, a master,

restrained, a prophet, so the lowness is not lack. It is the office performed.

And the last line of the forerunner's speech hands the whole scene upward. *I have baptized you with water, but he will baptize you with the Holy Spirit.* The corpus says of 'Īsā AS, three times, that he was strengthened *bi-rūḥi al-quḍus*, with the Holy Spirit, Q 2:87, Q 2:253, Q 5:110. The forerunner's sentence and the corpus's sentence draw the same line in the same place: water is what a man can administer; the Spirit is administered from above. John's own grammar keeps him on the near side of that line, and the corpus keeps the Spirit as the strengthening *given to* the Messiah, not a possession held. Both texts route the higher baptism through the same upward door.

The Baptism and the Voice · Mark 1:9-11

> In those days Jesus came from Nazareth of Galilee and was baptized by John in the Jordan. And immediately, coming up out of the water, he saw the heavens being torn open and the Spirit descending on him like a dove. And a voice came from heaven: You are my beloved Son; with you I am well pleased.

Commentary based on Quran

Three verses, and each carries something the later tradition would have written differently if it could have.

First, the fact itself: he is baptized by John, in a baptism Mark has just called a baptism of repentance for the forgiveness of sins. Matthew, copying, inserts an objection from John and a justification from Jesus before allowing it; Mark has no embarrassment to manage and manages none. From the fixed position this is not a difficulty at all. The corpus's clean file (Part I) is a file of *recorded fault*, and there is none here either: Mark narrates no confession from him, only the entering of the water everyone else entered. What the scene does is place the prophet inside the practice of the community he is sent to, under the hand of the attester, and the corpus's picture of the 'abd who does not disdain (Q 4:172) stands closer to this scene than the later picture that needed the objection inserted.

Second, the tearing. Mark says the heavens were *torn open*, *schizomenous*, a violent word; Matthew and Luke soften it to *opened*, a door-word. Mark chose the tearing and will use its root exactly once more, at the far end of the book, when the veil of the sanctuary is *torn*, *eschisthē*, from top to bottom (Mk 15:38). Two tearings, one at the water and one at the death, both from the upper side downward, frame the entire Gospel: the barrier is breached from above at the beginning and at the end, and never by the man from below. That is the direction this whole commentary will keep finding, and Mark built it into his structure before his story had properly begun. The corpus states the same direction as law: *lā tufattaḥu lahum abwābu al-samā'* (Q 7:40) is its word over those for whom the doors do not open, and the opening of what is above is His act, from His side, in every verse that mentions it.

Third, the voice, and here the earliest Gospel performs the most precise refusal in its opening chapter. *You are my beloved Son; with you I am well pleased.* The first clause is the second Psalm: *You are my son*, Psalm 2:7, the enthronement formula of the Davidic king, recited over a man at his installation. Every hearer who knew the Psalter knew the next clause: *today I have begotten you.* Mark's voice does not say it. The quotation stops at sonship-as-office and declines sonship-as-generation, at the one moment in the book where heaven itself is speaking and could have said anything. The Western text of Luke's parallel famously completes the Psalm, *today I have begotten you*, which shows both that the continuation was available and that a scribal hand willing to write it existed. Mark's hand did not write it. The fence of Q 19:35, *it was not for Allah ٱللّٰه to take to Himself any offspring*, and the mechanism of Q 3:47, *kun fa-yakūn*, arrive six centuries later at exactly the line where the earliest Gospel had already stopped its quotation. The construction the corpus addresses, Mark never carried.

And the clause it does carry is the one the corpus can read without adjustment. *Agapētos*, beloved, the Septuagint's word for Isaac in Genesis 22, the one and cherished. *With you I am well pleased*, *eudokēsa*, the verb of favour. The corpus's account of the same figure runs on the same two notes: *wajīhan fī al-dunyā wa-l-ākhirah*, eminent in this world and the next, *wa-min al-muqarrabīn*, and of those brought near (Q 3:45). Favour conferred, nearness granted, an office announced from above onto a servant below. Set the two opening declarations side by side. Mark: the first words spoken *over* him in this Gospel are heaven's, naming him beloved and favoured. The corpus: the first words spoken *by* him in that book are his own, from the cradle, *innī 'abdu Allāh*, I am the servant of Allah ٱللّٰه (Q 19:30). The voice from above says *chosen*; the voice from below says *servant*; and Part I has already shown that these are the two halves of the one guarded position. Neither text lets the other half go missing. Mark's heaven confers; the corpus's cradle receives; the relation is identical, read from its two ends.

The Wilderness · Mark 1:12-13

> And immediately the Spirit drove him out into the wilderness. And he was in the wilderness forty days, being tempted by Satan. And he was with the wild beasts, and the angels were ministering to him.

Commentary based on Quran

Two verses where Matthew and Luke each spend a scene, and Mark's compression is itself the reading.

The Spirit drove him out: ekballei, the same verb Mark will use for the casting out of unclean spirits a few verses later. The prophet does not stride into the wilderness; he is propelled, by the Spirit, under an authority that moves him before he has performed a single work. The corpus's grammar for its prophets is the same grammar: sent, commanded, carried, *wa-mā natanazzalu illā bi-amri rabbik* (Q 19:64), and none descends except by the

command of your Lord. Agency in both books runs downhill from above, and Mark's verb choice puts even the Messiah's first movement inside it.

Forty days, tempted by Satan. Forty is Mūsā AS on the mountain, *arba'ina laylatan*, forty nights (Q 7:142), the proving-number of the earlier scripture carried forward. And the tempter is the corpus's *Shaytān* under his own name, the enemy declared 'aduwwun *mubīn*, an open adversary, in the corpus's first story about the first man. Mark gives the temptation no content, no dialogue, no three questions; that is Matthew's and Luke's expansion. In the earliest layer there is only the fact: the announced one is placed under trial by the adversary, at the outset, before any public work. The corpus states that placement as a universal law of the office: *And We did not send before you any messenger or prophet except that when he recited, Satan cast into his recitation* (Q 22:52), with the next clause giving the outcome, *fa-yansakhu Allāhu mā yulqī al-shaytān*, then Allah ﷻ abolishes what Satan casts. Trial by the adversary is not a hazard the mission runs into. It is a stage the mission is appointed to pass through, and the abolishing is His.

And he was with the wild beasts, and the angels were ministering to him. Mark alone has the beasts, and the line has puzzled readers into allegory. Read plainly it is a location-claim and a protection-claim: the man is placed where creation is unsubdued, and he is unharmed, and the service he receives there is angelic, *diēkonoun autō*, they were serving him. The corpus's wilderness has the same furniture arranged the same way: the adversary given his respite, *matā'un ilā hīn*, an enjoyment for a time (Q 2:36), the servant protected, and the angels as ministers of the command, *bal 'ibādun mukramūn*, honoured servants who precede Him not in speech and act by His command (Q 21:26-27). Note who serves whom, because Mark will pick the verb up again: here the angels serve him; at Mk 10:45 he will say the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve. The ministry he receives in the wilderness he will spend the book handing on downward, and the corpus's Messiah, who *does not disdain to be a servant*, is the same figure drawn from the other side.

Thirteen verses in, and the architecture of the whole is already standing: announcement, attestation, water, the torn heaven, the guarded sonship-without-begetting, the driven servant, the appointed trial, the ministering angels. Nothing in it required adjustment from the fixed position, and one thing in it, the dropped clause of the Psalm, turned out to be the corpus's fence built six centuries early.

Structural Commentary · The Movement Entire

What stands. One office with two seats. A forerunner who measures himself by a sandal strap, and one who comes after him, ranked in the forerunner's own mouth before the narrative has moved.

What moves. The descent. The heavens are torn, the Spirit comes down onto a located point, and the same Spirit immediately drives

the one it landed on into the wilderness. A real traversal with a named landing-site and a named cost.

How they bind. The ordering. *Opisō mou*, after me, is what makes the first figure an attester rather than a rival and the second a term rather than a return, and it is the *taṣḍīq* relation of Q 3:39 stated from the other side.

The three stand apart and compose. Collapse the two seats and Herod's sentence in chapter six becomes a datum instead of a confusion. Collapse the descent and the voice has no addressee. Collapse the ordering and nothing distinguishes an attestation from two competing claims. ∟ GOL on the opening frame.

Galilee · Mark 1:14-3:6

The public work opens, and within two chapters every major instrument of the book is on the table: the proclamation, the calling, the authority, the silencing, the healing in the passive voice, the forgiveness dispute, the table-fellowship scandal, the bridegroom's taking, the appointed day, and the first plot. Mark builds fast. The reading walks each piece in order.

Box | What to Watch

The first public sentence is corpus-grammar in all four clauses: appointed term filled, arrival announced, turn, believe.

The healings run in the passive. *Be cleansed* and *the hand was restored*: the agent of the cure is left above the sentence.

The scribes object in the Quran's own words, *who can forgive sins but God alone*, and the scene never leaves their doctrine.

The bridegroom is taken away, in the passive, six centuries before *rafa'ahu Allāhu ilayh* names the hand.

The Proclamation · Mark 1:14-15

> Now after John was arrested, Jesus came into Galilee, proclaiming the gospel of God, and saying: The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand; repent and believe in the gospel.

Commentary based on Quran

The forerunner is handed over, *paradothēnai*, the verb that will later carry the Messiah himself, and only then does the public work begin. The office of confirmation passes at the attester's arrest: two seats, one relay, exactly the structure Q 3:39 set.

The first public sentence has four clauses and every one of them is corpus-grammar. *The time is fulfilled*: *peplērōtai ho kairos*, a perfect passive, the appointed term has been filled, and the corpus's word for that structure is *ajal musammā*, a term appointed, which nothing hastens and nothing delays, *fa-idhā jā'a ajaluhum lā yasta'khirūna sā'atan wa-lā yastaqdimūn* (Q 7:34). *The kingdom of God is at hand*: *ēngiken*, has drawn near, and the corpus opens one of its surahs on the same announcement in the same aspect, *atā amru Allāhi fa-lā tasta'jilūh*, the command of

Allah ﷻ has come, so do not seek to hasten it (Q 16:1), arrival announced, haste forbidden. *Repent: metanoëite*, turn, the corpus's *tūbū ilā Allāhi jamī'an* (Q 24:31). *And believe in the good news: āminū and bushrā* in one clause. A Muslim reader can recite Mk 1:15 without adjusting a single term. It is the sentence every messenger in the corpus is sent to say.

The Four Called • Mark 1:16-20

> Passing alongside the Sea of Galilee, he saw Simon and Andrew the brother of Simon casting a net in the sea, for they were fishermen. And Jesus said to them: Follow me, and I will make you become fishers of men. And immediately they left their nets and followed him. And going on a little farther, he saw James the son of Zebedee and John his brother, who were in their boat mending the nets. And immediately he called them, and they left their father Zebedee in the boat with the hired servants and followed him.

Commentary based on Quran

The call is two words and the response is one motion. Mark's *euthys*, immediately, does its first real work here: no deliberation is narrated, no terms are negotiated. The corpus commands exactly this shape of response and gives its reason: *istajībū lillāhi wa-li-l-rasūli idhā da'ākum limā yuhyīkum*, respond to Allah ﷻ and to the messenger when he calls you to what gives you life (Q 8:24). The call is to life; delay is the only loss.

And the promise is worded with a care worth keeping. *I will make you become fishers of men: poiēsō hymas genesthai*. Not *you will be*, but *I will make you become*, the transformation is granted, not achieved, and the granting is the caller's. That is the corpus's *rabbāniyyūn* structure at Q 3:79: the true teacher says *be devoted servants of the Lord, kūnū rabbāniyyīn*, by what you have been taught, the becoming commanded from above and enabled by what was given. Four working men leave nets, boat, father, and hire, and the leaving is the first enacted commentary on a sentence the rich man will fail at nine chapters later. Mark plants both ends of that comparison himself; the reading only has to notice that he did.

A Sabbath in Capernaum • Mark 1:21-28

> And they went into Capernaum, and immediately on the Sabbath he entered the synagogue and was teaching. And they were astonished at his teaching, for he taught them as one who had authority, and not as the scribes. And immediately there was in their synagogue a man with an unclean spirit. And he cried out: What have you to do with us, Jesus of Nazareth? Have you come to destroy us? I know who you are, the Holy One of God. But Jesus rebuked him, saying: Be silent, and come out of him. And the unclean spirit, convulsing him and crying out with a loud voice, came out of him. And they were all amazed, so that they questioned among themselves, saying: What is this? A new teaching with authority. He commands even the unclean spirits,

and they obey him. And at once his fame spread everywhere throughout all the surrounding region of Galilee.

Commentary based on Quran

Two things happen in this synagogue and the second interprets the first.

The first is the teaching *as one who had authority, and not as the scribes: hōs exousian echōn*. The scribes taught by chain of citation, authority borrowed sideways from precedent. He teaches as one *holding* authority, and the word is *exousia*, which throughout this Gospel means conferred warrant, authority held because given. The crowd hears the difference before they can name it. The corpus names it: *wa-mā yanṭiqu 'an al-hawā, in huwa illā wahyun yūhā*, he does not speak from desire; it is only a revelation revealed (Q 53:3-4). Speech from the upstream source needs no sideways chain.

The second is the spirit, and here Mark records something stranger and more precise than an exorcism. The unclean spirit *knows. I know who you are, the Holy One of God*. The identification is true, early, and supernatural, and the response is not gratitude for the testimony. It is a muzzle: *phimōthēti*, be silenced, the word for gagging an animal. Verse 34 will generalise it: *he would not permit the demons to speak, because they knew him*. Knowledge from that register is real and its testimony is refused.

The corpus has the doctrine for exactly this, stated about its own revelation: *wa-mā tanazzalat bihi al-shayāṭīn, wa-mā yanbaghī lahum wa-mā yastaṭī'ūn, innahum 'anī al-sam'ī la-mā' zūlūn*, the satans did not bring it down; it is not fitting for them, nor are they able; they are barred from the hearing (Q 26:210-212). The spirit-register is excluded from the transmission channel as a matter of standing law, not because its information is false but because its testimony is unauthorised. Mark's Messiah enforces in a synagogue the same exclusion the corpus states as cosmology, and the silencing thread that will run the whole first half of this Gospel begins here, on a witness whose statement was *correct*. Hold that fact. It is the key to every silencing that follows: what is being managed is not truth but authorisation, and the count of the silencings starts now: one.

The Evening at the Door • Mark 1:29-34

> And immediately he left the synagogue and entered the house of Simon and Andrew, with James and John. Now Simon's mother-in-law lay ill with a fever, and immediately they told him about her. And he came and took her by the hand and lifted her up, and the fever left her, and she began to serve them. That evening at sundown they brought to him all who were sick or oppressed by demons. And the whole city was gathered together at the door. And he healed many who were sick with various diseases, and cast out many demons. And he would not permit the demons to speak, because they knew him.

Commentary based on Quran

The first healing in the book is domestic, unnamed in request, and wordless in method: a hand taken, a lifting, *ēgeiren autēn*, the raising verb that will close the Gospel at the tomb. And her first act on being raised is *diēkonei autois*, she began to serve them. Mark has now used the serving verb twice in one chapter, of the angels in the wilderness and of a woman in a kitchen, and both times of ministry offered to him. The book is quietly stockpiling the verb for the day its subject inverts it: *the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve* (Mk 10:45). Every early instance of receiving service is capital the later sentence will spend.

Then the door, the whole city, the many healed. And the closing clause repeats the law of the synagogue in general form: *he would not permit the demons to speak, because they knew him*. Silencing, two, and now explicitly grounded: *because they knew*. True knowledge, barred testimony, Q 26:212's *ma'zūlūn* enforced at a doorway in Capernaum.

Before Dawn, Alone · Mark 1:35-39

> And rising very early in the morning, while it was still dark, he departed and went out to a desolate place, and there he prayed. And Simon and those who were with him hunted for him, and they found him and said to him: Everyone is looking for you. And he said to them: Let us go on to the next towns, that I may preach there also, for that is why I came out. And he went throughout all Galilee, preaching in their synagogues and casting out demons.

Commentary based on Quran

Three verses that later theology never managed to make comfortable, and this reading does not need to.

He rises in the dark, *ennycha lian*, deep in the night, leaves the house where the whole city had gathered, and goes where no one is, *erēmon topon*, to pray. Alone. The scene has no audience inside the story; Mark asserts it happened where nobody could watch. A man to whom the whole city is queuing withdraws from the queue to stand as a petitioner. The corpus prescribes this exact watch to its own Prophet ﷺ: *qumī al-layla illā qalilā*, rise in the night, except a little (Q 73:2), and *wa-mina al-layli fa-tahajjad bihi nāfilatan laka*, and in part of the night keep vigil with it, as an addition for you (Q 17:79). The night office is the prophetic office's private half, and Mark's Messiah keeps it before his first full day of work is over. What the scene establishes is direction: the one they are all seeking is himself seeking, and his seeking runs upward, unwitnessed, unbrokered. The single voice that Part II found in the grammar of Q 2:186 is here as narrative: no intermediary appears in the desolate place, because between the servant and the Lord there is nothing to appear.

Simon *hunted him down*, *katediōxen*, a pursuit verb with an edge on it, and the report is the report of every manager of a successful man: everyone is looking for you, the crowd is an asset, come back. The answer redirects the whole enterprise in one clause: *let us go elsewhere, that I may preach there also, for that is why I*

came out. *Exēlthon*, I came out: the sent one states his sending, and the purpose is proclamation, not concentration of a following. The corpus states the same office-definition as a bare rule: *wa-mā 'alā al-rasūli illā al-balāgh*, nothing is upon the messenger except the delivery (Q 24:54). The crowd at Capernaum's door is not the mission. The delivery is, and the delivery moves.

The Leper · Mark 1:40-45

> And a leper came to him, imploring him, and kneeling said to him: If you will, you can make me clean. Moved with compassion, he stretched out his hand and touched him and said to him: I will; be clean. And immediately the leprosy left him, and he was made clean. And Jesus sternly charged him and sent him away at once, and said to him: See that you say nothing to anyone, but go, show yourself to the priest and offer for your cleansing what Moses commanded, for a proof to them. But he went out and began to talk freely about it, and to spread the news, so that Jesus could no longer openly enter a town, but was out in desolate places, and people were coming to him from every quarter.

Commentary based on Quran

The leper's own sentence carries a theology: *ean thelēs dynasai me katharisai*, if you are willing, you are able to make me clean. He does not question the ability. He locates it inside a will, and waits on the will. That is precisely where the corpus locates every prophetic ability: real, and conditional on a permission that sits above the prophet. The corpus's 'Īsā AS says it with this very disease in the list: *wa-ubri'u al-akmaha wa-l-abraṣa bi-idhni Allāh*, and I heal the blind and the leper, by the permission of Allah ﷻ (Q 3:49). The *abraṣ* of the corpus and the *lepros* of Mark are the same sufferer, and the two texts hang the same cure on the same hinge. The leper in Mark, kneeling, has intuited the permission-structure from below; the corpus states it from above; the scene and the verse interlock like a socket and its plug.

Then the answer, and Mark's grammar performs the doctrine. *Thelē*, I am willing. *Katharisthēti*: be cleansed. A passive imperative. Not *I cleanse you*, active, first person, but a command that the cleansing happen, with the agent of the cleansing unnamed, which in the speech of that world is the reverent way of naming the Unnamed. Divine passive, one, and the count that Part V will gather begins here. The compassion is his, *splanchnistheis*, moved in the guts; the touch is his; the willingness is his; and the verb of the cure is written so that the cure itself arrives from the unstated Agent above the sentence. Mark's Greek and Q 3:49's Arabic are two drawings of one circuit.

Structural Commentary · The Leper, Mark 1:40-45

What stands. A sufferer, a disease, and a healer who holds no inventory of cures.

What moves. A willing stated, a touch given, and a cleansing that arrives.

How they bind. The passive imperative. *Be cleansed* names the event and leaves the Agent above the sentence, so the willing belongs to the servant and the cleansing to the One unnamed.

The three stand apart and compose, which is why the reading closes. Collapse the third into the first, and the healer becomes the source of the cure; the text declines that collapse in its own grammar, and Q 3:49 hangs the same circuit on *bi-idhni Allāh*, four times in one verse. ۞ GOL on the leper, the instantaneous lock.

Two more details close the passage. The cleansed man is sent to the priest with the offering *Moses commanded*: the Torah is upheld, not bypassed, *muṣaddiqan limā bayna yadayya mina al-Tawrāt*, confirming what came before me of the Torah, as the corpus's 'Īsā AS says of himself (Q 3:50). And the man is charged to silence, *say nothing to anyone*, silencing three, this time on a beneficiary rather than a spirit, and he disobeys, and the cost is immediate and structural: the healer *can no longer openly enter a town*. Unauthorised proclamation, even grateful, even true, distorts the mission's geometry; the crowds displace the delivery. Mark has now shown the silencing rule enforced on a demon and broken by a healed man, and shown the price of the breach, and the reader begins to understand that the secrecy in this book is not mystification. It is traffic control on testimony, until the appointed hour when the ban will be lifted by the only voice with the authority to lift it.

The Paralytic, and the Scribes' Sentence · Mark 2:1-12

> And when he returned to Capernaum after some days, it was reported that he was at home. And many were gathered together, so that there was no more room, not even at the door, and he was preaching the word to them. And they came, bringing to him a paralytic carried by four men. And when they could not get near him because of the crowd, they removed the roof above him, and when they had made an opening, they let down the bed on which the paralytic lay. And when Jesus saw their faith, he said to the paralytic: Child, your sins are forgiven. Now some of the scribes were sitting there, questioning in their hearts: Why does this man speak like that? He is blaspheming. Who can forgive sins but God alone? And immediately Jesus, perceiving in his spirit that they thus questioned within themselves, said to them: Why do you question these things in your hearts? Which is easier, to say to the paralytic, Your sins are forgiven, or to say, Rise, take up your bed and walk? But that you may know that the Son of Man has authority on earth to forgive sins, he said to the paralytic: I say to you, rise, pick up your bed, and go home. And he rose and immediately picked up his bed and went out before them all, so that they were all amazed and glorified God, saying: We never saw anything like this.

Commentary based on Quran

This is the first collision of the book, and the astonishing thing, from the fixed position, is what the collision is made of.

Begin with the scribes' objection, because it is a sentence this reader already knows by heart. *Who can forgive sins but God alone? Tis dynatai aphienai hamartias ei mē heis ho theos*. Now hear the corpus: *wa-man yaghfiru al-dhunūba illā Allāh*, and who forgives sins except Allah ﷻ (Q 3:135). The same sentence. The same rhetorical question, the same exclusive *illā*, the same doctrine, and in the corpus it is spoken in praise of the God-fearing who seek forgiveness from the only place forgiveness lives. The opponents of Mark's Messiah state the Quran's own clause, word for word across the two languages. So the question the scene puts is not whether the doctrine is true. Both books hold it true. The question is whether anything in the scene breaks it.

Walk the scene's grammar and nothing does. What is said to the paralytic is *aphientai sou hai hamartiai*: your sins *are forgiven*, a passive, present, with the forgiving agent unstated, the same reverent passive as the leper's *katharisthēti* one column earlier. He does not say *I forgive you*. No Gospel has him say it, here or anywhere. The announcement declares a forgiveness whose Agent sits above the sentence, exactly as the cleansing did. And when the objection is engaged, the claim made is not identity but warrant: *the Son of Man has authority, exousian echei, on earth to forgive sins*. *Exousia* is this Gospel's word for conferred authority, the teaching *as one having exousia* of the synagogue scene, and *on earth* names the jurisdiction of a delegate, not the throne of the Principal. An announcement in the divine passive, grounded in a delegated warrant, with the visible healing offered as the *proof* of the invisible grant, *that you may know*: this is, clause for clause, the corpus's permission-structure at Q 3:49, where every mighty work of 'Īsā AS is listed with *bi-idhni Allāh* hung on it like a seal, and the works are *āyatan lakum*, a sign for you, the visible attesting the granted.

Even the perception is in the inventory. Mark says he perceived *in his spirit* what they reasoned *in their hearts*, and the corpus's 'Īsā AS announces, in the same Q 3:49 list, by the same permission: *wa-unabbi'ukum bimā ta'kulūna wa-mā taddakhirūna fī buyūtikum*, and I inform you of what you eat and what you store in your houses, knowledge of the hidden granted as a sign. The heart-reading in Capernaum is not an attribute leaking through a disguise. It is an item on the granted list, and the corpus wrote the list.

And Mark himself files the verdict, in the crowd's mouth, in the last line: *they were all amazed and glorified God. Edoxasan ton theon*. The scene that began with a charge of blasphemy ends with the room's worship going upward, past the healer, to the Agent of the passives, and the narrator records the arrow without comment. The corpus's rule for every servant, *wa-mā bikum min ni'matin fa-mina Allāh*, whatever favour is with you is from Allah ﷻ (Q 16:53), is the crowd's instinct and the evangelist's punctuation. The first blasphemy charge in the Gospel dissolves under the two texts read together: the scribes were right about the doctrine and wrong about the scene, because the scene never left the doctrine.

One title entered quietly and should be marked on its way in. *The Son of Man*: its first appearance in this Gospel, and its second will come at the end of the next dispute (Mk 2:28). Not in a vision, not in glory, but in a forgiveness quarrel and a Sabbath quarrel, both of them arguments about *warrant*. The book introduces its subject's chosen self-designation in the two scenes where what is at issue is delegated authority, and the designation itself, in the Aramaic under the Greek, is *bar enasha*, the son of the human, the human one. The corpus's 'Īsā-file and its Prophet-file both anchor in the same self-word: *innamā anā basharun mithlukum*, I am only a human like you (Q 18:110). The title will gather weight through the book, and the reading will meet it fully on the road to Jerusalem. Here it is enough to record where it chose to be born: among the humans, in a dispute about what a human may carry.

Levi, and the Physician · Mark 2:13-17

> He went out again beside the sea, and all the crowd was coming to him, and he was teaching them. And as he passed by, he saw Levi the son of Alphaeus sitting at the tax booth, and he said to him: Follow me. And he rose and followed him. And as he reclined at table in his house, many tax collectors and sinners were reclining with Jesus and his disciples, for there were many who followed him. And the scribes of the Pharisees, when they saw that he was eating with sinners and tax collectors, said to his disciples: Why does he eat with tax collectors and sinners? And when Jesus heard it, he said to them: Those who are well have no need of a physician, but those who are sick. I came not to call the righteous, but sinners.

Commentary based on Quran

The call crosses a boundary the first four calls did not. Fishermen were poor and ritually ordinary; a tax farmer for the tetrarchy was a collaborator, presumed dishonest, socially unclean. The call is the same two words, and the response is the same single motion, and Mark makes the point by making no point: the call does not check credentials on its way in.

The objection comes at table, where that world kept its boundaries, and the answer is a proverb and a mission-statement. *Those who are well have no need of a physician, but those who are sick*. The corpus carries the same medical figure for the same office: the revelation is *shifā'un limā fī al-ṣudūr*, a healing for what is in the breasts (Q 10:57), and *We send down of the Qur'ān that which is healing and mercy* (Q 17:82). A physician's presence among the sick is not contamination; it is deployment. And the mission-clause, *I came not to call the righteous, but sinners*, is the corpus's own address written as a sending: *qul yā 'ibādiya alladhīna asrafū 'alā anfusihim lā taqnaṭū min raḥmati Allāh*, say, O My servants who have transgressed against their own souls, do not despair of the mercy of Allah ﷻ (Q 39:53). The corpus aims its tenderest verse at the very class the Pharisees' scribes would not recline with, and Mark's Messiah eats his way through the same doctrine. Two texts, one triage protocol: the call goes where the sickness is.

The Bridegroom, and the Taking · Mark 2:18-22

> Now John's disciples and the Pharisees were fasting. And people came and said to him: Why do John's disciples and the disciples of the Pharisees fast, but your disciples do not fast? And Jesus said to them: Can the wedding guests fast while the bridegroom is with them? As long as they have the bridegroom with them, they cannot fast. The days will come when the bridegroom is taken away from them, and then they will fast in that day. No one sews a piece of unshrunk cloth on an old garment. If he does, the patch tears away from it, the new from the old, and a worse tear is made. And no one puts new wine into old wineskins. If he does, the wine will burst the skins, and the wine is destroyed, and so are the skins. But new wine is for fresh wineskins.

Commentary based on Quran

A question about fasting, and inside the answer, half-hidden, the first prediction in this Gospel of the end of the story.

The days will come when the bridegroom is taken away from them. The verb is *aparthē*, from *apairō*, to be taken away, and it is passive: the bridegroom does not leave, is not lost, does not die in this sentence. He *is taken*, by an Agent the grammar declines to name, and the reader of this commentary has met that grammar twice already in two chapters. Now set the corpus beside it: *innī mutawaffika wa-rāfi'uka ilayya*, I am taking you and raising you to Myself (Q 3:55), and *bal raḥa'ahu Allāhu ilayh*, rather, Allah ﷻ raised him to Himself (Q 4:158). The corpus's whole account of this prophet's departure is an active *taking* with Allah ﷻ as the subject; Mark's earliest prediction of the departure is a passive *being taken* with the subject unstated; and a passive with an unstated divine agent is the same sentence written from below. Long before this Gospel narrates an arrest, it has told the reader, in a wedding metaphor, that the ending of this story is a removal performed from above. The two texts will part later over what the removal passed through. They do not part over whose hand performs it.

And then the fasting-clause completes, and it is a prophecy with a checkable afterlife: *and then they will fast in that day*. While the bridegroom is present, feasting; when he is taken, the fast returns. The corpus, six centuries downstream of the taking, writes to the community it gathers: *kutiba 'alaykumu al-ṣiyām kamā kutiba 'alā alladhīna min qablikum*, fasting is prescribed for you as it was prescribed for those before you (Q 2:183). A community on the far side of the bridegroom's taking, fasting as those before them fasted, is what Mk 2:20 says the future holds. The verse and its fulfilment are in different scriptures, and they interlock.

The two little parables that close the passage state why the new cannot be administered inside the old containers, and Mark's vocabulary winks at his own book: the patch pulls away and a worse tear is made, *cheiron schisma ginetai*, the tearing-root of the baptism and the veil, here in miniature. New wine, fresh skins: a new deposit requires a new vessel, or both are destroyed. The

corpus knows the principle as the succession of revelations, each *muṣaddiqan limā bayna yadayh wa-muḥayminan ‘alayh*, confirming what preceded it and standing guard over it (Q 5:48): continuity of the wine, renewal of the skin, and the guarding of the one by the other.

The Grainfields, and the Appointed Day · Mark 2:23-28

> One Sabbath he was going through the grainfields, and as they made their way, his disciples began to pluck heads of grain. And the Pharisees were saying to him: Look, why are they doing what is not lawful on the Sabbath? And he said to them: Have you never read what David did, when he was in need and was hungry, he and those who were with him, how he entered the house of God, in the time of Abiathar the high priest, and ate the bread of the Presence, which it is not lawful for any but the priests to eat, and also gave it to those who were with him? And he said to them: The Sabbath was made for man, not man for the Sabbath. So the Son of Man is lord even of the Sabbath.

Commentary based on Quran

First, the famous rough spot, because this commentary promised to exhibit the text's difficulties wherever they fall. The priest of the showbread episode in 1 Samuel 21 is Ahimelech; Abiathar is his son. Mark writes *in the time of Abiathar the high priest*. Matthew and Luke, copying the argument, both drop the name, the copyists' hands smoothing the earliest text for the third time in three chapters. The reading takes the seam as it took the Isaiah label at Mk 1:2: as the signature of a text preserved rougher than its copies, which is the property the whole of Part III was built on. A forger polishes; a witness transmits.

The argument itself is scripture against scripture-as-fence: David, in need, ate what only priests may eat, and the text that records it records no condemnation. Need, in the precedent, outranked the fence. Then the principle, and it is worth hearing with corpus ears: *the Sabbath was made for man, not man for the Sabbath*. To *sabbaton dia ton anthrōpon egeneto*: the Sabbath *came to be*, was made, appointed, for the human. The corpus says of the same institution, with the same verb-idea: *innamā ju'ila al-sabtu 'alā alladhīna ikhtalafū fih*, the Sabbath was appointed only upon those who differed concerning it (Q 16:124). *Egeneto* and *ju'ila*: both texts class the Sabbath as a made thing, an ordinance instituted for a purpose within history, not an uncreated absolute. And a made thing serves the purpose of its Maker for the ones it was made for. The corpus states the Maker's purpose in its own legislation, in, of all places, its fasting-chapter: *yurīdu Allāhu bikumu al-yusra wa-lā yurīdu bikumu al-'usr*, Allah ﷻ intends for you ease and does not intend for you hardship (Q 2:185), and again, *wa-mā ja'ala 'alaykum fī al-dīni min ḥaraj*, He has placed upon you in the religion no strangling difficulty (Q 22:78). The Sabbath-principle of Mk 2:27 is the ease-principle of Q 2:185, applied to the seventh day.

Then the closing sentence, *the Son of Man is lord even of the Sabbath*, and the fixed position reads it inside the structure the

passage itself built. The Sabbath is a made ordinance; ordinances rank below the purpose they serve; and the one sent to declare the purpose carries warrant over the ordinance's application, which is exactly the office the corpus assigns its Messiah toward this very law-code: *wa-li-uḥilla lakum ba'da alladhī ḥurrima 'alaykum*, and to make lawful for you some of what was forbidden to you (Q 3:50). A messenger with delegated authority to loosen appointed restrictions, *by permission*, is both books' picture. The sentence claims jurisdiction over an ordinance, under the Ordainer; it does not claim the Ordainer's seat, and the whole argument that carries it, David's precedent, the made-for-man principle, would be unnecessary scaffolding for anyone who held that seat. You do not argue from precedent for what you own outright. The argument's very existence is the sentence's own commentary.

The Withered Hand, and the First Plot · Mark 3:1-6

> Again he entered the synagogue, and a man was there with a withered hand. And they watched him, to see whether he would heal him on the Sabbath, so that they might accuse him. And he said to the man with the withered hand: Come here. And he said to them: Is it lawful on the Sabbath to do good or to do harm, to save life or to kill? But they were silent. And he looked around at them with anger, grieved at their hardness of heart, and said to the man: Stretch out your hand. He stretched it out, and his hand was restored. And the Pharisees went out and immediately held counsel with the Herodians against him, how to destroy him.

Commentary based on Quran

The Sabbath question returns sharpened to a fork: *is it lawful on the Sabbath to do good or to do harm, to save life or to kill?* The verb *exestin*, is it permitted, the vocabulary of warrant again, and the fork is built so that silence itself answers it, because refusing to permit the good is choosing the harm. *But they were silent: hoi de esiōpōn*. Mark has spent two chapters silencing spirits and beneficiaries whose testimony, though true, was unauthorised. Here the watchers, whose office it was to speak the law, silence themselves rather than answer it. The two silences face each other across the book's first act: the silenced who knew, and the self-silenced who would not say. The corpus's diagnosis for the second silence is the one Mark reaches for in the same breath, *hardness of heart: thumma qasat qulūbukum min ba'di dhālika fa-hiya ka-l-ḥijārati aw ashaddu qaswah*, then your hearts hardened after that and became like stones, or harder (Q 2:74), spoken to the same community's ancestors about the same organ.

The healing itself is two imperatives and a passive. *Come here. Stretch out your hand*. And then: *apekatestathē hē cheir autou*, his hand was restored. No touch this time, no spittle, no formula, not even a healing-word addressed to the limb: a command to the man, and a restoration whose agent the grammar leaves unstated. Divine passive, two. The circuit of Q 3:49 runs again with even the wires hidden: the prophet supplies the occasion and the command; the restoring arrives from above the sentence.

And then the movement closes on its darkest line. *The Pharisees went out and immediately held counsel with the Herodians against him, how to destroy him.* Chapter three, verse six, and the plot to kill is already convened, between two parties who agreed on nothing else. Mark's *symbolion*, counsel, is the corpus's *makr*: *wa-makarū wa-makara Allāh, wa-Allāhu khayru al-mākirīn*, and they plotted, and Allah ﷻ plotted, and Allah ﷻ is the best of plotters (Q 3:54), a verse the corpus writes about this very story, in the chapter that carries this very prophet's name. The plotters have entered the narrative. The counter-plot, both books agree, was already in place before theirs convened, and the rest of this Gospel is the two plots converging on a hill outside the city, where the corpus will say the plotters' version of events was never what happened, and Mark, read closely, will turn out to have left more room for that sentence than fourteen centuries of readers assumed.

This movement stands, then, with nothing forced. The proclamation was corpus-grammar entire. The callings ran on *istajībū*. The authority was *exousia*, conferred. The silencings enforced Q 26:212's bar on the spirit-register and began their count at three. The healings ran in the divine passive, two of them now, on the circuit Q 3:49 wired. The scribes objected in the Quran's own sentence and the scene never left the sentence's doctrine. The bridegroom's taking was announced in the passive six centuries before *rafa'ahu Allāhu ilayh* named the hand. The Sabbath was a made thing in both books, serving the ease both books legislate. And the plot convened on schedule, opposite a counter-plot older than itself.

Structural Commentary · The Movement Entire

What stands. A conferred authority. The crowd notices it in the first synagogue and Mark never explains where it came from, which is itself the report: it is remarked upon as unlike the scribes' and never derived from the man.

What moves. The healings, each of them an expenditure with a cost and an instant, and each of them written with the acting verb in the passive: *be cleansed, the hand was restored, your sins are forgiven*.

How they bind. The permission, and the movement's own grammar is what carries it. Across five healings the acting verb goes passive at exactly the moment of the cure, so the authority remarked upon in the synagogue is never once written as the healer's possession. What Q 3:49 states as a clause, *bi-idhni Allāh*, four times in one verse, this movement builds into the morphology of its verbs and never explains.

Collapse the authority into the person and the healer is a technician with an inventory. Collapse the healings and the authority is a claim with no discharge. Collapse the permission and every passive in the movement is decoration, which is exactly what a reader has to assume in order to miss the pattern. √ GOL on the permission circuit.

The Twelve and the Seed · Mark 3:7-4:34

The middle of the Galilean act: a withdrawal, an appointment, the gravest charge in the book answered, a family redefined, and then a chapter of seed. Mark sets his hardest doctrine, the veiling, inside his gentlest imagery, the sowing, and the arrangement is itself a teaching.

Box | What to Watch

The Twelve are appointed on the precedent the corpus itself records: twelve chieftains at the covenant of the Children of Israel, Q 5:12.

The one unforgivable sin and the one unforgivable *shirk* are the same act read from two sides: misattribution at the root of the ledger.

Kinship is redrawn by deed, which is Q 11:46 spoken gently: *he is not of your family*.

Four seed-parables relocate growth, yield, timing, and scale away from the human middle and upward.

The Crowds and the Sea · Mark 3:7-12

> Jesus withdrew with his disciples to the sea, and a great crowd followed, from Galilee and Judea and Jerusalem and Idumea and from beyond the Jordan and from around Tyre and Sidon. When the great crowd heard all that he was doing, they came to him. And he told his disciples to have a boat ready for him because of the crowd, lest they crush him, for he had healed many, so that all who had diseases pressed around him to touch him. And whenever the unclean spirits saw him, they fell down before him and cried out: You are the Son of God. And he strictly ordered them not to make him known.

Commentary based on Quran

The catchment widens to the whole map, north, south, east, and across the water, and the pressure becomes physical: a boat kept ready so the crowd does not crush him. The healed press to touch; the spirits fall and shout a title. And the closing line runs the standing law again: *he strictly ordered them not to make him known*. Silencing, four. The title the spirits shout is the very one the later church would build on, and Mark shows it being refused from the mouths that offered it earliest and loudest. The bar of Q 26:212 holds precisely where holding it costs the most: testimony from the barred register is not promoted to doctrine merely because it flatters. If anything, the scene teaches the harder half of the rule, that the spirit-register's flattery is the more dangerous half of its speech, and the corpus says as much of the whisperer whose speech is *ghurūran*, delusion by adornment (Q 4:120). What the spirits know is managed; what they proclaim is muzzled; and the reader is being trained, four scenes in, to ask of every title in this book not *is it exalted* but *who authorised it*.

The Twelve Appointed · Mark 3:13-19

> And he went up on the mountain and called to him those whom he desired, and they came to him. And he appointed twelve, whom he also named apostles, so that they might be with him, and he might send them out to preach and have authority to cast out demons. He appointed the twelve: Simon, to whom he gave the name Peter; James the son of Zebedee and John the brother of James, to whom he gave the name Boanerges, that is, Sons of Thunder; Andrew, and Philip, and Bartholomew, and Matthew, and Thomas, and James the son of Alphaeus, and Thaddaeus, and Simon the Zealot, and Judas Iscariot, who betrayed him.

Commentary based on Quran

Up the mountain, the appointment-height of both scriptures, and the election is stated twice over before a single name is given: *he called to him those whom he desired*, *hous ēthelen autos*, whom he himself willed, and *he appointed twelve*, *epoiēsen dōdeka*, literally he *made* twelve. Election by the caller's will, and a making rather than a recruiting: this is the corpus's own vocabulary of prophetic company. *Inna Allāha ṣṭafā*, Allah ﷻ chose Adam and Nūḥ and the house of Ibrāhīm and the house of 'Imrān above the worlds (Q 3:33): *iṣṭifā'*, election from above, never application from below.

And the number is not free-floating. The corpus itself records the precedent, in the covenant-scene of the earlier community: *wa-ba'athnā minhumu ithnay 'ashara naqībā*, and We raised up from among them twelve chieftains (Q 5:12), one for each tribe, at the taking of the covenant of the Children of Israel. Twelve appointed overseers at the covenant of Mūsā AS; twelve appointed companions at the renewal under 'Īsā AS; the number is the covenant-community's own architecture, carried forward, and the corpus is the book that states the earlier twelve in so many words.

The purpose-clause is two-stage and the order matters: *that they might be with him*, first, and *that he might send them out*, second. Companionship, then commission; formation, then mission. The corpus's word for this cohort is *al-ḥawāriyyūn*, and it records their enlistment in the same two-stage grammar, the call and the response: *man anṣārī ilā Allāh, qāla al-ḥawāriyyūna naḥnu anṣāru Allāh*, who are my helpers toward Allah ﷻ? The disciples said: we are the helpers of Allah ﷻ (Q 3:52, and again at Q 61:14). Helpers *toward* Allah ﷻ, not toward a cause of their own: the preposition assigns the mission's direction in both books, upward through the sender.

Two shadows sit inside the list, and Mark plants both without comment. Simon is renamed, and the renamer's authority to rename is simply exercised, the way the corpus's Lord renames and retitles at will. And the list ends: *Judas Iscariot, who betrayed him*. The betrayal is announced in the appointment-scene itself, twelve chapters early, the wound built into the roster from the first hour. The corpus states the general law of which this is the instance: *wa-kadhālika ja'alnā li-kulli nabiyyin 'aduwwan*, and thus We appointed for every prophet an enemy (Q 6:112, and Q

25:31). The enemy is *appointed*, part of the architecture of the office, not an accident that befalls it, and Mark's roster, with its last name pre-marked, is that verse in list form.

The House, the Strong Man, and the Unforgivable · Mark 3:20-30

> Then he went home, and the crowd gathered again, so that they could not even eat. And when his family heard it, they went out to seize him, for they were saying: He is out of his mind. And the scribes who came down from Jerusalem were saying: He is possessed by Beelzebul, and by the prince of demons he casts out the demons. And he called them to him and said to them in parables: How can Satan cast out Satan? If a kingdom is divided against itself, that kingdom cannot stand. And if a house is divided against itself, that house will not be able to stand. And if Satan has risen up against himself and is divided, he cannot stand, but is coming to an end. But no one can enter a strong man's house and plunder his goods, unless he first binds the strong man. Then indeed he may plunder his house. Truly, I say to you, all sins will be forgiven the children of man, and whatever blasphemies they utter, but whoever blasphemes against the Holy Spirit never has forgiveness, but is guilty of an eternal sin. For they were saying: He has an unclean spirit.

Commentary based on Quran

Here Mark begins the first of his interruptions, the device this commentary will count as it recurs: a story opened, a second story inserted whole, the first story resumed, so that each reads the other. The family set out to seize him at verse 21; they will arrive at verse 31; and between departure and arrival Mark seats the gravest charge and the gravest warning in the book. Intercalation, one. The frame and the filling are one argument: those who should know him best call him mad, and those whose office is discernment call him possessed, and the two misreadings are left standing side by side so the reader can weigh which one the warning falls on.

The charge from Jerusalem is not that the works are fake. No one in this Gospel ever disputes that the works happen. The charge concerns the *source*: by the prince of demons he casts out the demons. And the first answer is pure structure: a power warring on itself is a power ending. *How can Satan cast out Satan?* The corpus argues the unity of the Source by the same instrument, from order to singleness: *law kāna fīhimā ālihatun illā Allāhu la-fasadatā*, had there been in the heavens and the earth gods other than Allah ﷻ, both would have gone to ruin (Q 21:22). A divided sovereignty cannot produce a standing order; the standing of the order is the proof of the undivided hand. Mark's Messiah applies the theorem downward to the adversary's kingdom, and the corpus applies it upward to the throne, and it is one theorem.

Then the strong man. *No one can enter a strong man's house and plunder his goods, unless he first binds the strong man*. The word is *ischyros*, and the count that began with the forerunner's *ischyroteros* now reads: strength, two. The forerunner announced

one mightier; here the mightier one describes his own work as the binding of the strong. The exorcisms are not negotiations, they are the evidence that the binder has already entered the house. The corpus's cosmology of the same event is the barring of the listeners: the satans *are struck from every side, repelled* (Q 37:8-9), pursued by the piercing lamp when they steal a hearing (Q 15:17-18, Q 72:8-9). Both books describe the same military fact from two theatres: the spirit-realm's freedom of movement has been curtailed by a stronger hand, and the plundering of its house, the freeing of the possessed, is proceeding.

Then the sentence that has frightened readers for twenty centuries, and the fixed position is the one place from which its logic is plain. *All sins will be forgiven the children of man, and whatever blasphemies they utter, but whoever blasphemes against the Holy Spirit never has forgiveness.* One sin unforgivable, everything else open to pardon: that is the exact architecture of the corpus's own mercy-clause, *inna Allāha lā yaghfiru an yushraka bihi wa-yaghfiru mā dūna dhālika li-man yashā'*, Allah ﷻ does not forgive that partners be set beside Him, and He forgives what is less than that for whom He wills (Q 4:48). One exception, total amnesty available beneath it. And the two exceptions are the same act read from two sides. Mark names the act by its direction here: the scribes watched the Spirit of Allah ﷻ work and filed the work under the unclean, attribution of the Holy to the demonic. Shirk is the same misfiling reversed: attribution of what is His alone to another. Both are root-level misattribution, the corruption of the ledger itself, and both books mark that one corruption as the sin the system cannot process, because it is not a sin *within* the ledger but a falsification *of* the ledger. Mark even supplies the referent-line lest anyone read the warning as mystery: *for they were saying, he has an unclean spirit.* The eternal sin is not a mysterious trapdoor. It is calling the Spirit unclean while looking straight at His work, and its Quranic twin is calling a creature the Creator while looking straight at creation.

The Family at the Door · Mark 3:31-35

> And his mother and his brothers came, and standing outside they sent to him and called him. And a crowd was sitting around him, and they said to him: Your mother and your brothers are outside, seeking you. And he answered them: Who are my mother and my brothers? And looking about at those who sat around him, he said: Here are my mother and my brothers. For whoever does the will of God, he is my brother and sister and mother.

Commentary based on Quran

The interrupted story resumes: the family that set out to seize him arrives and stands *outside*, *exō*, the word Mark will use in the next chapter for those to whom the mystery is not given. The seating is the sermon: blood at the door, listeners in the circle.

And the answer redefines kinship by a criterion, not an insult. *Whoever does the will of God, he is my brother and sister and mother.* The corpus performed this exact redefinition first, in its severest scene, on a prophet's own son at the height of the flood:

innahu laysa min ahlik, innahu 'amalun ghayru ṣāliḥ, he is not of your family; he is unrighteous conduct (Q 11:46). The Arabic is more radical than any translation: the son is not merely *doing* unrighteous deeds, he *is* an unrighteous deed; conduct has replaced substance in the definition of *ahl*, family. Membership in a prophet's house is constituted by deed, and forfeited by deed, and blood neither confers nor protects it. The corpus runs the doctrine in both directions to close it: the wives of Nūḥ AS and of Lūṭ AS, inside two prophetic households and lost, and the wife of Fir'awn, inside the enemy's own house and saved, with Maryam AS set beside her (Q 66:10-12). Mark's sentence at the door of the crowded house is Q 11:46 spoken gently: the will of God draws the family line, and it runs through the room, not the bloodline.

And note what the sentence does *not* do, because the restraint is the second half of the teaching. It does not disown; it enlarges. The mother standing outside this scene, the corpus honours above the women of the worlds (Q 3:42), and this Gospel will place her at the cross when the circle has fled. The criterion that admits the crowd does not expel her; it tells her, and everyone, on what ground all standing rests. Nothing in either book lets nearness to the prophet substitute for obedience to the One who sent him, and the corpus says that to its own community about its own Prophet ﷺ in the plainest terms: on the Day the ties will be as if cut, *fa-lā ansāba baynahum yawma'idhin*, no kinship among them that day (Q 23:101). The intercalation closes with its two halves interpreting each other: the charge from Jerusalem showed discernment corrupted at the root, and the scene at the door shows kinship reordered at the root, and both corrections cut in the same direction, toward the will of God as the only load-bearing tie.

The Sower · Mark 4:1-9

> Again he began to teach beside the sea. And a very large crowd gathered about him, so that he got into a boat and sat in it on the sea, and the whole crowd was beside the sea on the land. And he was teaching them many things in parables, and in his teaching he said to them: Listen. Behold, a sower went out to sow. And as he sowed, some seed fell along the path, and the birds came and devoured it. Other seed fell on rocky ground, where it did not have much soil, and immediately it sprang up, since it had no depth of soil. And when the sun rose, it was scorched, and since it had no root, it withered away. Other seed fell among thorns, and the thorns grew up and choked it, and it yielded no grain. And other seeds fell into good soil and produced grain, growing up and increasing and yielding thirtyfold and sixtyfold and a hundredfold. And he said: Whoever has ears to hear, let him hear.

Commentary based on Quran

The teacher sits in the boat, the congregation stands on the shore, and the first word of the first parable is the first word of the corpus's own creed-sentence: *Listen, akouete*, the shore-side *shema'*. Then one sower, one seed, four grounds, and the whole variance of outcome located in the receiving soil. Nothing is wrong with the sower's arm and nothing is wrong with the seed; the parable is a doctrine of reception. The corpus carries the same

doctrine in the same image: *wa-l-baladu al-ṭayyibu yakhruju nabātuahu bi-idhni rabbih, wa-lladhī khabutha lā yakhruju illā nakidā*, and the good land, its vegetation comes forth by the permission of its Lord, and that which is bad brings forth nothing but scantily (Q 7:58), with the verse's own closing note that this is how the signs are turned about *li-qawmin yashkurūn*, for a people who give thanks. Even the yield-ladder has its corpus twin: the good soil's thirty, sixty, hundredfold is the grain of Q 2:261 that grows seven ears with a hundred grains in each ear, *wa-Allāhu yuḍā'ifu li-man yashā'*, and Allah ﷻ multiplies for whom He wills. Same seed, same soils, same arithmetic of grace: the increase is never the ground's achievement, and always the Giver's multiplication.

Why Parables · Mark 4:10-12

> And when he was alone, those around him with the twelve asked him about the parables. And he said to them: To you has been given the mystery of the kingdom of God, but for those outside everything is in parables, so that they may indeed see but not perceive, and may indeed hear but not understand, lest they should turn and be forgiven.

Commentary based on Quran

This is the hardest saying in the chapter and among the hardest in the Gospel, and the commentary will not soften what Mark wrote. The purpose-clause is real: *hina*, so that, seeing without perceiving, hearing without understanding. The words are Isaiah's commission (Isaiah 6:9-10), and Mark quotes them as the standing explanation of the parable-form itself.

The fixed position does not need to blunt this, because the corpus carries the same doctrine in the same grammar and supplies the piece that makes it just. *Wa-ja'alnā 'alā qulūbihim akinnatan an yafqahūhu wa-fī ādhānihim waqrā*, and We have placed over their hearts coverings, lest they understand it, and in their ears a heaviness (Q 17:46): the veiling is His act, stated with the same purpose-syntax, *an yafqahūhu*, lest they understand. And the justice of it is in the sequence the corpus states at its front door: *inna alladhīna kafarū sawā'un 'alayhim... khatama Allāhu 'alā qulūbihim*, those who have refused, it is the same to them whether you warn them or not, *then* Allah ﷻ has set a seal upon their hearts (Q 2:6-7). The refusal precedes the seal; the seal ratifies a choice already made and persisted in. The veiling is judicial, not arbitrary.

And now look at where Mark placed this teaching, because the placement is the theodicy. The parable-veiling is announced immediately after the Beelzebul scene, in which the watchers of Israel looked at the Spirit's work and pronounced it unclean. The capital misattribution comes first; the parables follow. Mark's sequence is Q 2:6-7's sequence enacted in narrative: first the settled refusal, publicly filed, then the form of teaching that veils exactly those who have veiled themselves. *Those outside, tois exō*, is not a class created by the parables; it is the class the previous chapter watched constitute itself, standing at the door of

its own accord. To the circle, the mystery *has been given, dedotai*, one more divine passive in the reverent convention, gift-grammar; to the outside, story-form, which preserves the truth in a sealed container they may yet choose to open, for the parable that veils also keeps, and whoever turns finds the meaning intact where it was left. Both books hold the door's handle on the inside of the hearer.

The Sower Explained · Mark 4:13-20

> And he said to them: Do you not understand this parable? How then will you understand all the parables? The sower sows the word. And these are the ones along the path, where the word is sown: when they hear, Satan immediately comes and takes away the word that is sown in them. And these are the ones sown on rocky ground: the ones who, when they hear the word, immediately receive it with joy. And they have no root in themselves, but endure for a while; then, when tribulation or persecution arises on account of the word, immediately they fall away. And others are the ones sown among thorns. They are those who hear the word, but the cares of the age and the deceitfulness of riches and the desires for other things enter in and choke the word, and it proves unfruitful. But those that were sown on the good soil are the ones who hear the word and accept it and bear fruit, thirtyfold and sixtyfold and a hundredfold.

Commentary based on Quran

The decoding names the seed as *the word* and the four grounds as four careers of hearing, and the third ground is where the two texts touch item for item. What chokes the word: *the cares of the age, the deceitfulness of riches, and the desires for other things*. Now the corpus's inventory of the same choking growth: *know that the life of this world is play and diversion and adornment and boasting among you and rivalry in wealth and children*, and the verse continues, in the same breath, into a seed-parable of its own: *like rain whose vegetation delights the tillers; then it dries and you see it turn yellow; then it becomes chaff* (Q 57:20). The same chapter of the corpus that lists the thorns grows the withering crop beside them. Mark's thorn-list and Q 57:20's world-list are one inventory in two languages, and both books plant it inside the same agricultural warning, green growth without endurance, delight without yield. The deceit of riches, *hē apatē tou ploutou*, is the corpus's *matā'u al-ghurūr*, the enjoyment of delusion, which is Q 57:20's own closing phrase. The parable and its Quranic twin end on the same word: deceit.

The Lamp That Comes · Mark 4:21-25

> And he said to them: Does the lamp come to be put under a basket, or under a bed, and not on a stand? For nothing is hidden except to be made manifest; nor is anything secret except to come to light. If anyone has ears to hear, let him hear. And he said to them: Pay attention to what you hear. With the measure you use, it will be measured to you, and still more will be added to you. For to the one who has, more will be given, and from the one who has not, even what he has will be taken away.

Commentary based on Quran

The Greek of the first question is stranger than any translation shows, and the strangeness is the doctrine. *Mēti erchetai ho lychnos*: does the lamp *come*? Lamps do not come; lamps are brought. Mark writes the lamp as a subject in motion, an arriving thing, a *sent* thing, and the grammarians have noticed the oddity for centuries. The fixed position reads it without strain, because the corpus has a verse that assigns every term of this image its rank. *Allāhu nūru al-samāwāti wa-l-arḍ*, Allah ﷻ is the Light of the heavens and the earth; *mathalu nūrihi ka-mishkātin fihā mišbāh*, the likeness of His light is as a niche in which is a lamp (Q 24:35). The Light, unqualified, is His and is Him; the lamp, *mišbāh*, belongs to the *likeness* of the light, the bearer-image within the similitude, glass and niche and blessed oil around it. A lamp is not the light's source. It is where the light is set so that it reaches the house. And a lamp that *comes* is a lamp on assignment: kindled elsewhere, arriving here, placed on the stand for the sake of the room. Mark's odd verb and the corpus's careful simile are the same discipline: the prophet is luminous the way a lamp is luminous, derivatively, positionally, sent into the room and set up high, and the Light itself stays where Q 24:35 put it, above every likeness. The hiddenness-clause then gives the lamp its schedule: *nothing is hidden except to be made manifest*. The concealments this Gospel has been counting, the silencings, the private explanations, are not the story's destination; they are its staging. The veil is temporary by design, and the corpus's word for the Day is simply *yawma tublā al-sarā'ir*, the day the secrets are tested and laid bare (Q 86:9).

Then the measure. *With the measure you use, it will be measured to you, and still more will be added*. The reciprocity is law and the surplus is grace, and the corpus writes both clauses in its own arithmetic: *man jā'a bi-l-ḥasanati fa-lahu 'ashru amthālihā*, whoever brings a good deed shall have ten like it (Q 6:160), and the ladder runs on up through seven hundred, *wa-Allāhu yuḍā'ifu li-man yashā'* (Q 2:261). Measure for measure is justice; the *added more* is the Giver exceeding the scale He Himself set, and both books refuse to let the arithmetic of return close at par. The severe closing line, that the one who has not loses even what he has, is the rocky ground restated as economics: a gift unrooted is a gift in departure, and the corpus's *fa-lammā zāghū azāgha Allāhu qulūbahum*, when they deviated, Allah ﷻ made their hearts deviate (Q 61:5), is the same compounding, downward.

The Seed That Grows of Itself · Mark 4:26-29

> And he said: The kingdom of God is as if a man should scatter seed on the ground. He sleeps and rises night and day, and the seed sprouts and grows; he knows not how. The earth produces by itself, first the blade, then the ear, then the full grain in the ear. But when the grain is ripe, at once he puts in the sickle, because the harvest has come.

Commentary based on Quran

This parable is Mark's alone; neither of the Gospels that copied him kept it, and it is the most Quranic paragraph in the book. A man scatters seed and then does the two least impressive things a man can do, he sleeps and he rises, and the growth proceeds *he knows not how*, *hōs ouk oiden autos*, and the earth produces *automatē*, of itself, with no further agency from the farmer at all. The corpus asks the question to which this parable is the answer, and asks it as a challenge: *a-fa-ra'aytum mā taḥruthūn*, *a-antum tazra'ūnahu am naḥnu al-zāri'ūn*, have you considered what you till? Is it you who make it grow, or are We the Grower? (Q 56:63-64). Mark's farmer, asleep while the blade rises, is the corpus's answer drawn as a cartoon: not you. The *automatē* is not a claim that the earth is autonomous; it is the narrative removal of the human middle so that the real Agency stands alone behind the process, the same divine passive this Gospel has been writing in its healings, now written across a field.

And the corpus binds this exact image to the resurrection, which is where the death-register of this commentary first opens. *I'lamū anna Allāha yuḥyī al-arḍa ba'da mawtiḥā*, know that Allah ﷻ gives life to the earth after its death (Q 57:17), the seed-cycle commanded as a thing to *know*, because it is the annual public rehearsal of the raising: *wa-aḥyaynā bihi baldatan maytan*, *kadhālika al-khurūj*, and We give life thereby to a dead land; thus is the coming-forth (Q 50:11). The sleeping farmer and the self-raising grain are both books' primer on the power the Sadducees will deny in chapter twelve, and Mark has quietly stocked the answer eight chapters before the question. Then the sickle, *because the harvest has come*: Joel's sickle (Joel 3:13), the appointed cutting at the appointed ripeness, the corpus's *ajal* closing the parable the way it closed the proclamation at Mk 1:15.

The Mustard Grain · Mark 4:30-32

> And he said: With what can we compare the kingdom of God, or what parable shall we use for it? It is like a grain of mustard seed, which, when sown on the ground, is the smallest of all the seeds on earth, yet when it is sown it grows up and becomes larger than all the garden plants and puts out large branches, so that the birds of the air can make nests in its shade.

Commentary based on Quran

The corpus holds the same seed in its hand. *Yā bunayya innahā in taku mithqāla ḥabbatin min khardalin fa-takun fī ṣakhratin aw fī al-samāwāti aw fī al-arḍi ya'ti bihā Allāh*, O my son, if it be but the weight of a grain of mustard, and it be in a rock or in the heavens or in the earth, Allah ﷻ will bring it forth (Q 31:16), and the same mustard-weight calibrates the scales of the Day at Q 21:47, where no soul is wronged by so much as it. The two books reach for the identical seed to make adjoining points: Mark, that no beginning is too small for the kingdom's full growth; the corpus, that no deed is too small for the King's full accounting; and beneath both, the shared premise that smallness is invisible only to creatures. The great shrub with the nesting birds is the old

promise-image of the kingdom-tree sheltering the nations, Ezekiel's cedar sprig grown until *birds of every sort* nest in its shade (Ezekiel 17:22-23), and the corpus draws the same botany of the good word: *kalimatan ṭayyibatan ka-shajaratīn ṭayyibah*, a good word is like a good tree, its root firm and its branches in the sky, giving its fruit in every season by the permission of its Lord (Q 14:24-25). Small sowing, vast shelter, permission all the way up the trunk.

As They Were Able to Hear · Mark 4:33-34

> With many such parables he spoke the word to them, as they were able to hear it. He did not speak to them without a parable, but privately to his own disciples he explained everything.

Commentary based on Quran

The chapter closes on the teaching-method's mercy-clause: *kathōs ēdynanto akoueīn*, as they were able to hear. The dosage is calibrated to capacity, which is the corpus's stated law of every burden: *lā yukallifu Allāhu nafsan illā wus'ahā*, Allah ﷻ does not task a soul beyond its capacity (Q 2:286). And the private explaining, *epelyen*, resolves the chapter's tension honestly: the veiling of Mk 4:12 was never the whole policy; alongside it runs the unveiling, to those in the circle, of *everything*. Concealment for the self-sealed, explication for the given: the corpus's pair is the sealing of Q 2:7 alongside the promise of Q 75:19, *thumma inna 'alaynā bayānah*, then upon Us is its explication. Both books run the two channels at once, and both put the explication on the Teacher's side of the ledger, not the pupil's.

The movement closes with the field sown. The Twelve stand appointed on the corpus's own precedent of twelve. The one unforgivable sin has been identified in both books as the same root-misattribution. The family line has been redrawn through deed, as Q 11:46 drew it. And four seed-parables have relocated every agency that matters, growth, yield, timing, scale, away from the human middle and upward, which is the single direction this Gospel has pointed since the heavens tore. The next movement takes the boat out onto the water, where the question of the book is finally asked aloud: who then is this?

Structural Commentary · The Movement Entire

What stands. One deposit. A single seed in four soils, a single word given to hearers who differ, with the differentiator never once located in what was sown.

What moves. The growth, *automatē*, of itself, proceeding through the farmer's sleep and his rising and known by him at no stage, first the blade, then the ear, then the full grain.

How they bind. The receiving condition. The soil determines nothing about the seed and everything about the yield, and its inversion is the one unforgivable act: a discriminator that calls the clean thing unclean has broken the very faculty by which it would return.

Collapse the seed into the soil and the word varies by audience, which the parable forecloses by using one seed. Collapse the

growth into the sower and the kingdom is a work rather than a gift, which Q 56:63-64 refuses by question. Collapse the receiving condition and the four outcomes have no explanation and the Beelzebul charge has no mechanism. ✎ GOL on the reception structure.

The Crossings · Mark 4:35-6:6

Four scenes across and around the lake: a storm, a legion, a woman inside a raising, and a hometown that cannot receive. The movement is built on boundaries, sea and shore, clean and unclean, death and sleep, honour and offence, and at every boundary the same question surfaces in a new mouth: who, then, is this? Mark asks it and declines to answer it in his own voice; the two texts together answer it more precisely than either community's later shorthand.

Box | What to Watch

A man sleeps in the stern of a boat owned by the One of whom Q 2:255 says neither slumber nor sleep seizes Him.

The sea is muzzled with the exorcism's own verb, under the same conferred authority.

Power goes out of him and he turns to find where, and credits the healing to the woman's trust.

At Nazareth he *could not*, which Matthew converts to *did not*, and which is the permission-structure showing its underside.

The Storm Muzzled · Mark 4:35-41

> On that day, when evening had come, he said to them: Let us go across to the other side. And leaving the crowd, they took him with them in the boat, just as he was. And other boats were with him. And a great windstorm arose, and the waves were breaking into the boat, so that the boat was already filling. But he was in the stern, asleep on the cushion. And they woke him and said to him: Teacher, do you not care that we are perishing? And he awoke and rebuked the wind and said to the sea: Peace. Be muzzled. And the wind ceased, and there was a great calm. He said to them: Why are you so afraid? Have you still no faith? And they were filled with great fear and said to one another: Who then is this, that even the wind and the sea obey him?

Commentary based on Quran

Two details anchor the whole scene, and they pull in opposite directions on purpose.

The first is the sleep. Mark alone furnishes the cushion, *proskephalaion*, the steersman's pillow in the stern, and on it the exhausted teacher sleeps through a storm that is filling the boat. The corpus has a verse whose entire work is to mark the line this detail draws: *Allāhu lā ilāha illā huwa al-Ḥayyu al-Qayyūm, lā ta'khudhuhu sinatun wa-lā nawm*, Allah ﷻ, there is no god but He, the Living, the Self-Subsisting; neither slumber seizes Him nor sleep (Q 2:255). Sleep is the creature's signature; the Sustainer

of the boat and the sea does not do it. A sleeping man in the stern is, by the Throne Verse's own criterion, on the near side of the line, and Mark paints the sleep in before he paints the power, so that the reader must hold both.

The second is the muzzle. He rebukes the wind and says to the sea, *siōpa, pephimōso*, be silent, be muzzled, and *pephimōso* is the identical verb he used on the unclean spirit in the Capernaum synagogue (Mk 1:25). The sea is addressed with the exorcism's vocabulary, under the same *exousia*, in the same direction: delegated command exercised over an unruly subject. And the corpus states whose subjection the sea stands under as standing law: *Allāhu alladhī sakhkhara lakumu al-baḥra li-tajriya al-fulku fīhi bi-amrih*, Allah ﷻ is the one who subjected the sea for you, that the ships may run upon it by His command (Q 45:12). The sea is *musakhkhar*, already subjected, held on His leash; a word of command spoken with His warrant pulls the leash, and the great calm follows. Psalm 107 had sung the same circuit generations earlier, they cried to the LORD and *He* stilled the storm to a whisper, and the disciples in the boat, who knew that psalm, ask the question the psalm forces: *who then is this, that even the wind and the sea obey him?* Mark leaves their question standing, and the two texts read together answer it without strain: this is the servant through whom the Owner of the sea is exercising the Owner's calm, the sleeping conduit of a power that does not sleep. The corpus even supplies the scene's missing sermon, spoken to sailors: *and when harm touches you at sea, those you call upon besides Him vanish; and when He delivers you to the land, you turn away* (Q 17:67). The disciples' great fear after the calm is the correct fear, and it is fear of the One the calm disclosed.

And the rebuke that matters most is the one aimed at the crew: *why are you so afraid? Have you still no faith?* The storm was never the examination; the sleep was. Whether they could trust the sent one to be carried by the Sender, boat and all, was the question, and the corpus sets the same examination as a general syllabus: *wa-la-nabluwannakum bi-shay'in mina al-khawfi*, and We will surely test you with something of fear (Q 2:155). The storm passes; the syllabus stands.

The Legion and the Herd · Mark 5:1-20

> They came to the other side of the sea, to the country of the Gerasenes. And when Jesus had stepped out of the boat, immediately there met him out of the tombs a man with an unclean spirit. He lived among the tombs. And no one could bind him anymore, not even with a chain, for he had often been bound with shackles and chains, but he wrenched the chains apart, and he broke the shackles in pieces. No one had the strength to subdue him. Night and day among the tombs and on the mountains he was always crying out and cutting himself with stones. And when he saw Jesus from afar, he ran and fell down before him. And crying out with a loud voice, he said: What have you to do with me, Jesus, Son of the Most High God? I adjure you by God, do not torment me. For he was saying to him: Come out of the man,

you unclean spirit. And Jesus asked him: What is your name? He replied: My name is Legion, for we are many.

Commentary based on Quran

The far shore is Gentile ground, and the first figure on it is the book's extreme case: a man the community could not hold. Mark's sentence for it carries the thread: *oudeis ischyen auton damasai*, no one had the strength to subdue him. Strength, three. The teaching of Mk 3:27 is now enacted on a beach: here is the strong man's house in a single body, chains snapped, shackles ground to pieces, and the binder of the strong steps off the boat and the unbindable falls at his feet before a word is spoken. The corpus keeps the image of the fettered rebellious in the same vocabulary, *muqarranīna fī al-aṣṣād*, bound together in shackles (Q 14:49, Q 38:38): what human chains could not do to this man, the arriving authority does without chains at all.

And the spirit's own speech is a small seminar in rank. *I adjure you by God: horkizō se ton theon*. The demon swears the healer by God, invoking the higher Name against the one tormenting him, and the grammar of the oath concedes the whole structure this commentary has been tracing: even the unclean know where the top is, and it is not the man in front of them, or the oath would be nonsense. The corpus's satans have the same forced theology, *fa-bi-‘izzatika*, then by Your might, Iblīs swears by the Lord's own honour in the act of rebelling (Q 38:82). Rebellion in both books is conducted in the vocabulary of the throne it rebels against, because there is no other vocabulary.

> And he begged him earnestly not to send them out of the country. Now a great herd of pigs was feeding there on the hillside, and they begged him: Send us to the pigs; let us enter them. So he gave them permission. And the unclean spirits came out and entered the pigs; and the herd, numbering about two thousand, rushed down the steep bank into the sea and drowned in the sea. The herdsmen fled and told it in the city and in the country. And people came to see what it was that had happened. And they came to Jesus and saw the demon-possessed man sitting there, clothed and in his right mind, the man who had had the legion, and they were afraid. And those who had seen it described to them what had happened to the demon-possessed man and to the pigs. And they began to beg Jesus to depart from their region. And as he was getting into the boat, the man who had been possessed with demons begged him that he might be with him. And he did not permit him but said to him: Go home to your friends and tell them how much the Lord has done for you, and how he has had mercy on you. And he went away and began to proclaim in the Decapolis how much Jesus had done for him, and everyone marveled.

Even the spirits' exit runs on the book's one grammar: they *beg*, and *he gave them permission, epetrepsen autois*. Permission, the corpus's *idhn*, governs the traffic of the unseen in both directions, and the drowned herd is the region's ledger made visible: two thousand pigs against one man restored, and the region does its arithmetic and asks the restorer to leave. The healed man asks the

opposite, *to be with him*, the very purpose-clause of the Twelve's appointment, and is refused it, and the refusal is a commission: *go home to your friends and tell them how much the Lord has done for you*.

Mark the wording, because the silencing policy has just inverted, and the inversion proves the policy's logic. In Galilee, where a wrong messianic politics stood ready to ignite, testimony was muzzled. Here in the Decapolis, Gentile ground with no such tinder, the healed man is *ordered* to proclaim, and the content he is given is attribution upward: what *the Lord, ho kyrios*, has done for you, how *He* has had mercy. The commission's grammar sends the glory past the healer to the Source, exactly as the crowd's doxology did at Mk 2:12. And then Mark, honest to a fault, records what the man actually proclaimed: *how much Jesus had done for him*. The instruction said the Lord; the proclamation said Jesus; and the narrator preserves the slippage without smoothing it, the first field-report in the book of how attribution drifts one link down the chain in transmission. Six centuries later the corpus would build its sternest fences at exactly the joint where this one sentence shows the timber already creeping. The first commissioned preacher of this Gospel is a Gentile ex-demoniac, and his first sermon already needed the fence.

The Woman Inside the Raising · Mark 5:21-43

> And when Jesus had crossed again in the boat to the other side, a great crowd gathered about him, and he was beside the sea. Then came one of the rulers of the synagogue, Jairus by name, and seeing him, he fell at his feet and implored him earnestly: My little daughter is at the point of death. Come and lay your hands on her, so that she may be made well and live. And he went with him. And a great crowd followed him and thronged about him.

Commentary based on Quran

The book's second interruption opens, and it is the most deliberate. Intercalation, two. A father's errand is suspended for twelve verses while a woman's twelve-year affliction is healed, and Mark stitches the two halves with a needle he lets the reader see: the woman has bled *twelve years*, the girl is *twelve years old*. One number, two lives, and it is the span of the girl's whole existence set against the span of the woman's whole suffering. The insertion is not a delay. It is a lens.

> And there was a woman who had had a discharge of blood for twelve years, and who had suffered much under many physicians, and had spent all that she had, and was no better but rather grew worse. She had heard the reports about Jesus and came up behind him in the crowd and touched his garment. For she said: If I touch even his garments, I will be made well. And immediately the flow of blood dried up, and she felt in her body that she was healed of her disease.

Twelve years unclean under Leviticus, cut off from the sanctuary and from touch, her money gone to physicians who made her worse. She approaches from behind, in a crowd, silently, and her whole theology is one conditional: *if I touch even his garments, I*

will be made well. The verb is passive again, *sōthēsomai*, I shall be saved, agent unstated. She does not say he will heal her. She says healing will come, and she reaches for the nearest edge of the channel it comes through.

> And Jesus, perceiving in himself that power had gone out from him, immediately turned about in the crowd and said: Who touched my garments? And his disciples said to him: You see the crowd pressing around you, and yet you say, Who touched me? And he looked around to see who had done it. But the woman, knowing what had happened to her, came in fear and trembling and fell down before him and told him the whole truth. And he said to her: Daughter, your faith has made you well; go in peace, and be healed of your disease.

Mark writes this exchange with a precision the later tradition found awkward and this reading finds decisive. *Perceiving in himself that power had gone out from him: epignous tēn ex autou dynamin exelthousan*. Power went out of him, and he perceives the outflow, and then he asks a question, twice, and looks around to find the answer. The disciples' reply is nearly mocking, and the narrator lets it stand. Whatever is happening in this scene, it is not a possessor of unlimited knowledge staging a teaching moment. It is a conduit registering a withdrawal and turning to find where it went. The corpus's grammar for its own prophets fits this scene without a seam: *lā aqūlu lakum 'indī khazā'inu Allāh wa-lā a'lamu al-ghayb*, I do not say to you that with me are the treasures of Allah ﷻ, nor do I know the unseen (Q 6:50), and everything given is given *bi-idhn*, by permission, on the occasion. The power is real, it flows, and it is not inventory the channel holds and audits.

And the verdict he pronounces removes himself from the transaction entirely: *your faith has made you well, hē pistis sou sesōken se*. Not *I have healed you*. The healing is credited to her trust, and her trust reached upward through the garment's hem. She had grasped, in a crowd, the one available edge of the rope, and the corpus's name for that grasp is *al-'urwa al-wuthqā*, the most trustworthy handhold that does not break, given to whoever entrusts himself to Allah ﷻ (Q 2:256, Q 31:22). She is called *daughter*, spoken to publicly, and sent *in peace*: the untouchable is restored to touch, to speech, and to the congregation, in one sentence.

> While he was still speaking, there came from the ruler's house some who said: Your daughter is dead. Why trouble the Teacher any further? But overhearing what they said, Jesus said to the ruler of the synagogue: Do not fear, only believe. And he allowed no one to follow him except Peter and James and John the brother of James. They came to the house of the ruler, and Jesus saw a commotion, people weeping and wailing loudly. And when he had entered, he said to them: Why are you making a commotion and weeping? The child is not dead but sleeping. And they laughed at him. But he put them all outside and took the child's father and mother and those who were with him and went in where the child was. Taking her by the hand he said to her: Talitha koum, which

means: Little girl, I say to you, arise. And immediately the girl got up and began walking; for she was twelve years of age. And they were overcome with amazement. And he strictly charged them that no one should know this, and told them to give her something to eat.

The interruption has cost the father his daughter, and the sentence he receives is the sentence the crowd received in the boat: *do not fear, only believe*. The same examination, run on a father instead of a crew.

Then the clause the mourners laughed at: *the child is not dead but sleeping, ou apethanen alla katheudei*. The mockery is Mark's guarantee that the girl was, by every observer's judgment, dead; and the correction is not a medical claim but a re-typing of the state, and the corpus supplies the same re-typing as a general doctrine of the two conditions: *Allāhu yatawaffā al-anfusa hīna mawtiḥā wa-llatī lam tamut fī manāmiḥā, fa-yumsiku allatī qaḍā 'alayhā al-mawta wa-yursilu al-ukhrā ilā ajalīn musammā, Allah ﷻ takes the souls at the time of their death, and those that have not died, in their sleep; then He withholds those upon whom He has decreed death and releases the others until an appointed term (Q 39:42). Sleep and death are one administration with two settings, and the holding and the releasing are His verbs. In that verse's light the sentence over the girl is exact rather than euphemistic: this soul is on the released setting, until a term appointed elsewhere. The corpus's sleepers of the cave lie under the same word for centuries and are called awakened, ba'athnāhum, when the term expires (Q 18:12).*

Talitha kourm. The Aramaic is kept and glossed: retention, one, and the pattern this commentary flagged in Part III begins its count here. The evangelist writes for Greek readers and still preserves the two words the child actually heard, at the moment of address, and translates them in an aside. And the verb of the raising is *egeire*, arise, whose passive *ēgerthē* will be spoken by the young man at the tomb in the last chapter. Mark rehearses his final sentence on a twelve-year-old in a back room, and then, with the household in uproar, has the raiser order silence, five, and add the most ordinary instruction in the Gospel: *give her something to eat*. The sign is sealed and the child is fed. Both books end their miracles the same way, in the register of daily provision: the corpus's Maryam AS, at the height of her own impossible sign, is told to shake the palm and eat and drink and cool her eye (Q 19:25-26).

Nazareth, and What Could Not Be Done · Mark 6:1-6

> He went away from there and came to his hometown, and his disciples followed him. And on the Sabbath he began to teach in the synagogue, and many who heard him were astonished, saying: Where did this man get these things? What is the wisdom given to him? How are such mighty works done by his hands? Is not this the carpenter, the son of Mary and brother of James and Joses and Judas and Simon? And are not his sisters here with us? And they took offense at him. And Jesus said to them: A prophet is not

without honor, except in his hometown and among his relatives and in his own household. And he could do no mighty work there, except that he laid his hands on a few sick people and healed them. And he marveled because of their unbelief. And he went about among the villages teaching.

Commentary based on Quran

Three things in six verses, and every one of them is a sentence a later hand would have written differently.

The townspeople's own question contains the doctrine they are rejecting. *What is the wisdom given to him? Hē sophia hē dotheisa toutō*: given, passive, by the unnamed Giver. Even the scoffers phrase it correctly. And *how are such mighty works done by his hands*, again passive, the works *done* through the hands rather than generated by them. Mark puts the whole permission-structure of Q 3:49 into the mouths of the men refusing it, which is precisely how the corpus records the refusals of every town: the mechanism is understood well enough to be resented.

Is not this the carpenter, the son of Mary? A man in that culture is named for his father; this one is named for his mother, in his own village, by neighbours who have known him since childhood. Mark does not explain it, and the two Gospels that copy him both alter it, one to *the carpenter's son*, the other to *Joseph's son*. The earliest text names the mother, and the corpus names him the same way, always and without exception: *'Isā ibn Maryam*, in every one of its references, the matronymic carried as his standing title. Two scriptures, one naming convention, and between them a village's raised eyebrow preserved without comment.

Then the line that has embarrassed commentators for eighteen centuries. *And he could do no mighty work there: ouk edynato ekei oudemian dynamin poiēsai*. Could not. Matthew, copying, writes *did not do many mighty works there*, converting an inability into a decision, and the smoothing is watchable in parallel columns. Mark's *could not* is the harder reading and therefore the original, and from the fixed position it is not an embarrassment at all but the permission-structure showing its underside. If every work is *bi-idhni Allāh*, by the permission of Allah ﷻ, granted per occasion, then where the occasion is refused the permission does not issue, and the channel stands dry. The corpus states the same conditionality of every messenger in the same grammar: *wa-mā kāna li-rasūlin an ya'tiya bi-āyatin illā bi-idhni Allāh*, it was not for any messenger to bring a sign except by the permission of Allah ﷻ (Q 40:78, and Q 13:38). A prophet who *could not* is a prophet whose ability was never his own inventory, and Mark's sentence is the cleanest single proof in the Gospel that this is the kind of power the book is describing.

And the last clause completes it: *he marveled because of their unbelief, ethaumasen*. He is surprised. Surprise requires not having known, and the corpus's own Prophet ﷺ is commanded to say *mā adrī mā yuf'alu bī wa-lā bikum*, I do not know what will be done with me or with you (Q 46:9). The Gospel and the corpus

keep the same creaturely interior in their prophets, and neither treats it as a deficiency to be managed.

The movement closes on that dry channel. Across the water the strong man was bound without chains and the freed man's first sermon already drifted one link down the chain of attribution. In the boat the sleeping conduit stilled a sea that never sleeps. In the crowd a woman's grasp drew power the conduit felt leaving him and credited to her faith. In the back room a death was re-typed as sleep in the corpus's own administration of souls, and the Aramaic of the raising was kept. And in his own village the permission did not issue, and the earliest evangelist wrote that down.

Structural Commentary · The Movement Entire

What stands. A creation already under command. The sea is *musakhkhar* before anyone speaks to it, so its obedience is a fact about the sea and not only about the speaker.

What moves. The word spoken into it, and the power that leaves him and that he turns around to trace, and the exit of the legion into a herd. Real expenditures, one of them measured by the one paying it.

How they bind. The permission, and the movement supplies its own control. The spirits ask and *he gave them permission*; the sea is stilled under the *bi-amrih* of Q 45:12; and at Nazareth, where the anchor on the receiving side is cut, the permission does not issue and Mark writes *ouk edynato*, he could not.

Collapse the subjection and every stilling is a seizure of nature. Collapse the outgoing power and the healings are declarations rather than costs. Collapse the permission and the hometown scene is inexplicable, because a possessed power does not fail where it is least welcome. ↵ GOL on the subjection-and-permission structure, with Nazareth as its negative exhibit.

The Bread · Mark 6:7-8:26

The longest movement of the Galilean half, and its subject is provision: who sends, who supplies, who eats, and who cannot see that he has already been fed. Mark builds it around two feedings and hangs between them a beheading, a walk on water, a quarrel about washing, a Gentile mother's argument, and a deaf man's tongue loosed. It ends with a blind man healed in two stages, which is the movement's own self-portrait.

Box | What to Watch

The mission kit strips stored provision and leaves walking gear: Q 65:3's *He is sufficient for him*, enacted.

Herod's oath is the cage the corpus legislates a door out of, at the price of ten meals (Q 5:89).

Both feedings open with the eyes going up, and the corpus preserves the prayer that was said when they went up (Q 5:114).

The sign is refused in the passive, because the signs are '*inda Allāh*, with Him.

The Twelve Sent · Mark 6:7-13

> And he called the twelve and began to send them out two by two, and gave them authority over the unclean spirits. He charged them to take nothing for their journey except a staff, no bread, no bag, no money in their belts, but to wear sandals and not put on two tunics. And he said to them: Whenever you enter a house, stay there until you depart from there. And if any place will not receive you and they will not listen to you, when you leave, shake off the dust that is on your feet as a testimony against them. So they went out and proclaimed that people should repent. And they cast out many demons and anointed with oil many who were sick and healed them.

Commentary based on Quran

Two by two, dyo dyo: the pairing is the corpus's own prescription for standing up in truth, *an taqūmū lillāhi mathnā wa-furādā*, that you stand for Allah ﷻ in twos and singly (Q 34:46), and the second half of Mark's sentence explains why the first half is possible at all: *he gave them authority, edidou autois exousian*. Delegated warrant, handed down one further level, and the whole chain now visible in a single verse, the Sender above, the sent one, the sent ones' sent ones, each carrying only what was given.

The kit is a study in dependence. No bread, no bag, no coin in the belt, one tunic, and, in Mark alone, a staff and sandals permitted. The two Gospels that copy him forbid both, which tells us the permission was original and felt too lax to keep. What the list strips is stored provision; what it leaves is walking gear. The corpus writes the same posture as a promise rather than a rule: *wa-man yattaqi Allāha yaj'al lahu makhrajan wa-yarzuqhu min haythu lā yahtasib, wa-man yatawakkal 'alā Allāhi fa-huwa ḥasbuh*, whoever is mindful of Allah ﷻ, He makes for him a way out and provides for him from where he does not reckon; and whoever entrusts himself to Allah ﷻ, He is sufficient for him (Q 65:2-3). Travel without stores is the enacted form of *ḥasbuh*, He is enough. And the sandals are the one item of this kit that crossed every tradition intact, the same footwear the forerunner declared himself unworthy to untie in chapter one: transit, full, one.

The dust shaken from the feet is a legal gesture, not a curse: it terminates responsibility and leaves the record with the refusers. The corpus gives the messengers the identical closing formula, *fa-*

in *tawallaw fa-innamā* 'alayka al-balāgh, if they turn away, upon you is only the delivery (Q 3:20, Q 16:82). Delivery made, receipt refused, ledger closed, and the messenger walks on with nothing added to his pack and nothing owed.

The Death of the Forerunner · Mark 6:14-29

> King Herod heard of it, for Jesus' name had become known. Some said: John the Baptist has been raised from the dead. That is why these miraculous powers are at work in him. But others said: He is Elijah. And others said: He is a prophet, like one of the prophets of old. But when Herod heard of it, he said: John, whom I beheaded, has been raised.

Commentary based on Quran

The Twelve go out at verse thirteen and return at verse thirty, and between the sending and the return Mark inserts the killing of the attester. Intercalation, three, and the deepest in the book: the mission of the messengers is framed by the fate of a messenger, so that no reader can hear *they went out and proclaimed* without also hearing what proclamation costs.

The chapter opens on three confident identifications, and Mark ratifies none of them. John raised, Elijah returned, a prophet like the old ones. This commentary noted in Part I that the corpus closes the merger of the two clean files with a single verse, *muṣaddiqan bi-kalimatīn min Allāh* (Q 3:39), because a confirmer and the confirmed cannot be one person. Here the collapse is staged by a guilty king, who adds the beheading himself so no reader misses that he knows better, and it is left standing as rumour. The reader who carries the two-place office already holds the correction the narrative declines to supply.

> For it was Herod who had sent and seized John and bound him in prison for the sake of Herodias, his brother Philip's wife, because he had married her. For John had been saying to Herod: It is not lawful for you to have your brother's wife. And Herodias had a grudge against him and wanted to put him to death. But she could not, for Herod feared John, knowing that he was a righteous and holy man, and he kept him safe. When he heard him, he was greatly perplexed, and yet he heard him gladly.

The portrait of the king is the finest piece of characterisation in Mark, and it is a portrait of a man ruled by what other people think of him. He fears the prophet, protects him, listens to him gladly, and is perplexed by him, and none of it survives contact with a dinner party. What John said was a plain application of the law, *it is not lawful*, and the corpus's Yaḥyā AS file has exactly that steel in it: *wa-āṭaynāhu al-ḥukma ṣabiyyā*, We gave him judgment while a boy (Q 19:12), and *lam yakun jabbāran* 'aṣiyyā, he was not a tyrant, not disobedient (Q 19:14). A man who is not a tyrant tells a tyrant the law, and the tyrant, in this scene, half wants to hear it.

> But an opportunity came when Herod on his birthday gave a banquet for his nobles and military commanders and the leading men of Galilee. For when Herodias's daughter came in and

danced, she pleased Herod and his guests. And the king said to the girl: Ask me for whatever you wish, and I will give it to you. And he vowed to her: Whatever you ask me, I will give you, up to half of my kingdom. And she went out and said to her mother: For what should I ask? And she said: The head of John the Baptist. And she came in immediately with haste to the king and asked, saying: I want you to give me at once the head of John the Baptist on a platter. And the king was exceedingly sorry, but because of his oaths and his guests he did not want to break his word to her. And immediately the king sent an executioner with orders to bring John's head. He went and beheaded him in the prison and brought his head on a platter and gave it to the girl, and the girl gave it to her mother. When his disciples heard of it, they came and took his body and laid it in a tomb.

Up to half of my kingdom is Ahasuerus's offer to Esther, word for word from the Greek of that book, the banquet, the pleased king, the open-ended oath, the request routed through a queen. In Esther the machinery saves a people; here the same machinery kills a prophet. The image crossed into this scene and was inverted: transit, partial, and the ledger records it as a borrowed frame with a reversed outcome, which is itself a comment on how much depends on who is standing behind the girl.

Then the hinge of the whole passage: *because of his oaths and his guests*. Two chains, and Mark names them in that order. The king is exceedingly sorry, *perilypos*, and kills anyway, because he has sworn in front of men whose opinion he cannot bear to lose. And here the corpus does something worth stating plainly: it legislates the exit Herod could not find. *Lā yu'ākhidhukum Allāhu bi-l-laghwi fī aymānikum wa-lākin yu'ākhidhukum bimā 'aqqadtumu al-aymān, fa-kaffāratuhu iṭ'āmu* 'asharati masākīn, Allah ﷻ does not take you to task for what is thoughtless in your oaths, but He takes you to task for the oaths you have deliberately sworn; its expiation is feeding ten needy persons (Q 5:89). An oath sworn to a wrong outcome is not a cage; it is a debt with a published price, ten meals or a fast, and the verse ends *dhālika kaffāratu aymānikum idhā ḥalaftum*, that is the expiation for your oaths when you have sworn. The corpus's own Prophet ﷺ was corrected in exactly this territory, told *lima tuḥarrimu mā aḥalla Allāhu lak*, why do you forbid yourself what Allah ﷻ has made lawful, and given the same release, *qad faraḍa Allāhu lakum taḥillata aymānikum* (Q 66:1-2). Herod had no such door, or believed he had none, and a man who thinks his word to a room is stronger than a life will always find the room heavier. The corpus's diagnosis is the shorter one: *wa-takhshā al-nāsa wa-Allāhu aḥaqqu an takhshāh*, and you feared people, when Allah ﷻ is worthier of being feared (Q 33:37). Herod feared the guests.

And Mark closes with the disciples coming for the body and laying it in a tomb, a sentence he will need again, in almost the same words, when a councillor asks for another body and lays it in another tomb. The forerunner goes ahead of his Messiah in death as he did in preaching, and the corpus's word over him covers both: *wa-salāmūn* 'alayhi yawma wulida wa-yawma

yamūtu wa-yawma yub'athu hayyā, peace be upon him the day he was born, the day he dies, and the day he is raised alive (Q 19:15). The peace was already spoken over this ending six centuries before the platter, and the same threefold peace is spoken by 'Īsā AS over himself eighteen verses later in the same surah.

The Five Thousand · Mark 6:30-44

> The apostles returned to Jesus and told him all that they had done and taught. And he said to them: Come away by yourselves to a desolate place and rest a while. For many were coming and going, and they had no leisure even to eat. And they went away in the boat to a desolate place by themselves. Now many saw them going and recognized them, and they ran there on foot from all the towns and got there ahead of them. When he went ashore he saw a great crowd, and he had compassion on them, because they were like sheep without a shepherd. And he began to teach them many things.

Commentary based on Quran

The intercalation closes: the messengers come back from their mission into the shadow of the murdered messenger, and the first thing said to them is *come away and rest*. The care is practical, they have not had time to eat, and the crowd defeats it by running around the lake on foot.

Like sheep without a shepherd is Moses's own phrase, asking that Israel not be left leaderless (Numbers 27:17), and the shepherd-image is one this Gospel will pick up again at the arrest, when the sheep scatter. The image reaches the corpus only in part: the corpus keeps the pastoral care as *ra'fa* and *rahma* placed in the hearts of his followers (Q 57:27) and keeps the flock-language for the Day, but it does not build the shepherd-title as a Christological office. Transit, partial, and the ledger notes the reason: an office-title is exactly the kind of thing the corpus's fences are careful about, while the care itself passes through untouched. And note what the compassion produces here: *he began to teach them many things*. Hungry crowd, remote place, and the first ration issued is instruction. The corpus ranks the two provisions in the same order, teaching before bread, in the four verses this commentary set at the head of Sūrat al-Raḥmān: *'allama al-Qur'ān* stands at verse two and *khalaqa al-insān* at verse three.

> And when it grew late, his disciples came to him and said: This is a desolate place, and the hour is now late. Send them away to go into the surrounding countryside and villages and buy themselves something to eat. But he answered them: You give them something to eat. And they said to him: Shall we go and buy two hundred denarii worth of bread and give it to them to eat? And he said to them: How many loaves do you have? Go and see. And when they had found out, they said: Five, and two fish. Then he commanded them all to sit down in groups on the green grass. So they sat down in groups, by hundreds and by fifties. And taking the five loaves and the two fish, he looked up to heaven and said a blessing and broke the loaves and gave them to the disciples to set before the people. And he divided the two fish

among them all. And they all ate and were satisfied. And they took up twelve baskets full of broken pieces and of the fish. And those who ate the loaves were five thousand men.

You give them something to eat: dote autois hymeis phagein, the pronoun emphatic. The disciples' answer is a budget objection, and the counter-question is an inventory question, *how many loaves do you have? Go and see*. The provision begins with a count of what is already in hand, which is the corpus's own method with Mūsā AS at the burning bush, *wa-mā tilka bi-yamīnika yā Mūsā*, and what is that in your right hand, O Mūsā (Q 20:17), a staff, and the staff is what the miracle is made of. Neither book conjures from nothing in these scenes; both start from the little already given.

Then the gesture on which the whole passage turns. *He looked up to heaven and said a blessing, anablepsas eis ton ouranon eulogēsen*. The eyes go up before the bread is broken. In a scene later readers would treat as the supreme display of the miracle-worker's own power, the miracle-worker is looking upward and blessing the One above, and Mark records the direction rather than the words. This is the pattern the Finding in Brief named as running the length of the book, and here it stands in its clearest single frame: authority received, acknowledged upward, then distributed downward through the hands of servants, for it is the disciples who set the bread before the people.

And the corpus has the scene, told from the other side. *Qāla 'Īsā ibnu Maryama: Allāhumma rabbanā anzil 'alaynā mā'idatan mina al-samā'i takūnu lanā 'īdan li-awwalinā wa-ākhirinā wa-āyatan minka, wa-rzuqnā wa-anta khayru al-rāziqīn*, 'Īsā son of Maryam said: O Allah ﷻ, our Lord, send down to us a table from heaven, to be for us a festival for the first of us and the last of us, and a sign from You, and provide for us, for You are the best of providers (Q 5:114). The corpus's account of the miraculous meal is a *prayer*, in his own mouth, addressed upward, asking the Provider to send and asking Him to provide, and the answer comes from Allah ﷻ: *innī munazziluhā 'alaykum*, I will send it down to you (Q 5:115). Set the two accounts side by side and they are one event described from its two ends. Mark, from below, sees the man look up and bless; the corpus, from above, records what was said when he looked and Who answered. The Gospel's *anablepsas* and the corpus's *Allāhumma rabbanā* are the same upward turn. And the twelve baskets of surplus are the corpus's *rizq* in its usual excess, the same arithmetic as the multiplied grain: what is asked of the Provider returns more than was set down.

The corpus attaches a warning to its table, that whoever disbelieves after it will be punished as none other (Q 5:115), and the honest note is that Mark attaches no such clause; what he attaches instead is the disciples' failure to understand the loaves, twice, which is the same theme in a lower key. The bread was given, and the ones who carried the baskets did not read what they were carrying.

The Walking on the Sea · Mark 6:45-52

> Immediately he made his disciples get into the boat and go before him to the other side, to Bethsaida, while he dismissed the crowd. And after he had taken leave of them, he went up on the mountain to pray. And when evening came, the boat was out on the sea, and he was alone on the land. And he saw that they were making headway painfully, for the wind was against them. And about the fourth watch of the night he came to them, walking on the sea. He meant to pass by them, but when they saw him walking on the sea they thought it was a ghost, and cried out, for they all saw him and were terrified. But immediately he spoke to them and said: Take heart; it is I. Do not be afraid. And he got into the boat with them, and the wind ceased. And they were utterly astounded, for they did not understand about the loaves, but their hearts were hardened.

Commentary based on Quran

Between the feeding and the water Mark puts a mountain and a prayer, alone, at night, again. The pattern of Mk 1:35 recurs at the height of public success: the greater the crowd, the more deliberate the withdrawal upward. Whatever crossed the water at the fourth watch had spent the evening on a hillside praying.

Then the strangest clause in the chapter: *he meant to pass by them, ēthelen parelthein autous*. Readers have found it inexplicable, and the Greek Old Testament supplies its home. When Mūsā AS asks to see, the Lord sets him in the cleft and says *I will cover you with my hand until I have passed by* (Exodus 33:22); when Elijah stands at the cave, *behold, the LORD passed by* (1 Kings 19:11). *Passing by* is the technical form of a self-disclosure to a prophet on a mountain. Mark uses the form, and then declines it: they cry out, he speaks, and *he got into the boat with them*. The passing-by is aborted for a boarding. Whatever the scene was arranged to display, its ending is a man climbing into a boat with frightened fishermen and the wind dropping. The corpus's own account of a disclosure requested is the refusal at Sinai, *lan tarānī*, you shall not see Me (Q 7:143), and what is granted instead is manifestation to the mountain and the prophet's fall. Both books stage the approach and both withhold the seeing, and Mark's withholding takes the form of a servant getting in and sitting down.

Take heart; it is I. Do not be afraid. The Greek is *egō eimi*, which is both the ordinary way to say *it is me* in the dark and the words of the burning bush in the Septuagint. Readers have long divided over which is heard here. The commentary states both and lets the scene decide: the clause sits between *take heart* and *do not be afraid*, which is the standard formula of reassurance to a terrified party, and the terror it answers is the fear of a *phantasma*, a ghost. The sentence's work in its own context is identification, not proclamation, and the corpus's angels say the equivalent in every annunciation, *lā takhaf*, do not fear, *innā bushshirnāka*, we bring you good news (Q 15:53, Q 51:28). The higher reading is available to those who bring it; the sentence itself does no more

than name the walker and calm the boat, and this reading declines to make a creed out of a reassurance.

And Mark's closing diagnosis is aimed at the disciples, not the sea: *they did not understand about the loaves, but their hearts were hardened, pepōrōmenē*. The failure is not that they doubted a man could walk on water; it is that they had just carried twelve baskets of surplus and had not read them. The corpus's word for the same organ in the same condition is *qasat qulūbukum* (Q 2:74), and its word for the failure to read given provision is the one it uses of every ungrateful witness: the signs were shown, the eyes passed over them. The men in this boat have seen the sign and eaten it, and Mark says the hardening is theirs, inside the circle, not the crowd's.

Gennesaret · Mark 6:53-56

> When they had crossed over, they came to land at Gennesaret and moored to the shore. And when they got out of the boat, the people immediately recognized him and ran about the whole region and began to bring the sick people on their beds to wherever they heard he was. And wherever he came, in villages, cities, or countryside, they laid the sick in the marketplaces and implored him that they might touch even the fringe of his garment. And as many as touched it were made well.

Commentary based on Quran

Four verses of summary, and one word in them is worth stopping for. The sick ask to touch *the fringe of his garment, tou kraspedou tou himatiou autou*, and *kraspedon* is the Greek Old Testament's word for the tassel the Torah commands on the corners of a garment, the *šīṣīt* of Numbers 15:38, worn as a reminder to keep the commandments. The earliest Gospel dresses its subject in the tassels of the law, in passing, without comment, in a sentence about crowds. He is an observant man in observant clothing, and the corpus says of him exactly that: *muṣaddiqan limā bayna yadayya mina al-Tawrāt*, confirming what was before me of the Torah (Q 3:50). The detail is small and it is load-bearing, because the next passage is a quarrel about the law, and Mark has just shown, in his own quiet way, which side of that quarrel his subject dresses on.

The rest of the summary is the woman of chapter five multiplied: the same reaching for the hem, the same *esōzonto*, they were made well, in the passive with the Agent unnamed. What one woman found by grasping, a region now practises openly.

Corban, and the Commandment Set Aside · Mark 7:1-13

> Now when the Pharisees gathered to him, with some of the scribes who had come from Jerusalem, they saw that some of his disciples ate with hands that were defiled, that is, unwashed. For the Pharisees and all the Jews do not eat unless they wash their hands, holding to the tradition of the elders, and when they come from the marketplace, they do not eat unless they wash. And there are many other traditions that they observe. And the Pharisees and

the scribes asked him: Why do your disciples not walk according to the tradition of the elders, but eat with defiled hands? And he said to them: Well did Isaiah prophesy of you hypocrites, as it is written: This people honors me with their lips, but their heart is far from me; in vain do they worship me, teaching as doctrines the commandments of men. You leave the commandment of God and hold to the tradition of men.

Commentary based on Quran

The charge is precise and it is not a charge against the law. The disciples are accused of breaking *the tradition of the elders*, *tēn paradōsin tōn presbyterōn*, and Mark, writing for readers outside the community, explains the custom in an aside because they would not know it. The answer separates two things that had been welded together: *the commandment of God*, *tēn entolēn tou theou*, and *the tradition of men*, *tēn paradōsin tōn anthrōpōn*. Isaiah's line supplies the diagnosis, *teaching as doctrines the commandments of men*, and the whole of the corpus's critique of religious inheritance stands in that phrase.

The corpus makes the same cut and names the mechanism by which the human accretion acquires divine weight. *Ittakhadhū aḥbārahū wa-ruhbānahū arbāban min dūni Allāh*, they took their scholars and their monks as lords besides Allah ﷻ (Q 9:31), and the classical explanation, inside that tradition, is that no one worshipped a rabbi or a monk; the lordship consisted in accepting their permissions and prohibitions as binding where Allah ﷻ had not bound. That is Mk 7:8 stated as a doctrine of *shirk* in legislation, and it is the sharper of the two formulations because it names what the elevation of tradition actually is.

And the corpus goes further, to the specific device: *mā ja'ala Allāhu min baḥīratin wa-lā sā'ibatin wa-lā waṣīlatin wa-lā ḥām, wa-lākinna alladhīna kafarū yaftarūna 'alā Allāhi al-kadhib*, Allah ﷻ has not instituted the slit-eared camel, nor the freed camel, nor the twin-bearing ewe, nor the stallion released; but those who refuse invent falsehood about Allah ﷻ (Q 5:103). Four named categories of animal set aside by human vow and thereby withdrawn from ordinary use, invented dedications treated as sacred obligations. The corpus's list and Mark's next paragraph describe the identical device.

> He said to them: You have a fine way of rejecting the commandment of God in order to establish your tradition! For Moses said: Honor your father and your mother; and: Whoever reviles father or mother must surely die. But you say: If a man tells his father or his mother, Whatever you would have gained from me is Corban (that is, given to God), then you no longer permit him to do anything for his father or mother, thus making void the word of God by your tradition that you have handed down. And many such things you do.

Corban, and Mark glosses the Aramaic for his Greek readers: *qorbān*, an offering, from the root of drawing near. The corpus uses the same word twice, at Q 3:183 and Q 5:27, in both places for a genuine offering brought to Allah ﷻ, and the second is the

offering of Adam's two sons, where one is accepted and one is not, with the reason given: *innamā yataqabbalu Allāhu mina al-muttaqīn*, Allah ﷻ accepts only from those who guard themselves. So the word itself is clean in both scriptures. What Mark exposes is its use as an instrument: a man declares his assets dedicated, the dedication outranks the duty, and the parents go without. A vow has been used to cancel a commandment.

Making void the word of God by your tradition: akyrountes ton logon tou theou. And the corpus's parallel is Q 5:103's *yaftarūna 'alā Allāhi al-kadhib*, inventing a falsehood about Allah ﷻ, which is what any human dedication becomes the moment it is treated as binding at the divine level. Both texts locate the corruption in the same place, not in the desire to give to God, but in the ranking that lets a self-imposed vow overrule an imposed duty.

And the duty in question is the one the corpus places immediately after the command to worship none but Him: *wa-qaḍā rabbuka allā ta'budū illā iyyāhu wa-bi-l-wālidayni iḥsānā*, and your Lord has decreed that you worship none but Him, and to parents good conduct (Q 17:23), with the verse continuing into *lā taqul lahumā uff*, do not say to them a word of contempt. Mark's Messiah defends the fifth commandment against a pious device, and the corpus wires the same commandment directly into the first. On this passage the two texts are not merely compatible; they are running one argument, and the corpus supplies both the name of the error and the case law.

What Defiles · Mark 7:14-23

> And he called the people to him again and said to them: Hear me, all of you, and understand: There is nothing outside a person that by going into him can defile him, but the things that come out of a person are what defile him. And when he had entered the house and left the people, his disciples asked him about the parable. And he said to them: Then are you also without understanding? Do you not see that whatever goes into a person from outside cannot defile him, since it enters not his heart but his stomach, and is expelled? And he said: What comes out of a person is what defiles him. For from within, out of the heart of man, come evil thoughts, sexual immorality, theft, murder, adultery, coveting, wickedness, deceit, sensuality, envy, slander, pride, foolishness. All these evil things come from within, and they defile a person.

Commentary based on Quran

The spoken teaching is a relocation of defilement from the surface to the interior, and every clause of it is at home in the corpus. The heart is the organ of accountability, *wa-lākin yu'ākhidhukum bimā kasabat qulūbukum*, He takes you to task for what your hearts have earned (Q 2:225); it is the heart that is sealed, hardened, softened, or made sound, and the only thing a man brings on the Day that counts is *qalbin salīm*, a sound heart (Q 26:89). The vice-list itself could be lifted into the corpus without a seam: *ithm, fawāḥish, baghy, ghībah, ḥasad, kibr*, each of the thirteen has its Arabic counterpart in a corpus list, and the corpus's own summary

sentence is Q 7:33, say: my Lord has forbidden only the shameful deeds, what is apparent of them and what is concealed, and sin, and unjust aggression, with the concealed named first because that is where the trouble starts.

Two things need saying honestly about the passage, and the commentary says them in the open.

The first is that the relocation of defilement to the heart is not, in either scripture, the abolition of exterior law. The corpus keeps a short list of forbidden foods, *innamā ḥarrama ‘alaykumu al-maytata wa-l-dama wa-laḥma al-khinzīr* (Q 2:173, Q 5:3), while insisting that what reaches Allah ﷻ is never the substance but the state, which is the same two-level structure the Torah keeps and the same one Mark's spoken teaching assumes: he is arguing against *unwashed hands*, a tradition of the elders, not against Leviticus, and the word he uses of the food is that it *goes into the stomach and is expelled*, an observation about digestion, not a repeal.

The second is the clause that is not spoken. After the digestion sentence Mark adds, in his own voice, three words that no one in the story says: *katharizōn panta ta brōmata*, cleansing all foods. It is a narrator's aside, of the same kind as his explanations of Jewish washing and his glosses of Aramaic, and this commentary reports it as what it is: the evangelist's comment on the implication, written for a mixed community in which the food question was live, and not a sentence placed in the mouth of his subject. The distinction matters and it is checkable in the Greek: the clause is a loose participle, and the two Gospels that copy Mark drop it. Where the corpus keeps a food-law and the aside of Mk 7:19 declares foods cleansed, the two texts stand at different places, and the commentary names the divergence rather than dissolving it, and names its layer precisely: the divergence is between the corpus and the *narrator's aside*, while the spoken teaching, on the heart as the seat of defilement, is corpus doctrine entire. Both books put the weight in the same organ; they differ on what happens to the shorter exterior list, and one of the two places that difference in an editorial parenthesis rather than in the teacher's mouth.

The Syrophoenician Mother · Mark 7:24-30

> And from there he arose and went away to the region of Tyre. And he entered a house and did not want anyone to know, yet he could not be hidden. But immediately a woman whose little daughter had an unclean spirit heard of him and came and fell down at his feet. Now the woman was a Gentile, a Syrophoenician by birth. And she begged him to cast the demon out of her daughter. And he said to her: Let the children be fed first, for it is not right to take the children's bread and throw it to the dogs. But she answered him: Yes, Lord; yet even the dogs under the table eat the children's crumbs. And he said to her: For this statement you may go your way; the demon has left your daughter. And she went home and found the child lying in bed and the demon gone.

Commentary based on Quran

This is the only exchange in the Gospel that its subject loses, and he awards the victory himself.

The saying he offers is a household picture with an order of service in it, *let the children be fed first, prōton*, and the diminutive he uses is not the street-dog of insult but *kynaria*, the little dogs under the table, animals of the house. Even so, the sentence is hard, and Mark does not soften it. It states a sequence, Israel first, and the woman does not dispute the sequence. She works inside it: if the children are being fed at the table, then crumbs are falling now, and crumbs are not the children's portion taken away. She has accepted the priority and located a surplus, which is exactly what the twelve baskets in the previous chapter proved exists.

And the reply is the most remarkable clause in the movement: *dia touton ton logon*, because of this word, go your way. Not *because of your faith*, which is what he says to everyone else, but because of what she *said*. A Gentile woman argues, and the argument is granted, and the healing is done at a distance without a touch, a look, or a formula. The corpus makes the granting of the petition a standing rule rather than an exception, and states it in the one verse where the messenger is removed from the grammar: *wa-idhā sa'alaka 'ibādī 'annī fa-innī qarīb, ujību da'wata al-dā'i idhā da'ān*, and when My servants ask you about Me, I am near; I answer the call of the caller when he calls Me (Q 2:186). The caller here is a foreign mother with no standing in the covenant, and the answer arrives. The corpus's word over the class she belongs to is *wa-mā arsalnāka illā raḥmatan li-l-'ālamīn*, We sent you only as a mercy to the worlds (Q 21:107), and its rule for who may call is the widest in the book: *ud'ūnī astajīb lakum*, call upon Me and I will answer you (Q 40:60), with no ethnicity attached.

Two further things this scene settles quietly. The mission's sequence is real in both scriptures, a messenger is sent first to his own people, *li-tundhira qawman mā undhira ābā'uḥum* (Q 36:6), and the sequence is not a wall, since the corpus's own Prophet ﷺ is sent to the worlds. And the woman's *yes, Lord* is the only place in Mark where anyone calls him *kyrie* to his face and is answered with a granted request, and she does it while conceding the lower place. The book's whole doctrine of received authority has its mirror here in received mercy: it comes to the one who asks from below, and her lowness, like the forerunner's at the sandal-thong, is the position from which the granting is made.

Ephphatha · Mark 7:31-37

> Then he returned from the region of Tyre and went through Sidon to the Sea of Galilee, in the region of the Decapolis. And they brought to him a man who was deaf and had a speech impediment, and they begged him to lay his hand on him. And taking him aside from the crowd privately, he put his fingers into his ears, and after spitting touched his tongue. And looking up to heaven, he sighed and said to him: Ephphatha, that is, Be opened. And his ears were opened, his tongue was released, and he spoke

plainly. And Jesus charged them to tell no one. But the more he charged them, the more zealously they proclaimed it. And they were astonished beyond measure, saying: He has done all things well. He even makes the deaf hear and the mute speak.

Commentary based on Quran

The healing is the most physical in the book and the most carefully staged. The man is taken *aside from the crowd*, away from spectators. Fingers into the ears, spittle on the tongue, and then, before a word is spoken, the gesture that has now become this Gospel's signature: *anablepsas eis ton ouranon*, looking up to heaven. He looked up before he broke the bread, and he looks up before he opens the ears. The direction is fixed and Mark keeps recording it.

Then *estenaxen*, he sighed, or groaned. A groan is effort or grief, and it belongs to a creature; the corpus's picture of the same office keeps that register exactly, the messenger who is *ḥarīṣun 'alaykum*, anxious over them (Q 9:128), and who is told not to destroy himself with grief over those who refuse (Q 18:6, Q 35:8). The healer sighs on the way to the healing, and neither book finds that beneath the office.

And the charge follows the healing, *tell no one*, silencing, six, and it is disobeyed the more he presses it, exactly as the leper disobeyed it.

Ephphatha, and Mark glosses it: Aramaic retention, two. The pattern holds, the source language kept at the moment of address, and the Greek supplied in an aside for readers who need it.

The spittle needs its count begun here, because it will matter at the end of the book. *Ptyas*, having spat: spittle, one. It appears next at Bethsaida, where the same substance opens eyes; it is predicted at the third passion announcement, *they will spit on him*; and it is enacted twice in the passion itself, in the sanhedrin's courtyard and in the praetorium. Five occurrences of one fluid: twice as the medium of healing, once as prophecy, twice as humiliation. The servant who spat to open a deaf man's ears is spat upon by men who will not hear, and Mark planted the vocabulary here so that the last two instances would land on a prepared surface.

The crowd's verdict is the closing line and it is a quotation. *He has done all things well*, *kalōs panta pepoiēken*, is the Greek Old Testament's refrain over creation, *God saw everything that he had made, and behold, it was very good* (Genesis 1:31), and the pairing *the deaf hear and the mute speak* is Isaiah's sign-list for the coming deliverance (Isaiah 35:5-6), where the Greek uses the same rare word for the speech-impediment that Mark uses here. The crowd reaches for creation-language and prophecy-language in one breath. And the corpus, listing the works of this same prophet, keeps every item of that list and hangs the permission on each: *and I heal the blind and the leper, and I give life to the dead, by the permission of Allah ﷻ* (Q 3:49). The crowd says *he has*

done all things well; the corpus says by whose leave; and the Gospel itself has just shown the healer looking up before he did it.

The Four Thousand · Mark 8:1-10

> In those days, when again a great crowd had gathered, and they had nothing to eat, he called his disciples to him and said to them: I have compassion on the crowd, because they have been with me now three days and have nothing to eat. And if I send them away hungry to their homes, they will faint on the way. And some of them have come from far away. And his disciples answered him: How can one feed these people with bread here in this desolate place? And he asked them: How many loaves do you have? They said: Seven. And he directed the crowd to sit down on the ground. And he took the seven loaves, and having given thanks, he broke them and gave them to his disciples to set before the people; and they set them before the crowd. And they had a few small fish. And having blessed them, he said that these also should be set before them. And they ate and were satisfied. And they took up the broken pieces left over, seven baskets full. And there were about four thousand people. And he sent them away.

Commentary based on Quran

The second feeding is on the far side of the lake, in Gentile country, and Mark keeps its numbers scrupulously distinct from the first: seven loaves rather than five, four thousand rather than five, and *spyridas*, seven of them, a different word for basket from the *kophinoi* of chapter six. The distinctness is the point, and the two Gospels that copy Mark keep both feedings for the same reason. He is not telling one story twice. He is establishing a record with two entries, because he is about to hold an examination on it.

The opening sentence is the whole doctrine of the passage: *I have compassion on the crowd, because they have been with me now three days and have nothing to eat*. The concern is that they will collapse on the road, and *some of them have come from far away*. Provision here is not spectacle; it is logistics under mercy, and the corpus's word for the same care is the pairing it places in the hearts of this prophet's followers, *ra'fatan wa-rahmatan* (Q 57:27), and its standing description of the Provider, *wa-mā min dābbatin fī al-arḍi illā 'alā Allāhi rizquhā*, there is no creature on earth but that its provision is upon Allah ﷻ (Q 11:6). Four thousand people three days from home are creatures on the earth, and the provision arrives through a servant's hands, from seven loaves, after thanks are given.

Eucharistēsas, having given thanks, and then *eulogēsas*, having blessed: the two verbs of the upward turn again, one for the bread and one for the fish. The pattern is now so consistent that the reader can predict it, which is precisely what the disciples in the next passage will fail to do.

The Sign Refused · Mark 8:11-13

> The Pharisees came and began to argue with him, seeking from him a sign from heaven to test him. And he sighed deeply in his

spirit and said: Why does this generation seek a sign? Truly, I say to you, no sign will be given to this generation. And he left them, got into the boat again, and went to the other side.

Commentary based on Quran

He has just fed four thousand people, and they ask for a sign. The request is *to test him, peirazontes*, the verb used of the adversary in the wilderness, and Mark records the reaction before the answer: *anastenaxas tō pneumatī autou*, he groaned deeply in his spirit. The same verb as at the deaf man's healing, intensified. The groan is the servant's, and it is grief at a demand he will not meet.

No sign will be given to this generation: ou dothēsetai, a passive again, and the passive is the whole answer. He does not say *I will not give you a sign*. He says *none will be given*, which puts the withholding upstream of himself, where the giving would have had to come from. And the corpus states the same jurisdiction in a single clause, in answer to the same demand: *qul innamā al-āyātu 'inda Allāh*, say: the signs are only with Allah ﷻ (Q 6:109, and Q 29:50, where the messenger adds *wa-innamā anā nadhīrun mubīn*, and I am only a clear warner). *'Inda Allāh*, with Him: the preposition this commentary has been tracking since Part II, and its link-count now stands at four, the mother of the book with Him, the provision found with her, what is with Him remaining while what is with you runs out, and now the signs. The corpus adds, in the verse before, the sentence that explains the refusal rather than merely stating it: *wa-mā mana'anā an nursila bi-l-āyāti illā an kadhdhaba bihā al-awwalūn*, nothing prevented Us from sending the signs except that the former peoples denied them (Q 17:59). A sign given to a demand made in bad faith becomes a judgment, and the mercy is in the withholding.

And this generation has already been given the signs it is asking for. The two feedings sit immediately behind this request, seven baskets of surplus still being carried. Mark's arrangement is the argument: the sign-demand is made by people standing in a landscape littered with signs, which is the corpus's constant diagnosis, *wa-ka-ayyin min āyatin fī al-samāwāti wa-l-arḍi yamurrūna 'alayhā wa-hum 'anhā mu'riḍūn*, how many a sign in the heavens and the earth they pass by, turning away from it (Q 12:105).

The Leaven, and the Examination · Mark 8:14-21

> Now they had forgotten to bring bread, and they had only one loaf with them in the boat. And he cautioned them, saying: Watch out; beware of the leaven of the Pharisees and the leaven of Herod. And they began discussing with one another the fact that they had no bread. And Jesus, aware of this, said to them: Why are you discussing the fact that you have no bread? Do you not yet perceive or understand? Are your hearts hardened? Having eyes do you not see, and having ears do you not hear? And do you not remember? When I broke the five loaves for the five thousand, how many baskets full of broken pieces did you take up? They said to him: Twelve. And the seven for the four thousand, how many baskets full of broken pieces did you take

up? And they said to him: Seven. And he said to them: Do you not yet understand?

Commentary based on Quran

A warning about corruption is heard as a complaint about catering, and the misunderstanding triggers the sharpest questioning in the Gospel. Mark's aside is quietly devastating: *they had only one loaf with them in the boat*. One loaf, in a boat, with the man who has twice fed thousands from less, and they are worried.

The rebuke is a chain of five questions and its middle link is a quotation: *having eyes do you not see, and having ears do you not hear?* The words are Jeremiah's and Ezekiel's, and the corpus writes the same sentence about the same condition: *lahum qulūbun lā yafqahūna bihā, wa-lahum a'yunūn lā yubṣirūna bihā, wa-lahum ādhānūn lā yasma'ūna bihā*, they have hearts with which they do not understand, and eyes with which they do not see, and ears with which they do not hear (Q 7:179). Three organs, all present, all inoperative, in both books, in the same order.

And then the examination itself, which is unique in the Gospels and worth pausing on. He does not explain. He asks them to *count*. How many baskets, the first time? Twelve. The second? Seven. He makes them recite the inventory of what they have already received, and then asks the closing question, *do you not yet understand?*, and Mark does not record an answer. The method is the corpus's own method, in the surah that repeats one refrain thirty-one times, *fa-bi-ayyi ālā'i rabbikumā tukadhdhibān*, then which of the favours of your Lord will you deny (Q 55), a catechism conducted entirely by enumerating what has been given. Remembering is treated in both books as the cure for anxiety and the ground of faith, and the corpus makes it an imperative addressed to the community about its own history: *wa-dhkurū ni'mata Allāhi 'alaykum*, and remember the favour of Allah ﷻ upon you (Q 2:231, Q 3:103, Q 5:7). The disciples in the boat have the numbers. They can recite them on demand. What they cannot yet do is read them, and that is the exact condition the next healing is about.

Bethsaida, in Two Stages · Mark 8:22-26

> And they came to Bethsaida. And some people brought to him a blind man and begged him to touch him. And he took the blind man by the hand and led him out of the village, and when he had spit on his eyes and laid his hands on him, he asked him: Do you see anything? And he looked up and said: I see men, but they look like trees, walking. Then Jesus laid his hands on his eyes again; and he opened his eyes, his sight was restored, and he saw everything clearly. And he sent him to his home, saying: Do not even enter the village.

Commentary based on Quran

Mark alone tells this, and it is the only healing in the four Gospels that takes two attempts. Neither of the evangelists who copy him

keeps it, which is itself the usual signal that a passage was too rough to carry forward.

Read as a healing it is strange. Read where Mark placed it, immediately after men with eyes who cannot see and immediately before the confession at Caesarea Philippi, it is the hinge of the entire book. The disciples are the blind man. They are about to see, at the first attempt, something true and badly out of focus, Peter's *you are the Messiah*, followed at once by a rebuke because his idea of what that word means is trees walking. Then the long road to Jerusalem is the second touch. Mark diagnosed his own narrative with a miracle.

The intermediate report is the finest phrase in the chapter: *I see men, but they look like trees, walking*. Vision present, resolution absent, the objects confused with each other. The corpus has the exact condition and gives it a name, in the mouths of the Children of Israel about a cow: *inna al-baqara tashābaha 'alaynā*, cattle are all alike to us (Q 2:70). *Tashābaha 'alaynā*, they resemble one another to us, is the root the corpus uses for things that look alike and are confused, and it is the same root it uses of the verses that are *mutashābihāt*, ambiguous, which the sound of heart leave alone and the deviant chase (Q 3:7). Half-sight is not blindness and is more dangerous, because it produces confident reports. The blind man reports honestly, and gets the second touch.

And the closing instruction is the seventh silencing, *do not even enter the village*, which is the only one of the nine that removes the healed man from the crowd rather than only from speech.

Three details finish it. He is *led out of the village* by the hand, *exēnenken auton exō tēs kōmēs*: taken out before he is healed, and told at the end not to go back in. The leading-out is a motion the corpus makes the purpose of revelation itself, *kitābun anzalnāhu ilayka li-tukhrija al-nāsa mina al-ẓulumāti ilā al-nūr*, a book We have sent down to you that you may bring people out of the darknesses into the light (Q 14:1), and the same verb governs Q 2:257, where Allah ﷻ is the guardian who brings the faithful *out* of darkness. Sight is given outside the crowd, and the healed man is not sent back into it.

And the second touch is not a failure of power but a picture of how permission works in process. Q 3:49 hangs every work on *bi-idhni Allāh*, per occasion, and nothing in that grammar requires a single occasion. The corpus's own ladder-verse for the raising is a sequence, *thumma... thumma*, then and then (Q 2:28), and its account of guidance is a stage-process, *wa-yazīdu Allāhu alladhīna ihtadaw hudā*, and Allah ﷻ increases in guidance those who are guided (Q 19:76). Sight given in two stages is grace administered in the shape of a road, which is the shape the next three chapters take.

The movement closes here. Messengers were sent out with nothing and came back to the news that a messenger had been killed for saying *it is not lawful*, and the corpus's law would have released the king's oath for the price of ten meals. Thousands were fed twice by a man who looked up before he broke anything,

and the corpus preserved his prayer at that table. The passing-by on the water was declined for a boarding. Tradition was separated from commandment in the words the corpus uses for scholars taken as lords. A Gentile mother argued and was answered, because He is near and answers the caller. A deaf man's ears were opened with a groan and a spitting, and the count of that fluid stands at one. A sign was refused because the signs are with Him. And the men who had carried nineteen baskets between them were asked to count, and could count, and could not read, and then Mark healed a blind man twice.

Structural Commentary · The Movement Entire

What stands. The provision. Bread that is not counted into existence, and which the corpus states twice with the same negation: *bi-ghayri ḥisāb*, without reckoning, and *min ḥaythu lā yaḥtasib*, from where he does not calculate.

What moves. The breaking and the giving. He breaks the loaves down and *edidou*, kept giving, imperfect against the aorists around it, so that the increase lives in the distributing and not in a stock held before it.

How they bind. The upward glance. *Anablepsas eis ton ouranon*, he looked up, before a single loaf comes apart, and he never once addresses the bread. The source is named by a gesture, which is what the corpus states outright when it answers the same petition with *innī munazziluhā 'alaykum*, I am sending it down.

Collapse the provision into the loaves and the disciples' twelve and seven are the right answer instead of a true answer in the wrong register. Collapse the breaking and the multiplication is a lump that appears and the imperfect tense is unreadable. Collapse the glance and the scene is a conjuring, which is precisely the reading both texts spend a gesture and a clause to prevent. ۛ GOL on the fertility of the fracture.

The Way · Mark 8:27-10:52

The centre of the book. Three times the coming suffering is announced, three times it is misheard, and three times the correction is a teaching about rank. The whole movement is set on a road, *hodos*, and it ends with a blind beggar following on that road, which is the second touch the last movement's miracle promised.

Box | What to Watch

The confession is silenced and the suffering is published, *parrēsia*, two verses apart.

Peter is answered in the words the corpus speaks to its own Prophet ﷺ: *not for you is anything of the matter*.

On the mountain he says nothing, two figures are removed, and one imperative is left: *listen to him*.

The seats are not his to give, and the preparing is done by another.

Caesarea Philippi · Mark 8:27-30

> And Jesus went on with his disciples to the villages of Caesarea Philippi. And on the way he asked his disciples: Who do people say that I am? And they told him: John the Baptist; and others say, Elijah; and others, one of the prophets. And he asked them: But who do you say that I am? Peter answered him: You are the Christ. And he strictly charged them to tell no one about him.

Commentary based on Quran

The three public opinions are the three of chapter six, unchanged, and the reader who holds Part I already knows why the first is impossible and the second a category error. Then the question turns inward and Peter answers with the title: *sy ei ho Christos*, you are the Messiah, *al-Masīh*, the word the corpus confers eleven times and never withdraws. The confession is correct. It is the correct confession that gets silenced.

He strictly charged them to tell no one about him: epetimēsen autois, the rebuke-verb, silencing, eight, and the heaviest yet, because now it falls on truth spoken by the inner circle. And this is the point at which the pattern this commentary has counted since the Capernaum synagogue becomes fully legible. What is silenced is never falsehood. The demons were correct. The healed leper was grateful and correct. Peter is correct. What is managed is the *timing and the authorisation* of the announcement, in a province where the word Messiah meant an armed deliverer and would have recruited a following for the wrong thing. The corpus's parallel is not a secret but a schedule: revelation itself is released in portions, *wa-qur'ānan faraqnāhu li-taqra'ahu 'alā al-nāsi 'alā mukthin wa-nazzalnāhu tanzīlā*, a recitation We have divided, that you may recite it to people at intervals, and We have sent it down in successive descents (Q 17:106). Deliverance of a true message on a governed schedule is a mercy toward the receivers, in both books.

The First Announcement, and the Rebuke · Mark 8:31-33

> And he began to teach them that the Son of Man must suffer many things and be rejected by the elders and the chief priests and the scribes and be killed, and after three days rise again. And he said this plainly. And Peter took him aside and began to rebuke

him. But turning and seeing his disciples, he rebuked Peter and said: Get behind me, Satan! For you are not setting your mind on the things of God, but on the things of man.

Commentary based on Quran

The silence has an exact boundary and Mark marks it in the next sentence. *And he said this plainly: kai parrēsia ton logon elalei*. *Parrēsia*, openness of speech, occurs once in this Gospel, here, two verses after the strictest charge to say nothing. The title is embargoed; the suffering is announced openly. Whatever this book is protecting, it is not the information about the cross, which is published the moment the title is sealed. The corpus's Prophet ﷺ is given the identical instruction about his own limits, to be said in the open: *qul mā kuntu bid'an mina al-rusuli wa-mā adrī mā yuf'alu bī wa-lā bikum*, say: I am not a novelty among the messengers, and I do not know what will be done with me or with you (Q 46:9). Both books publish the vulnerability and manage the title.

Peter, who had the title right, rebukes the man for the announcement, and receives the hardest words in the Gospel: *hypage opisō mou, Satana*. The reason given is not that Peter is wicked but that his mind is in the wrong register: *ou phroneis ta tou theou alla ta tōn anthrōpōn*, you are minding not the things of God but the things of men. The corpus draws that line with the same instrument, and draws it for its own Prophet ﷺ at the moment he most wanted a different outcome: *laysa laka mina al-amri shay'un*, not for you is anything of the matter (Q 3:128), spoken on a battlefield when he wished to curse his enemies or see them relent, and the verse continues, *aw yatūba 'alayhim aw yu'adhdhibahum*, whether He turns to them or punishes them, the disposal is His. And the corpus states the general form of Peter's error as a law of human judgment: *wa-'asā an takrahū shay'an wa-huwa khayrun lakum, wa-Allāhu ya'lamu wa-antum lā ta'lamūn*, it may be that you hate a thing and it is good for you; Allah ﷻ knows and you do not (Q 2:216). Peter hates the announcement. The corpus's verse is the exact commentary.

And a word about the title that carries this announcement and every one that follows. *The Son of Man* is Mark's own preferred designation in his subject's mouth, and it is heard best in the language actually spoken: *bar enasha*, the son of the human, the human one. In Daniel's vision one like a son of man approaches the Ancient of Days and is *given* dominion, *yehiv*, a passive of conferral (Daniel 7:14): even at its most exalted the phrase names a recipient. The corpus's self-designation for its own prophets runs on the same word, *innamā anā basharun mithlukum*, I am only a human like you (Q 18:110), and its final reduction of this prophet is *in huwa illā 'abdun an'amnā 'alayhi*, he was only a servant whom We favoured (Q 43:59). The announcement that begins here, that the human one must suffer, be killed, and rise, is spoken in a title whose grammar has always been the grammar of the recipient. This commentary reads it that way and notes that Mark gives no other.

The Terms of Following · Mark 8:34-9:1

> And he called to him the crowd with his disciples and said to them: If anyone would come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross and follow me. For whoever would save his life will lose it, but whoever loses his life for my sake and the gospel's will save it. For what does it profit a man to gain the whole world and forfeit his soul? For what can a man give in return for his soul? For whoever is ashamed of me and of my words in this adulterous and sinful generation, of him will the Son of Man also be ashamed when he comes in the glory of his Father with the holy angels. And he said to them: Truly, I say to you, there are some standing here who will not taste death until they see the kingdom of God after it has come with power.

Commentary based on Quran

The terms are three: deny yourself, take up the cross, follow. *Aparnēsasthō heauton*, let him say no to himself, and the corpus's word for the same discipline is *wa-nahā al-naḥṣa 'ani al-hawā*, and restrained the self from its craving, with the garden named as the consequence in the next clause (Q 79:40-41). The self-denial of the Gospel and the self-restraint of the corpus are the same operation, and both books make it the entry condition rather than a counsel for the advanced.

The economics that follow are the corpus's own. *What does it profit a man to gain the whole world and forfeit his soul?* The corpus runs that ledger constantly: *wa-mā al-ḥayātu al-dunyā illā matā'u al-ghurūr*, the life of this world is nothing but the enjoyment of delusion (Q 3:185), and *qul matā'u al-dunyā qalīlun wa-l-ākhiratu khayrun li-man ittaqā*, say: the enjoyment of this world is little, and the hereafter is better for the one who guards himself (Q 4:77). And the unanswerable question, *what can a man give in return for his soul?*, is the corpus's own rhetorical dead end at the Day: *fa-lan yuqbala min aḥadihim mil'u al-arḍi dhahaban wa-law iftadā bih*, an earth full of gold would not be accepted from one of them, though he offered it as ransom (Q 3:91). Both books put the same price on a soul, which is that it is not purchasable.

Then the shame-clause, and it carries a phrase this reading takes plainly. *When he comes in the glory of his Father with the holy angels: en tē doxē tou patros autou*. The glory is the Father's, and the coming is in it, which is the grammar of derived and conferred splendour, not of owned splendour. Daniel's *yehiv* again, in a Greek sentence. The corpus's picture of that Day places the majesty in one place only, *wa-jā'a rabbuka wa-l-malaku ṣaffan ṣaffā*, and your Lord comes, and the angels rank upon rank (Q 89:22), and *al-mulku yawma'idhin al-ḥaqqu li-l-Raḥmān*, the sovereignty that Day, the true one, belongs to the Merciful (Q 25:26). A servant arriving in his Lord's glory with his Lord's angels is a sentence both books can carry, and neither book has to be adjusted to carry it.

The last verse is the movement's first hard saying: *there are some standing here who will not taste death until they see the kingdom*

of God after it has come with power. The commentary does not paper over it. What can be said from the fixed position is that the corpus knows a category of the living-who-have-not-died-in-the-ordinary-sense and a category of sight granted before the general resurrection, and that its word for the transition is not annihilation but a taking: *kullu nafsin dhā'iqatu al-mawt*, every soul shall taste death (Q 3:185, Q 21:35, Q 29:57), the same tasting-metaphor Mark uses, and beside it the sentence about those killed in His way, *lā taqūlū li-man yuqtalu fī sabīli Allāhi amwātun, bal aḥyā'un wa-lākin lā tash'urūn*, do not say of those slain in the way of Allah ﷻ that they are dead; rather they are living, but you do not perceive (Q 2:154). Death in both books is a threshold with traffic in both directions and a Doorkeeper, and *tasting* it is an event that can be timed. Whether Mark's sentence refers to the transfiguration six days later, which is where he places it, or to the fall of the temple, or to something else, the commentary does not decide, and it notes that Mark's own arrangement puts the mountain in the very next verse.

The Mountain · Mark 9:2-8

> And after six days Jesus took with him Peter and James and John, and led them up a high mountain by themselves. And he was transfigured before them, and his clothes became radiant, intensely white, as no one on earth could bleach them. And there appeared to them Elijah with Moses, and they were talking with Jesus. And Peter said to Jesus: Rabbi, it is good that we are here. Let us make three tents, one for you and one for Moses and one for Elijah. For he did not know what to say, for they were terrified. And a cloud overshadowed them, and a voice came out of the cloud: This is my beloved Son; listen to him. And suddenly, looking around, they no longer saw anyone with them but Jesus only.

Commentary based on Quran

The scene is the book's summit and it is worth stating first what does not happen in it. He is *transfigured*, *metemorphōthē*, passive: the change is worked upon him. His clothes are made white beyond any earthly bleaching, which is a simile about laundry, and Mark reaches for it because he wants the whiteness understood as conferred rather than emitted. Two figures appear and *they were talking with Jesus*, and Mark reports no word of his. In the one scene where a later theology would most want a declaration, the subject of the Gospel says nothing at all. That is checkable in the text, and it is the scene's most eloquent feature.

Peter speaks instead, and proposes three tents, one apiece, and Mark supplies the note that has kept this passage honest for twenty centuries: *for he did not know what to say, for they were terrified*. The narrator marks the proposal as confusion before the correction arrives. And the correction is the whole point of the scene: a cloud, a voice, and then, *suddenly, looking around, they no longer saw anyone with them but Jesus only*. The three-way arrangement is dismantled in a single verse. The two who appeared are removed, and the redirection is total.

The voice says two things and the second is the operative one. *This is my beloved Son*, the words of the baptism, again stopping short of the Psalm's next clause. And then a command that is not in the baptism at all: *akouete autou*, listen to him. The scene ends in an imperative to the hearers, not a definition for the theologians. The corpus's own summit-scene has this shape exactly. When Mūsā AS asks to see, the Lord manifests to the mountain and the prophet falls senseless, and what he says on waking is *subhānaka tubtu ilayk*, glory be to You, I turn to You (Q 7:143): the disclosure ends in the servant's own act of turning, not in a formula. And the corpus's arrangement of the prophetic company runs the same dismantling of any three-way tableau: it assembles the prophets in long lists and then redirects, *ulā'ika alladhīna hadā Allāhu fa-bi-hudāhumu iqtadih*, those are the ones Allah ﷻ guided, so follow their guidance (Q 6:90), the roll called and the imperative delivered.

What the corpus never does is stack figure upon figure. Its typing is message upon message: *wa-mā arsalnā min qablika min rasūlin illā nūhī ilayhi annahu lā ilāha illā anā fa-'budūn*, We sent no messenger before you but that We revealed to him that there is no god but Me, so worship Me (Q 21:25), and *shara'a lakum mina al-dīni mā waṣṣā bihi Nūḥan wa-lladhī awḥaynā ilayka wa-mā waṣṣaynā bihi Ibrāhīma wa-Mūsā wa-'Isā, an aqīmū al-dīna walā tatafarraqū fih*, He has instituted for you of the religion what He enjoined upon Nūḥ, and what We have revealed to you, and what We enjoined upon Ibrāhīm and Mūsā and 'Isā: that you establish the religion and do not divide over it (Q 42:13). Five names in one sentence, one message, and the closing warning is against splitting. The mountain in Mark performs that verse in narrative: three figures, one voice, one instruction, and then two of the three withdrawn so that the instruction has a single addressee.

And the corpus's warning about what happens after such moments deserves to sit beside this scene, because it is the reason both books put the redirection first. Division comes *after* the knowledge arrives, never before it: *wa-mā tafarraqu illā min ba'di mā jā'ahumu al-'ilmu baghyan baynahum*, they did not divide until after knowledge had come to them, out of rivalry among themselves (Q 42:14, and the same clause at Q 45:17 and Q 98:4, with Q 2:213 and Q 3:105 completing the set). Five times the corpus states that the splitting followed the clarity. On a high mountain, at the moment of maximum clarity, a disciple proposed three tents; the cloud came, and the arrangement was taken down.

Coming Down · Mark 9:9-13

> And as they were coming down the mountain, he charged them to tell no one what they had seen, until the Son of Man had risen from the dead. So they kept the matter to themselves, questioning what this rising from the dead might mean. And they asked him: Why do the scribes say that first Elijah must come? And he said to them: Elijah does come first to restore all things. And how is it written of the Son of Man that he should suffer many things and

be treated with contempt? But I tell you that Elijah has come, and they did to him whatever they pleased, as it is written of him.

Commentary based on Quran

Silencing, nine, and this one carries an expiry date: *until the Son of Man had risen from the dead*. The embargo is temporary by design, exactly as the lamp of Mk 4:22 was hidden only in order to be set out.

Then Mark records something no evangelist inventing a seamless narrative would write: *they kept the matter to themselves, questioning what this rising from the dead might mean*. Three men who have just seen the mountain do not know what the phrase means. The Greek is *ek nekrōn*, from among the dead, a partitive: not *from death* as an abstract state but *out of the dead ones*, a population. And their puzzlement is honest, because the resurrection they had been taught was general and at the end; a single rising out of the middle of the dead was not a category they held. The corpus supplies both categories and keeps them distinct. The general one is the ladder of Q 2:28, *kuntum amwātan fa-aḥyākum thumma yumītukum thumma yuḥyīkum thumma ilayhi turja'ūn*, you were dead and He gave you life, then He causes you to die, then He gives you life, then to Him you return; and Q 40:11 states the same arithmetic in the mouths of those who lived it, *rabbanā amattanā ithnatayni wa-aḥyaytanā ithnatayn*, our Lord, You made us die twice and gave us life twice. And beside the general ladder the corpus keeps particular risings: the sleepers raised after their long term, *thumma ba'athnāhum* (Q 18:12); the man who was made to die a hundred years and then raised with his food unspoiled and his donkey rebuilt before his eyes (Q 2:259); the slain man struck with part of the cow and returned to speak (Q 2:72-73). Individual raisings out of the population of the dead are a thing the corpus narrates plainly. The disciples' confusion is a fact about first-century expectation, not a gap in either scripture.

The Elijah exchange then settles the identification the crowds kept fumbling. *Elijah has come, and they did to him whatever they pleased*: the forerunner, already beheaded four chapters back. The corpus's own instrument for this is the office, not the person. It calls Yahyā AS *muṣaddiqan bi-kalimatīn min Allāh* (Q 3:39), a confirmer standing in the appointed place, and it never transmigrates a soul; what recurs in both books is the *function*, the one sent ahead to prepare, and Mark's sentence says the function was filled and the filler was killed.

One clause in this passage is more difficult than any commentary should pretend, and the honest report is short. *How is it written of the Son of Man that he should suffer many things and be treated with contempt?* No single passage of the Hebrew scriptures says that. Daniel 7 has the exalted human figure who is *given* dominion; Isaiah 53 has the servant despised and crushed; and the welding of the two, an exalted son of man who suffers, happens in this sentence and not in any source it could be quoting. The Qumran library, which preserves the messianic expectations of the period in the community's own hand, keeps the two apart: a

priestly and a royal messiah are named together (1QS 9:11), a coming figure's works are listed as healing and raising the dead (4Q521), and no securely readable text presents a *suffering* messiah, the one candidate being a fragment whose damaged line reads either way. So the scriptural warrant for a suffering Son of Man is asserted here rather than cited, and the corpus, six centuries later, is the book that declines to build that fusion at all: it keeps the servant's honour and the raising and states, at Q 4:157-158, that the ending did not run the way the plotters recorded. The commentary marks the seam, states what the manuscripts show, and does not manufacture a source that the evidence does not contain.

The Boy at the Foot of the Mountain · Mark 9:14-29

> And when they came to the disciples, they saw a great crowd around them, and scribes arguing with them. And immediately all the crowd, when they saw him, were greatly amazed and ran up to him and greeted him. And he asked them: What are you arguing about with them? And someone from the crowd answered him: Teacher, I brought my son to you, for he has a spirit that makes him mute. And whenever it seizes him, it throws him down, and he foams and grinds his teeth and becomes rigid. So I asked your disciples to cast it out, and they were not able. And he answered them: O faithless generation, how long am I to be with you? How long am I to bear with you? Bring him to me.

Commentary based on Quran

The mountain descends into a shouting match. The disciples have failed publicly, the scribes are pressing the failure, and the father's sentence carries the movement's key word: *ouk ischysan*, they were not able, literally they had not the strength.

Strength, four, and with this instance the chain is complete and worth reading whole. The forerunner announced one *mightier* than himself (Mk 1:7). The teaching said no one can plunder the strong man's house unless he first binds the strong (Mk 3:27). On the far shore, *no one had the strength* to subdue the man among the tombs (Mk 5:4). Here, nine chapters in, the men who were *given* authority over unclean spirits find they have not the strength to use it. And the chain will close on Peter in a garden, *you had not the strength to watch one hour* (Mk 14:37). Read in sequence it is a single argument: strength in this Gospel is never a possession, it is a grant, and the grant is renewed per occasion or it is not there. The corpus states that as the plain condition of every messenger, *wa-mā kāna li-rasūlin an ya'tiya bi-āyatin illā bi-idhni Allāh* (Q 40:78), and states it of the strongest creature in its own narrative when the corpus's Sulaymān AS asks for the throne and the one *with knowledge from the Book* delivers it and immediately says *hādha min faḍli rabbī*, this is from the bounty of my Lord (Q 27:40).

> And they brought the boy to him. And when the spirit saw him, immediately it convulsed the boy, and he fell on the ground and rolled about, foaming at the mouth. And Jesus asked his father: How long has this been happening to him? And he said: From

childhood. And it has often cast him into fire and into water, to destroy him. But if you can do anything, have compassion on us and help us. And Jesus said to him: If you can! All things are possible for one who believes. Immediately the father of the child cried out and said: I believe; help my unbelief!

How long has this been happening? He asks, and receives information. The question is not a device; the narrative has him learn the case history from the father, exactly as he learned who touched him by turning and looking. The corpus's grammar for its prophets, *wa-lā a'lamu al-ghayb* (Q 6:50), fits the scene without adjustment.

Then the exchange that turns the whole passage. The father says *if you can do anything*, and the phrase is thrown back at him: *to ei dynē*, this *if you can!* The ability is not the variable under discussion, and the answer relocates it: *panta dynata tō pisteuonti*, all things are possible for the one who trusts. Not *for me*, but *for the one who trusts*, which moves the question from the healer's capacity to the receiver's posture, and moves the capacity itself upstream of both. The corpus performs the identical relocation, and in the mouth of this same prophet. When the disciples ask *hal yastaṭī'u rabbuka an yunazzila 'alaynā mā'idatan mina al-samā'*, is your Lord able to send down a table from heaven, the answer is not a demonstration but a correction of posture: *ittaḡu Allāha in kuntum mu'minīn*, be mindful of Allah ﷻ if you are believers (Q 5:112). The ability question was the wrong question in both scenes, and both texts answer it by turning it around.

And the father's reply is one of the great sentences of the Gospel: *pisteuō; boēthei mou tē apistia*, I believe; help my unbelief. A petition made from inside an acknowledged deficiency, asking the One addressed to supply what the petitioner lacks in order to petition. The corpus's standing prayer has the same shape, *ihdinā al-ṣirāṭ al-mustaqīm*, guide us to the straight path, asked by people already on it, and *rabbī zidnī 'ilmā*, my Lord, increase me in knowledge (Q 20:114), the one increase its Prophet ﷺ is commanded to keep asking for. Faith in both books is not a stock that is either held or missing; it is a thing given, and asked for, and increased, *li-yazdādū ṡmānan ma'a ṡmānihim*, that they might increase in faith along with their faith (Q 48:4).

> And when Jesus saw that a crowd came running together, he rebuked the unclean spirit, saying to it: You mute and deaf spirit, I command you, come out of him and never enter him again. And after crying out and convulsing him terribly, it came out, and the boy was like a corpse, so that most of them said: He is dead. But Jesus took him by the hand and lifted him up, and he arose. And when he had entered the house, his disciples asked him privately: Why could we not cast it out? And he said to them: This kind cannot be driven out by anything but prayer.

The boy is left *like a corpse*, and the crowd pronounces him dead, and the lifting is the same gesture as the girl's in chapter five: *kratēsas tēs cheiros*, taking the hand, *ēgeiren*, he raised him. Mark keeps rehearsing that verb.

And the private answer is the movement's quietest and largest sentence. *This kind cannot be driven out by anything but prayer.* The earliest manuscripts read exactly that, and later copies add *and fasting*, a scribal supplement that the oldest witnesses do not carry. The unadorned original is stronger and it is the whole doctrine of this Gospel in nine words: authority that was genuinely given can be genuinely unavailable, and what re-opens it is not technique but petition. The one who has been withdrawing to pray since chapter one tells the men who failed that the missing element was the thing they had watched him do alone in the dark.

And here the corpus supplies its most precise grammatical witness, the one this commentary named at its threshold. Through Sūrat al-Baqarah a series of questions comes to the Prophet ﷺ, and every answer is routed through him by command: they ask you about the new moons, *qul*, say; they ask you about fighting in the sacred month, *qul*, say; they ask you about wine and gambling, *qul*, say; they ask you what they should spend, *qul*, say. The pattern is unbroken except once. *Wa-idhā sa'alaka 'ibādī 'annī fa-innī qarīb, ujibu da'wata al-dā'i idhā da'ān*, and when My servants ask you about Me, then I am near; I answer the call of the caller when he calls Me (Q 2:186). No *qul*. On the one subject that is Himself, the messenger is deleted from the sentence and the answer is given in the first person, direct. That is the structure of prayer in the corpus, stated by the absence of a single word, and it is the structure Mark's Messiah practises in the desolate place, on the mountain, in Gethsemane, and prescribes here to men who could not do what they had been empowered to do. The line runs from the servant to the Lord with nothing standing in it, and the corpus's grammar proves the vacancy.

The Second Announcement, and the Argument on the Road · Mark 9:30-37

> They went on from there and passed through Galilee. And he did not want anyone to know, for he was teaching his disciples, saying to them: The Son of Man is going to be delivered into the hands of men, and they will kill him. And when he is killed, after three days he will rise. But they did not understand the saying, and were afraid to ask him. And they came to Capernaum. And when he was in the house he asked them: What were you discussing on the way? But they kept silent, for on the way they had argued with one another about who was the greatest. And he sat down and called the twelve. And he said to them: If anyone would be first, he must be last of all and servant of all. And he took a child and put him in the midst of them, and taking him in his arms, he said to them: Whoever receives one such child in my name receives me, and whoever receives me, receives not me but him who sent me.

Commentary based on Quran

The second announcement is briefer and its verb is the one that will govern the passion: *paradidotai*, is being delivered, handed over, a passive in the present tense with the deliverer unnamed. And the response is a silence with fear in it, *ephobounto auton*

eperōtēsai, and then, on the road, an argument about rank. Mark places the two side by side without comment. The announcement of the handing-over and the quarrel about precedence are separated by one verse.

The correction is not a scolding but an inversion of the order they were ranking themselves in: *if anyone would be first, he must be last of all and servant of all.* *Diakonos pantōn*, and the serving-verb this Gospel has been storing since the angels in the wilderness and the woman in the kitchen now arrives in its imperative form. The corpus's own picture of the ranks it honours is built on the same inversion, *wa-'ibādu al-Raḥmāni alladhīna yamshūna 'alā al-arḍi hawnan*, and the servants of the Merciful are those who walk upon the earth in humility (Q 25:63), a title-list that begins with the word *servants* and describes a gait.

Then the child, and the sentence that is the clearest statement of transmission in the book. *Whoever receives me, receives not me but him who sent me: ouk eme dechetai alla ton aposteilanta me.* The correction is inside the sentence, *not me*, and it is the same self-effacement the corpus builds into obedience itself: *man yuṭī 'i al-rasūla fa-qad aṭā 'a Allāh*, whoever obeys the messenger has obeyed Allah ﷻ (Q 4:80). The messenger is transparent to the Sender in both books, and both books say so in one clause that first names the messenger and then moves past him. Mark's version is the more radical of the two, because it uses a negation: it corrects the reception mid-sentence. The receiving stops at nobody until it reaches the One who sent.

The Outsider, and the Cup of Water · Mark 9:38-41

> John said to him: Teacher, we saw someone casting out demons in your name, and we tried to stop him, because he was not following us. But Jesus said: Do not stop him, for no one who does a mighty work in my name will be able soon afterward to speak evil of me. For the one who is not against us is for us. For truly, I say to you, whoever gives you a cup of water to drink because you belong to Christ will by no means lose his reward.

Commentary based on Quran

An unlicensed exorcist, effective, outside the circle, and the circle wants him stopped. The objection is stated with unusual candour: *because he was not following us.* Not *not following you*. The disciples have already begun to think of the mission as a franchise with themselves inside it.

Do not stop him. The permission-structure this commentary has tracked from the first chapter cuts both ways: if the works are done by a granted authority and not an owned one, then the grant is the Giver's to place where He wills, and no circle can fence it. The corpus states that as a rule about the Giver rather than about the recipients: *yakhtaṣṣu bi-raḥmatihī man yashā'*, He singles out for His mercy whom He wills (Q 2:105, Q 3:74), and *a-hum yaqsimūna raḥmata rabbik*, is it they who apportion the mercy of your Lord (Q 43:32).

And the closing line prices the smallest possible act. *A cup of water* given for the sake of the name will not lose its reward, and the corpus's scale is the same and finer: *fa-man ya'mal mithqāla dharratin khayran yarah*, whoever does an atom's weight of good will see it (Q 99:7). Both books close their teaching on rank by valuing the least conspicuous deed, and both do it immediately after warning the insiders about gatekeeping.

The Millstone, the Hand, and the Salt · Mark 9:42-50

> Whoever causes one of these little ones who believe in me to sin, it would be better for him if a great millstone were hung around his neck and he were thrown into the sea. And if your hand causes you to sin, cut it off. It is better for you to enter life crippled than with two hands to go to hell, to the unquenchable fire. And if your foot causes you to sin, cut it off. It is better for you to enter life lame than with two feet to be thrown into hell. And if your eye causes you to sin, tear it out. It is better for you to enter the kingdom of God with one eye than with two eyes to be thrown into hell, where their worm does not die and the fire is not quenched. For everyone will be salted with fire. Salt is good, but if the salt has lost its saltiness, how will you make it salty again? Have salt in yourselves, and be at peace with one another.

Commentary based on Quran

The passage opens on the gravest warning in the Gospel about the vulnerable, and this is where the corpus and Mark move in step: harming the small is not a lesser offence in either book. The corpus fences the same class with its own severity, the orphan's property as fire swallowed into the belly (Q 4:10), and the buried infant summoned as a witness on the Day, *bi-ayyi dhanbin qutilat*, for what sin was she killed (Q 81:8-9). Both books make the defenceless the sharpest edge of the judgment.

Then the amputations, and this reading names a divergence rather than dissolving it. Mark's Messiah says cut off the hand, cut off the foot, tear out the eye. The register is the hyperbolic wisdom-speech of that world, and the same speaker who says this heals hands and eyes throughout the book, so nothing in Mark suggests a surgical programme. But the corpus, addressing the identical problem of the organ that leads a man into ruin, legislates rather than exaggerates, and legislates restraint: *qul li-l-mu'minīna yaghuḍḍū min abṣārihim wa-yaḥfaẓū furūjahum*, tell the believing men to lower their gaze and guard their chastity, and the same to the believing women in the next verse (Q 24:30-31). Lower the eye, do not remove it. The two texts share the diagnosis exactly, that the member is the doorway, and they differ in the treatment prescribed, one by shocking figure and one by governed discipline. The commentary states that difference and leaves it standing, and notes only that the corpus's instrument is the one a community can actually be given.

Then the salt, three sentences that have puzzled readers for centuries and that come clear the moment the older law is put back beside them.

Salt in that world is the one kitchen substance that cannot be grown. Grain is sown, oil is pressed, wine is trodden, but salt is dug or evaporated and then carried and bought, and no household produces its own. That single physical fact is why the Torah made it the covenant material. *All the holy offerings that the Israelites present to the LORD I have given to you and your sons and daughters as a perpetual due; it is a covenant of salt forever* (Numbers 18:19), and what that covenant conveys is a *stipend*: the priests receive from the offerings because they hold no land and grow nothing. The idiom persists in the imperial administration of the region, where the officials of the Persian court write to the king *because we eat the salt of the palace* (Ezra 4:14), which means we are on your provision and our loyalty follows our bread. And Leviticus makes it a standing rule of the altar, *with all your offerings you shall offer salt* (Leviticus 2:13), so that nothing is presented to God without the ingredient the presenter could not make.

That is the whole doctrine, and it is the corpus's doctrine of provision rendered in a mineral. A covenant sealed in salt is a covenant with dependence built into its material: the token itself declares that the party bringing it did not produce it. The corpus states the same thing without a token, which is the direction this commentary keeps finding, from applied blood to added salt to the word alone: *wa-mā bikum min ni'matin fa-mina Allāh*, whatever favour is with you is from Allah ﷻ (Q 16:53), and *wa-in ta'uddū ni'mata Allāhi lā tuḥṣūhā*, if you count the favour of Allah ﷻ you will not number it (Q 14:34).

Then the last clause and its verb. *Have salt in yourselves: echete en heautois hala*. Not *become salty*, which would be an instruction to manufacture, but *have it in you*, a possession by nature received. The salt is already given; the instruction is to keep it. And the pairing with the final phrase is the passage's point: *have salt in yourselves, and be at peace with one another*, addressed to men who had spent the last road arguing about who was greatest. The mineral of the covenant is set directly against the quarrel about rank, and the corpus supplies the sentence that closes the loop, spoken about the joining of a community's hearts: *law anfaqtā mā fī al-arḍi jamī'an mā allafta bayna qulūbihim walākinna Allāha allafa baynahum*, had you spent all that is in the earth you could not have joined their hearts, but Allah ﷻ joined them (Q 8:63). Peace among the servants is the second thing in this passage that cannot be produced by the ones who need it, and both are given. Have the salt you were given; be at peace with the brother you were joined to.

A last note on transmission, because it is visible in the manuscripts. Some copies of Mark add to *everyone will be salted with fire* the words *and every sacrifice will be salted with salt*, which is Leviticus 2:13 quoted directly. The addition is not original, and it is a scribe's gloss rather than a corruption of sense: an early reader recognised the altar-law standing behind the sentence and wrote it in the margin, and the margin came into the

text. The connection this commentary makes is one the copyists had already made.

Divorce, and the Beginning · Mark 10:1-12

> And he left there and went to the region of Judea and beyond the Jordan, and crowds gathered to him again. And again, as was his custom, he taught them. And Pharisees came up and in order to test him asked: Is it lawful for a man to divorce his wife? He answered them: What did Moses command you? They said: Moses allowed a man to write a certificate of divorce and to send her away. And Jesus said to them: Because of your hardness of heart he wrote you this commandment. But from the beginning of creation, God made them male and female. Therefore a man shall leave his father and mother and hold fast to his wife, and the two shall become one flesh. So they are no longer two but one flesh. What therefore God has joined together, let not man separate. And in the house the disciples asked him again about this matter. And he said to them: Whoever divorces his wife and marries another commits adultery against her, and if she divorces her husband and marries another, she commits adultery.

Commentary based on Quran

The question is a trap between two rabbinic schools, and the answer refuses the terms by going behind the legislation to the design. *Because of your hardness of heart he wrote you this commandment*: the Mosaic permission is classed as an accommodation to a condition, not as the intention. The corpus uses the identical instrument on the identical people, *fa-bimā naqđihim mīthāqahum la'annāhum wa-ja'alnā qulūbahum qāsiyah*, so for their breaking of their covenant We cursed them and made their hearts hard (Q 5:13), and it also classes certain of their restrictions as consequences rather than as the original good, *fa-bi-zulmin mina alladhīna hādū ḥarramnā 'alayhim ṭayyibātīn uḥillat lahum*, for the wrongdoing of those who were Jews We forbade them good things that had been lawful to them (Q 4:160). Legislation calibrated to a hardened condition is a category both books hold.

The argument from the beginning is Genesis, and the corpus argues from the same beginning with the same move: *yā ayyuhā al-nāsu ittaqū rabbakumu alladhī khalaqakum min nafsin wāḥidatin wa-khalaqa minhā zawjahā*, O mankind, be mindful of your Lord who created you from a single soul and created from it its mate (Q 4:1). One origin, then the pair, then the derivation of every duty from that origin: the corpus's verse continues straight into the command about kinship ties, exactly as Mark's argument moves from the one flesh to the prohibition on separating.

And here a divergence must be named at its right layer, because the two texts do not legislate the same way. The corpus permits divorce and regulates it in detail: waiting periods, two announcements with the option of return, witnesses, provision, and the standing instruction *fa-imsākun bi-ma'rūfin aw tasrīhun bi-iḥsān*, retention in kindness or release with excellence (Q 2:229), with the reminder not to forget generosity between them.

Mark's sentence, taken as legislation, forbids what the corpus regulates. What the two share, and share exactly, is the weight placed on the bond itself. The corpus calls the marriage contract *mīthāqan ghalīẓan*, a solemn covenant (Q 4:21), and it uses that phrase for only three things in the whole book: the covenant taken from the prophets (Q 33:7), the covenant taken at Sinai (Q 4:154), and this. A marriage ranked with the covenant of the prophets is not a dissoluble convenience, and the corpus's own transmitted teaching calls its permitted dissolution the most detested of permitted things. So the layer report is precise: on the sanctity and origin of the bond the two texts stand together and use the same argument from creation; on whether the bond may be dissolved and under what discipline, they part, one prohibiting and one regulating, and the commentary lets the parting stand where it falls rather than dissolving it upward.

The Children · Mark 10:13-16

> And they were bringing children to him that he might touch them, and the disciples rebuked them. But when Jesus saw it, he was indignant and said to them: Let the children come to me; do not hinder them, for to such belongs the kingdom of God. Truly, I say to you, whoever does not receive the kingdom of God like a child shall not enter it. And he took them in his arms and blessed them, laying his hands on them.

Commentary based on Quran

The gatekeeping instinct appears for the third time in two chapters, and the reaction is stronger than anywhere else in the book: *ēganaktēsen*, he was indignant. What the child models is not innocence but *receiving*: a child in that world owned nothing, earned nothing, and was given everything, which is the exact posture the whole Gospel has been teaching about authority, provision, strength, and sight. The corpus's word for the original constitution a person is given and then either keeps or overlays is *fiṭra*: *fa-aqim wajhaka li-l-dīni ḥanīfan*, *fiṭrata Allāhi allatī faṭara al-nāsa 'alayhā*, set your face to the religion, upright, the original nature of Allah ﷻ upon which He originated humankind (Q 30:30). Entering as a child is returning to what was given before anything was accumulated, and the arms and the blessing that close the scene are Mark's last tenderness before the road turns to Jerusalem.

The Man Who Ran · Mark 10:17-31

> And as he was setting out on his journey, a man ran up and knelt before him and asked him: Good Teacher, what must I do to inherit eternal life? And Jesus said to him: Why do you call me good? No one is good except God alone. You know the commandments: Do not murder, Do not commit adultery, Do not steal, Do not bear false witness, Do not defraud, Honor your father and mother. And he said to him: Teacher, all these I have kept from my youth. And Jesus, looking at him, loved him, and said to him: You lack one thing: go, sell all that you have and give to the poor, and you will have treasure in heaven; and come,

follow me. Disheartened by the saying, he went away sorrowful, for he had great possessions.

Commentary based on Quran

The address is unusual and the deflection turns on it. *Didaskale agathe*, good teacher: an adjective attached to a title, and the rabbinic literature of the period offers no parallel for addressing a teacher that way. The man reaches for a compliment, and the compliment is returned to its owner: *why do you call me good? No one is good except God alone, ei mē heis ho theos*. Matthew, copying, moves the adjective off the person and onto the deed, asking about *the good thing to do*, and the smoothing is watchable.

From the fixed position this is the plainest sentence in the Gospel and it needs no commentary at all, only its Arabic. But there is more in it than a refusal, because the corpus works this exact root and shows what the deflection is protecting. *Al-Barr* is a divine name, the Good, the Beneficent, sealed at the end of *Sūrat al-Ṭūr*: *innahu huwa al-Barru al-Raḥīm*, He is the Good, the Merciful (Q 52:28), and the pronoun-plus-definite construction is the same equational form Part II examined. Beneath the Name stands the quality, *al-birr*, and the corpus defines it in one long verse rather than leaving it a mood: *laysa al-birra an tuwallū wujūhakum qibala al-mashriqi wa-l-maghrib, wa-lākinna al-birra man āmana bi-llāh*, goodness is not that you turn your faces east or west, but goodness is one who believes in Allah ﷻ, and the verse continues into the giving of wealth, *out of love for it*, to kin, orphans, the needy, the traveller, the beggar, and for the freeing of necks (Q 2:177). And then the corpus states the condition of attaining it: *lan tanālū al-birra ḥattā tunfiqū mim mā tuḥibbūn*, you will never attain goodness until you spend of what you love (Q 3:92).

Set that beside what happens next in Mark and the two halves lock. The man calls him good; the title is deflected upward to its Owner; and then the man is told the one thing he lacks, which is to give away what he loves. The deflection and the instruction are the same root two forms apart, the Name refused for himself and the quality prescribed for the questioner, and the corpus's verse states the prescription in words the scene is enacting. *Go, sell what you have and give to the poor* is *lan tanālū al-birra ḥattā tunfiqū mim mā tuḥibbūn*, and the sorrow the man leaves with is the measure of how much he loved it.

One item in the commandment list is not from the Decalogue at all: *mē apostērēsēs*, do not defraud, do not withhold what is owed. It belongs to the wage-law, *you shall not oppress a hired worker who is poor and needy; you shall give him his wages on the same day* (Deuteronomy 24:14-15, Leviticus 19:13). Both evangelists who copy Mark drop it, and it is left standing here in a list given to a rich man. The corpus opens an entire surah on the same offence: *waylun li-l-muṭaffifīn*, woe to those who give short measure, who take in full from people and shortchange them when they measure out (Q 83:1-3), and it closes the door with *wa-awfū al-kayla wa-l-mizāna bi-l-qist*, give full measure and weight in justice (Q 6:152). The commandment inserted for the wealthy

man is about what he owes those who work for him, and it is the same substance as the salt: a stipend, unwithheld.

> And Jesus looked around and said to his disciples: How difficult it will be for those who have wealth to enter the kingdom of God! And the disciples were amazed at his words. But Jesus said to them again: Children, how difficult it is to enter the kingdom of God! It is easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle than for a rich person to enter the kingdom of God. And they were exceedingly astonished, and said to him: Then who can be saved? Jesus looked at them and said: With man it is impossible, but not with God. For all things are possible with God.

The camel and the needle is the one image in this Gospel that crosses into the corpus intact, word for word, with the same two animals of scale and aperture: *lā tufattaḥu lahum abwābu al-samā'i wa-lā yadkhulūna al-jannata ḥattā yaliya al-jamalu fī sammi al-khiyāt*, the gates of heaven will not be opened for them, nor will they enter the garden until the camel passes through the eye of the needle (Q 7:40). Transit, full, two, and the ledger notes that the corpus places it in exactly the same argumentative position, on those whose wealth and pride shut the upper door.

And the closing exchange gives the 'inda-chain its Greek link. *Para anthrōpōis adynaton, all' ou para theō; panta gar dynata para tō theō*: with men impossible, but not with God, for all things are possible with God. *Para tō theō* is the Greek of 'inda *Allāh*, the preposition this commentary has been counting since the Mother of the Book, and here it carries the same freight: what is impossible in the register of human capacity is not impossible in the register of what is with Him. Link five. The corpus's own formula for this exact reassurance is *inna Allāha 'alā kulli shay'in qadīr*, Allah ﷻ is powerful over all things, repeated across the book, and the whole doctrine of the rich man's case is that entry is not purchased by the entrant, which is why the disciples' question, *then who can be saved*, receives an answer that names nobody's competence but His.

> Peter began to say to him: See, we have left everything and followed you. Jesus said: Truly, I say to you, there is no one who has left house or brothers or sisters or mother or father or children or lands, for my sake and for the gospel, who will not receive a hundredfold now in this time, houses and brothers and sisters and mothers and children and lands, with persecutions, and in the age to come eternal life. But many who are first will be last, and the last first.

The hundredfold is promised, and Mark alone inserts two words into the middle of the promise: *meta diōgmōn*, with persecutions. Neither copyist keeps them. The honesty is the authentication, and the corpus's own promise to those who emigrate for His sake is built the same way, the reward stated and the cost named in the same breath: *wa-man yuhājir fī sabīli Allāhi yajid fī al-arḍi murāghaman kathīran wa-sa'ah*, whoever emigrates in the way of Allah ﷻ will find on the earth many a refuge and abundance (Q 4:100), set among verses about those driven from their homes.

And the closing inversion, *many who are first will be last*, is a warning to the men who have just listed their sacrifices, delivered one verse after their spokesman said *see, we have left everything*. The corpus grades the Day by proportion rather than reversal, *fa-man ya'mal mithqāla dharratin khayran yarah* (Q 99:7), and it warns the ones who count their own credit in its own way: *lā tubtīlū ṣadaqātikum bi-l-manni wa-l-adhā*, do not nullify your charities with reminders of your generosity and with injury (Q 2:264). Peter reminded. The next sentence he hears is that the order can invert.

The Third Announcement · Mark 10:32-34

> And they were on the road, going up to Jerusalem, and Jesus was walking ahead of them. And they were amazed, and those who followed were afraid. And taking the twelve again, he began to tell them what was to happen to him, saying: See, we are going up to Jerusalem, and the Son of Man will be delivered over to the chief priests and the scribes, and they will condemn him to death and deliver him over to the Gentiles. And they will mock him and spit on him and flog him and kill him. And after three days he will rise.

Commentary based on Quran

Jesus was walking ahead of them, ēn proagōn autous. The verb enters here and it will carry to the end: he goes before them to Jerusalem, he tells them at the supper that he will go before them into Galilee, and the young man at the tomb repeats the word to the women. The one who is delivered is the one walking in front, and the company behind him is amazed and afraid.

The announcement is the fullest of the three, and among its verbs is *emptysousin autō*, they will spit on him. Spittle, three, and this instance is prophecy rather than event: the fluid that opened a deaf man's ears and a blind man's eyes is now foretold as an instrument of contempt. The corpus's general law for the treatment of messengers covers it without needing the detail: *yā ḥasratān 'alā al-'ibād, mā ya'tīhim min rasūlin illā kānū bihi yastahzi'ūn*, what regret for the servants; no messenger came to them but they mocked him (Q 36:30).

The Sons of Zebedee, and the Cup · Mark 10:35-45

> And James and John, the sons of Zebedee, came up to him and said to him: Teacher, we want you to do for us whatever we ask of you. And he said to them: What do you want me to do for you? And they said to him: Grant us to sit, one at your right hand and one at your left, in your glory. Jesus said to them: You do not know what you are asking. Are you able to drink the cup that I drink, or to be baptized with the baptism with which I am baptized? And they said to him: We are able. And Jesus said to them: The cup that I drink you will drink, and with the baptism with which I am baptized, you will be baptized, but to sit at my right hand or at my left is not mine to grant, but it is for those for whom it has been prepared.

Commentary based on Quran

The third announcement of the killing is followed immediately by a request for cabinet positions. Mark's arrangement is the sharpest in the book, and he does not comment.

And the answer contains the sentence this commentary has been walking toward since chapter one. *To sit at my right hand or at my left is not mine to grant: ouk estin emon dounai*. The Greek is unambiguous and no manuscript softens it. Asked for the highest thing in his gift, the answer is that it is not in his gift. The corpus asks the same question as a rebuke to anyone who assumes otherwise: *a-hum yaqsimūna raḥmata rabbik*, is it they who apportion the mercy of your Lord? *Naḥnu qasamnā baynahum ma'ishatahum*, We have apportioned among them their livelihood (Q 43:32). The apportioning is the Lord's, and the Gospel's own Messiah says so in the plainest words available to him.

And the clause that completes it is the third of Mark's formal divine passives: *alla hois hētoimastai*, but for those for whom it has been prepared. Prepared, passive, by the unnamed Preparer, and the Preparer is the one the seats belong to. The count of that construction now stands at three, the cleansing commanded, the hand restored, the seats prepared, and the convention has been running under every major scene in the book. The corpus's own version of the sentence is *a'adda Allāhu lahum*, Allah ﷻ has prepared it for them (Q 9:89, Q 58:15, and elsewhere), the identical verb with the Agent named rather than reverently omitted. Mark leaves the blank; the corpus fills it; and the two grammars agree that the seats were not the servant's to distribute.

The cup is the other half of the answer, and the transit ledger records it as partial. *The cup that I drink* is the prophets' cup of Isaiah 51:17 and Jeremiah 25:15, the cup of wrath handed to a people to drink; the image carries the sense of a portion assigned and unavoidable, and the Gethsemane prayer will take it up. The corpus's *ka's* is never that cup. Every occurrence of the word in the corpus is the drink of the garden, *yusqawna min raḥiqin makhtūm*, given a sealed nectar (Q 83:25), *ka'san kāna mizājuhā kāfūrā*, a cup mixed with camphor (Q 76:5), and *lā laghwun fīhā wa-lā ta'thīm*, no idle talk in it and no sin (Q 52:23). The image crossed the earlier scriptures and did not cross into the corpus, which reserved the word for the reward and named the portion of suffering with other vocabulary altogether, *balā'* and *fitna* and *ibtīlā'*. Transit, partial, and the ledger states which way it broke.

> And when the ten heard it, they began to be indignant at James and John. And Jesus called them to him and said to them: You know that those who are considered rulers of the Gentiles lord it over them, and their great ones exercise authority over them. But it shall not be so among you. But whoever would be great among you must be your servant, and whoever would be first among you must be slave of all. For even the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many.

The political analysis is two words long and exact: *katakryrieuousin*, they lord it down over them, and

katexousiazousin, they wield authority down upon them. Both compounds are downward. And the inversion follows: not so among you, the great one is the servant, the first is the slave of all. The corpus's picture of the same disease and the same cure is Q 28:83, *tilka al-dāru al-ākhiratu naj' aluhā li-lladhīna lā yurīdūna 'uluwwan fī al-arḍi wa-lā fasādā*, that final home We assign to those who desire neither exaltation on the earth nor corruption, and its picture of the office of its own Prophet ﷺ is *wa-mā anta 'alayhim bi-jabbār*, you are not a tyrant over them (Q 50:45), and *lasta 'alayhim bi-muṣaytir*, you are not over them a controller (Q 88:22).

Then *the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve*, and the verb this commentary has been storing since chapter one arrives at its inversion. Angels served him in the wilderness; a woman raised from fever served the table; and here the receiving is spent and reversed. The corpus's word for the same figure, in the strongest reduction it offers, is *in huwa illā 'abdun an'amnā 'alayh*, he was only a servant whom We favoured (Q 43:59), and its statement of what he never disdained is *lan yastankifa al-Masīhu an yakūna 'abdan lillāh* (Q 4:172). The Gospel's sentence and the corpus's sentence describe one posture, and the Gospel's is the narrative and the corpus's is the doctrine.

The last clause, *to give his life as a ransom for many*, *lytron anti pollōn*, is the one place in Mark where the death is given an interpretation, and the commentary reports what is there rather than what centuries built on it. *Lytron* is the price of release, a commercial and legal word. Mark supplies no theory of how the release operates, no altar, no substitutionary mechanism, no doctrine of imputation; the whole clause is four words at the end of a lesson about not lording it over people, and the lesson is its context. The corpus has one ransom-narrative and one only, and it is stated with the same word-family: *wa-fadaynāhu bi-dhibhin 'aẓīm*, and We ransomed him with a mighty sacrifice (Q 37:107), where the Ransomer is Allah ﷻ, the ransomed is the son of Ibrāhīm AS, and the direction runs from above downward as deliverance. So the category of a ransom given is present in both scriptures and its subject in the corpus is always the Giver above. The corpus states elsewhere, in the same breath as its account of that son, the law that no soul carries another's load, *wa-lā taziru wāziratun wizra ukhrā* (Q 6:164, Q 35:18). Both sentences stand in the same book, which means the corpus itself does not read a ransom as a transfer of guilt but as an act of release from above. This commentary reads Mark's clause at the weight Mark gives it, a servant's life laid down under a lesson about service, and it says plainly what is not there: exactly what is exchanged, and to whom, is not stated in this Gospel, and the corpus does not supply that term from its own side either.

Structural Commentary · The Servanthood Terminus, Mark 10:45

What stands. A conferred height. The title is a citation, and in its source the figure is presented before the throne and *given*

dominion, which is why a height is genuinely there to be descended from.

What moves. The descent through it. He trades the word down inside his own answer, *diakonos* at one verse and *doulos pantōn* at the next, slave of all, with *of all* removing the last place a hierarchy could hide, and the sentence ends in a table-servant's word.

How they bind. The voluntariness. The descent requires the height to be real or it is not a descent, and the height requires the descent to be real or it is a title, and the corpus states both in one verse: *lan yastankifa al-Masīhu an yakūna 'abdan lillāh*, the Messiah will never disdain to be a servant of Allah ﷻ (Q 4:172), where *yastankif* presupposes the height in the act of denying the disdain.

Collapse the height and the servanthood is deficiency, which is exactly what the fault-silence of Part I exists to prevent. Collapse the descent and the title stands alone as sovereignty. Collapse the voluntariness and *yastankif* has nothing left to negate. Two moves, the same two, in the same order, in one verse of each scripture, and neither is quoting the other. √ GOL↑ on the servanthood terminus. What the descent terminates in at Mk 10:45, a release-price constituted by the one descending, is read at the weight Mark gives it and is not built into the closure, which stands on the trajectory: a conferred height descended through to table-service.

Bartimaeus · Mark 10:46-52

> And they came to Jericho. And as he was leaving Jericho with his disciples and a great crowd, Bartimaeus, a blind beggar, the son of Timaeus, was sitting by the roadside. And when he heard that it was Jesus of Nazareth, he began to cry out and say: Jesus, Son of David, have mercy on me! And many rebuked him, telling him to be silent. But he cried out all the more: Son of David, have mercy on me! And Jesus stopped and said: Call him. And they called the blind man, saying to him: Take heart. Get up; he is calling you. And throwing off his cloak, he sprang up and came to Jesus. And Jesus said to him: What do you want me to do for you? And the blind man said to him: Rabbi, let me recover my sight. And Jesus said to him: Go your way; your faith has made you well. And immediately he recovered his sight and followed him on the way.

Commentary based on Quran

The last healing in the Gospel, and the second touch that Bethsaida's two-stage miracle promised. Between the two blind men lie three announcements of the death and three failures to hear them; the first man saw walking trees, and this one, on the far side of the road, sees and follows.

Two details carry the passage. He *throws off his cloak*, *apobalōn to himation autou*, and a beggar's cloak is his working capital, the thing spread on the ground to catch coins and his only covering at night. He discards the whole of what he owns to come, without

being asked, one chapter after a wealthy man was asked and could not. Mark sets the two men opposite each other and lets the arrangement do the work.

And the title he shouts is *Son of David*, its first occurrence in the book, from a beggar in the road, and the crowd tries to silence him, and the silencing does not come from the front this time. He is called instead. The title is neither endorsed nor corrected here; two chapters later, in the temple, it will be put under question by the man himself, and this commentary will meet it there. What is notable now is where it arrives from: the bottom of the social order, shouted, and answered with a question rather than a claim.

The question is the same one the sons of Zebedee were asked, word for word: *what do you want me to do for you?* They asked for thrones and were told the seats are not his to give. The beggar asks to see, and receives it, and the verdict is the one given to the woman in the crowd: *hē pistis sou sesōken se*, your faith has made you well. No touch, no spittle, no formula, no gesture at all. The healing is credited entirely to the receiver's trust and the giving is left unnamed, which is the same grammar the corpus uses for the granting of discernment to those who guard themselves: *in tattaqū Allāha yaj'al lakum furqānan*, if you are mindful of Allah ﷻ He will make for you a criterion (Q 8:29). The corpus's promise of sight to the mindful and Mark's crediting of sight to the trusting are the same transaction read from its two ends.

And the last clause is the movement's closing signature: *and he followed him on the way, ēkolouthei autō en tē hodō*. The word for road has been the frame of this whole movement, and the man who was sitting beside it is now walking on it. Mark's arrangement is complete: the blind see in two stages, and the second stage ends in discipleship.

The movement closes here. A correct confession was sealed and the suffering was published in the open. The one who rebuked the announcement was answered in the words the corpus speaks to its own Prophet ﷺ, *not for you is anything of the matter*. On the mountain the subject of the Gospel said nothing, two figures were removed, and one imperative was left. At the foot of it the strength-chain reached the disciples and failed, and the missing element was named as prayer, which is the corpus's one unbrokered channel. The salt was set against the argument about rank. A man was told to spend what he loved and could not. Two men asked for thrones and were told the seats are not his to give but prepared by another. And a beggar threw away everything he had, asked only to see, and got up and walked the road.

Structural Commentary · The Movement Entire

What stands. The road, and the *dei* upon it. It is necessary that the Son of Man suffer, stated three times on one journey, with no agent supplied for the necessity and no negotiation admitted.

What moves. The following. A confession sealed, a rebuke returned, a man told to spend what he loves, two men asking for

thrones, and a beggar throwing off the one thing he owns in order to walk the road.

How they bind. The inversion of rank. First and last exchange places, greatness is defined as service, and the two seats are declined in the one sentence where he says a thing is not his to give.

Collapse the road and the announcements are prophecy rather than direction. Collapse the following and the teaching has no cost attached and the rich man simply walks away from an opinion. Collapse the inversion and *ouk estin emon dounai* is modesty rather than structure, and the whole movement's argument about who allocates is lost. ◀ GOL on the inverted-rank structure.

The City · Mark 11:1-12:44

The road ends and the city begins. Six days of confrontation in the temple courts, framed by a fig tree and closed by a widow, and the whole movement runs on one psalm that the entry-crowd sings at its opening and the vineyard-parable quotes at its close.

Box | What to Watch

The crowd blesses the kingdom, not the king; both copyists move the blessing onto the man.

The temple clause both copyists lost, *for all the nations*, is what makes the action a defence of the Gentiles' court.

Isaiah destroys the vineyard; Mark keeps it and replaces the tenants. Custodianship transferred, trust untouched.

Psalm 110's riddle is two Hebrew words flattened into one Greek word.

The Entry · Mark 11:1-11

> Now when they drew near to Jerusalem, to Bethphage and Bethany, at the Mount of Olives, he sent two of his disciples and said to them: Go into the village in front of you, and immediately as you enter it you will find a colt tied, on which no one has ever sat. Untie it and bring it. If anyone says to you, Why are you doing this? say, The Lord has need of it and will send it back here immediately. And they went away and found a colt tied at a door outside in the street, and they untied it. And some of those standing there said to them: What are you doing, untying the colt? And they told them what Jesus had said, and they let them go. And they brought the colt to Jesus and threw their cloaks on it, and he sat on it. And many spread their cloaks on the road, and others spread leafy branches that they had cut from the fields. And those who went before and those who followed were shouting: Hosanna! Blessed is he who comes in the name of the Lord! Blessed is the coming kingdom of our father David! Hosanna in the highest! And he entered Jerusalem and went into the temple. And when he had looked around at everything, as it was already late, he went out to Bethany with the twelve.

Commentary based on Quran

Zechariah's oracle of the king coming humble and riding on a colt stands behind this scene, and Mark does not quote it. Matthew, copying, quotes it in full and, following the Hebrew parallelism too literally, produces two animals. The earliest evangelist stages the sign and leaves the reader to recognise it, and the restraint is the pattern this commentary has been counting.

The cloaks on the road are the older scripture's gesture for acclaiming a king, spread under Jehu's feet on the steps when the army proclaimed him (2 Kings 9:13), and they arrive here without a crown or an anointing to follow. Transit, partial: the gesture crossed into the scene, the enthronement it belonged to did not.

Hosanna is not praise but petition. *Hōshi'a-nna*, save now, we beseech you, from Psalm 118:25, and the crowd is shouting a prayer, addressed past the rider to the One who saves. That psalm is about to frame the entire visit: its next verse, *blessed is he who comes in the name of the LORD*, is the crowd's second shout, and its verse about the rejected stone will be the closing line of the vineyard parable two chapters later. One psalm, sung at the gate and quoted in the temple, and both ends of it point at the same Saviour.

And then the sentence that shows how careful this text is. The crowd shouts *blessed is the coming kingdom of our father David*. Not *blessed is the son of David*, and not *blessed is the king*. They bless the *kingdom*. Matthew changes it to *hosanna to the son of David*, and Luke changes it to *blessed is the king who comes*. Both copyists move the blessing from the reign to the man, and the earliest text has it on the reign. This is the same restraint Mark showed at the baptism when the voice stopped short of the Psalm's begetting clause, and it is the reason this Gospel reads cleanly from the fixed position: what arrives is a kingdom, and the one riding is the one announcing it. The corpus's own picture of a granted entry into a sacred city is a promise of security rather than a coronation: *la-tadkhulunna al-masjida al-ḥarāma in shā'a Allāhu āminīn*, you will surely enter the sacred mosque, if Allah ﷻ wills, in security (Q 48:27), with the conditional *if Allah ﷻ wills* written into the promise itself.

The scene's last verse is an anticlimax that no legend-maker would write. He enters the temple, *looks around at everything*, notices that it is late, and leaves for the night. The palms belong to another Gospel. Mark's rider inspects and withdraws.

The Fig Tree and the Temple · Mark 11:12-25

> On the following day, when they came from Bethany, he was hungry. And seeing in the distance a fig tree in leaf, he went to see if he could find anything on it. When he came to it, he found nothing but leaves, for it was not the season for figs. And he said to it: May no one ever eat fruit from you again. And his disciples heard it.

Commentary based on Quran

Mark's fourth interruption opens, and it is the most artful. A tree is cursed, the temple is cleansed, and the tree is found withered, so that the middle scene is read through the outer ones. Intercalation, four.

And Mark includes the clause every reader stumbles on and no copyist would have invented: *for it was not the season for figs*. He tells us the tree was innocent. The detail is not an oversight; it is the signal that the tree is not the subject. Leaves without fruit, appearance without substance, and the temple is one hundred metres away. The corpus's own image for the same condition is the crop that delights the tiller and turns yellow and becomes chaff (Q 57:20), and its judgment on a people whose observance had become display is stated of the earlier community exactly here: *mathalu alladhīna ḥummilū al-tawrāta thumma lam yaḥmilūhā ka-mathali al-ḥimāri yaḥmilu asfārā*, the likeness of those who were charged with the Torah and then did not carry it is the likeness of a donkey carrying volumes (Q 62:5). Full foliage, no load borne.

> And they came to Jerusalem. And he entered the temple and began to drive out those who sold and those who bought in the temple, and he overturned the tables of the money-changers and the seats of those who sold pigeons. And he would not allow anyone to carry anything through the temple. And he was teaching them and saying to them: Is it not written, My house shall be called a house of prayer for all the nations? But you have made it a den of robbers. And the chief priests and the scribes heard it and were seeking a way to destroy him, for they feared him, because all the crowd was astonished at his teaching.

Three things in this scene are Mark's alone, and each one is load-bearing.

The first is the full quotation. *My house shall be called a house of prayer for all the nations: pasin tois ethnesin*, from Isaiah 56:7. Matthew and Luke both quote the verse and both drop those three words. The earliest Gospel keeps them, and keeping them is what makes the action intelligible, because the trading stood in the Court of the Gentiles, the one precinct where a non-Israelite could pray, and it had been turned into a market. The complaint is that the nations' place of prayer has been requisitioned. And the corpus legislates precisely that principle for its own sanctuary: *al-masjidi al-ḥarāmi alladhī ja'alnāhu li-l-nāsi sawā'an al-'ākifu fīhi wa-l-bād*, the sacred mosque which We made for mankind, equal are the one who dwells there and the visitor (Q 22:25), and it names the obstruction of worship as among the gravest wrongs: *wa-man aḏlamu mimman mana'a masājida Allāhi an yudhkara fīhā ismuh*, who is more unjust than one who prevents the mosques of Allah ﷻ from having His name remembered in them (Q 2:114). Mark alone preserves the clause that makes his subject's action a defence of that very rule, and both his copyists lost it.

The second is the merchandise named. *Those who sold pigeons*: the pigeon is the offering the Torah prescribes for the poor who

cannot afford a lamb (Leviticus 5:7, 12:8). The overturned tables belong to the trade in the poor's own sacrifice. The corpus's anger falls in the same place, at those who consume people's wealth in falsehood and bar the way of Allah ﷻ, *inna kathīran mina al-aḥbāri wa-l-ruhbāni la-ya'kulūna amwāla al-nāsi bi-l-bāṭili wa-yaṣuddūna 'an sabīli Allāh* (Q 9:34), a verse about religious professionals monetising access.

The third is a sentence found in no other Gospel: *he would not allow anyone to carry anything through the temple*. Using the temple courts as a shortcut for porters was already forbidden in the rabbinic ruling of the period, and here the enforcement is stricter than the enforcers'. This is not a man abolishing the sanctuary's law. It is a man applying it where its own custodians had let it lapse, which is the same posture as the tassels on his garment at Gennesaret and the leper sent to the priest in chapter one.

The quotation's second half carries a charge the hearers would have completed for themselves. *A den of robbers* is Jeremiah 7:11, and three verses later that oracle says what happened to Shiloh and promises the same to this house. Mark's subject cites the sermon that ends in a demolition, and two chapters later he will say not one stone will be left on another. The corpus records the demolitions as accomplished fact, twice over: *fa-idhā jā'a wa'du ūlāhumā ba'athnā 'alaykum 'ibādan lanā ulī ba'sin shadīdin fa-jāsū khilāla al-diyār*, when the promise of the first of the two came, We sent against you servants of Ours of great might, and they searched through the homes, and again for the second, *wa-li-yutabbirū mā 'alaw tatbīrā*, and to destroy utterly what they had overcome (Q 17:5-7).

> As they passed by in the morning, they saw the fig tree withered away to its roots. And Peter remembered and said to him: Rabbi, look! The fig tree that you cursed has withered. And Jesus answered them: Have faith in God. Truly, I say to you, whoever says to this mountain, Be taken up and thrown into the sea, and does not doubt in his heart, but believes that what he says will come to pass, it will be done for him. Therefore I tell you, whatever you ask in prayer, believe that you have received it, and it will be yours. And whenever you stand praying, forgive, if you have anything against anyone, so that your Father also may forgive you your trespasses.

The frame closes, and the teaching drawn from it is about prayer rather than about trees. *Have faith in God, echete pistin theou*, and then the mountain, and then the general promise, and then a condition.

The mountain-saying has a Quranic counterpart that names the category precisely, and it is worth setting down because it prevents the promise from being read as a licence. *Wa-law anna qur'ānan suyyirat bihi al-jibālū aw quṭṭi'at bihi al-arḍu aw kullima bihi al-mawtā, bal lillāhi al-amru jamī'ā*, and if there were a recitation by which mountains were moved, or the earth were cleft, or the dead were spoken to, rather, to Allah ﷻ belongs the command entirely (Q 13:31). The corpus raises the exact three

miracles, moving a mountain among them, and answers with a correction of ownership rather than a denial of possibility: the command is His, entirely. Mark's promise and the corpus's clause are compatible in the only way that matters, because Mark's own instruction begins *have faith in God* and continues *whatever you ask in prayer*. The moving is asked for, not wielded. The one who says *this kind comes out only by prayer* is not two chapters later handing out mountain-moving as a personal capacity.

And the last verse attaches the condition both books attach to the same request. *Whenever you stand praying, forgive*, and the corpus's own most striking instance is spoken to a man who had sworn to cut off charity to a relative who had slandered his family: *wa-l-ya'fū wa-l-yaṣfahū, a-lā tuḥibbūna an yaghfira Allāhu lakum*, let them pardon and overlook; do you not love that Allah ﷻ should forgive you (Q 24:22). The asker who will not release is asking to receive what he refuses to give, and both scriptures close that door in the same sentence in which they open the other.

By What Authority · Mark 11:27-33

> And they came again to Jerusalem. And as he was walking in the temple, the chief priests and the scribes and the elders came to him, and they said to him: By what authority are you doing these things, or who gave you this authority to do them? Jesus said to them: I will ask you one question; answer me, and I will tell you by what authority I do these things. Was the baptism of John from heaven or from man? Answer me. And they discussed it with one another, saying: If we say, From heaven, he will say, Why then did you not believe him? But shall we say, From man? They were afraid of the people, for they all held that John really was a prophet. So they answered Jesus: We do not know. And Jesus said to them: Neither will I tell you by what authority I do these things.

Commentary based on Quran

The question is the right question, and this commentary has been answering it since chapter one. *By what authority, en poia exousia*, and *who gave you this authority, tis soi edōken*: the questioners themselves phrase it as a grant. Their grammar is correct even in hostility, exactly as the Nazareth villagers' was.

The counter-question is not evasion; it is a test of whether they can recognise a grant when they have already seen one. *Was the baptism of John from heaven or from man?* If they can locate the source of the forerunner's authority they will have located his, since the two offices are one relay. And their deliberation is the scene's whole judgment: they calculate consequences in both directions and answer neither. Mark records the calculation verbatim, so the reader can see that what looks like agnosticism is arithmetic.

The corpus stages the same self-interrogation and lets it succeed. When Ibrāhīm AS asks the idol-worshippers to consult their gods, *fa-raja'ū ilā anfusiḥim fa-qālū innakum antumu al-zālimūn*, they returned to themselves and said, indeed it is you who are the

wrongdoers (Q 21:64), and then, the corpus adds, *thumma nukisū 'alā ru'ūsihim*, they were turned upside down on their heads and went back to their position. The turn inward happens, the truth is reached, and the position is resumed anyway. Mark's council performs the first half of that verse and never says the second half aloud. *We do not know* is what the corpus calls being reversed on the head.

And the refusal that follows is just: an answer is owed to a question asked in good faith, and this one was asked by men who had just demonstrated that they would not act on the answer. The corpus's own formula for that condition is *wa-law 'alima Allāhu fīhim khayran la-asma'ahum, wa-law asma'ahum la-tawallaw*, had Allah ﷻ known any good in them He would have made them hear, and had He made them hear they would have turned away (Q 8:23).

The Vineyard • Mark 12:1-12

> And he began to speak to them in parables. A man planted a vineyard and put a fence around it and dug a pit for the winepress and built a tower, and leased it to tenants and went into another country. When the season came, he sent a servant to the tenants to get from them some of the fruit of the vineyard. And they took him and beat him and sent him away empty-handed. Again he sent to them another servant, and they struck him on the head and treated him shamefully. And he sent another, and him they killed. And so with many others: some they beat, and some they killed. He had still one other, a beloved son. Finally he sent him to them, saying, They will respect my son. But those tenants said to one another, This is the heir. Come, let us kill him, and the inheritance will be ours. And they took him and killed him and threw him out of the vineyard. What will the owner of the vineyard do? He will come and destroy the tenants and give the vineyard to others. Have you not read this Scripture: The stone that the builders rejected has become the cornerstone; this was the Lord's doing, and it is marvelous in our eyes? And they were seeking to arrest him, but feared the people, for they perceived that he had told the parable against them.

Commentary based on Quran

The opening sentence is a quotation. The fence, the pit for the press, the tower: four elements in the order Isaiah gives them in the Song of the Vineyard (Isaiah 5:1-2), and Isaiah's own seventh verse supplies the referent, *the vineyard of the LORD of hosts is the house of Israel*. Any hearer in that court knew the song, which is why they perceived immediately that the parable was against them.

But the parable and its source diverge at the decisive point, and the divergence is the reading. In Isaiah the vineyard itself is at fault, producing wild grapes, and the owner destroys it: *I will remove its hedge, and it shall be devoured; I will break down its wall, and it shall be trampled*. In Mark the vineyard is faultless. What has gone wrong is the *tenancy*, and the owner's judgment falls on the custodians and *gives the vineyard to others*. The estate

is preserved and the management is replaced. That distinction is the whole shape of what the corpus says happened, and it says it as a general law rather than a single event: *wa-in tatawallaw yastabdil qawman ghayrakum thumma lā yakūnū amthālakum*, and if you turn away He will replace you with another people, and they will not be the likes of you (Q 47:38), and *fa-sawfa ya'tī Allāhu bi-qawmin yuḥibbuhum wa-yuḥibbūnah*, then Allah ﷻ will bring a people He loves and who love Him (Q 5:54), and *in yasha' yudhhibkum wa-yastakhliḥ min ba'dikum mā yasha'*, if He wills He can remove you and bring after you whom He wills (Q 6:133). Custodianship transferred, the trust itself untouched.

The sequence of beaten and killed servants is the corpus's own summary of that history, twice, in nearly identical words: *a-fakullamā jā'akum rasūlun bimā lā tahwā anfusukumū istakbartum fa-farīqan kadhdhabtum wa-farīqan taqtulūn*, is it that whenever a messenger came to you with what your souls did not desire, you grew arrogant, and some you denied and some you killed (Q 2:87, and again at Q 5:70). Two verbs, denied and killed, matching the parable's two treatments exactly.

Then the son, and the parable's most delicate line: *he had still one other, a beloved son, huion agapēton*, the word of the voice at the baptism and on the mountain. The tenants' reasoning is quoted, *this is the heir, let us kill him*, and the corpus quotes the same reasoning in the same story: *wa-idh yamkuru bika alladhīna kafarū li-yuthbitūka aw yaqtulūka aw yukhrijūk, wa-yamkurūna wa-yamkuru Allāh, wa-Allāhu khayru al-mākirīn*, and when those who refused plotted against you, to restrain you or kill you or drive you out; and they plotted, and Allah ﷻ plotted, and Allah ﷻ is the best of plotters (Q 8:30). And in the surah that carries this prophet's own mother's family in its name, the two clauses stand consecutively: *wa-makarū wa-makara Allāhu wa-Allāhu khayru al-mākirīn* and then, immediately, *idh qāla Allāhu yā 'Īsā innī mutawaffika wa-rāfi'uka ilayya*, when Allah ﷻ said: O 'Īsā, I am taking you and raising you to Myself (Q 3:54-55). The plot and the raising in adjacent verses, and the parable in Mark ends the same way: the killing is narrated, and then the rejected stone becomes the cornerstone, and *this was the Lord's doing*.

That closing quotation is Psalm 118:22, and with it the psalm that the crowd sang at the gate closes its own frame. *Hosanna* at the entrance, the rejected stone in the temple, one psalm holding the whole visit, and its own verse naming the doer: *para kyriou egeneto hautē*, this came about from the Lord.

One fence is worth setting, because the parable's owner goes *into another country*. Absence is a feature of the story's mechanics, not a theology: it explains why tenants could imagine seizing an inheritance. Neither book has an absent owner. The corpus states the opposite as its most famous verse, *lā ta'khudhuhu sinatun wa-lā nawm*, neither slumber seizes Him nor sleep, *wa-huwa al-'Aliyyu al-'Aẓīm* (Q 2:255), and Mark's own parable has the owner arriving.

The Coin • Mark 12:13-17

> And they sent to him some of the Pharisees and some of the Herodians, to trap him in his talk. And they came and said to him: Teacher, we know that you are true and do not care about anyone's opinion. For you are not swayed by appearances, but truly teach the way of God. Is it lawful to pay taxes to Caesar, or not? Should we pay them, or should we not? But knowing their hypocrisy, he said to them: Why put me to the test? Bring me a denarius and let me look at it. And they brought one. And he said to them: Whose likeness and inscription is this? They said to him: Caesar's. Jesus said to them: Render to Caesar the things that are Caesar's, and to God the things that are God's. And they marveled at him.

Commentary based on Quran

The flattery in the approach is exact and, from the fixed position, accurate: *you are not swayed by appearances*, literally you do not look at the face of men. The corpus's standing description of its own messengers is the same, *wa-lā yakshawna aḥadan illā Allāh*, they fear none but Allah ﷻ (Q 33:39), and it commands the same posture in judgment, *wa-lā takshawu al-nāsa wa-khshawna*, do not fear people, fear Me (Q 5:44). His enemies open by stating his character correctly and then try to use it.

The answer runs on one word. *Whose likeness and inscription is this?* *Eikōn*, image. They say Caesar's, and the ruling follows: give back to Caesar what carries Caesar's image. And the second half of the argument is the half he does not say, which every hearer raised on Genesis would complete for himself: the coin carries Caesar's image and is his; the human being carries the image of God and is His. Mark leaves the syllogism open, and the crowd's amazement is the sound of people finishing it in their heads.

Here the two texts genuinely differ in their anthropology and the difference should be stated cleanly rather than smoothed. The corpus has no image-clause. Its word for forming is *ṣawwara* and it means shaping, not resembling: *wa-ṣawwarakum fa-aḥsana ṣuwarakum*, and He formed you and made your forms excellent (Q 40:64), *fī ayyi ṣūratin mā shā'a rakkabak*, in whatever form He willed He assembled you (Q 82:8), with *al-Muṣawwir*, the Fashioner, as one of His names (Q 59:24). The corpus's fence, *laysa ka-mithlihi shay'un*, there is nothing like Him (Q 42:11), forecloses the resemblance-reading entirely, and what it puts in the image's place is a different relation, breath and trust: *wa-nafakhtu fīhi min rūḥi*, and I breathed into him of My spirit (Q 15:29), and the *amānah* offered to the heavens and the earth and borne by the human (Q 33:72). So the ownership-argument stands in both books and its ground differs: Mark's is likeness, the corpus's is the breath given and the trust accepted. What both reach is the identical conclusion, that the human belongs to God in a way no coin belongs to Caesar.

And the ruling itself is a ranking, not a partition into equal halves. The corpus states the same order with its own precedence-clause: *aṭī'ū Allāha wa-aṭī'ū al-rasūla wa-ulī al-amri minkum*, obey

Allah ﷻ and obey the messenger and those in authority among you, and then, in the same verse, *fa-in tanāza'tum fī shay'in fa-ruddūhu ilā Allāhi wa-l-rasūl*, and if you dispute in anything, refer it to Allah ﷻ and the messenger (Q 4:59). Civil authority is real and it is second, and the appeal runs upward when the two collide. Mark's sentence and the corpus's verse hold the same two obligations in the same order.

The Resurrection Question • Mark 12:18-27

> And Sadducees came to him, who say that there is no resurrection. And they asked him a question, saying: Teacher, Moses wrote for us that if a man's brother dies and leaves a wife, but leaves no child, the man must take the widow and raise up offspring for his brother. There were seven brothers; the first took a wife, and when he died left no offspring. And the second took her, and died, leaving no offspring. And the third likewise. And the seven left no offspring. Last of all the woman also died. In the resurrection, when they rise again, whose wife will she be? For the seven had her as wife. Jesus said to them: Is this not the reason you are wrong, because you know neither the Scriptures nor the power of God? For when they rise from the dead, they neither marry nor are given in marriage, but are like angels in heaven. And as for the dead being raised, have you not read in the book of Moses, in the passage about the bush, how God spoke to him, saying, I am the God of Abraham, and the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob? He is not God of the dead, but of the living. You are quite wrong.

Commentary based on Quran

The diagnosis comes before the answer and it names two deficits: *you know neither the Scriptures nor the power of God*, *mē eidotes tas graphas mēde tēn dynamin tou theou*. Scripture and power, text and capacity, and the corpus answers both in a single verse, in the same order, about the same question. A man comes with a decayed bone asking who will give life to bones when they are dust, and the reply is: *qul yuhyīhā alladhī ansha'ahā awwala marratin wa-huwa bi-kulli khalqin 'alīm*, say: He will give them life who produced them the first time, and He is knowing of all creation (Q 36:79). The power-argument is the first-creation argument, and the scripture-argument is the corpus's own *a-wa-lam yaraw anna Allāha alladhī khalaqa al-samāwāti wa-l-arḍa qādirun 'alā an yakhlūqa mithlahum* (Q 17:99). Both deficits, one verse, and the corpus's own preferred proof of the resurrection is exactly the one Mark's Messiah reaches for: go back to how it worked the first time.

Then the marriage-clause, which has been read for centuries as a divergence between the two scriptures and turns out, read closely, to be two halves of one sentence.

Mark's verbs are the verbs of the human transaction. *Gamousin oude gamizontai*: they neither marry nor are given in marriage, the active for the man who takes a wife and the passive for the woman who is given by her family. Both verbs name the contracting, the arrangement, the transfer that a society performs.

What is denied is the institution's continued operation, and the reason is given in the same breath: they are *like angels*, that is, no longer in the order where lineage, inheritance, and succession, the whole apparatus the Sadducees' riddle depends on, are the point.

Now the corpus. It speaks of the garden's pairing constantly, and it never once puts the wedding verb in a creature's hands. *Wa-zawwajnāhum bi-ḥūrin* 'īn, and We paired them (Q 44:54, Q 52:20): the verb is transitive with *We* as its subject, in every occurrence. The corpus's companions are *azwāj muṭahharah*, purified pairs, and they are entered into rather than contracted for, *hum wa-azwājuhum fī zilālin* 'alā al-arā'iki muttaki'ūn, they and their pairs in shade, reclining on couches (Q 36:56).

Put the two side by side and the sentence completes. The Gospel removes the transaction from the creatures; the corpus assigns the pairing to the Lord. One says the contracting ends; the other says the giving is His. Nothing in Mark denies companionship in the raised state, and nothing in the corpus has anyone marrying there. What both refuse, in their different idioms, is the projection of this world's arrangements, its inheritance law and its seven brothers, onto the next.

This is worth naming honestly rather than filling. What the raised state *is*, from inside, neither text puts into a proposition. The corpus says of it *fa-lā ta'lamu nafsun mā ukhfiya lahum min qurrati a'yūn*, no soul knows what has been hidden for them of comfort for the eyes (Q 32:17), which is a statement that the content is withheld, not a description of it. This commentary locates the deciding input on the far side of that verse and does not cross to it.

The closing argument is grammatical and both books make it. *I am the God of Abraham*: present tense, spoken to Moses long after the patriarchs died, and the inference is that they are alive to Him. *He is not God of the dead, but of the living, theos zōntōn*, and the corpus's title for the same argument is a divine name: *wa-tawakkal* 'alā al-Ḥayyi alladhī lā yamūt, and rely upon the Living who does not die (Q 25:58). And the corpus states the conclusion Mark's argument reaches, as a direct instruction about how to speak of the dead: *wa-lā taqūlū li-man yuqtalu fī sabīli Allāhi amwātun, bal ahyā'un wa-lākin lā tash'urūn*, do not say of those slain in the way of Allah ﷻ that they are dead; rather they are living, but you do not perceive (Q 2:154), and *ahyā'un* 'inda rabbiḥim yurzaqūn, living, with their Lord, provided for (Q 3:169). 'Inda rabbiḥim, with their Lord: the preposition again, link six, and it is doing the same work as the present tense of the burning bush. The dead are with Him, and what is with Him remains.

The corpus adds one further word that belongs here, because it settles which of the two lives is the real one: *wa-inna al-dāra al-ākhirata la-hiya al-ḥayawān*, and the final home, that is truly the life (Q 29:64), using an intensive form of the word for living rather than the ordinary noun. The Sadducees came to ask which husband a woman would have in a lesser copy of this world. The

answer given in both books is that they had the direction of the copying backwards.

The Greatest Commandment · Mark 12:28-34

> And one of the scribes came up and heard them disputing with one another, and seeing that he answered them well, asked him: Which commandment is the most important of all? Jesus answered: The most important is: Hear, O Israel: The Lord our God, the Lord is one. And you shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind and with all your strength. The second is this: You shall love your neighbor as yourself. There is no other commandment greater than these. And the scribe said to him: You are right, Teacher. You have truly said that he is one, and there is no other besides him. And to love him with all the heart and with all the understanding and with all the strength, and to love one's neighbor as oneself, is much more than all whole burnt offerings and sacrifices. And when Jesus saw that he answered wisely, he said to him: You are not far from the kingdom of God. And after that no one dared to ask him any question.

Commentary based on Quran

This is the passage in which the two scriptures come closest, and it is worth reading slowly.

The answer begins where the corpus begins. *Hear, O Israel: the Lord our God, the Lord is one*, and the Greek is *kyrios heis estin*. The corpus's own opening of the surah of pure devotion is *qul huwa Allāhu aḥad*, say: He is Allah ﷻ, One (Q 112:1), and the corpus keeps two words for oneness which Part II distinguished, *wāḥid* for the numerical unity that excludes partners and *aḥad* for a oneness that admits no composition at all, the form used only here in the whole book. Mark's Messiah quotes the Shema as the first commandment, and the corpus's shortest surah is a single-verse Shema. Both texts place the declaration of the one before every duty that follows from it.

And you shall love the Lord your God with all your heart, and the corpus makes love the measuring rod of belief itself: *wa-lladhīna āmanū ashaddu ḥubban lillāh*, and those who believe are stronger in love for Allah ﷻ (Q 2:165), a verse whose whole subject is the misplacement of that love onto rivals. The command and the description are the same content in two moods.

You shall love your neighbor as yourself, and the corpus, at Q 4:36, moves straight from *worship Allah ﷻ and associate nothing with Him* into the widest circle of neighbours in either scripture: parents, kin, orphans, the needy, *wa-l-jāri dhī al-qurbā wa-l-jāri al-junub*, the neighbour who is kin and the neighbour who is a stranger, the companion at your side, the traveller, and those your right hands possess. One verse: the first commandment and the second, in that order, with the second spelled out into eight named categories. Mark's pair and Q 4:36 are the same architecture.

Then the scribe answers, and Mark gives him a longer speech than the questioner usually gets. He repeats the oneness, adds *and*

there is no other besides him, and then draws a conclusion of his own: that to love Him and the neighbour is *much more than all whole burnt offerings and sacrifices*. That sentence is the corpus's own, stated of the corpus's own rite, at the end of the passage on the sacrificial animals: *lan yanāla Allāha luḥūmuhā wa-lā dimā'uhā wa-lākin yanāluhu al-taqwā minkum*, neither their flesh nor their blood reaches Allah ﷻ, but the reverence from you reaches Him (Q 22:37). A scribe in the temple courts, standing within sight of the altar, says what the corpus says about the altar, and the answer he receives is *you are not far from the kingdom of God*.

And that reply carries a last precision. *Ou makran ei*, you are not far. The corpus's word for the nearness of the One being discussed is *qarīb*, and it stands in the verse this commentary has returned to throughout: *fa-innī qarīb, ujību da'wata al-dā'i idhā da'ān*, I am near, I answer the call of the caller when he calls Me (Q 2:186). The scribe is told he is near; the corpus tells every caller Who is nearer. Nobody dared ask another question after that, and the reason is legible: the exchange had ended in agreement.

David's Son · Mark 12:35-37

> And as Jesus taught in the temple, he said: How can the scribes say that the Christ is the son of David? David himself, in the Holy Spirit, declared: The Lord said to my Lord, Sit at my right hand, until I put your enemies under your feet. David himself calls him Lord. So how is he his son? And the great throng heard him gladly.

Commentary based on Quran

The puzzle as it stands in Greek looks like a paradox: *eipen kyrios tō kyriō mou*, the Lord said to my Lord, the same word twice, and how can a man's descendant be his lord? Centuries of argument for a more-than-human sonship were built on that repetition.

The repetition is not in the original. Psalm 110 opens *ne'um YHWH la-adoni*, and the two words are entirely different. The first is the divine Name. The second is *adoni*, my lord, the ordinary honorific of that language, used by a servant to a master, by a subject to a king, by Sarah of Abraham, and by Joseph's household of Joseph. When the Greek translators rendered the psalm they used *kyrios* for both, because *kyrios* covers the Name and the courtesy alike, and the flattening produced the riddle. The Greek Gospel inherits the flattened text and poses the question that only the flattened text can pose.

The corpus keeps the two tiers the Hebrew kept. *Rabb* is reserved: it is used of Allah ﷻ throughout, and where it appears with a human possessor it is only in the mouths of others describing a master, as when the corpus's Yūsuf AS says *innahu rabbī aḥsana mathwāy*, he is my master who made good my lodging (Q 12:23), and the corpus records that as reported speech in a specific human relation. The human honorific is *sayyid*, and the corpus applies it to a prophet without any risk of confusion: Yaḥyā AS is *sayyidan wa-ḥaṣūran wa-nabiyyan min al-ṣāliḥīn*, a master, restrained, a prophet, of the righteous (Q 3:39). Two words, two levels, never

collapsed. And the corpus names the collapse itself as the error it invites everyone to renounce: *wa-lā yattakhidha ba'ḍunā ba'ḍan arbāban min dūni Allāh*, and that none of us take others as lords besides Allah ﷻ (Q 3:64).

What remains of the passage, once the translation-effect is set aside, is what Mark actually left: a question, unanswered. He does not say *the Christ is more than David's son* and he does not say the scribes are wrong about the lineage. He asks how the two things fit and stops, and the crowd hears him gladly. The corpus's own placement of this figure's future station is likewise a hedge rather than a declaration, and it is spoken to its own Prophet ﷺ: *'asā an yab'athaka rabbuka maqāman maḥmūdā*, it may be that your Lord will raise you to a praised station (Q 17:79). *'Asā*, it may be, in the mouth of the Giver about the receiver. Neither text hands the servant a title he did not receive, and Mark's open question is the more careful of the two treatments, since he leaves it open.

The Scribes and the Widow · Mark 12:38-44

> And in his teaching he said: Beware of the scribes, who like to walk around in long robes and like greetings in the marketplaces and have the best seats in the synagogues and the places of honor at feasts, who devour widows' houses and for a pretense make long prayers. They will receive the greater condemnation.

Commentary based on Quran

Four vanities and one crime. The robes, the greetings, the front seats, the head table: the corpus's word for exactly this is *ri'ā' al-nās*, being seen by people, and it names the whole disease in a short surah that ends on the same two items Mark pairs here, prayer performed for display and the withholding of small kindnesses: *fa-waylun li-l-muṣallīn, alladhīna hum 'an ṣalātihim sāhūn, alladhīna hum yurā'ūn, wa-yamna'ūna al-mā'ūn*, woe to those who pray, who are heedless of their prayer, who make a display, and withhold small assistance (Q 107:4-7). Long prayers as a pretext and widows' houses devoured is that surah's diagnosis in a single Greek sentence, and the corpus adds the fence about charity ruined by display, *lā tubṭilū ṣadaqātikum bi-l-manni wa-l-adhā ka-lladhī yunfiqū mālahu ri'ā' al-nās* (Q 2:264).

> And he sat down opposite the treasury and watched the people putting money into the offering box. Many rich people put in large sums. And a poor widow came and put in two small copper coins, which make a penny. And he called his disciples to him and said to them: Truly, I say to you, this poor widow has put in more than all those who are contributing to the offering box. For they all contributed out of their abundance, but she out of her poverty has put in everything she had, all she had to live on.

He sits down opposite the treasury and watches. The scene is observation before it is teaching, and what he sees is arithmetic.

Lepta duo, two small coins, and the detail is exact: two is the smallest divisible sum. She could have kept one. The Greek makes the choice visible, because a single *lepton* was a legal

offering, and she had a remainder available and did not take it. And what she gives is named twice, once as *everything she had* and once with a word Mark chooses carefully: *holon ton bion autēs*, her whole *bios*. Not *zōē*, the life that animates, but *bios*, the livelihood, the means of living. She put in what she was going to live on.

The corpus states the rule this scene illustrates as arithmetic rather than as sentiment: *li-yunfiq dhū sa'atin min sa'atih, wa-man qudira 'alayhi rizquhu fa-l-yunfiq mimmā ātāhu Allāh, lā yukallifu Allāhu nafsan illā mā ātāhā*, let the man of abundance spend out of his abundance, and let the one whose provision is restricted spend out of what Allah ﷻ has given him; Allah ﷻ does not burden a soul beyond what He has given it (Q 65:7). Proportion, not amount, and both books measure the gift against what remains rather than against what is deposited. And the corpus knows this widow's exact type, the poor person whose restraint conceals the poverty: *yahsabuhumu al-jāhilu aghniyā'a mina al-ta'affuf*, the ignorant would think them wealthy because of their restraint (Q 2:273). She was not identified by anyone in the court except the man who was watching.

The corpus also grades the manner, and its grading favours what this scene shows: *in tubdū al-ṣadaqāti fa-ni'immā hiya, wa-in tukhfūhā wa-tu'tūhā al-fuqarā'a fa-huwa khayrun lakum*, if you disclose your charities it is good, and if you conceal them and give them to the poor it is better for you (Q 2:271). Many rich people put in large sums, openly. She put in two coins that nobody would have noticed.

And now the arrangement, because Mark is doing something across these three paragraphs that no single verse of them shows. He puts the scribes who *devour widows' houses* immediately before a widow giving away her last coin, and immediately after her he puts a disciple admiring the temple's masonry and the reply that not one stone will be left on another. Devoured, giving, demolished, in that order, without a connecting word. The institution that consumes the widow receives her last two coins and is then condemned to rubble. Mark's interruptions have been noted four times in this commentary as a device; here he performs the same operation across pericope boundaries, and the argument is entirely in the sequence.

The movement closes with her. A crowd sang a psalm of petition at the gate and the same psalm named the rejected stone in the temple. A tree in full leaf bore nothing and a house of prayer for all the nations had been requisitioned. Tenants were replaced and the estate was kept. A coin bore Caesar's image and the questioner bore another. The Sadducees had the direction of copying backwards. A scribe said what the corpus says about the altar and was told he was not far. Psalm 110's riddle turned out to be two Hebrew words flattened into one Greek word. And a woman with two coins gave both, and the only person who noticed was the one who had sat down to watch.

Structural Commentary · The Movement Entire

What stands. The trust. A vineyard leased, a temple held, a treasury administered, a commandment deposited, and not one of them the custodian's property.

What moves. The custody. Real administration with real proceeds, tables and doves and long prayers and widows' houses, which is where the whole movement's failure lives.

How they bind. The accounting. Fruit returned at the season, the coin returned to the one whose image it carries, the first commandment discharged into the second, and two small coins weighed against large sums by what remained rather than by what was given.

Collapse the trust into the custody and the tenants are correct and the inheritance is theirs. Collapse the custody and there is nothing to be accountable for and the fig tree is arbitrary. Collapse the accounting and the widow's two coins and the scribes' long prayers become indistinguishable, which is exactly the confusion the movement exists to break. ✎ GOL on the trust-and-accounting structure.

The Discourse · Mark 13:1-37

One chapter, spoken on a hillside facing the temple, and it is the only sustained discourse in this Gospel. It belongs to a recognisable genre, the apocalypse, and the corpus knows every element of that genre and keeps almost all of them. The one element it refuses is the one this chapter also refuses, at its centre, in the most Quranic sentence Mark ever wrote.

Box | What to Watch

The genre calculates; this chapter refuses to. Mk 13:32 and Q 7:187 stand clause for clause.

The Spirit promised in the dock is the same strengthening the corpus extends to believers under trial, Q 58:22.

The corpus exceeds the Gospel on the cosmic dismantling: seven verbs against two.

The four watches of the parable are the four movements of the passion, in order.

Not One Stone · Mark 13:1-2

> And as he came out of the temple, one of his disciples said to him: Look, Teacher, what wonderful stones and what wonderful buildings! And Jesus said to him: Do you see these great buildings? There will not be left here one stone upon another that will not be thrown down.

Commentary based on Quran

The masonry was worth admiring; Herod's platform stones are among the largest ever set by hand. And the reply cashes the Jeremiah quotation of two chapters back, where the den of robbers stood three verses from what happened to Shiloh. The

corpus records the two demolitions of this house as accomplished history, *fa-idhā jā'a wa'du al-ākhirati... wa-li-yudakhhilū al-masjida kamā dakhālūhu awwala marratin wa-li-yutabbirū mā 'alaw tatbīrā*, and to enter the sanctuary as they entered it the first time, and to destroy utterly what they had overcome (Q 17:7). The corpus writes it as a completed pattern; Mark writes it as a coming one; and the stones came down within forty years of the sentence.

The Four on the Mountain • Mark 13:3-13

> And as he sat on the Mount of Olives opposite the temple, Peter and James and John and Andrew asked him privately: Tell us, when will these things be, and what will be the sign when all these things are about to be accomplished? And Jesus began to say to them: See that no one leads you astray. Many will come in my name, saying, I am he! and they will lead many astray. And when you hear of wars and rumors of wars, do not be alarmed. This must take place, but the end is not yet. For nation will rise against nation, and kingdom against kingdom. There will be earthquakes in various places; there will be famines. These are but the beginning of the birth pains.

Commentary based on Quran

Four men ask, and they are the four called first, by the sea, in chapter one. Peter and Andrew, James and John, the first names in the book, asking the last question in it. Mark closes his circle quietly and says nothing about having done so.

Their question is the one the whole chapter will decline to answer: *when*, and *what will be the sign*. And the first word of the reply is a warning about being misled, repeated four times through the chapter, *blepete*, watch out. The corpus's counsel to the same question is identical in posture: it treats curiosity about the timing as the wrong appetite and redirects to preparedness.

Many will come in my name, saying, I am he. Impersonation is the predicted hazard, and the corpus builds its anti-impersonation locks into its own founding documents: the office sealed by declaration, *khātam al-nabiyyīn* (Q 33:40), and the anti-cult clause revealed on a battlefield when a rumour of the Prophet's death ran through the ranks, *wa-mā Muḥammadun illā rasūlun qad khalat min qablihi al-rusul, a-fa-in māta aw qutila inqalabtum 'alā a'qābikum*, Muhammad ﷺ is only a messenger; messengers have passed away before him; if he died or were killed, would you turn back on your heels (Q 3:144).

The beginning of the birth pains, ōdinōn, and the corpus reaches for the same body for the same event: *yawma tarawnahā tadhhalu kullu murđi'atin 'ammā arđa'at wa-tađa'u kullu dhāti ḥamlin ḥamlahā*, the day you see it, every nursing mother will forget what she nursed, and every pregnant one will deliver her burden (Q 22:2). Labour is the shared figure, and it carries the same double sense in both books: the pains are real and they are the pains of something being born.

> But be on your guard. For they will deliver you over to councils, and you will be beaten in synagogues, and you will stand before governors and kings for my sake, to bear witness before them. And the gospel must first be proclaimed to all nations. And when they bring you to trial and deliver you over, do not be anxious beforehand what you are to say, but say whatever is given you in that hour, for it is not you who speak, but the Holy Spirit. And brother will deliver brother over to death, and the father his child, and children will rise against parents and have them put to death. And you will be hated by all for my name's sake. But the one who endures to the end will be saved.

Do not be anxious beforehand what you are to say, but say whatever is given you in that hour, for it is not you who speak, but the Holy Spirit. This sentence has a Quranic counterpart that deserves to be stated plainly, because it is the corpus's most generous verse about the Spirit. The threefold strengthening of 'Isā AS with the Holy Spirit is well known, *wa-ayyadnāhu bi-rūḥi al-quḍus* (Q 2:87, Q 2:253, Q 5:110). What is less noticed is that the corpus extends the same strengthening to ordinary believers under pressure, and in almost the same words: *ulā'ika kataba fī qulūbihimu al-īmāna wa-ayyadahum bi-rūḥin minhu*, those, He has written faith in their hearts and strengthened them with a spirit from Him (Q 58:22). The verb is *ayyada*, the same verb; the recipients are the faithful of a community under trial; and the verse's context is families divided by belief, *lā tajidu qawman yu'minūna bi-llāhi wa-l-yawmi al-ākhirī yuḥaddūna man ḥadda Allāha wa-rasūlah wa-law kānū ābā'ahum aw abnā'ahum*, you will not find a people who believe in Allah ﷻ and the Last Day loving those who oppose Him, though they be their fathers or their sons. Mark's promise of the Spirit speaking in the dock, and his prediction that brother will hand over brother, stand together in one Quranic verse.

And the corpus adds the plain word about family under trial that Mark's harder sentence needs beside it: *inna min azwājikum wa-awlādikum 'aduwwan lakum fa-ḥdharūhum*, among your spouses and your children are enemies to you, so beware of them, and then, in the same verse, *wa-in ta'fū wa-taṣfahū wa-taghfirū fa-inna Allāha ghafūrun raḥīm*, and if you pardon and overlook and forgive, Allah ﷻ is forgiving, merciful (Q 64:14). The betrayal is named, and the instruction after it is pardon.

The one who endures to the end will be saved, ho hypomeinas eis telos, and the corpus's closing imperative to its own community is built on that root: *yā ayyuhā alladhīna āmanū iṣbirū wa-ṣābirū wa-rābiṭū wa-ttaqū Allāha la'allakum tufliḥūn*, endure, and outlast others in endurance, and hold your posts, and be mindful of Allah ﷻ, that you may succeed (Q 3:200), the last verse of the surah that carries this prophet's mother's family in its name.

The Desolating Sacrilege • Mark 13:14-23

> But when you see the abomination of desolation standing where he ought not to be (let the reader understand), then let those who are in Judea flee to the mountains. Let the one who is on the

housetop not go down, nor enter his house, to take anything out, and let the one who is in the field not turn back to take his cloak. And alas for women who are pregnant and for those who are nursing infants in those days! Pray that it may not happen in winter. For in those days there will be such tribulation as has not been from the beginning of the creation that God created until now, and never will be. And if the Lord had not cut short the days, no human being would be saved. But for the sake of the elect, whom he chose, he shortened the days. And then if anyone says to you, Look, here is the Christ! or Look, there he is! do not believe it. For false christs and false prophets will arise and perform signs and wonders, to lead astray, if possible, the elect. But be on guard; I have told you all things beforehand.

Commentary based on Quran

The abomination of desolation is Daniel's phrase (Daniel 9:27, 11:31, 12:11), and the readers of the first century had a dated referent for it: the altar to Zeus erected on the altar of the temple in 167 BCE, which the first book of Maccabees names with the same words. Mark's aside, *let the reader understand*, is the narrator speaking directly to a community that would know what he meant and that he preferred not to name.

The corpus's own word for that category of object works at root level rather than by allusion. *Innamā al-khamru wa-l-maysiru wa-l-anṣābu wa-l-azlāmu rijsun min 'amali al-shayṭān*, wine and gambling and the *anṣāb* and divining arrows are an abomination of Satan's work (Q 5:90), and *anṣāb* is from the root for *setting up*, things erected and installed. An abomination standing where it ought not to be, in Mark's phrase, is *anṣāb* in the corpus's: the defilement is in the erecting.

The flight instructions are the most concrete lines in the chapter, and their concreteness is the point: do not go down for your goods, do not turn back for your cloak, and the corpus's own evacuation-narratives run identically, *fa-asri bi-ahlīka bi-qit'in mina al-layli wa-lā yaltafit minkum aḥad*, so set out with your family in a portion of the night and let none of you look back (Q 11:81). Do not look back is one of the oldest instructions in either scripture.

If the Lord had not cut short the days, no human being would be saved. But for the sake of the elect, whom he chose, he shortened the days. Three clauses, and every one of them assigns the action upward: the shortening is His, the election is His, *hous exelaxato*, whom He chose. Mercy operating as a limit on the duration of a trial is the corpus's constant: *yurīdu Allāhu bikumu al-yusra wa-lā yurīdu bikumu al-'usr* (Q 2:185), *lā yukallifu Allāhu naṣṣan illā wus'ahā* (Q 2:286). The tribulation is not shortened because the elect are strong. It is shortened because they are not.

And the warning about the false ones ends with a phrase worth marking: they will perform *signs and wonders*, and they will be persuasive enough to endanger even the chosen. Neither book treats the ability to produce marvels as a certificate. The corpus's discipline on this is severe and it is stated of every messenger

without exception: *wa-mā arsalnā min qablīka min rasūlin wa-lā nabiyyin illā idhā tamannā alqā al-shayṭānu fī umniyyatih*, We sent no messenger or prophet before you but that when he recited, Satan cast something into his recitation, *fa-yansakhu Allāhu mā yulqī al-shayṭānu thumma yuḥkimu Allāhu āyātih*, then Allah ﷻ abolishes what Satan casts and then Allah ﷻ makes His signs firm (Q 22:52). Interference is expected and the correction is the Sender's. Marvels prove capability, never authorisation, which is the same distinction this Gospel drew in its first synagogue when it muzzled a spirit that was telling the truth.

The Gathering · Mark 13:24-27

> But in those days, after that tribulation, the sun will be darkened, and the moon will not give its light, and the stars will be falling from heaven, and the powers in the heavens will be shaken. And then they will see the Son of Man coming in clouds with great power and glory. And then he will send out the angels and gather his elect from the four winds, from the ends of the earth to the ends of heaven.

Commentary based on Quran

The cosmic list is short and Isaiah stands behind it. Sun darkened, moon dimmed, stars falling, powers shaken: four events. And here the corpus does not merely match the Gospel; it exceeds it by a wide margin, and the excess is worth setting down because it settles the question of which book takes this Day more seriously.

The corpus devotes whole surahs to the dismantling. *Idhā al-shamsu kuwwirat*, when the sun is wound up and extinguished; *wa-idhā al-nujūmu inkadarat*, when the stars fall and scatter; *wa-idhā al-jibālu suyirāt*, when the mountains are set moving; *wa-idhā al-bihāru sujjiṛāt*, when the seas are set boiling (Q 81:1-6). *Idhā al-samā'u infāṭarat*, when the sky is split; *wa-idhā al-kawākibu intatharat*, when the planets are strewn (Q 82:1-2). *Fa-idhā bariqa al-baṣaru*, *wa-khasafa al-qamaru*, *wa-jumi'a al-shamsu wa-l-qamar*, when the sight is dazzled, and the moon is eclipsed, and the sun and moon are joined (Q 75:7-9). *Fa-idhā al-nujūmu ṭumisat*, *wa-idhā al-samā'u furijat*, *wa-idhā al-jibālu nusifat*, when the stars are obliterated, and the sky is opened, and the mountains are blown away (Q 77:8-10). Seven distinct verbs against the prophets' two, and the corpus's own summary of the scale is *wa-mā qadarū Allāha ḥaqqā qadriḥ*, they have not measured Allah ﷻ with the measure due to Him (Q 39:67).

One image in that inventory Mark declines. Isaiah's oracle says the heavens will be rolled up like a scroll (Isaiah 34:4), and Mark, quoting the verses around it, leaves that clause out. The corpus takes it up: *yawma naṭwī al-samā'a ka-ṭayyi al-sijilli li-l-kutub*, the Day We roll up the heaven like the rolling of a scroll for writings (Q 21:104). The image passed from Isaiah into the corpus and around the earliest Gospel, and the ledger records it as a transit Mark declined.

They will see the Son of Man coming in clouds with great power and glory. Daniel 7:13 is the source and Daniel's own next verse is the commentary: *to him was given dominion and glory and a*

kingdom, yehiv, given. The most exalted picture the Hebrew scriptures offer of this figure is a picture of conferral, and Mark's sentence keeps the recipient-grammar throughout, since the power and the glory arrive with him rather than originating in him, exactly as at Mk 8:38 they were *his Father's*. And what he does on arrival is send angels and gather: the corpus's *yawma yajma'ukum li-yawmi al-jam'*, the Day He gathers you for the Day of Gathering (Q 64:9), with the gathering everywhere in the corpus a divine act performed through angelic agency, *wa-jā'a rabbuka wa-l-malaku šaffan šaffā* (Q 89:22).

The Hour • Mark 13:28-32

> From the fig tree learn its lesson: as soon as its branch becomes tender and puts out its leaves, you know that summer is near. So also, when you see these things taking place, you know that he is near, at the very gates. Truly, I say to you, this generation will not pass away until all these things take place. Heaven and earth will pass away, but my words will not pass away. But concerning that day or that hour, no one knows, not even the angels in heaven, nor the Son, but only the Father.

Commentary based on Quran

The fig returns, no longer cursed but read: leaves mean the season is close. And then two sayings that have divided readers for centuries, and this commentary reports them rather than resolving them.

This generation will not pass away until all these things take place. If *these things* are the stones and the tribulation, the sentence was fulfilled within forty years. If they include the gathering of verse 27, it was not. Mark places the two together and supplies no key, and the honest report is that the referent of *these things* is not fixed by anything in the text. This commentary leaves it standing rather than choosing the reading that would be tidier.

Heaven and earth will pass away, but my words will not pass away. The corpus says the same of what it carries, in the same shape: *kullu man 'alayhā fān, wa-yabqā wajhu rabbika dhū al-jalāli wa-l-ikrām*, everyone upon it will perish, and there remains the face of your Lord, the Majestic and Honouring (Q 55:26-27), and of the word itself, *lā tabdīla li-kalimāti Allāh* (Q 10:64) and *wa-tammat kalimatu rabbika šidqan wa-'adlan* (Q 6:115). What endures is the given word, and the corpus is careful to name whose it is; Mark's speaker says *my words*, and the whole of this Gospel has established the direction those words came from, *he does not speak from himself* being the corpus's way of putting it (Q 53:3-4).

And then verse 32, which is the reason this movement exists.

But concerning that day or that hour, no one knows, not even the angels in heaven, nor the Son, but only the Father. Oude ho huios, ei mē ho patēr. An apocalyptic discourse, in a genre whose entire commercial value is the calculation of the timetable, arrives at its climax and disclaims the timetable, and disclaims it in a ladder

that names the angels, then the Son, then stops at the Father. This is the most Quranic sentence in the Gospel of Mark, and it can be set beside its counterpart clause for clause.

Yās'alūnaka 'ani al-sā'ati ayyāna mursāhā, qul innamā 'ilmuhā 'inda rabbī, lā yujallihā li-waqtihā illā huw, they ask you about the Hour, when will it arrive; say: its knowledge is only with my Lord; none will reveal it at its time but He (Q 7:187). The same question, the same refusal, the same exclusive clause, and the messenger commanded to say it in the first person. And the corpus repeats it: *inna Allāha 'indahū 'ilmu al-sā'ah* (Q 31:34); *ilayhi yuraddu 'ilmu al-sā'ah*, to Him is referred the knowledge of the Hour (Q 41:47); *wa-'indahū 'ilmu al-sā'ah* (Q 43:85). Four times, and each time the preposition is *'inda*, with Him. The chain this commentary has tracked from the Mother of the Book now reaches its densest cluster, links seven through ten, and every one of them is about this same Hour.

The corpus does not merely withhold the date; it forecloses the whole calculating enterprise by making suddenness the Hour's defining property. *Lā ta'tikum illā baghtatan*, it will not come upon you but suddenly (Q 7:187), and the same word again at Q 6:31, Q 12:107, Q 22:55, Q 43:66, and Q 47:18: six occurrences of *baghtatan*, unannounced. And the corpus states why the withholding is itself the mercy: *akādu ukhfīhā li-tujzā kullu nafsin bimā tas'ā*, I almost conceal it, that every soul may be recompensed for what it strives (Q 20:15). A known date would convert striving into scheduling.

So Mk 13:32 is not an embarrassment inside an apocalypse. It is the anti-calculation clause planted at the centre of a calculating genre, and the corpus takes that clause and makes it the whole of its posture. And the verse's ladder is worth reading once more for what it does to the argument of this commentary: the angels do not know, and the Son does not know, and the Father does. Whatever else the title Son carries in this Gospel, it stands here on the creaturely side of a line drawn by knowledge, in the speaker's own mouth, in the one chapter where he is speaking about the end of the world.

Watch • Mark 13:33-37

> Be on guard, keep awake. For you do not know when the time will come. It is like a man going on a journey, when he leaves home and puts his servants in charge, each with his work, and commands the doorkeeper to stay awake. Therefore stay awake, for you do not know when the master of the house will come, in the evening, or at midnight, or when the rooster crows, or in the morning, lest he come suddenly and find you asleep. And what I say to you I say to all: Stay awake.

Commentary based on Quran

The discourse ends in an imperative rather than a schedule, and the parable that carries it is a household with the servants each given a task and a doorkeeper told to stay awake. The corpus's picture of the same arrangement is the deputyship, *huwa alladhī ja'alakum khalā'ifa fī al-arḍ*, He it is who made you successors

on the earth (Q 35:39), and the trust accepted at Q 33:72. Assigned work, an absent hour, and an accounting.

And then Mark does something with the four watches of the night that no reader notices until the passion arrives. *In the evening, or at midnight, or when the rooster crows, or in the morning.* Two chapters later the supper is *when it was evening* (Mk 14:17); the arrest and the trial run through the night; Peter's denial ends when *the rooster crowed* (Mk 14:72); and the delivery to Pilate is *as soon as it was morning* (Mk 15:1). The four watches of the parable are the four movements of the passion, in order. Mark has just told his disciples to stay awake through the night, and in the next chapter they will fall asleep three times in a garden while the hours he named run past them one by one.

The last line universalises it and closes the chapter: *what I say to you I say to all, pasin*. The command was never for the four on the mountain.

Structural Commentary · The Movement Entire

What stands. The Word, permanent against a perishing cosmos. *Heaven and earth will pass away, but my words will not pass away*, which is *lā mubaddila li-kalimātih* (Q 6:115) in the same clause-shape.

What moves. The dismantling. Sun darkened, moon withholding, stars falling, the powers shaken: a staged unmaking, which the corpus carries in seven verbs where the prophets used two.

How they bind. The reserved hour. *Not even the Son*, which keeps the timing on the source side and therefore keeps the whole discourse a summons to watch rather than a schedule to compute.

Collapse the Word into the cosmos and there is nothing that does not pass. Collapse the dismantling and the discourse is metaphor and the warning has no referent. Collapse the reservation and the chapter becomes a calendar, which is the one use both texts foreclose by placing the speaker himself inside the exclusion. √ GOL on permanence against dissolution, with the reservation as the binding term.

The Cup · Mark 14:1-15:47

Two chapters, one night and one morning, and the density of the writing changes. Mark slows to hours and then to minutes. The movement holds the anointing, the supper, the garden, the arrest, two trials, the denials, and the death, and it closes with a councillor asking for a body.

Box | What to Watch

The unbidden anointing succeeds, and the corpus names its category: *‘afā Allāhu ‘anhā*, a space left unlegislated.

Mark issues no command to repeat the supper. *Do this in remembrance* belongs to Luke and Paul.

In the garden two wills are named in one sentence, and one is placed beneath the other by the one praying.

The mockers state the doctrine when they say he cannot save himself.

The Woman with the Flask · Mark 14:1-11

> It was now two days before the Passover and the Feast of Unleavened Bread. And the chief priests and the scribes were seeking how to arrest him by stealth and kill him, for they said: Not during the feast, lest there be an uproar from the people.

Commentary based on Quran

The fifth interruption opens: a plot, an anointing, and a betrayal, the middle scene framed by the two that pay for it. Intercalation, five.

> And while he was at Bethany in the house of Simon the leper, as he was reclining at table, a woman came with an alabaster flask of ointment of pure nard, very costly, and she broke the flask and poured it over his head. There were some who said to themselves indignantly: Why was the ointment wasted like that? For this ointment could have been sold for more than three hundred denarii and given to the poor. And they scolded her. But Jesus said: Leave her alone. Why do you trouble her? She has done a beautiful thing to me. For you always have the poor with you, and whenever you want, you can do good for them. But you will not always have me. She has done what she could; she has anointed my body beforehand for burial. And truly, I say to you, wherever the gospel is proclaimed in the whole world, what she has done will be told in memory of her.

She is not named, she is not asked, and she does something no law required and no custom prescribed. She breaks the flask, which is the detail that makes it irreversible: a broken alabaster neck cannot be resealed, so the whole is spent at once. And the objection is a costing, three hundred denarii, a labourer's year, and it is framed as concern for the poor.

The corpus names the category this act belongs to, and names it precisely. *Lā tas'alū ‘an ashyā’a in tubda lakum tasu’kum*, do not ask about things which, if disclosed to you, would trouble you, and the verse continues, *‘afā Allāhu ‘anhā, wa-Allāhu ghafūrun ḥalīm*, Allah ﷻ has left them alone, and Allah ﷻ is forgiving, forbearing (Q 5:101). *‘Afā Allāhu ‘anhā*: there is a space the Lawgiver deliberately did not legislate, and the corpus's warning is against the impulse to fill it. The objectors in this room are doing exactly that. They are legislating an unlegislated act,

pricing a gift that carried no price, and the answer they receive begins *aphete autēn*, leave her alone.

Two guards keep this from becoming sentimentality. The first is that unbidden does not mean unrejectable: a gift offered freely can be refused, and the corpus records a refusal, when Sulaymān AS sends back the queen's present, *a-tumiddūnani bi-māl*, do you offer me wealth (Q 27:36). So the acceptance here is itself a verdict, and it is stated as one, *kalon ergon ērgasato en emoi*, she has worked a beautiful work on me. The second is that the poor-clause is not a shrug. *You always have the poor with you, and whenever you want, you can do good for them* quotes Deuteronomy 15:11, and that verse is a command, not a resignation: *the poor will never cease from the land, therefore I command you, open wide your hand to your brother*. The clause is a standing imperative with the door held open, and the corpus makes the same provision permanent and obligatory rather than occasional, *wa-ḥi amwālihim ḥaqqun li-l-sā'ili wa-l-maḥrūm*, in their wealth is a right for the asker and the deprived (Q 51:19), a *ḥaqq*, a due, not a charity.

She has anointed my body beforehand for burial: proelaben myrisai, she has anticipated. And here Mark sets up a pair he will complete in his last chapter. This anointing is unbidden, unnamed, unplanned, and it succeeds. In chapter sixteen, women will buy spices, plan carefully, name themselves, and arrive to find the body gone; their anointing will fail. The one that worked was the one nobody asked for.

Wherever the gospel is proclaimed in the whole world, what she has done will be told in memory of her. A deed bound to the proclamation itself, carried wherever the message goes. The corpus does the same thing four times in one surah, with the same construction, for Nūḥ and Ibrāhīm and Mūsā and Hārūn and Ilyās: *wa-taraknā 'alayhi fī al-ākhirīn*, and We left for him among later generations (Q 37:78, 108, 119, 129), a remembrance deposited in the future. And it is worth noting what the corpus does with women's names in this register, since Mark leaves this woman unnamed: the corpus names exactly one woman in its whole text, Maryam AS, and refers to every other by her relation or her deed, the wife of Fir'awn, the woman who disputes, the queen who submitted. Both books preserve the acts of women whose names they do not record, and both bind the remembrance to the message rather than to the name.

> Then Judas Iscariot, who was one of the twelve, went to the chief priests in order to betray him to them. And when they heard it, they were glad and promised to give him money. And he sought an opportunity to betray him.

The frame closes on the transaction the woman's act inverts: she spends three hundred denarii on him without being asked, and one of the twelve sells him for a sum Mark does not even bother to record. The two halves of the intercalation are a broken flask and a struck bargain.

The Supper · Mark 14:12-25

> And on the first day of Unleavened Bread, when they sacrificed the Passover lamb, his disciples said to him: Where will you have us go and prepare for you to eat the Passover? And he sent two of his disciples and said to them: Go into the city, and a man carrying a jar of water will meet you. Follow him, and wherever he enters, say to the master of the house, The Teacher says, Where is my guest room, where I may eat the Passover with my disciples? And he will show you a large upper room furnished and ready; there prepare for us. And the disciples set out and went to the city and found it just as he had told them, and they prepared the Passover.

Commentary based on Quran

A man carrying a water jar was a visible anomaly in that city, since the work was women's, and it makes a findable sign in a crowd. The room is *estrōmenon hetoimon*, furnished and ready, prepared in advance by arrangements the disciples did not make, which is the same shape as the colt tied and waiting. The corpus's image for provision found already in place is Maryam AS in the sanctuary: *kullamā dakhala 'alayhā Zakariyyā al-miḥrāba wajada 'indahā rizqan*, whenever Zakariyyā entered upon her in the chamber he found provision with her, and when he asked, she said *huwa min 'indi Allāh*, it is from Allah ﷻ (Q 3:37). 'Inda, twice in one verse, the preposition of what is with Him arriving where it is needed. The upper room was furnished before anyone went looking for it.

> And when it was evening, he came with the twelve. And as they were reclining at table and eating, Jesus said: Truly, I say to you, one of you will betray me, one who is eating with me. They began to be sorrowful and to say to him one after another: Is it I? He said to them: It is one of the twelve, one who is dipping bread into the dish with me. For the Son of Man goes as it is written of him, but woe to that man by whom the Son of Man is betrayed! It would have been better for that man if he had not been born.

Evening: the first of the four watches the parable named, and the clock begins to run.

The betrayer is identified by table-fellowship rather than by name, *one who is dipping bread into the dish with me*, which is the Psalter's own bitterness, *even my close friend in whom I trusted, who ate my bread, has lifted his heel against me* (Psalm 41:9). And then a sentence that holds two things most systems try to separate: *the Son of Man goes as it is written of him, but woe to that man by whom he is betrayed*. The event is written and the man is liable, in one breath, with no attempt to soften either half.

The corpus holds the identical pair with the same refusal to resolve it. *Li-man shā'a minkum an yastaqīm, wa-mā tashā'ūna illā an yashā'a Allāhu rabbu al-'ālamīn*, for whoever among you wills to go straight; and you do not will unless Allah ﷻ, Lord of the worlds, wills (Q 81:28-29). Human willing named, divine willing named, in consecutive clauses, and the corpus does not

dissolve the first into the second. And *it would have been better for that man if he had not been born* has its counterpart in the wish the corpus records at the reckoning: *wa-yaqūlu al-kāfiru yā laytanī kuntu turābā*, and the one who refused says: would that I were dust (Q 78:40).

> And as they were eating, he took bread, and after blessing it broke it and gave it to them, and said: Take; this is my body. And he took a cup, and when he had given thanks he gave it to them, and they all drank of it. And he said to them: This is my blood of the covenant, which is poured out for many. Truly, I say to you, I will not drink again of the fruit of the vine until that day when I drink it new in the kingdom of God.

Read what Mark actually writes, because what is absent from his account is as striking as what is present.

He blesses. He breaks. He gives. He says the words. And then he says nothing else. There is no interpretation supplied, no explanation of how the bread is the body, and, most notably, **no command to repeat it**. *Do this in remembrance of me* is not in Mark and is not in Matthew; it appears in Luke and in Paul. The earliest Gospel records the act and issues no institution. Whatever the later rite became, the first written account of this meal does not establish it, and that restraint belongs on the same list as the dropped begetting clause and the blessed kingdom rather than the blessed king.

This is my blood of the covenant: touto estin to haima mou tēs diathēkēs. The phrase is Sinai's, and Sinai is where its meaning is fixed. Moses takes the blood of the offerings, throws half against the altar, reads the covenant aloud, and *threw it on the people, and said, Behold the blood of the covenant that the LORD has made with you* (Exodus 24:8). The blood of the covenant is thrown *upon* people. It is never drunk. And the prohibition on drinking it is not a detail but a stated law with a stated reason: *the life of the flesh is in the blood, and I have given it to you upon the altar to make atonement for your souls; therefore no person among you shall eat blood* (Leviticus 17:11-12). The Torah bars the ingestion in the same verse in which it explains the blood's function.

The corpus keeps that bar in force three times, listing blood among the four forbidden things (Q 2:173, Q 5:3, Q 16:115). And then, in the passage on the sacrificial animals of its own pilgrimage, it states the principle that resolves the whole matter: *lan yanāla Allāha luḥūmuḥā wa-lā dimā'uhā, wa-lākin yanāluḥu al-taqwā minkum*, neither their flesh nor their blood reaches Allah ﷻ, but the reverence from you reaches Him (Q 22:37).

Set the three scriptures in sequence and an arc appears that neither community usually draws. At Sinai the covenant token is blood, applied externally. In the priestly law the covenant token is salt, added to every offering, and this commentary has already shown what salt declares: dependence, since it cannot be produced by the one who brings it. At the corpus the token is withdrawn entirely and what ascends is *taqwā*, the reverence itself, with the flesh and the blood explicitly stated not to reach Him. Blood applied, then

salt added, then nothing material at all: the covenant sign is progressively interiorised across the three revelations until only the disposition rises. Mark's cup stands at the middle of that arc, spoken in Sinai's own words on the night of a Passover, and the corpus stands at its end and says which part of any offering ever arrived.

This is one of the eight places where the reader's own scripture would correct the received practice, and one of the five in which the correction is an operation the corpus performs on its own community first. The eight are gathered at VI.3, in thematic order rather than in order of arrival. Q 22:37 is not addressed to Christians. It is addressed to pilgrims bringing camels, and it tells them what does and does not reach Him.

The last clause of the supper is a vow of abstention with a horizon: *I will not drink again of the fruit of the vine until that day when I drink it new in the kingdom of God*. A cup renounced now and a cup promised then, and the corpus's every cup is that second one: *wa-suqū sharāban ṭahūrā*, and they are given a pure drink (Q 76:21), *ka'san lā laghwun fihā wa-lā ta'thīm*, a cup in which is no idle talk and no sin (Q 52:23). The wine of the kingdom in both books is not this wine.

Gethsemane • Mark 14:26-42

> And when they had sung a hymn, they went out to the Mount of Olives. And Jesus said to them: You will all fall away, for it is written, I will strike the shepherd, and the sheep will be scattered. But after I am raised up, I will go before you to Galilee. Peter said to him: Even though they all fall away, I will not. And Jesus said to him: Truly, I tell you, this very night, before the rooster crows twice, you will deny me three times. But he said emphatically: If I must die with you, I will not deny you. And they all said the same.

Commentary based on Quran

The hymn is the Hallel, the second half of which is Psalm 118, the psalm the crowd sang at the gate and the parable quoted in the temple. It frames the visit and it is sung on the way out to the garden.

I will strike the shepherd is Zechariah 13:7, and the striking in that oracle is God's own act. The shepherd-image, already logged as a partial transit, appears here in its harshest form. And beside the prediction of scattering stands a promise the disciples do not hear: *after I am raised up, I will go before you, proaxō hymas*, the verb from the road to Jerusalem, and the young man at the tomb will repeat it to the women. The failure is announced and the regathering is announced in the same breath.

Peter's protest is the moment the corpus's clause about the community was revealed for: *wa-mā Muḥammadun illā rasūlun qad khalat min qablihi al-rusul, a-fa-in māta aw qutila inqalabtum 'alā a'qābikum*, if he died or were killed, would you turn back on your heels (Q 3:144). The turning back is predicted in both books, and in both it is followed by mercy rather than by dismissal.

> And they went to a place called Gethsemane. And he said to his disciples: Sit here while I pray. And he took with him Peter and James and John, and began to be greatly distressed and troubled. And he said to them: My soul is very sorrowful, even to death. Remain here and watch. And going a little farther, he fell on the ground and prayed that, if it were possible, the hour might pass from him. And he said: Abba, Father, all things are possible for you. Remove this cup from me. Yet not what I will, but what you will.

This is the centre of the movement and, from the fixed position, the least difficult passage in the Gospel.

Abba: the third of the four preserved Aramaic words, and with the fourth one scene away the pattern can now be stated whole. *Talitha kum* to a dead girl, *ephphatha* to a deaf man, *Abba* in prayer, *Elōi Elōi lema sabachthani* from the cross. All four are moments of *address*, two spoken to the afflicted and two spoken upward, and in every case Mark keeps the language the speaker actually used and glosses it for readers who cannot. A text being remade in Greek categories does not preserve the source language at precisely the moments of address and then translate it in an aside. Aramaic retentions, four, and the count is closed.

All things are possible for you. He says it upward, in the second person, about the One he is addressing. Chapter nine had him say *all things are possible for the one who trusts*, and here the same phrase is directed where it belongs, and the request follows: *remove this cup*. He asks. He is refused. And the refusal is accepted in the sentence that is the whole doctrine of this commentary in seven Greek words: *all' ou ti egō thelō alla ti sy*, yet not what I will, but what you will.

Follow *thelō* through this Gospel and the arc is complete here. A leper said *if you are willing, you can make me clean*, and the answer was *thelō, I am willing*. Now the willing one places his own will beneath another's, in the same verb. The corpus's sentence for that placement is the one it addresses to everyone: *wa-mā tashā'ūna illā an yashā'a Allāh*, and you do not will unless Allah ﷻ wills (Q 76:30, Q 81:29). And its portrait of the servant who prays exactly like this is Ayyūb AS, *innī massaniya al-ḡurru wa-anta arḡamu al-rāḡimīn*, harm has touched me, and You are the most merciful of the merciful (Q 21:83), a petition that states the affliction and names the mercy and issues no demand.

Nothing in this scene requires adjustment from the corpus's position, and a great deal in it would require adjustment from any position that holds the one praying and the One prayed to are the same. Two wills are named in one sentence and one is subordinated to the other, by the speaker, on his face on the ground.

Structural Commentary · Gethsemane, Mark 14:32-42

What stands. A servant, a cup, and the One addressed as *Abba*.

What moves. A petition: *all things are possible for you; remove this cup*.

How they bind. *Yet not what I will, but what you will.* The binding clause names two wills and ranks them, and the ranking is performed by the lower of the two.

The reading closes because the three are genuinely distinct. Any reading that identifies the one praying with the One prayed to collapses the first register into the third, and the sentence stops parsing: a will subordinated to itself is not a subordination. The corpus states the same ranking as a universal, *and you do not will unless Allah ﷻ wills* (Q 76:30), and its own portrait of the praying servant, Ayyūb AS at Q 21:83, states the affliction and names the mercy and issues no demand. ۞ GOL on the two wills in one sentence.

> And he came and found them sleeping, and he said to Peter: Simon, are you asleep? Could you not watch one hour? Watch and pray that you may not enter into temptation. The spirit indeed is willing, but the flesh is weak. And again he went away and prayed, saying the same words. And again he came and found them sleeping, for their eyes were very heavy, and they did not know what to answer him. And he came the third time and said to them: Are you still sleeping and taking your rest? It is enough; the hour has come. The Son of Man is betrayed into the hands of sinners. Rise, let us be going; see, my betrayer is at hand.

Ouk ischysas mian hōran grēgorēsai: you had not the strength to watch one hour. The chain closes. It opened with the forerunner announcing one *mightier*; it ran through the strong man bound, the man among the tombs whom no one had *strength* to subdue, and the disciples who *were not able* to cast out a spirit; and it ends on Peter, awake for less than an hour. Strength, five, and the argument the sequence makes is finished: in this Gospel strength is never held, it is granted, and where it is not granted a man cannot stay awake.

The spirit indeed is willing, but the flesh is weak. The corpus's anthropology in one clause: *wa-khuliqa al-insānu ḡa'īfā*, and the human was created weak (Q 4:28), stated in a verse about mercy and lightening. Neither book treats the weakness as a scandal. Both treat it as the reason the watching has to be prayed for rather than mustered.

And the parable's clock is running exactly as it was set: evening has passed, this is the middle watch, and Peter's rooster is two hours away.

The Arrest · Mark 14:43-52

> And immediately, while he was still speaking, Judas came, one of the twelve, and with him a crowd with swords and clubs, from the chief priests and the scribes and the elders. Now the betrayer had given them a sign, saying: The one I will kiss is the man. Seize him and lead him away under guard. And when he came, he went up to him at once and said: Rabbi! And he kissed him. And they laid hands on him and seized him. But one of those who

stood by drew his sword and struck the servant of the high priest and cut off his ear. And Jesus said to them: Have you come out as against a robber, with swords and clubs to capture me? Day after day I was with you in the temple teaching, and you did not seize me. But let the Scriptures be fulfilled. And they all left him and fled. And a young man followed him, with nothing but a linen cloth about his body. And they seized him, but he left the linen cloth and ran away naked.

Commentary based on Quran

The sign agreed with the arresting party is a kiss, and the word Mark uses for the act itself is intensive, *katēphilēsen*, he kissed him warmly. The corpus has no verse about this scene, but it has the general law that covers it: *wa-kadhālika ja‘alnā li-kulli nabiyyin ‘aduwwan shayāṭīna al-insi wa-l-jinni yūhī ba‘ḍuhum ilā ba‘ḍin zukhrufa al-qawli ghurūrā*, thus We appointed for every prophet an enemy, satans of humankind and jinn, inspiring one another with ornamented speech as delusion (Q 6:112). Ornamented speech as the instrument of betrayal, and there is no ornament more complete than affection used as a marker.

The sword is drawn and an ear is cut off, and Mark reports the wound and no healing. Luke, later, adds the healing. The earliest text leaves a man mutilated in the dark and the rebuke that follows is aimed at the arresting party's method rather than at the swordsman: *have you come out as against a robber?* The complaint is that a public teacher available daily in the temple has been taken by night with a mob, which is a complaint about procedure, and the corpus's standing description of its own messenger's conduct is the contrast, *qul hādhihi sabīlī ad‘ū ilā Allāhi ‘alā baṣīratin*, say: this is my way, I call to Allah ﷻ upon clear evidence (Q 12:108), open, argued, in daylight.

And they all left him and fled. The prediction of an hour before is fulfilled in four words, and Mark does not soften it: the flight is total.

Then two verses that no evangelist would invent and none of the others keeps. A young man is following, wearing nothing but a linen sheet; they grab at him; he leaves the sheet and runs away naked. There is no explanation, no name, no lesson drawn, and the detail serves no theological purpose whatever. It is the kind of thing a text contains when it is reporting rather than composing, and it belongs on the same list as the family who thought him mad and the ending that stops on a conjunction. This commentary declines to allegorise it and records it as what it looks like: a memory.

Before the Council · Mark 14:53-65

> And they led Jesus to the high priest. And all the chief priests and the elders and the scribes came together. And Peter had followed him at a distance, right into the courtyard of the high priest. And he was sitting with the guards and warming himself at the fire.

Commentary based on Quran

The sixth and last interruption opens, and Mark builds it as a comparison: inside, a man is asked who he is and answers; outside, a man is asked who he is and denies. Two interrogations run at once in the same building. Intercalation, six.

> Now the chief priests and the whole council were seeking testimony against Jesus to put him to death, but they found none. For many bore false witness against him, but their testimony did not agree. And some stood up and bore false witness against him, saying: We heard him say, I will destroy this temple that is made with hands, and in three days I will build another, not made with hands. Yet even about this their testimony did not agree. And the high priest stood up in the midst and asked Jesus: Have you no answer to make? What is it that these men testify against you? But he remained silent and made no answer.

Mark states twice that the testimony did not agree, *isai hai martyriai ouk ēsan*, and the doubling is a legal observation: under the law of that court two witnesses had to concur, and they did not. The corpus's standard for testimony is stated as a command to its own community and it is the inversion of this scene: *kūnū qawwāmīna bi-l-qisṭi shuhadā‘a lillāhi wa-law ‘alā anfusikum*, be upholders of justice, witnesses for Allah ﷻ, even against yourselves (Q 4:135). What is convened here is witness against a man for the sake of a verdict already chosen.

And he answers nothing. *Ho de esiōpa kai ouk apekrinato ouden.* The silence is the servant of Isaiah 53:7, who *opened not his mouth* before his shearers, and the image crossed this far and no further: transit, partial, since the corpus takes up neither that chapter's silence-figure nor its wounding-figure for this prophet. What the corpus does carry is the disposition, *wa-ṣbir wa-mā ṣabrūka illā bi-llāh*, and be patient, and your patience is only through Allah ﷻ (Q 16:127), patience itself named as a thing given rather than summoned.

> Again the high priest asked him: Are you the Christ, the Son of the Blessed? And Jesus said: I am, and you will see the Son of Man seated at the right hand of Power, and coming with the clouds of heaven. And the high priest tore his garments and said: Why do we still need witnesses? You have heard his blasphemy. What is your decision? And they all condemned him as deserving death. And some began to spit on him and to cover his face and to strike him, saying to him: Prophecy! And the guards received him with blows.

Here the long deferral ends, and it ends at the exact point where speaking costs everything.

Trace the count that this commentary has kept since the first synagogue: nine silencings, on demons who spoke correctly, on a cleansed leper, on crowds, on the disciples after Peter's confession, on the three coming down the mountain. The one publication in all that time was of the suffering, spoken *parrēsia*, openly. Now, under direct question, in the one setting where the

answer is a capital matter, the embargo is lifted. Nothing was ever being hidden for its own sake; the release comes when the release can no longer be mistaken for a bid for power, because it is a confession made under arrest.

And what he actually says is worth reading closely. *Egō eimi*, I am, answering the question as put. Then the content, and the content is two quotations. *Seated at the right hand of Power* is Psalm 110:1, the psalm whose riddle he had opened in the temple; and *coming with the clouds* is Daniel 7:13, whose next verse says the dominion *was given* to that figure. Note the periphrasis: he says *the right hand of Power*, *tēs dynamēōs*, avoiding the Name in the manner of the pious speech of that time, which is the same reverence that produces the divine passives running under this whole Gospel. He answers a question about his office by quoting two texts in which the exalted figure is seated by another and given his dominion by another.

The high priest's response is to tear his robes and name it blasphemy, which is the same charge as in the very first controversy of the book, when scribes said *who can forgive sins but God alone* and used the corpus's own sentence. The commentary said then that the doctrine was right and the application wrong, and the same holds here: what has been claimed is a seat *at the right hand*, which is by definition not the throne, and a coming with clouds in a glory that Daniel and Mark alike call conferred.

Mark then does something with a verb he has used exactly once before. The high priest *tore*, *dierrēxen*, his garments. The heavens were *torn* at the baptism and the sanctuary curtain will be *torn* at the death, both by an unnamed hand from above, and here in the middle a man tears his own clothes as a legal gesture of horror. Three tearings: two from above, opening, and one from below, condemning.

Some began to spit on him. Spittle, four, and the prediction of chapter ten is now event. The men who cover his face and demand *prophecy* have devised a test that requires him to see without eyes, and the corpus's word over exactly this class of mockery is *yā ḥasratān 'alā al-'ibād, mā ya'tihim min rasūlin illā kānū bihi yastahzi'ūn* (Q 36:30).

The Denials • Mark 14:66-72

> And as Peter was below in the courtyard, one of the servant girls of the high priest came, and seeing Peter warming himself, she looked at him and said: You also were with the Nazarene, Jesus. But he denied it, saying: I neither know nor understand what you mean. And he went out into the gateway, and the rooster crowed. And the servant girl saw him and began again to say to the bystanders: This man is one of them. But again he denied it. And after a little while the bystanders again said to Peter: Certainly you are one of them, for you are a Galilean. But he began to invoke a curse on himself and to swear: I do not know this man of whom you speak. And immediately the rooster crowed a second time. And Peter remembered how Jesus had said

to him: Before the rooster crows twice, you will deny me three times. And he broke down and wept.

Commentary based on Quran

The interruption closes and the comparison stands complete. Inside, under oath, before the court that can kill him, a man says who he is. Outside, at a fire, questioned by a serving girl with no power at all, a man says he does not know him. The one who said *even though they all fall away, I will not* is undone by the least dangerous questioner in the building, and the escalation is exact: a denial, then a denial, then oaths and a self-curse.

Mark reports the whole of it, and it is worth remembering who his first readers understood the source to be. This is the most damaging story in the Gospel about the most prominent figure in the early community, and it is preserved with every detail intact, including the cursing. A text managing its reputation removes this. It is the same authentication as the *could not* at Nazareth and the family who came to seize him.

And the corpus, read on this scene, does something that no reader expects until they see it. It has a clause for exactly this case. In the middle of its severest passage about renouncing faith after having held it, it opens a door and specifies who walks through: *illā man ukriha wa-qalbuḥu muṭma'innun bi-l-īmān*, except one who is compelled while his heart is at rest with faith (Q 16:106). The exception is not for the strong. It is for the one whose mouth said what his heart did not, under duress, and the corpus's judgment on him is that he stands outside the condemnation entirely.

Mark supplies precisely the evidence that clause requires. He does not report that Peter shrugged and went home. He reports that Peter *remembered*, and then *epibalōn eklaien*, he broke down and wept. The weeping is the state of the heart made visible in the same hour as the denial, and it is the only thing in the scene that testifies to what was inside the man while his mouth was working. Both texts, in their different ways, refuse to let the words be the whole verdict.

And the last word on Peter in this Gospel is not this scene. Two chapters on, at the tomb, the messenger's instruction will name him separately from the others, *tell his disciples and Peter*, and the singling out is a restoration by name. The corpus's own clause and Mark's own ending agree on the disposition of a man who denied under pressure and wept.

Before Pilate • Mark 15:1-15

> And as soon as it was morning, the chief priests held a consultation with the elders and scribes and the whole council. And they bound Jesus and led him away and delivered him over to Pilate. And Pilate asked him: Are you the King of the Jews? And he answered him: You have said so. And the chief priests accused him of many things. And Pilate again asked him: Have you no answer to make? See how many charges they bring against you. But Jesus made no further answer, so that Pilate was amazed.

Commentary based on Quran

Morning: the last of the four watches. The parable's clock has run its whole course, evening to midnight to cockcrow to dawn, in exactly the order the chapter named, and the disciples have slept through the middle of it.

Pilate's question is political, not theological, because *King of the Jews* is a charge of sedition rather than a religious title, and the answer is a deflection: *sy legeis*, you say so. It neither affirms in the questioner's terms nor denies, and it is the same manoeuvre as *why do you call me good*: the predicate is handed back to the one who offered it. Then silence again, and Pilate's amazement, *thaumazein*, which Mark records as a fact about the governor's experience of the man.

> Now at the feast he used to release for them one prisoner for whom they asked. And among the rebels in prison, who had committed murder in the insurrection, there was a man called Barabbas. And the crowd came up and began to ask Pilate to do as he usually did for them. And he answered them, saying: Do you want me to release for you the King of the Jews? For he perceived that it was out of envy that the chief priests had delivered him up. But the chief priests stirred up the crowd to have him release for them Barabbas instead. And Pilate again said to them: Then what shall I do with the man you call the King of the Jews? And they cried out again: Crucify him. And Pilate said to them: Why? What evil has he done? But they shouted all the more: Crucify him. So Pilate, wishing to satisfy the crowd, released for them Barabbas, and having scourged Jesus, he delivered him to be crucified.

The governor knows. Mark says it plainly: *he perceived that it was out of envy that the chief priests had delivered him up*, and he asks the crowd twice, and the second time he asks *what evil has he done?* and receives no answer, only volume. Then he releases the murderer and hands over the man he has just described as innocent, and the reason Mark gives is not law and not conviction: *boulomenos tō ochlō to hikanon poiēsai*, wishing to satisfy the crowd.

That is the second official in this Gospel destroyed by an audience. Herod knew John was righteous and killed him because of his guests. Pilate knows this man is innocent and condemns him because of a crowd. Mark has built the same portrait twice, and the corpus's diagnosis, spoken to a prophet about a lesser matter, covers both: *wa-takhshā al-nāsa wa-Allāhu aḥaqqu an takhshāh*, and you feared people, when Allah ﷻ is worthier of being feared (Q 33:37). And the corpus states the general rule for anyone standing where these two men stood: *wa-in tuṭī' akthara man fī al-arḍi yuḍillūka 'an sabīli Allāh*, and if you obey most of those on the earth, they will lead you astray from the way of Allah ﷻ (Q 6:116).

The prisoner's name carries an irony Mark never points at. *Bar-Abba* is Aramaic for *son of the father*. The crowd is offered two men and asks for the other son of the father, and the earliest

Gospel sets the two names side by side and says nothing whatever about it.

The Mocking and the Road · Mark 15:16-21

> And the soldiers led him away inside the palace, that is, the governor's headquarters, and they called together the whole battalion. And they clothed him in a purple cloak, and twisting together a crown of thorns, they put it on him. And they began to salute him: Hail, King of the Jews! And they were striking his head with a reed and spitting on him and kneeling down in homage to him. And when they had mocked him, they stripped him of the purple cloak and put his own clothes on him. And they led him out to crucify him. And they compelled a passerby, Simon of Cyrene, who was coming in from the country, the father of Alexander and Rufus, to carry his cross.

Commentary based on Quran

The mockery is a coronation performed as a joke: a robe, a crown, a sceptre-reed, a salute, and genuflection. Every element of an enthronement is present and every one is inverted, and this Gospel, which declined to let the crowd bless the king at the gate, allows a barracks to crown him in mockery.

Spitting on him: spittle, five, and the count is closed. The fluid that opened a deaf man's ears at Decapolis and a blind man's eyes at Bethsaida, foretold at the third announcement, enacted in the high priest's courtyard, and enacted here for the last time. Two healings and three humiliations, one substance. The servant who used it to open the senses of others is covered in it by men who will not use theirs.

The corpus has a verse that sits over this scene with unusual exactness, and it is spoken at the reckoning to a man who had been arrogant in the world: *dhuq innaka anta al-'azīzu al-karīm*, taste it; indeed you are the mighty, the noble (Q 44:49). The corpus knows the device of the sarcastic honorific, and it reserves it for the Day and for those who claimed height. Here the device runs in the opposite direction, a mock-title conferred by soldiers on a man who never claimed the height, and the corpus's own use of the form shows what the soldiers were doing and to whom such mockery properly belongs.

Then Simon, and Mark gives his sons' names, *Alexander and Rufus*, which is how a first-century writer says *you can ask them*. He is *compelled*, *angareuousin*, a technical loanword for a soldier's right of impressment, and he carries the wood.

And here a distinction should be made carefully, because a reader coming from the corpus will feel it immediately. One man carried another man's cross-beam up a hill; that is a fact of Roman procedure and it is what the verb says. The corpus's law about carrying is about something else entirely and it is stated four times: *wa-lā taziru wāziratun wizra ukhrā*, no bearer of burdens bears the burden of another (Q 6:164, Q 17:15, Q 35:18, Q 53:38). Timber can be shouldered by a passerby; *wizr*, the load of what a soul has earned, cannot be transferred at all. Both

sentences are true and they are about different objects, and the distinction between them is itself the teaching: what Simon carried was the instrument, and the corpus's law concerns the account.

The Crucifixion · Mark 15:22-32

> And they brought him to the place called Golgotha, which means Place of a Skull. And they offered him wine mixed with myrrh, but he did not take it. And they crucified him and divided his garments among them, casting lots for them, to decide what each should take. And it was the third hour when they crucified him. And the inscription of the charge against him read, The King of the Jews. And with him they crucified two robbers, one on his right and one on his left. And those who passed by derided him, wagging their heads and saying: Aha! You who would destroy the temple and rebuild it in three days, save yourself, and come down from the cross! So also the chief priests with the scribes mocked him to one another, saying: He saved others; he cannot save himself. Let the Christ, the King of Israel, come down now from the cross that we may see and believe. Those who were crucified with him also reviled him.

Commentary based on Quran

The wine mixed with myrrh was an analgesic, offered by custom to the condemned, and *ouk elaben*, he did not take it. The refusal is recorded without comment and it is the last free act the narrative gives him.

Then Psalm 22 begins to run through the scene, and it runs three times. *They divided his garments among them, casting lots* is Psalm 22:18. *Wagging their heads* is Psalm 22:7. And the cry from the cross will be Psalm 22:1. Mark quotes one psalm at the beginning, the middle, and the end of the crucifixion, and the reader who follows the citations back will find where they lead.

Two robbers, *one on his right and one on his left*. Five chapters earlier two disciples asked for exactly those two places, in his glory, and were told the seats were not his to give but were prepared for those for whom they had been prepared. Mark writes the request and its dark fulfilment into the same book and joins them with nothing.

And the mockery contains the truest sentence anyone speaks in this Gospel. *He saved others; he cannot save himself*: *allous esōsen, heauton ou dynatai sōsai*. They intend it as proof of fraud. It is, precisely, the doctrine. A power that is granted per occasion and never owned is exactly a power one cannot turn on oneself at will, and this commentary has watched that grammar operate since the first divine passive: *be cleansed, was restored, has been prepared, no sign will be given*. The corpus puts the same sentence in the mouth of its own Prophet ﷺ as a commanded declaration: *qul lā amliku li-nafsī naf'an wa-lā ḍarran illā mā shā'a Allāh*, say: I hold no power to benefit or harm myself, except what Allah ﷻ wills (Q 7:188), and again *qul innī lā amliku lakum ḍarran wa-lā rashadā*, say: I hold no power over harm or

right guidance for you (Q 72:21). The mockers state the servant's own creed and think they are refuting him.

Structural Commentary · The Mockery, Mark 15:29-32

What stands. A man on a cross who has healed others.

What moves. Nothing. No descent, no sign, no self-rescue.

How they bind. *He saved others; he cannot save himself*. Read as an accusation it alleges fraud. Read structurally it states the relation the whole book has been drawing: a capacity that arrives per occasion cannot be turned on its holder at will, because it was never held.

The taunt closes the reading rather than breaking it, and the corpus puts the identical sentence in its own Prophet's ﷺ mouth as a commanded declaration: *say, I hold no power to benefit or harm myself, except what Allah ﷻ wills* (Q 7:188). ۛ GOL on the sentence the mockers got right.

Come down now, that we may see and believe. It is the sign-demand of chapter eight, made a third time and in its final form, and the answer given then stands: no sign will be given to this generation, because the signs are with Allah ﷻ (Q 6:109), and a sign granted to a demand made in mockery has never once, in either scripture, produced belief.

The Cry, and the Veil · Mark 15:33-41

> And when the sixth hour had come, there was darkness over the whole land until the ninth hour. And at the ninth hour Jesus cried with a loud voice: Eloi, Eloi, lema sabachthani? which means, My God, my God, why have you forsaken me? And some of the bystanders hearing it said: Behold, he is calling Elijah. And someone ran and filled a sponge with sour wine, put it on a reed and gave it to him to drink, saying: Wait, let us see whether Elijah will come to take him down. And Jesus uttered a loud cry and breathed his last. And the curtain of the temple was torn in two, from top to bottom. And when the centurion, who stood facing him, saw that in this way he breathed his last, he said: Truly this man was a son of God.

Commentary based on Quran

Darkness at noon for three hours, which is Amos's oracle, *I will make the sun go down at noon and darken the earth in broad daylight* (Amos 8:9), and the corpus's own register for the Day includes the same failure of the lights, *wa-khasafa al-qamar* (Q 75:8).

Then the cry, and this commentary owes it a careful reading rather than a fast one.

Elōi, Elōi, lema sabachthani. The fourth Aramaic retention, kept and glossed, and Matthew, copying, alters the opening word toward Hebrew and produces a smoother text; Mark's version is the harder and the earlier. And Mark keeps something harder still: the bystanders *mishear it*. They think he is calling Elijah, which is a mistake possible only in the Aramaic he actually used. An evangelist composing a theological set-piece does not build in a

mishearing; a witness reports what was said and what people thought they heard.

The words are the first line of Psalm 22, and everything turns on whether one reads the line or the psalm. In that culture a psalm was cited by its opening, and the opening carries the whole with it. So read the whole. The psalm that begins *my God, my God, why have you forsaken me* contains, at its own centre, the flat denial of the abandonment it opened with: *for he has not despised or scorned the suffering of the afflicted one; he has not hidden his face from him, but has listened to his cry for help* (Psalm 22:24). *Lo histir panav*, he has not hidden his face. The psalm answers its own first line, and it ends in a congregation praising and *all the families of the nations* turning to the Lord. Mark has been quoting this psalm since the garments were divided. The reader who follows the third quotation back finds a text whose whole trajectory is from apparent abandonment to declared faithfulness and a gathering of the nations, and the centurion, a Gentile, speaks eight verses later.

The corpus states the psalm's own denial in its own words, and it states it to a prophet in a moment of apparent silence from heaven: *mā wadda'aka rabbuka wa-mā qalā*, your Lord has not forsaken you, nor is He displeased (Q 93:3). The occasion of that verse, in the tradition of its own community, is a period in which revelation paused and the Prophet ﷺ was mocked for having been abandoned. Psalm 22:24 and Q 93:3 are the same sentence in two languages, and each one arrives at the moment its speaker most looked forsaken.

And the corpus has an entire register for the complaint uttered upward, which it neither rebukes nor conceals. *Innamā ashkū baththī wa-ḥuznī ilā Allāh*, I complain of my anguish and grief only to Allah ﷻ, says Ya'qūb AS (Q 12:86), and the word *ashkū* is a complaint, addressed to the only address that takes it. Ayyūb AS calls out *massaniya al-ḍurr*, harm has touched me (Q 21:83). Yūnus AS cries *from the darknesses*, and the corpus records the answer: *fa-stajabnā lahu wa-najjaynāhu min al-ghamm*, *wakadhālika nunjī al-mu'minīn*, so We responded to him and delivered him from the distress, and thus do We deliver the believers (Q 21:88). And the corpus puts the sharpest form of the question in the mouths of the faithful and answers it in the same verse: *hattā yaqūla al-rasūlu wa-lladhīna āmanū ma'ahu matā naṣru Allāh, alā inna naṣra Allāhi qarīb*, until the messenger and those with him said, when will the help of Allah ﷻ come? Truly, the help of Allah ﷻ is near (Q 2:214). The cry and the answer occupy one verse.

So the cry from the cross is not, in either book's register, a rupture in the relation. It is an address, made across the appearance of absence, in the words of a psalm that denies the absence in its own middle, by a man whose scripture-tradition and whose successor-tradition both hold that this is precisely what the afflicted servant does. What lies inside that moment for the one who spoke it is not written in either text, and this commentary does not write it. The interior of that cry is disclosed in no

scripture, and the only testimony that could disclose it would have to come from the One addressed.

And the curtain of the temple was torn in two, from top to bottom. *Eschisthē*, the verb of the first chapter, where the heavens were *torn* at the baptism. The Gospel's frame closes: the barrier above was opened as the work began and the barrier within is opened as it ends, both *from the top*, both by no named hand. Between them stood a high priest tearing his own robes from below. Two openings and one condemnation, and the two openings are not human acts.

Then the centurion. He has watched executions before, and Mark says exactly what convinced him: *seeing that in this way he breathed his last*, the manner of the dying. And he says *alēthōs houtos ho anthrōpos huioṣ theou ēn*. The Greek has no article, which in that position is characteristically qualitative, and the phrase in a Roman soldier's mouth is what it is: a man's judgment, at a cross, in the vocabulary his own world used for figures of divine favour. Mark's placement is the argument. The confession this Gospel has been silencing for fifteen chapters is finally spoken, and it is spoken by a Gentile, about a corpse, with no power in view.

> There were also women looking on from a distance, among whom were Mary Magdalene, and Mary the mother of James the younger and of Joses, and Salome. When he was in Galilee, they followed him and ministered to him, and there were also many other women who had come up with him to Jerusalem.

The disciples fled at the arrest and are not mentioned again. The women are at the cross, and Mark names three and says there were many more. And the verb he uses of them is *diēkonoun autō*, they served him, the same verb as the angels in the wilderness and the woman raised from fever. The serving that has run under this whole Gospel is, at the end, what is still standing at the foot of the cross.

Structural Commentary · The Cry, Mark 15:34

What stands. The addressee. *Elōi, elōi*: the vocative comes first and it comes twice, with the possessive attached, before any complaint is made.

What moves. The complaint, real and unedited, spoken at the ninth hour out of a darkness the narrator has already put over the whole land, and preserved by Mark in the language it was spoken in.

How they bind. The order of the clauses. An address issued into total absence is what the sentence describes and what it simultaneously refutes, because a vocative cannot be issued to nothing. The paradox is not resolved; it is held, and the holding is in the grammar.

The corpus builds the same call the same way. Yūnus AS calls *fi al-ḡulumāt*, from inside the darknesses, and the content of the call is the affirmation of the One called, *lā ilāha illā anta*, with the fault placed at the caller and not at the One called (Q 21:87). And

innamā ashkū baththī wa-ḥuznī ilā Allāh, I complain of my anguish only to Allah ﷻ (Q 12:86), licenses the register outright: the complaint is real and its direction is the one thing that keeps it from becoming a verdict. Collapse the addressee and there is nobody to cry to. Collapse the complaint and the scene is stoic and Mark's own Aramaic is inexplicable. Collapse the order and the sentence is either a report of abandonment or a formula, and it is neither. ⚡ GOL↑ on the cry.

The Burial · Mark 15:42-47

> And when evening had come, since it was the day of Preparation, that is, the day before the Sabbath, Joseph of Arimathea, a respected member of the council, who was also himself looking for the kingdom of God, took courage and went to Pilate and asked for the body of Jesus. Pilate was surprised to hear that he should have already died. And summoning the centurion, he asked him whether he was already dead. And when he learned from the centurion that he was dead, he granted the corpse to Joseph. And Joseph bought a linen shroud, and taking him down, wrapped him in the linen shroud and laid him in a tomb that had been cut out of the rock. And he rolled a stone against the entrance of the tomb. And Mary Magdalene and Mary the mother of Jesus saw where he was laid.

Commentary based on Quran

Joseph is a member of the council that condemned him, and Mark says two things about him that belong together: he was *looking for the kingdom of God*, and he *took courage, tolmēsas*. A man on the inside who held a conviction he had not declared, and who declares it by an action at the moment when declaring it is most costly.

The corpus has this figure, and gives him a chapter. *Wa-qāla rajulun mu'minun min āli Fir'awna yaktumu īmānahu*, and a believing man from the family of Pharaoh, who concealed his faith, said (Q 40:28), and the surah is named after him, *Ghāfir*, and his speech runs for a dozen verses, and its argument is procedural: would you kill a man for saying my Lord is Allah ﷻ, when he has brought you clear proofs? A concealed believer inside the hostile council who speaks up when the killing is at hand is a type the corpus knows well enough to build a surah around, and Mark's Joseph is that man at the other end of the same story, arriving one day late to say it with his hands instead of his mouth.

Pilate's surprise is a detail no one would compose. Crucifixion killed slowly, sometimes over days, and the governor *ethaumasen* that it was already over and sent for the centurion to confirm it. Mark includes an official verification of the death from the officer who ran the execution, and he includes it in passing, as procedure, not as apologetic.

And the last verse of the chapter is chain of custody: *Mary Magdalene and Mary the mother of Jesus saw where he was laid*. Mark names the witnesses and states that they observed the

location. The women who watched the death watched the burial, and in three days they will go to the place they watched.

The movement ends here, in a rock-cut tomb with a stone rolled against it, at evening, on the day before a Sabbath. A woman broke a flask over him and was told it would be remembered wherever the message went. A cup was poured and the covenant was named in Sinai's words, and the corpus said what part of any offering ever reaches Him. A man prayed with his face on the ground and placed his own will beneath another's. His closest companion could not stay awake, and then denied him, and wept. He was asked directly and answered directly, quoting two texts in which the exalted figure receives what he has. He was mocked with a creed he held, that he could not save himself. He cried out in the words of a psalm that denies the abandonment it opens with. The veil was torn from the top. A soldier said what fifteen chapters had suppressed. And a frightened councillor found his courage after everything was already lost.

Structural Commentary · The Movement Entire

What stands. The record, written before the bringing-into-being, which the corpus states as a general law at Q 57:22 and which Mark states of this week in three announcements and one *kathōs gegraptai*.

What moves. The enacting. A flask broken over his head, a man seeking a convenient hour, a cup asked to pass and then not asked again, a denial sworn three times, and a body taken down before evening. Three moral values and one register of cost.

How they bind. The asymmetry. The going is written and the betraying carries a woe, in one sentence, unreconciled, and the corpus states the mechanism in the adversary's own mouth: *do not blame me, blame yourselves*.

Collapse the record into the deed and the woe at Mk 14:21 is unjust. Collapse the deed into the record and the anointing is not hers and the memorial is empty. Collapse the asymmetry and Gethsemane is theatre, since a subordination that was never a real request subordinates nothing. ⚡ GOL on the written-and-willed asymmetry.

The Tomb · Mark 16:1-20

Eight verses, and then a problem the manuscripts themselves report. The Gospel that began with a torn heaven ends with a rolled stone and a sentence that stops before it finishes.

Box | What to Watch

The stone is rolled back by a grammar that names nobody, answering the women's own question.

He was raised, passive, where the corpus writes the Name in the active: *bal rafa'ahu Allāhu ilayh*.

Peter is named separately out of the group he had cursed his way out of.

The book stops on a conjunction, at fear, and Q 10:62 lifts it.

The Women at the Tomb · Mark 16:1-8

> When the Sabbath was past, Mary Magdalene, Mary the mother of James, and Salome bought spices, so that they might go and anoint him. And very early on the first day of the week, when the sun had risen, they went to the tomb. And they were saying to one another: Who will roll away the stone for us from the entrance of the tomb? And looking up, they saw that the stone had been rolled back, for it was very large.

Commentary based on Quran

The three named women are the three who watched the death. They buy spices, they plan, they set out at first light, and on the way they realise they have no answer to the one practical problem: the stone.

And here the pair Mark set up two chapters ago completes itself. In Bethany a woman nobody named, who asked nobody's permission and made no arrangements, broke a flask over his head and was told she had anointed his body beforehand for burial, *proelaben*, she anticipated. Here three women who are named, who bought the materials and made the plan, arrive to perform the anointing and find there is no body to anoint. The unbidden anointing succeeded; the organised one failed. Mark writes both and joins them with nothing, and the arrangement is the argument, as it was with the widow and the falling stones.

Looking up, they saw that the stone had been rolled back: anakekylitai, a perfect passive. Their question was *who will roll it away for us*, and the answer arrives in a grammar that names nobody. The convention that has run under this entire Gospel, the cleansing commanded, the hand restored, the seats prepared, the sign not given, is operating at the door of the tomb: the obstacle is removed and the Remover is unstated.

> And entering the tomb, they saw a young man sitting on the right side, dressed in a white robe, and they were alarmed. And he said to them: Do not be alarmed. You seek Jesus of Nazareth, who was crucified. He has risen; he is not here. See the place where they laid him. But go, tell his disciples and Peter that he is going before you to Galilee. There you will see him, just as he told you.

Ēgerthē: he was raised. Passive, and it is the passive of the whole book. Not *he rose*, which the Greek could have said and does not; the verb hands the act to the unnamed Agent who has been

operating under every scene since a leper was told *be cleansed*. And this is the sentence toward which the corpus's own account has been pointing from the beginning: *bal rafa'ahu Allāhu ilayhi*, rather, Allah ﷻ raised him to Himself (Q 4:158), and *innī mutawaffika wa-rāfi'uka ilayya*, I am taking you and raising you to Myself (Q 3:55). Mark's grammar leaves the blank where the corpus writes the Name. The earliest Gospel says *he was raised* and declines to say by whom; the corpus says by whom and uses the active voice. Between them there is no contradiction at all, only a reverent silence and its filling.

And the announcement cashes two threads at once. *He is going before you to Galilee, proagei hymas*, the verb from the road to Jerusalem and from the walk to the garden, kept to the last page: the one who goes in front is still in front. And *tell his disciples and Peter*: the denier is named separately, singled out of the group he had cursed his way out of. The corpus's clause for the compelled denier whose heart was at rest (Q 16:106) is answered here in narrative, and the answer is a name on a list.

Also cashed is the prediction Mark placed at the fasting-question in chapter two, where the bridegroom would be *taken away, aparthē*, in the passive with no agent named. Fourteen chapters later the taking is reported in the same voice.

> And they went out and fled from the tomb, for trembling and astonishment had seized them, and they said nothing to anyone, for they were afraid.

In the oldest manuscripts, that is the end.

The Greek is *ephobounto gar*, and *gar* is a connective that does not begin sentences and almost never ends them; the book closes on a conjunction, mid-breath, with the reader waiting for the rest of a clause that never comes. It is the strangest ending in ancient literature and it is what the two earliest complete Bibles, Sinaiticus and Vaticanus, both contain.

And the last irony of this Gospel is exact. Fifteen chapters of silencings, nine of them counted here, imposed on demons who spoke correctly, on healed men, on crowds, on disciples. At the end, for the first time, a messenger issues an instruction to *speak*, and the women say nothing to anyone, because they were afraid. The book that suppressed testimony throughout ends with testimony withheld, and stops.

Whether Mark intended that or whether a final leaf was lost cannot be settled, and this commentary does not settle it. What can be said is what the reader is left holding: a stone rolled away by nobody named, a raising in the passive voice, a promise that he goes before them, a denier restored by name, and three frightened women running.

And here the last sentence of the earliest Gospel meets the corpus's own word about fear, and the meeting is the reason this commentary was written. Mark's final clause is *ephobounto gar*, for they were afraid. The corpus's proclamation over those who are His is *alā inna awliyā'a Allāhi lā khawfun 'alayhim wa-lā*

hum yaḥzanūn, truly, upon the friends of Allah ﷻ there is no fear, nor shall they grieve (Q 10:62). One text breaks off at fear. The other opens by lifting it. The sentence that Mark left unfinished on the page is finished six centuries later in another language, and the reader who holds both books watches it complete across the gap.

The corpus adds, of those who fell in His way, the clause that speaks to what the women thought they had come to anoint: *wa-lā taqūlū li-man yuqṭalu fī sabīli Allāhi amwātun, bal aḥyā'un wa-lākin lā tash'urūn*, do not say of those slain in the way of Allah ﷻ that they are dead; rather they are living, but you do not perceive (Q 2:154). They went to a tomb with spices and were told to look at an empty shelf. *You do not perceive* is the corpus's own gloss on that morning.

The Longer Ending · Mark 16:9-20

> Now when he rose early on the first day of the week, he appeared first to Mary Magdalene, from whom he had cast out seven demons. She went and told those who had been with him, as they mourned and wept. But when they heard that he was alive and had been seen by her, they would not believe it. After these things he appeared in another form to two of them, as they were walking into the country. And they went back and told the rest, but they did not believe them. Afterward he appeared to the eleven themselves as they were reclining at table, and he rebuked them for their unbelief and hardness of heart, because they had not believed those who saw him after he had risen. And he said to them: Go into all the world and proclaim the gospel to the whole creation. Whoever believes and is baptized will be saved, but whoever does not believe will be condemned. And these signs will accompany those who believe: in my name they will cast out demons; they will speak in new tongues; they will pick up serpents with their hands; and if they drink any deadly poison, it will not hurt them; they will lay their hands on the sick, and they will recover. So then the Lord Jesus, after he had spoken to them, was taken up into heaven and sat down at the right hand of God. And they went out and preached everywhere, while the Lord worked with them and confirmed the message by accompanying signs.

Commentary based on Quran

The manuscript situation is not a matter of opinion and should be stated plainly, because it is the clearest documented instance in the New Testament of a text growing after its author put it down.

These twelve verses are absent from Sinaiticus and Vaticanus, the two oldest complete Greek Bibles. Eusebius and Jerome both report that the accurate copies known to them ended at verse eight. A number of manuscripts carry a different, shorter ending instead, and some carry both, one after the other; one Greek codex inserts an additional paragraph into the middle of these verses. The vocabulary and sentence-rhythm differ measurably from the rest of Mark, and the passage opens by re-introducing Mary Magdalene as though she had not been named three times in the

preceding chapter, which is what happens when a paragraph written for one context is attached to another.

The multiplicity is the evidence. The tradition did not merely add an ending; it added *endings*, in the plural, at different times and in different places, because verse eight felt unfinished to everyone who copied it. That is a community completing a book, in the open, in a record we can still read.

And this commentary reads the addition with care rather than with scorn, because two things in it are worth noticing.

The first is that the interpolating hand, whoever he was, still wrote in the received grammar. *Anelēmphthē*: he *was taken up*. Passive, agent unnamed, exactly like *ēgerthē* and *aparthē* and *hētoimastai* before it. Even the man completing the Gospel a century or more later reached instinctively for the construction that hands the act upward, and the corpus's own vocabulary for the same event is the active form of that very verb, *rafa'ahu Allāhu ilayhi*. The convention was so deep in the material that an editor could not write outside it.

The second is what the appended list does that the original never does. *In my name they will cast out demons; they will speak in new tongues; they will pick up serpents; if they drink poison it will not hurt them*. Set that beside how the corpus lists the same category of works for the same figure: *and I heal the blind and the leper, and I give life to the dead, by the permission of Allah ﷻ*, with the permission-clause attached four separate times in a single verse (Q 3:49), and again in the retelling at Q 5:110. And set it beside how Mark himself narrates: a leper cleansed in the passive, a hand restored in the passive, a man looking up to heaven before he breaks bread, a sign refused because it *will not be given*.

The appended list carries no permission-clause at all. It is an inventory of capacities promised to believers, with the grammar of grant removed. That is precisely the drift this commentary has been tracking since a healed man in the Decapolis was told to say what *the Lord* had done and went out saying what *Jesus* had done: attribution creeping one link down the chain. The first dilution of this Gospel is visible not only in the manuscript record but in the syntax, and the syntax is the more interesting witness, because it shows what was lost rather than merely that something was added.

The serpents and the poison are the clearest markers of legendary accretion, and the reader may weigh them as such. What matters for this commentary is narrower: the earliest recoverable Gospel of Mark ends at *for they were afraid*, and everything after that is the tradition's own hand, documented, dated, and visible.

This last movement closes the Gospel. The women bought their spices too late, the stone had been moved by nobody named, the raising was reported in the voice this whole book speaks in, the denier was called by name, and the last word was fear. What came

after the last word came from other hands, and the manuscripts say so themselves.

Structural Commentary · The Movement Entire

What stands. The completed count. A seventh spent before a first can open, which is the ordinal argument this Gospel has now used three times, at the Sabbath, at the mountain, and here at the door of a tomb.

What moves. The going. Women who bought spices when the Sabbath ended and walked out at sunrise to perform an anointing that had already been performed and was no longer possible, asking on the road who would move the stone.

How they bind. The unnamed Agent. *It had been rolled back. He was raised.* Both perfect passives, the obstacle removed and the Remover unstated, which is the convention the whole book has been writing and which the corpus writes in the active voice with the Name in it: *bal rafa'ahu Allāhu ilayh.*

Collapse the count and the first day is a date rather than a beginning. Collapse the going and there is nobody present to be told. Collapse the unnamed Agent and the passives are stylistic, and the one grammar that has run from the leper to the tomb has no meaning at its own conclusion. ✧ GOL on the unnamed Agent at the door.

PART V · THE THREADS

Eight things run the length of this Gospel that no single passage displays. They were counted aloud as they arrived; here they are gathered, because a thread is only visible when it is laid out straight. A ninth section stands apart at the end, because the preposition it follows is a Quranic thread rather than a Markan one, and it is the hinge on which the two books turn toward each other.

V.1 · The Unnamed Agent

The deepest habit of Mark's Greek is the reverent passive: an act reported with the acting party left unstated, in the manner of a writer who will not put the Name in an ordinary sentence. Three instances are formal and unmistakable. *Katharisthēti*, be cleansed, spoken to the leper (Mk 1:41), where the healer states his willing and then commands that a cleansing occur. *Apekatestathē*, the hand was restored (Mk 3:5), with no touch and no formula. *Hētoimastai*, it has been prepared, of the seats at the right and left (Mk 10:40), where the sentence's whole point is that the preparing was done by someone other than the one being asked.

Around those three the convention runs continuously. *Aphientai*, your sins are forgiven (Mk 2:5), in the scene where the scribes quote the corpus's own sentence about who alone forgives. *Aparthē*, the bridegroom will be taken away (Mk 2:20). *Dedotai*, to you it has been given (Mk 4:11). *Metemorphōthē*, he was transfigured (Mk 9:2). *Ou dothēsetai*, no sign will be given (Mk 8:12). And at Mk 13:20 the election clause, *tous eklektous hous exelaxato*, where Mark names the Lord for the shortening and

then leaves the choosing of the elect standing without a further agent. *Anakekylistai*, the stone has been rolled back (Mk 16:4). *Ēgerthē*, he was raised (Mk 16:6). And, in the appended ending written by a later hand, *anelēmphthē*, he was taken up (Mk 16:19), which shows how deep the habit ran.

Every one of these is a place where the corpus writes the Name in the active voice. *Rafa'ahu Allāhu ilayh. A'adda Allāhu lahum. Man yaghfiru al-dhunūba illā Allāh.* The two texts are performing the same theology with opposite typography: Mark leaves the blank and the corpus fills it. A reader who has been trained by the corpus reads Mark's blanks as blanks, which is what they are.

V.2 · Strength, Which Is Never Owned

Five occurrences of one root, and read in order they make a single argument.

The forerunner announces *ho ischyroteros*, one mightier than himself, and immediately measures the distance by the sandal-thong (Mk 1:7). The teaching says nobody enters the strong man's house, *tou ischyrou*, without first binding him (Mk 3:27). On the far shore, of the man among the tombs, *no one had the strength*, *oudeis ischyen*, to subdue him, and the arriving authority does it without chains (Mk 5:4). At the foot of the mountain the disciples, who had been given authority over unclean spirits, report *ouk ischysan*, they were not able (Mk 9:18). And in the garden, to Peter: *ouk ischysas mian hōran grēgorēsai*, you had not the strength to watch one hour (Mk 14:37).

The chain descends. It begins with a mightier one announced and ends with a chosen companion unable to stay awake, and in between the only strength that accomplishes anything arrives from outside the one exercising it. That is the corpus's law of every messenger, *wa-mā kāna li-rasūlin an ya'tiya bi-āyatin illā bi-idhni Allāh* (Q 40:78), and it is why the mockers at the cross, saying *he cannot save himself*, were stating the doctrine and not refuting it.

V.3 · The Spitting

One substance, five occurrences, and it crosses from healing to humiliation exactly at the midpoint of the book.

He spits and touches the tongue of the deaf man at Decapolis (Mk 7:33). He spits on the eyes of the blind man at Bethsaida (Mk 8:23). At the third announcement he says *they will spit on him* (Mk 10:34). In the high priest's courtyard *some began to spit on him* (Mk 14:65). In the praetorium the soldiers spit while they kneel in mockery (Mk 15:19).

Two healings, one prophecy, two humiliations. The fluid a servant used to open other people's senses is used on him by men who will not open theirs, and Mark laid the vocabulary down four chapters before he needed it.

V.4 · Four Words He Actually Said

Mark writes in Greek for readers who do not know Aramaic, and four times he keeps the Aramaic and translates it in an aside.

Talitha koum, to a dead girl (Mk 5:41). *Ephphatha*, to a deaf man (Mk 7:34). *Abba*, in the garden (Mk 14:36). *Elōi Elōi lema sabachthani*, from the cross (Mk 15:34).

All four are moments of address, two spoken downward to the afflicted and two spoken upward in prayer, and none of them is a formula or a title. A text being recast in Greek philosophical categories does not preserve the original language precisely at the points of address and then gloss it for the reader; that is what a text does when it is carrying a memory it will not smooth. And the fourth is preserved so faithfully that Mark also records the bystanders *mishearing* it, a mistake possible only in the Aramaic actually used.

V.5 · The Interruptions

Six times Mark opens a story, inserts a second story whole, and returns to the first, so that each reads the other. The device is his signature and no later evangelist uses it as consistently.

The family sets out to seize him and the Beelzebul charge is seated between departure and arrival (Mk 3:20-35): those who should know him best call him mad, those whose office is discernment call him possessed, and the frame asks which misreading the warning falls on. Jairus's errand is suspended for the woman with the flow of blood (Mk 5:21-43), and the two are stitched with a repeated number, twelve years of bleeding and a girl twelve years old. The mission of the Twelve frames the killing of the forerunner (Mk 6:7-30), so that no one hears *they went out and proclaimed* without hearing what proclamation costs. The cursed fig tree frames the temple action (Mk 11:12-21), leaves without fruit on either side of the scene. The plot and the betrayal frame the woman with the alabaster flask (Mk 14:1-11), a struck bargain on each side of a broken jar. And Peter's courtyard frames the council's interrogation (Mk 14:53-72): inside, a man is asked who he is and answers; outside, a man is asked who he is and denies.

A seventh instance is not an interruption but the same instinct working across pericope boundaries: scribes who *devour widows' houses*, then a widow giving her last two coins, then the prediction that not one stone of the building will be left (Mk 12:38-13:2). Devoured, giving, demolished, with no connecting word.

V.6 · What Crossed, and What Did Not

Images travel between scriptures, and the honest report distinguishes three cases.

Crossed whole. The sandal-thong of the servant too low to untie it (Mk 1:7), which the corpus's own tradition keeps in the mouth of its Prophet ﷺ concerning these two figures. And the camel

through the needle's eye (Mk 10:25), which the corpus writes with the same two objects and in the same argumentative position, against those whose wealth shuts the upper door: *ḥattā yalija al-jamalu fī sammi al-khiyāt* (Q 7:40).

Crossed in part. The shepherd and the scattered sheep: the corpus keeps the compassion and the care, *ra'fatan wa-raḥmatan* (Q 57:27), and does not build the shepherd as a title. Esther's half-kingdom oath, borrowed as a frame for Herod's banquet and inverted, since in the older book the machinery saves a people and here it kills a prophet. The cloaks spread on the road (Mk 11:8), which is Jehu's acclamation without the enthronement that followed it. The silent servant before the shearers (Mk 14:61), whose silence-figure the corpus does not take up for this prophet. And the cup, which is the sharpest case: the wrath-cup of Isaiah and Jeremiah reaches Gethsemane, and the corpus reserves *ka's* entirely for the drink of the garden, so the image crossed the earlier scriptures and stopped.

Declined by Mark. The heavens rolled like a scroll: Isaiah has it, the corpus takes it up as *ka-ṭayyi al-sijill* (Q 21:104), and Mark, quoting the verses around it, leaves it out. Zechariah's oracle of the king on a colt: staged and unquoted, while Matthew quotes it in full. And the second clause of Psalm 2:7, *today I have begotten you*, which the voice at the baptism stops one phrase short of, and which the Western text of Luke's parallel shows was available to be written.

V.7 · The Roughness That Authenticates

Part III argued that Mark's unpolished surface is the receipt of a text preserved rather than composed. The walk through the Gospel produced the instances, and here they are, twelve of them, in order.

The composite citation filed under Isaiah alone (Mk 1:2), which both copyists correct by dropping the Malachi half. The wrong high priest in the showbread precedent (Mk 2:26), which both copyists silently omit. *He could do no mighty work there* at Nazareth (Mk 6:5), which Matthew converts to *did not*. The permission of a staff and sandals in the mission kit (Mk 6:8-9), which both copyists forbid. *Prayer* alone as the answer at the foot of the mountain (Mk 9:29), to which later hands add *and fasting*. The crowd blessing *the kingdom* at the entry (Mk 11:10), which Matthew moves to the son and Luke to the king. Zechariah's oracle left unquoted (Mk 11:7). No command to repeat the supper (Mk 14:22-24), *do this in remembrance of me* belonging to Luke and Paul. The severed ear left unhealed (Mk 14:47), which Luke heals. The Aramaic cry left in its harder form and its mishearing preserved (Mk 15:34), which Matthew smooths toward Hebrew. Pilate's surprise that the death came so quickly (Mk 15:44), a detail no apologist composes. And the ending on a conjunction (Mk 16:8), which the tradition could not bear and completed in at least three different ways.

Twelve places where the earliest text is harder than the texts derived from it, and in every one the direction of change runs

from rough toward smooth. That direction is the argument. It is also the property this reader recognises from his own book, where a messenger's file contains *he frowned and turned away* addressed to himself in the third person.

V.8 · The Silencings

Nine times in this Gospel someone is told not to speak, and the count was opened in the first synagogue and carried to the council. It is the most explicitly tracked thread in the book and the one its last page turns on.

The demon in the Capernaum synagogue, muzzled mid-confession (Mk 1:25). The demons at the door, silenced *because they knew him* (Mk 1:34). The cleansed leper, told to say nothing and to go to the priest (Mk 1:44). The unclean spirits by the sea, forbidden to make him known (Mk 3:12). The household at Jairus's house, charged strictly that no one should know (Mk 5:43). The Decapolis crowd after the deaf man is opened, charged and proclaiming the more (Mk 7:36). The blind man at Bethsaida, sent home and told not to enter the village (Mk 8:26). The disciples after Peter's confession, charged to tell no one about him (Mk 8:30). And the three coming down from the mountain, told to say nothing *until the Son of Man should have risen from the dead* (Mk 9:9), the only one of the nine with a stated terminus.

Two things follow. The embargo is temporary by design, which the ninth instance says outright, and it is the corpus's own deferral written into narrative: *thumma inna 'alaynā bayānah*, then upon Us is its explication (Q 75:19), the explication placed after the recitation and assigned upstream. And the silenced parties are of two kinds and only one is a person who understood: the spirits are silenced because their testimony is accurate and inadmissible, which is the Provenance Firewall enacted on a speaker rather than on a text, while the healed and the disciples are silenced because the title in circulation carried a politics the office did not.

And then the inversion, which is the book's closing irony and the reason this thread is worth counting. Every one of the nine is an instruction not to speak, and the last instruction in the Gospel is the opposite: *go, tell his disciples and Peter*. It is the one command to speak, and it is the one that is disobeyed. *They said nothing to anyone, for they were afraid*.

Box | The Eight Threads at a Glance

The unnamed Agent. Three formal passives and nine further instances of the convention. Every one is a place the corpus writes the Name in the active.

Strength. Five occurrences, descending from *one mightier* to a companion who could not watch an hour.

The spitting. Five, crossing from healing to humiliation at the midpoint of the book.

Four Aramaic words. All four moments of address, two downward and two upward, each glossed for the Greek reader.

Six interruptions, plus a seventh working across pericope boundaries.

Transits. Two crossed whole, five crossed in part, three declined by Mark himself.

Twelve roughnesses, in every case running from rough toward smooth in the texts derived from Mark.

Nine silencings, every one an instruction not to speak, against a single instruction to speak that is disobeyed on the last page.

V.9 · The Preposition

One Arabic word carries a doctrine, and it appeared at eleven points in this reading: ten in the corpus and once in Mark's Greek, which was counted in its place as it arrived. '*Inda*, with, in the presence of, in the keeping of.

The Mother of the Book is '*indahu*, with Him (Q 13:39). What is with you runs out and *mā 'inda Allāhi bāq*, what is with Allah ﷻ remains (Q 16:96). Maryam AS is found with provision, and asked, she says *huwa min 'indi Allāh* (Q 3:37). The signs are '*inda Allāh* (Q 6:109), which is the answer to the sign-demand Mark's Messiah refuses in the passive. The appointed term is '*indah* (Q 6:2). The martyrs are *ahyā'un 'inda rabbihim*, living, with their Lord (Q 3:169), which is the corpus's form of the burning-bush argument Mark's Messiah makes to the Sadducees. And the Hour is '*inda* four times over (Q 7:187, Q 31:34, Q 41:47, Q 43:85), the densest cluster in the corpus, all of it about the one thing Mk 13:32 says the Son does not know.

The eleventh is Mark's own, in Greek, at the place where it matters most, and it was numbered link five in the walk because that is where the Gospel reached it: *para tō theō panta dynata*, with God all things are possible (Mk 10:27), spoken when the disciples ask who then can be saved. What is impossible in the register of human capacity is not impossible in the register of what is with Him. That is the whole doctrine of both books in one preposition, and the Gospel reaches for it at the exact point where human capability has been shown to end.

Box | Part V Summary

The threads were counted as they arrived, not assembled afterwards, which is why the counts are checkable against the passages rather than against this list.

One verb of strength, one gesture, four Aramaic words, six interruptions, three divine passives, twelve roughnesses, and nine silencings, with a ledger of images that crossed between the two scriptures whole, in part, or not at all, and one preposition standing apart at the close.

Every thread runs in one direction. Strength is announced, then bound, then found unbindable, then fails in the disciples' hands. Attribution is commanded upward and drifts downward within two verses of being commanded.

And the roughness is the receipt. What Mark declined to remove is the reason his text can be trusted, and the two Gospels that copied him let a reader watch the removing happen.

PART VI · THE CLOSING ARCHITECTURE

VI.1 · What the Reading Found

The commentary set out from a single asymmetry: four of the five figures the corpus says were given a book carry heavy records, and the fifth carries none. It read that silence as a guard rather than an elevation, and then walked the earliest Gospel from inside the position the corpus builds.

What it found, passage by passage, is one direction running the length of the book. The healer says *if you are willing* before he says *be clean*. The cleansing and the restoring and the preparing are written in a grammar that leaves the acting party unstated. He looks up to heaven before he breaks bread and before he opens ears. He says whoever receives me receives not me but the one who sent me. He says the seats at his right and left are not his to give. He says no sign will be given. He says all things are possible for you, remove this cup, yet not what I will but what you will. He says not even the Son knows the hour. And he is raised in the passive voice by an Agent the book declines to name.

That direction is the corpus's own, attached to every work it records of this prophet, four times in a single verse: *bi-idhni Allāh*, by the permission of Allah ﷻ. The two texts describe one circuit from its two ends. Mark, standing below, records the servant looking up. The corpus, speaking from above, records what was said when he looked and Who answered.

VI.2 · The Counterfeit Law

One structural observation deserves its own heading, because it explains why the two records differ in the way they do.

The corpus runs two devices on the prophetic file and they must not be confused. On 'Īsā AS and Yaḥyā AS it runs the clean file, which is the voluntariness guard: servanthood declared by a figure

who is never faulted is chosen, where servanthood proved by deficiency would be conceded. On the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ it runs the marked file, which is the anti-counterfeit device: seven recorded corrections, two commands to seek forgiveness, and an anti-cult clause revealed on a battlefield when a rumour of his death ran through the ranks. No impostor writes his own rebukes. The corrections are tamper-evidence.

Mark carries the same tamper-evidence in his own register, and V. 7 counted twelve instances of it. A family who thought him mad. A *could not* at Nazareth. Disciples who never understand. Peter called Satan. A wrong high priest. An ending on a conjunction. Both books authenticate by what they declined to remove, and the reader posited in Part I recognises the property immediately, because his own scripture taught it to him.

And the same law explains the longer ending. A tradition that completes a book in three different ways, in the open, in a record we can still read, is a tradition whose additions are visible precisely because the original was not managed. The dilution is documented because the source was not.

VI.3 · The Eight Corrections

Eight places where the reader's own scripture would correct what the received picture made of the Gospel. They are listed with their locations and, where it applies, with the note that the corpus performs the same operation on its own community first. Five of the eight carry that note.

One. Generation. The received picture made the sonship literal, *begotten not made, from the substance of the Father*. The corpus denies offspring and names what replaces it in the same breath, *kun fa-yakūn* (Q 2:117, Q 19:35). And the correction is not needed against Mark, who quotes Psalm 2 at the baptism and stops one clause before *today I have begotten you*.

Two. Number. The received picture counted. The corpus forbids the numeral in the very verse in which it supplies three designations for one referent, *wa-lā taqūlū thalāthah* (Q 4:171). Mark never counts persons.

Three. The equational sentence. The received picture wrote the identity as a creed. The corpus condemns the convertible identity at Q 5:17 and then writes that very construction in its own voice and fills it correctly, *fa-Allāhu huwa al-Walī wa-huwa yuḥyī al-mawtā* (Q 42:9), six times over. The condemnation was never of the grammar; it was of the occupant. The office of protector and life-giver is real and the quarrel is about who is seated in it.

Four. The blood. *This is my blood of the covenant* is Sinai's phrase, and at Sinai the blood is thrown *upon* the people and never drunk, with the ingestion barred by a law that states its own reason (Exodus 24:8, Leviticus 17:11). The corpus keeps the bar three times and then states the principle that resolves it: *neither their flesh nor their blood reaches Allah ﷻ, but the reverence from you reaches Him* (Q 22:37). **This correction is addressed to the corpus's own pilgrims, bringing their own animals.** The

covenant token is interiorised across three revelations, blood applied, salt added, and finally nothing material at all.

Five. Interpretive authority. The received picture ranked tradition beside commandment. Mark's Messiah separates them, *you leave the commandment of God and hold to the tradition of men* (Mk 7:8), and the corpus names the mechanism: *they took their scholars and their monks as lords besides Allah* ﷻ (Q 9:31), and lists four invented dedications, *Allah* ﷻ *has not instituted the baḥīra, nor the sā'iba* (Q 5:103). **The corpus's own community is warned in the same terms**, against inventing what was not given.

Six. The images and the intercessions. The received picture developed a devotional apparatus around the figures. The corpus's fence is *laysa ka-mithlihi shay'un* (Q 42:11), and it fences its own community first and hardest: **its own Prophet** ﷺ **is told to say I hold no power to benefit or harm myself** (Q 7:188), and the anti-cult clause of Q 3:144 was revealed to prevent exactly this development around him. The Gospel's own material runs the same way, since the seats are not his to give and the hour is not his to know.

Seven. Calculation of the end. The received picture produced periodised timetables. Mk 13:32 disclaims the timetable at the centre of an apocalypse, and the corpus makes the refusal its whole posture, six times *baghtatan*, suddenly, and the reason stated: *I almost conceal it, that every soul may be recompensed for what it strives* (Q 20:15). **The corpus disciplines its own community here**, since the appetite for dates is not confined to any one tradition.

Eight. Attribution. The subtlest and the one this commentary watched happen in the text. A healed man in the Decapolis is told to tell what *the Lord* has done for him, and goes out telling what *Jesus* has done for him (Mk 5:19-20), and Mark preserves the slippage without smoothing it. The same drift is visible in the appended ending, where a list of signs is promised to believers with the permission-clause removed, against Q 3:49, which attaches *bi-idhni Allāh* four times in one verse. **This is the correction the corpus applies most often to everyone, including itself:** *wa-mā bikum min ni'matin fa-mina Allāh* (Q 16:53).

Box | The Eight Corrections at a Glance

One. Generation, answered by *kun fa-yakūn*. Mark never carried it.

Two. Number, barred in the verse that supplies three designations for one referent.

Three. The equational sentence, where the frame is kept and the occupant refused.

Four. The blood, where Q 22:37 states what reaches Him. *Addressed to the corpus's own pilgrims*.

Five. Interpretive authority, scholars taken as lords and dedications invented. *The corpus warns its own community in the same terms*.

Six. The devotional apparatus, fenced by *laysa ka-mithlihi shay'un*. *Its own Prophet* ﷺ *is fenced first and hardest*.

Seven. Calculation of the end, refused six times as *baghtatan*. *The corpus disciplines its own community here*.

Eight. Attribution, the drift Mark preserved in the Decapolis and the appended ending performs. *This one the corpus applies to everyone, including itself*.

VI.4 · What the Reader Is Left Holding

Not a harmony, and not a polemic. Two books that were written six centuries apart, in two languages, by communities that have spent most of their shared history telling each other they hold incompatible accounts of one man.

Read together, passage by passage, what they hold is one figure who never claimed what was later claimed for him, whose every ability arrived by permission and was acknowledged upward before it was used, who withdrew alone in the dark to petition, who told his closest companions that the highest thing they wanted was not in his gift, who prayed with his face on the ground that a cup might pass and then placed his own will underneath another's, and who was taken up by a hand that one book names and the other reverently leaves blank.

The corpus says he was only a servant on whom favour was placed. The Gospel says he came not to be served but to serve. There is no daylight between those sentences.

And the last word of the earliest Gospel is fear, cut off mid-clause, and the first word the corpus speaks over those who are His is that the fear is lifted. The reader who holds both books watches one sentence finish across six hundred years, in another language, from the other side.

Everything in this commentary rests on constructions anyone can check: a concordance, a lexicon, a standard grammar, and the manuscripts themselves. Nothing in it asks anyone to take a word on authority, which is the only way a reading of two scriptures that both refuse to rest on authority could honestly be offered.

Box | Part VI Summary

Eight corrections, named and counted, and five of them are the same operation the corpus performs on itself: relocating an agency, bounding a quantifier, restoring a permission, correcting a name, releasing a token while the covenant stands.

The counterfeit law governs texts before it governs offices. What is faked is what is clean; what authenticates is the defect the original declined to remove; and the defence is publication with the roughness intact.

And the two books end on one sentence. The earliest Gospel stops at fear, mid-clause, and the corpus's first word over those who are His is that the fear is lifted.

APPENDIX A · THE STRUCTURAL COMMENTARY

Readers who want to see the instrument rather than only its work will find it here, in plain terms. Nothing in Parts I through VI depends on this appendix; it is offered because a method used throughout should be stated where it can be examined.

A.1 · The Floor

The commentary stands on one posit: to exist is to actuate. Whatever is, expends something in being what it is; nothing that exists is inert. This is a premise, not a theorem, and it is treated as one. Its only load in this reading is that the kinetic content of a claim, what a passage says happens, is treated as real and irreducible rather than dissolved into metaphor.

A.2 · Three Registers, Not Two or Four

Any complete claim decomposes into three things: what stands, what moves, and how the two bind. Delete any one and the remainder is incoherent rather than merely incomplete; add a fourth and it collapses back into one of the three. What that test actually shows is narrower than it looks, and the narrower statement is the honest one: it shows that a relational channel is often independent of the other two, which is what makes a structural reading worth performing, and it does not by itself demonstrate that the number is three. So the three registers are stated here as this commentary's working decomposition rather than as a result, and every reading in Parts I through VI stands on the texts it cites and not on the count.

The three must also be genuinely distinct. If the vocabulary filling one slot turns out to be a subset of another's, the slots were never separate and the apparent structure is one thing described twice. That check is what this commentary runs, silently, on every passage: are the existence-content, the kinetic content, and the relational content of this passage independent, and do they hold together?

A.3 · What a Closing Is

Three independent things enclose something the way three edges enclose a face; three collapsed things enclose nothing. So a reading closes when the three registers stand apart and compose, and breaks when they collapse into each other, and stays open when a register is missing and neither text supplies it.

The mark used for a closing is $\downarrow$. It stands at the end of a Structural Commentary when the three registers of that passage held apart and composed. Raised, $\downarrow$ GOL $\uparrow$, it marks a passage where a single utterance carries the whole architecture rather than one move within it, and that occurs twice in this book. Where a reading did not close, no mark is set and the reason is given in words. Appendix B lists every reading attempted and the term that binds it.

That is the whole of the machinery, and it explains the three verdicts this commentary uses in plain language throughout. Where a passage was said to hold, the three stood apart and composed. Where a divergence was named, the composition failed at a locatable point and the point was named. And where a text withholds something outright, the commentary says in one sentence what is not there rather than filling it, which is a report about the text and not a verdict on it.

A.4 · What the Geometry Cannot Do

Two limits, stated plainly because they bound every claim in this book.

The first is that a closing reading is not a true reading. Coherence is not truth; a well-built argument can rest on premises that do not hold. What this commentary certifies, when it says a reading closes, is that the reading is coherent, not that the world is as described.

The second is that the instrument is blind to direction. The test measures whether three registers are independent, and independence is unchanged if a claim is negated. So the structure alone can never tell a claim from its opposite. Direction has to be read from elsewhere: from the sentence itself, from what the words denote, from the arrow of the events. This is why the commentary never rests a finding on structure alone, and why every reading in it is anchored in a construction that can be checked in a lexicon or a manuscript.

A.5 · Where the Method Was Sovereign

One clause governed the harder passages. Where the two texts diverge on the surface, the structural reading is allowed to finish the sentence the words began: if the two occupy the same geometry, the divergence dissolves and the dissolution is shown; if they do not, the divergence is named and kept.

Three places show it working. On the resurrection of the married, the surface texts appear to conflict and the structure resolves them, since one removes the transaction from creatures and the

other assigns the pairing to the Lord, and together they are two halves of one sentence. On the amputations, the structure does not resolve them, since one text uses hyperbolic figure and the other legislates restraint, and the divergence is named at the level of the treatment prescribed. And on food, the divergence was located precisely at the layer where it actually falls, in a narrator's aside rather than in the teacher's mouth, which is a finding about layers rather than a dissolution.

Where neither the words nor the structure could close a question, the commentary said in one sentence what was missing and from which side it would have to come, and left the door standing open. That sentence is not a failure of the method. It is the method, working, at the edge of what any reading can do.

APPENDIX B · READINGS ATTEMPTED

Every structural reading in this commentary, with the term that binds its three registers. Fifteen readings, in the order they were reached, so a passage that earned its own commentary stands immediately before the unit that contains it.

Table*: Every structural reading, with its binding term

Where	Reading	Binding term	Mark
Mark 1:1-13	The opening frame: two seats, one descent	the ordering, <i>opisō mou</i>	↯ GOL
Mark 1:40-45	The leper: power, willing, and the touch	the passive imperative	↯ GOL
Mark 1:14-3:6	Galilee: authority remarked and never derived	the permission, built into the verbs	↯ GOL
Mark 3:7-4:34	One seed, four soils, and the inverted discriminator	the receiving condition	↯ GOL
Mark 4:35-6:6	The crossings: a creation already under command	the permission, with Nazareth as control	↯ GOL
Mark 6:7-8:26	The bread: fertility in the fracture	the upward glance	↯ GOL
Mark 10:45	The servanthood terminus	the voluntariness	↯ GOL ↑
Mark 8:27-10:52	The way: rank inverted on a road with a <i>dei</i>	the inversion of rank	↯ GOL
Mark 11:1-12:44	The city: trust, custody, and accounting	the accounting	↯ GOL
Mark 13:1-37	The discourse: permanence against dissolution	the reserved hour	↯ GOL
Mark 14:32-42	Gethsemane: two wills named and ranked	the ranking, performed by the lower	↯ GOL
Mark 15:29-32	The mockery: a capacity that was never held	<i>he cannot save himself</i>	↯ GOL
Mark 15:34	The cry: an address issued into darkness	the order of the clauses	↯ GOL ↑
Mark 14:1-15:47	The cup: written and willed, unreconciled	the asymmetry	↯ GOL
Mark 16:1-20	The tomb: the obstacle removed, the Remover unstated	the unnamed Agent	↯ GOL

Two readings carry the raised mark, and both for the same reason: a single utterance in each scripture holds the whole architecture rather than one move within it.

The servanthood. Q 4:172 and Mk 10:45. A conferred height presupposed by the very verb that denies disdain of the low place, and a descent through it that ends in a table-servant's word. Two

moves, the same order, one verse each, and neither text is quoting the other.

The cry. Q 21:87 and Mk 15:34. A doubled vocative issued from inside total darkness, with the complaint preserved rather than edited and the fault located at the caller rather than at the One called. The address precedes the complaint and survives it, which is a paradox held rather than resolved.

APPENDIX C · METHOD DISCLOSURE AND AUTHOR'S POSITION

C.1 · What was used

This commentary was developed under a verification discipline the author has been building and testing since 2013 and publishes under the name Trisduction. Its content is set out from first principles in Appendix A and can be assessed there without reference to anything else. Summarised in one paragraph: a claim is read on three registers, what stands, what moves, and how the two bind; a reading is admitted when the three are genuinely distinct and their composition encloses something, and is refused when any two collapse together; and the magnitude of a closure is constitutively blind to direction, so direction is supplied by language and never by structure.

The discipline organises and verifies. It generates no evidence and adds no warrant to what it organises. Every conclusion here rests on the two scriptures and on published grammatical, lexical, and text-critical scholarship, and each would stand or fall identically if the discipline had never been applied to it. Appendix A states in its own voice that nothing in Parts I through VI depends on it.

C.2 · How it was applied here

The three registers were instantiated as follows.

The formal register was grammar. The passive imperative at Mk 1:41 and the passive indicative at Mk 3:5 and Mk 10:40. The separative pronoun that marks the equational construction at Q 5:17 and the same construction affirmed six times over from Q 42:9. The gender agreement that breaks at Q 3:45 to follow the person. The ordinal position of the teaching before the creating at Q 55:2-3. The lexical separation of discrimination from vocalisation. The particle *fa-* that admits no interval between command and result.

The evidential register was distribution. Which predicates the corpus attaches to which terms, how many times, and where it withholds them: the eight occurrences of *kun fa-yakūn* and their clustering, the eleven occurrences of the messianic title and the four that stand inside clauses being corrected, the fourfold permission-clause in a single verse, and the fault-record read across the five who were given a book.

The registrational register was reader-invariance: whether a finding survives a change in the confessional position of the

person assessing it. The findings pass that test in a specific and uncomfortable sense. The inventory at II.3 is unwelcome to a polemicist of one tradition and the eight corrections at VI.3 are unwelcome to an apologist of the other, and neither section could have been written to please a reader of either commitment.

C.3 · Sources, and how they were weighted

The two scriptures are the primary evidence and the only register permitted to close a reading. Every post-canonical interpretive corpus of every tradition enters as witness only, is noted where it corroborates and named where it diverges, and carries no conclusion. This applies evenhandedly: classical Quranic exegesis, patristic and conciliar literature, rabbinic material, the Dead Sea material, and modern critical scholarship all stand downstream of the texts they gloss and are treated the same way. Where a grammatical observation is credited to a named scholar, the credit is for noticing the datum; the datum stands on the text.

Consensus carries no evidential weight in either direction. That a reading is standard is a fact about reception; that a reading is unusual is also a fact about reception. Neither is a fact about the text.

Where the manuscripts divide at a point that matters, the division is reported rather than resolved silently, because the copyists' hands are part of the evidence and are used as evidence at Part III and again at V.7.

C.4 · What is not claimed

No historical claim is made that the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ read the Gospel of Mark. The reading device is stated as a device in the Prologue and is used as an organising position, licensed by the fact that the corpus performs an extensive reading of the same material, and thirteen surahs carry sustained treatment of it, with passing mentions elsewhere: Q 2, Q 3, Q 4, Q 5, Q 9, Q 19, Q 21, Q 33, Q 42, Q 43, Q 57, Q 61, and Q 66. Every one of them is cited in this commentary and the list is checkable on the same terms as everything else in the book.

No determination is made about the identity of 'Īsā AS at the level the two traditions actually differ. That is not withheld as a courtesy. It is beyond the reach of the instrument used, for the reason set out at A.4, and an instrument returning a verdict there would be reporting its operator rather than its data.

No transmission claim is made anywhere. The convergence recorded at II.8 is convergence of independent strata on one architecture, which is evidence about the architecture and not about descent.

And no new philology, no new mathematics, and no new textual discovery is claimed. The contribution is the arrangement. Every ingredient is available to any reader with a concordance, a lexicon, a standard grammar, and a critical apparatus.

C.5 · The author's position

This commentary is uncomfortable for standard positions in at least two places, and both are named here rather than left for a reader to find.

The corpus applies to its own Word a set of attributes it applies to nothing created, and the community that noticed this drew the obvious inference and defended it at cost. The same community reads the Word-language about 'Īsā AS as though it carried no share of those attributes. That is two treatments of one term, and no textual ground for the split has been offered here or elsewhere. Section II.4 states the problem and II.5 offers the resolution, which costs the received position nothing it needs: the attributes belong to the Word of Allah ﷻ in its residence, the casting proceeds from the Word that carries them and is an act rather than a transfer of the predicated item, and the vessel is a servant who ate food and named the day of his own death.

And VI.3 marks eight places where the reader's own scripture corrects what the received picture made of the Gospel, five of which are the same operation the corpus performs on its own community first. The distinction is load-bearing and is kept there throughout: the first correction is not needed against Mark at all, since Mark quotes the second Psalm and stops one clause before the generation clause; the second observes that Mark never counts persons; and the fifth and the eighth both credit Mark with preserving the very material the corpus is correcting. The corpus's own word for what it does to what came before it is *muhaymin*, custodian, at Q 5:48: standing over the earlier deposit while confirming it. Custody is not replacement, and a custodian who corrects eight items in the reception of a text he confirms, while leaving the text itself standing where it stands, is doing custody.

Finally, and in the register the author regards as governing everything above: the commentary issues no certificate, least of all to itself. *Fa-lā tuzakkū anfusakum, huwa a'lamu bi-mani ttaqā* (Q 53:32). Do not certify your own purity; He knows best who guards himself.

APPENDIX D · GLOSSARY OF ARABIC AND GREEK TERMS

Every non-English term that carries argument in this commentary, with the sense it carries here. Arabic first, then Greek, with the two Aramaic words that matter set among the Greek where they occur.

Arabic

aḥad · one, in the sense of one-without-a-second; the word used in negative constructions for not-a-single-one. Contrast *wāḥid*.

amr · command, matter, affair. At Q 16:40 and Q 36:82 the creative command by which a thing comes to be, and the root by which Q 17:85 locates the Spirit.

anṣāb · set-up stones; called an abomination of Satan's work at Q 5:90, and the corpus's nearest term for what stands where it ought not.

anṣār · helpers, supporters. Used of the disciples in the corpus's own approving voice at Q 3:52 and Q 61:14.

āya, plural **āyāt** · a sign; also a verse of the Quran.

awwāb · ever-returning, one who turns back repeatedly. The epithet of Ayyūb AS and of Dāwūd AS, and a participle that presupposes something to return from.

ayyada · to brace, to reinforce, from the root for strength in the hand. The verb of the threefold strengthening at Q 2:87, Q 2:253, and Q 5:110: bracing, not replacing.

baghtatan · suddenly, without warning. The corpus's standing adverb for the Hour, six times, and its refusal of the calculating genre.

bayān · the faculty of between-making, of holding two things apart and registering the distinction. From the root of *bayna*, between. Given to the human as such at Q 55:4 and retained as a divine undertaking at Q 75:19.

bi-idhnī, bi-idhni Allāh · by My permission, by the permission of Allah ﷻ. The clause attached to every miracle the corpus records of 'Īsā AS, four times in a single verse at Q 5:110.

dhanb · offence, fault. Used of the Prophet ﷺ at Q 40:55 and Q 47:19 in a command to seek forgiveness for it.

furqān · the criterion, the splitter, from the root meaning to separate. The name of the whole revelation at Q 25:1 and the gift promised to anyone who guards himself at Q 8:29.

ghayb · what lies beyond the reach of sight or report; the unseen.

ḥanīf · upright, inclining away from all else. Paired with *fiṭra*, the original constitution, at Q 30:30.

ḥawāriyyūn · the disciples of 'Īsā AS.

ḥikma · wisdom.

ḥisāb · reckoning, counting. *Bi-ghayri ḥisāb*, without reckoning.

ikhṭilāf · discrepancy, disagreement; the thing Q 4:82 challenges the reader to look for and not find.

'inda · with, in the presence of, in the keeping of. The preposition that locates the Book, the provision, the signs, and the knowledge of the Hour on the source side.

Injīl · the Gospel, treated by the corpus as a book given to 'Īsā AS, with guidance and light in it.

iṣṭafā · to choose out, to select. Used of Maryam AS twice in one verse at Q 3:42.

jabbār · a tyrant, one who compels. Denied of Yaḥyā AS at Q 19:14.

kalima, plural **kalimāt** · word. Used of ʿĪsā AS at Q 3:45 and Q 4:171 and of the divine speech at Q 18:109 and Q 6:115.

khatama · to seal, to set a seal upon. Used of hearts at Q 2:7 and of the prophetic office at Q 33:40.

khaṭīʾa · a fault, a lapse; the word Ibrāhīm AS applies to himself, unprompted, at Q 26:82.

kibr · arrogance, self-magnification. Its absence is the reason the corpus gives at Q 5:82 for naming a community nearest in affection.

kun fa-yakūn · Be, and it is. The creative command, eight occurrences, tabled at II.5a.

māʾida · a table set with food; the table requested and granted at Q 5:112-115.

al-Masīḥ · the Messiah. Used eleven times of ʿĪsā AS and never withdrawn, including in the clauses correcting what was said about it. Morphologically a passive form: the one acted upon.

mathal · a likeness, a similitude. The governing word of Q 3:59, which compares two originations and not two natures.

mīthāq ghalīḻ · a solemn covenant. Used of the prophets at Q 33:7, of Banū Isrāʾīl at Q 4:154, and of marriage at Q 4:21.

muhaymin · custodian, one who watches over and safeguards. What the corpus calls itself in relation to the scriptures before it, at Q 5:48.

muqarrabūn · those brought near. Placed beside the Messiah at Q 4:172, which is what sets the height the verse then denies any disdain from.

muṣaddiq · one who confirms or attests; **taṣdīq** is the act of confirming, and it requires two parties.

musakhkhar · made subject, placed under command. Used of the sea at Q 45:12.

muttaqīn · those who guard themselves, the shield-keepers. The corpus's stated condition for receiving its own guidance, at Q 5:46, and the condition on which the criterion is issued at Q 8:29.

nafs · the self, the soul; the bounded layer that tastes death at Q 3:185.

nasab · lineage, kinship; a relation between positions in a descent, denied of the Source at Q 37:158.

qurʾān · recitation, and also gathering, from a root carrying both senses.

raʾfa · compassion. Placed with mercy in the hearts of the followers of ʿĪsā AS at Q 57:27.

rasūl · a sent one, a messenger. The office, not the person.

rizq · provision, sustenance; not restricted to material food, and twice attached to the negation of counting.

rūḥ · spirit, breath. *Rūḥ al-Qudus*, the Holy Spirit; *Rūḥ al-Amīn*, the Trustworthy Spirit.

ṣiddīq, feminine **ṣiddīqa** · one of truth; used of Maryam AS at Q 5:75.

shubbiha · it was made to resemble; from the root of *mutashābihāt*, the resembling verses of Q 3:7.

ṣuḥuf · scrolls, sheets; the scripture of Ibrāhīm AS at Q 87:19.

taqwā · guardedness; the practised habit of keeping oneself shielded.

tawaffā · to take in full, to receive back. Used of the taking of a self at death and at sleep, and of ʿĪsā AS at Q 3:55 with Allah ﷻ as the agent.

Tawrāt · the Torah.

wāḥid · one, in the sense of first-of-a-count; a countable one. Contrast *aḥad*.

wahy · revelation given from above.

wajh · face; what remains at Q 55:27 and Q 28:88, and never placed under the death-law.

walad · a child in the generative sense, offspring; the term whose denial at Q 6:101 is explained by the absence of a consort.

yastankif · he disdains, he holds himself above. The verb denied of the Messiah at Q 4:172, and it presupposes a height.

yatadabbar · to follow a thing through to its end, from the root for the back or outcome of a thing. The verb of the challenge at Q 4:82.

Zabūr · the Psalms.

ẓulumāt · darknesses, in the plural. Where Yūnus AS calls from at Q 21:87.

Greek, with two Aramaic words

abba · Aramaic, father. Kept untranslated and then glossed, at Mk 14:36.

anakekylitai · it has been rolled back; perfect passive, of the stone at Mk 16:4.

anastenaxas · groaning up from within; the only occurrence of the compound in the New Testament, at Mk 8:12.

anelēmphthē · he was taken up; passive, in the appended ending at Mk 16:19, which shows how deep the convention ran.

apekatestathē · it was restored; of the withered hand at Mk 3:5, with no touch and no formula.

aphientai · they are forgiven; at Mk 2:5, in the scene where the scribes quote the corpus's own sentence about who alone forgives.

automatē · of itself, without an agent's intervention; of the earth's yield at Mk 4:28.

bar enasha · Aramaic, son of man; in ordinary usage, a human being, and the phrase behind the Greek title.

dedotai · it has been given; at Mk 4:11.

diakoneō, diakonos · to wait at table; a table-servant. The word Mk 10:45 ends on, and the word used of the women at Mk 15:41.

doulos · a slave. The word Mk 10:44 trades down to from *diakonos*.

egō eimi · I am. At Mk 6:50 in the boat and at Mk 14:62 before the council.

ephobounto gar · for they were afraid; the last three words of the Gospel.

ephphatha · Aramaic, be opened; kept and glossed at Mk 7:34.

euthys · immediately; Mark's characteristic adverb, roughly forty times.

exousia · authority, and etymologically permission, from *exesti*, it is permitted. The word the crowd uses of him in the first synagogue.

gegraptai · it has been written; the citation-formula, and at Mk 14:21 it stands in the same sentence as a woe.

genea · generation; the disputed term at Mk 13:30.

hē pistis sou sesōken se · your trust has saved you; said to the woman at Mk 5:34 and to Bartimaeus at Mk 10:52.

hētoimastai · it has been prepared; of the seats at Mk 10:40, where the whole point is that the preparing was done by another.

horkizō · I adjure, I put you on oath; the demon's own verb at Mk 5:7, which swears the healer by the higher Name.

ischyros, ischyroteros, ouk ischysan · strong, mightier, they were not able. The thread that descends from Mk 1:7 to Mk 14:37.

kairos · appointed time, as against ordinary elapsed time. The word of the first public sentence at Mk 1:15.

katharisthēti · be cleansed; aorist passive imperative, the leper's healing at Mk 1:41.

kathōs · just as, according as. With *gegraptai*, the fulfilment formula.

kraspedon · the tassel or fringe of a garment, the *ḥiṣṣit* the Torah commands at Numbers 15:38.

kynaria · little dogs, household animals; the diminutive at Mk 7:27, not the word for scavenging dogs.

logos · word, account, reasoned utterance. At Mk 7:29 the woman's own argument is what the healing is granted for.

lytron · a release-price, the sum paid to free a captive; Mk 10:45.

metemorphōthē · he was transfigured; passive, at Mk 9:2.

parrēsia · openly, without reserve; once in Mark, at Mk 8:32, two verses after the charge to say nothing.

pephimōso · be muzzled; spoken to an unclean spirit at Mk 1:25 and to the sea at Mk 4:39.

proagō · to go on ahead; the thread from Mk 10:32 to Mk 14:28 and Mk 16:7.

prōton · first, in sequence. The word that lets the Syrophoenician woman grant the order and deny the exclusion at Mk 7:27.

schizomenous, eschisthē · being torn, it was torn; the heavens at Mk 1:10 and the temple curtain at Mk 15:38, the same verb and nowhere else in the book.

sy legeis · you say it; the answer to Pilate at Mk 15:2.

thelō · I will, I am willing. Granted at Mk 1:41 and subordinated at Mk 14:36.

yehiv · Aramaic, it was given; the passive of conferral in the Danielic scene the Son of Man title is cited from.

APPENDIX E · INDEX OF PRINCIPAL QURANIC CITATIONS

Grouped by the function each verse performs in this commentary. Four hundred and forty-five distinct verses are cited across the book, four hundred and forty-four of them in Parts I through VI and one further in the appendices; what follows is the load-bearing set, gathered so that a reader can find the argument a verse belongs to rather than only the page it fell on.

The fault-record. Q 2:37 · Q 7:23 · Q 7:143 · Q 7:150-151 · Q 9:114 · Q 11:46 · Q 11:78-80 · Q 12:24 · Q 12:42 · Q 12:67 · Q 12:84-86 · Q 18:73 · Q 20:93 · Q 20:115 · Q 20:121 · Q 21:87 · Q 26:14 · Q 26:82 · Q 27:20-22 · Q 28:15-16 · Q 37:140 · Q 38:24 · Q 38:31-34 · Q 38:44 · Q 68:48. And of the Prophet ﷺ at Q 8:67-68, Q 9:43, Q 17:73-75, Q 33:37, Q 40:55, Q 47:19, Q 48:2, Q 66:1, Q 80:1, and Q 94:2.

The two clean files. Q 3:39 · Q 3:45 · Q 4:163 · Q 4:171-172 · Q 5:46 · Q 5:116-117 · Q 6:85 · Q 19:7 · Q 19:12-15 · Q 19:19 · Q 19:30-33 · Q 43:59 · Q 87:19.

The Word: residence and predicates. Q 6:115 · Q 10:64 · Q 13:39 · Q 16:40 · Q 17:85 · Q 18:109 · Q 26:193-194 · Q 31:27 · Q 36:82 · Q 43:4 · Q 56:77-78 · Q 85:21-22 · Q 97:1.

The Christology, affirmed. Q 2:87 · Q 2:253 · Q 3:37 · Q 3:42 · Q 3:45-52 · Q 4:163 · Q 5:46 · Q 5:75 · Q 5:82 · Q 5:110 · Q 5:112-115 · Q 19:16-33 · Q 21:91 · Q 33:7 · Q 42:13 · Q 43:59 · Q 43:61 · Q 57:27 · Q 61:6 · Q 61:14 · Q 66:12.

The three constructions addressed. Q 4:171 · Q 5:17 · Q 5:72 · Q 5:73 · Q 5:116 · Q 6:101 · Q 9:30 · Q 19:35 · Q 43:81 · Q 112:1-4.

The equational form, affirmed. Q 42:9 · Q 22:6 · Q 22:62 · Q 31:30 · Q 51:58 · Q 57:24.

The ordinal, affirmed, and presence against membership. Q 9:40 · Q 58:7 · Q 53:20 · Q 37:1-4 · Q 37:164-166.

Kun fa-yakūn, all eight occurrences. Q 2:117 · Q 3:47 · Q 3:59 · Q 6:73 · Q 16:40 · Q 19:35 · Q 36:82 · Q 40:68. With Q 2:116 and Q 17:85 beside them.

The taking, the raising, and the layers. Q 2:156 · Q 3:55 · Q 3:185 · Q 4:157-158 · Q 5:117 · Q 11:123 · Q 25:58 · Q 28:88 · Q 39:42 · Q 55:26-27 · Q 57:3.

Transmission and comprehension. Q 6:50 · Q 7:188 · Q 10:15 · Q 18:65-82 · Q 20:114 · Q 46:9 · Q 53:3-4 · Q 69:44-46 · Q 75:16-19.

The faculty and the criterion. Q 2:53 · Q 4:82 · Q 8:29 · Q 8:41 · Q 12:1 · Q 25:1 · Q 26:2 · Q 27:1 · Q 27:16 · Q 28:2 · Q 41:21 · Q 43:2 · Q 44:2.

Signs, permission, and reception. Q 3:49 · Q 5:110 · Q 17:59 · Q 40:78 · Q 45:12.

The unbrokered call. Q 2:186 · Q 12:86 · Q 21:87 · Q 40:60 · Q 93:3.

Provision, mercy, and release. Q 3:37 · Q 6:54 · Q 24:22 · Q 39:53 · Q 65:3 · Q 5:89.

The bearer, the message, and the counterfeit law. Q 2:87 · Q 3:144 · Q 25:58 · Q 33:40.

The hour, and the refusal to calculate. Q 6:31 · Q 7:187 · Q 12:107 · Q 22:55 · Q 31:34 · Q 43:66 · Q 47:18.

Custody, continuity, and the substitution of a carrier. Q 5:13 · Q 5:48 · Q 5:54 · Q 6:164 · Q 9:31 · Q 17:15 · Q 35:18 · Q 42:13 · Q 47:38.

The adversary's forced theology. Q 38:82, where Iblīs swears by the Lord's own might in the very act of rebelling, because there is no other vocabulary to rebel in.

The ransom, and the bar on transferred liability. Q 37:107 · Q 6:164 · Q 17:15 · Q 35:18.

The unlegislated space, and the self-certification bar. Q 5:101 · Q 22:37.

REFERENCES

Three works are cited throughout. Everything else named in this commentary is identified in place.

The Gospel According to Mark. The Greek text as established in the modern critical editions, with the ending at Mk 16:8 in Codex Sinaiticus and Codex Vaticanus and the longer ending of Mk 16:9-20 treated as a later addition on the grounds set out in the last section of Part IV. Passages are given in a continuous rendering rather than in any single English version, because the commentary reads sequences, placements, and repetitions rather than the wording of one translation, and where a word carries the argument the Greek is given and glossed.

The Qur'ān. The received text in the 'Uthmānic recension, cited throughout as surah:verse. Renderings are the author's own, made to carry the grammatical feature under discussion rather than to serve as a devotional translation, and the Arabic is given wherever a rendering is doing work.

Islam, Mohammad F. *Condensed Trisduction: A Linguistically, Topologically, and Mathematically Sealed Verification Architecture. Triaxial Orthogonality, Twelve-Gate Closure, the Quaternionic Completion.* Zenodo, version 3, 29 July 2026. DOI 10.5281/zenodo.21664543, <https://zenodo.org/records/21664543>. Also deposited at PhilArchive, record ISLCTA, <https://philpapers.org/rec/ISLCTA>. The verification discipline whose method is set out from first principles in Appendix A and whose application to this commentary is disclosed in Appendix C.

And the companion volume to this one: *The Clean Gospel of Mark: A Passage by Passage Commentary on the Earliest Gospel Using Quranic Verses*, Structural Reading Edition. Zenodo, 2 August 2026. DOI 10.5281/zenodo.21756248, <https://zenodo.org/records/21756248>. Also at PhilArchive, record ISLTG. That edition reads eighteen selections; this one reads the Gospel entire.

Written by a servant who was taught, in the making of this, more than he brought to it. The praise belongs to the One who teaches what was not known.